The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra of the Great Parinirvāṇa

Āryamahāparinirvāṇanāmamahāyānasūtra · Toh 120 · Derge Kangyur
འཕགས་པ་ཡངས་སུ་མྱ་ངན་ལས་འདས་པ་ཆན་པ་ཐེག་པ་ཆེ་པའི་མདོ།

The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra of the Great Parinirvāṇa, known in Sanskrit as the Āryamahāparinirvāṇanāmamahāyānasūtra and in Tibetan as Phagpa yongsu nyangen le depa chenpo thekpa chenpo'i do, is a Mahāyāna sūtra set at the very end of the Buddha's life. It opens in the grove of twin sāla trees near Kuśinagara, on the bank of the Hiraṇyavatī River, where the Buddha, surrounded by a vast assembly of monks, announces on the full-moon morning of the last month of spring that his final passing is at hand, speaking so that every being understands him in its own language. Against this backdrop the sūtra presents his parting teachings, which are celebrated in the Mahāyāna tradition for proclaiming the permanence of the Tathāgata and the presence of buddha nature in all beings. It is Toh 120 in the Kangyur, where it belongs to the general sūtra section. This lengthy, multi-fascicle version is traditionally understood to have been rendered into Tibetan from a Chinese translation, alongside a separate, shorter Tibetan version of the same sūtra.

In the language of India: ārya mahā pari nirbāṇa nāma mahā yāna sūtra. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra of the Great Parinirvāṇa.

Fascicle one.

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One (the Buddha) was staying in the city of Kuśinagara, on the bank of the Hiraṇyavatī River, in the grove of twin sāla trees near the land of the Mallas. There the Blessed One was surrounded and attended by eighty hundred-thousand koṭis of monks. On the morning of the full moon of the last month of spring, as the time of his parinirvāṇa drew near, he made himself understood as far as the Peak of Existence, in words that conveyed the meaning with perfect skill in the language of each and every being's own land. He declared: "Today the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, who has compassion for the whole world, the protector of the whole world, who regards all beings as he regards Rāhula, the great sage who has become the abode and ground of great refuge, will pass into parinirvāṇa." And such plain words came forth, answering the questions of

all beings.

Moreover, at that time many kinds of light rays came forth from the Blessed One's own mouth: blue, yellow, red, white, the color of crystal, and the color of emerald. These rays reached throughout the great trichiliocosm and all the buddha fields of the ten directions, and struck the beings there: the hell-beings, animals, hungry ghosts, asuras, and the beings of the world of Yama. At that very moment all the darkness of the afflictions, all the lower realms, and all the unfavorable states were cut off.

Then, overcome by great sorrow, they cried out with one voice, "Alas, we are overwhelmed! We are overwhelmed!" They also wailed aloud, "Alas! Alas!" Stretching out their hands, they beat their heads; their bodies trembled, and they wept bitterly.

At that time the great earth, with its forests and its mountains, as far as the shores of the ocean, shook violently. Those beings took hold of one another and said, "Friends, hurry! Friends, hurry! Let us go, let us go to Kuśinagara, the city in the land of the Mallas! Let us bow at the feet of the Tathāgata, and entreat him to turn back from going into parinirvāṇa, and without haste to remain for an eon, or even longer than an eon."

Clutching one another, they said, "Alas, the world will become empty! Alas, the world will become empty! Alas, the ripening of the karma of beings' merit is exhausted! Terrible karma has come about! Venerable ones, hurry! Venerable ones, hurry! The Tathāgata, the perfectly complete Buddha, is about to pass into parinirvāṇa this very instant. Alas, the world will become empty! Alas, the world will become empty! If the Tathāgata does not remain, how will we fare, without a protector, without support, and destitute? We must ask him about whatever doubts and uncertainties we have."

These great śrāvakas were also present there: the elder Mahākātyāyana, the elder Bakkula, the elder Upananda, and others besides were present there. When the light struck them, they trembled and shook violently, they were shaken and deeply shaken, they were agitated and greatly agitated, they were alarmed and greatly alarmed, they were bewildered and utterly bewildered, they staggered and reeled, they were stupefied and utterly stupefied, they stiffened and grew rigid. In such states and others like them, they set out.

At that time eight million monks had finished chewing their tooth sticks and had come out. When the radiance of that light struck those elders, they hastily washed their faces and took hold of one another. All of these sons of the

Tathāgata were arhats who had attained mastery, who had done what was to be done and accomplished their work, thoroughbreds, great leaders, who had attained their own aim through great emptiness, with retinues like great sandalwood and retinues like lions. Endowed with these and countless other qualities, all of them, early in the morning as the sun was rising, felt the hairs of all their limbs stand on end, red at the roots like the flowers of the lac tree, and their eyes filled with tears like blood. Stricken with feelings of the most intense suffering, out of help, happiness, and compassion for all beings, for the sake of those to be trained, and in order that the Dharma gateway of the various words of intended meaning concerning the aspect of emptiness, the supreme secret of the Great Vehicle, might be explained, they went to where the Blessed One was. Having arrived, they bowed their heads at the Blessed One's feet, circumambulated the Blessed One a hundred thousand times, and, joining their palms and bowing toward where the Blessed One was, sat down to one side.

At that time six hundred-thousand koṭis of nuns, headed by Subhadrā, the daughter of Kotaka, were all arhats whose defilements were exhausted, who had attained mastery, who had done what was to be done and accomplished their work, who had laid down the burden, free of afflictions, great leaders, who had attained their own aim through great emptiness. They were the nun Subhadrā, daughter of Kotaka, the nun Upanandā, the nun Sāgaramati, and others, six hundred-thousand koṭis of nuns. Early in the morning as the sun was rising, the hairs of all their limbs stood on end, red at the roots like the flowers of the lac tree, and their eyes filled with tears like blood. Stricken with feelings of the most intense suffering, out of help, happiness, and compassion for all beings, for the sake of those to be trained, and in order that the Dharma gateway of the various words of intended meaning concerning the aspect of emptiness, the supreme secret of the Great Vehicle, might be explained, they went to where the Blessed One was. Having arrived, they bowed their heads at the Blessed One's feet, circumambulated the Blessed One a hundred thousand times, and, joining their palms and bowing toward where the Blessed One was, sat down to one side.

The nuns seated in that assembly were also all bodhisattvas, supreme among humans, who had attained the ten grounds. For the sake of those to be trained, they bore the form of women, the shape of women, and bodies of flesh, blood, many sinews and bone. They were constantly engaged in meditating on the four immeasurables, and all of them were able, by their own

power, to accomplish the aims of the great miracles that are the domain of the buddhas.

Furthermore, at that time the bodhisattvas led by the bodhisattva Sāgaradatta, as many as the sands of the river Ganges, had all attained the ten grounds, supreme among humans, and all bore bodies through skillful means. Among them were the bodhisattva great being Sāgaradatta, the bodhisattva great being Akṣayamati, and others. All these bodhisattva great beings wished to hear the Great Vehicle, had entered the Great Vehicle, hungered for the Great Vehicle, longed for the Great Vehicle, were free of stinginess toward the Great Vehicle, and were able to accord with the whole world. Thinking, "Having crossed over ourselves, we shall ferry others across," they had, for as many as ten million eons in the past, properly taken up the vows of the array of moral discipline and practiced the conduct of upholding them. Likewise they all thought, "Having been liberated ourselves, we shall liberate others." Likewise they thought, "We shall keep the lineage of the Three Jewels from being cut off," and "We shall turn the wheel of Dharma," and "We shall don the great armor." Likewise they were endowed with immeasurable qualities and regarded all sentient beings equally, as one would an only son.

At sunrise in the morning, the hair on all their limbs stood on end, reddish like the flowers of the lac tree, and their eyes filled with tears like blood. Stricken with feelings of the most intense suffering, out of help, happiness, and compassion for all beings, for the sake of those to be trained, and in order that the Dharma gateway of the various words of intended meaning concerning the aspect of emptiness, the supreme secret of the Great Vehicle, might be explained, they went to where the Blessed One was. Having arrived, they bowed their heads at the Blessed One's feet, circumambulated the Blessed One a hundred thousand times, and, joining their palms and bowing toward where the Blessed One was, sat down to one side.

Again at that time, the laymen led by the layman King Renowned for Stainless Light, as many as the sands of two Ganges rivers, had taken the five bases of training and were endowed with moral discipline, proper observance, and good qualities. All of them wished to understand things in their pairs: suffering and happiness, permanence and impermanence, the existence of a self and selflessness, the empty and the not empty, reality and what is not reality, refuge and what is not refuge, sentient beings and the absence of sentient beings, the stable and the unstable, the peaceful and the not peaceful, the

conditioned and the unconditioned, the everlasting and the not everlasting, parinirvāṇa and what is not parinirvāṇa, and so on. They all wished to know their distinctions and their finer distinctions.

Among them were the layman called King Renowned for Stainless Light, the layman Excellent Giver, and others. These laymen wished to hear the Great Vehicle, and, having vowed, "Once we have heard it, we shall teach it to others," had taken up moral discipline. Having quenched their thirst with the Great Vehicle, they had vowed, "We shall quench the thirst of others who are thirsty." They longed for the Great Vehicle, were free of stinginess toward the Great Vehicle, and were all able to accord with the whole world. They wished to train with the thoughts, "Having crossed over ourselves, we shall ferry others across. Having been liberated ourselves, we shall liberate others. We shall keep the lineage of the Three Jewels from being cut off. We shall turn the wheel of Dharma." They had donned the great armor, held the trainings in reverence, and likewise were endowed with countless qualities. They all had compassion for all sentient beings, as one would for an only son.

They too, at sunrise, in order to build the pyre for the cremation of the Tathāgata, each came bearing five thousand pieces apiece of firewood of sandalwood, aloeswood, the finest pine, and sandalwood of the most excellent soil, together with fragrant fuel sticks of fine quality. Each kind of fuel stick was wound with golden thread adorned with the seven precious substances of seven kinds, so that it looked just like something in a painting. All were naturally fresh and finely worked. Each kind had a great mass of light of many sorts, blue in color, and here and there in places white, in places pale blue, in places reddish, in places yellow, all delightful to the eye. The fringes of the covering of every bundle were all made of the seven precious substances. Each of the many binding cords was interspersed with hues like vermilion, like the color of sesame flowers, and with blue and yellow. Each of the many binding cords was also interwoven with the finest pure gold brocade, renowned in many lands.

Each kind of fuel stick was furnished with sweet-smelling incense, flower garlands and saffron powder, covered with gold brocade, and adorned with silk streamers. They were placed inside sheaths of the seven precious substances, blue, yellow, pale blue, white, and the color of madder, wrapped in the finest cloth of the land of Kaliṅga, linen cloth, brocade and Chinese silk, adorned with many flowers, and anointed with sweet-smelling unguents.

Each cart carrying each kind of fuel stick was adorned with the seven precious substances; some were beautified with gold, and some, with blue, white, the hue of acacia blossoms and the hue of red lead, shone with a surpassing clear radiance. The yokes of those carts were also adorned with the seven precious substances, matchless, and were all harnessed to swift thoroughbred horses.

The horses, too, were swift with the force of the wind, and their coats were all the color of herons, of realgar, or of clouds. At the front and the back of each chariot of that design, victory banners and pennants were raised. All the banners were made of jewels and covered with golden nets. In front of the banners, too, they carried parasols whose ribs and shafts were made of stainless, radiant gems, all hung with tassels of pearls. In front of each parasol, too, they carried golden flowers, kumuda, utpala and white lotuses, with stems made of beryl and anthers made of diamond. Many bees hummed among them. They were fragrant, delightful, radiant, large and many, and with them they carried great festoons. In front of the great festoons, too, they bore great paintings depicting the deeds of the bodhisattva's birth stories.

On the right and left of each painted figure, too, dancers performed many kinds of dance from the Middle Country (Madhyadeśa). Among the dancers, instruments made of jewels were beaten and blown: clay drums, bronze drums, round drums, lutes, flutes, single-stringed lutes, great drums, conches and others. From those instruments of the dance, too, came words to this effect: "Alas, the world will become empty!" And the dancers sang in mournful tones.

In front of each of the dance instruments, too, they carried finely crafted jeweled caskets, fresh and lovely, all filled with powder of many kinds of fragrant, glittering flowers, and many other caskets, beautiful to behold, all filled with saffron powder. In front of these, too, they went carrying food enough for the Blessed One (the Buddha) together with his retinue, the Saṅgha of monks. All this food had been cooked over a small fire of red sandalwood, aloeswood and pine, and cooked with water from the Ganges River. It had sour, salty, sweet, astringent, pungent and bitter tastes, and it gave a fine complexion and did one good.

All the surroundings near the pair of sāla trees were spread with soft golden sand, and over it were laid cotton cloth, woolens, dyed woolens, cloth of mule hair, Kaliṅga cloth, and soft, white silk. The ground of that place, thirty-two yojanas all around, was smeared with saffron. Great lion thrones of gold were

set out for the Blessed One and the Saṅgha of monks, adorned and made radiant with the seven kinds of precious things, vast as Mount Meru and lofty. They were covered with coverings all fit for them. They were surrounded by curtains with netting from which came the tinkling of golden bells and chimes and a jingling sound. Canopies of great bolts of fine Chinese silk were stretched over them. White parasols shaded them from the sun, and white yak-tail whisks fanned them. They were furnished with backrests in which makaras were set on elephant tusks, and from their mouths came strings of pearls, white as the rays of the full moon, hanging down as tassels. The ground all about was strewn with a shower of fragrant flowers.

Each of those laymen, too, thought: "To all sentient beings, to those who want food I shall give food. To those who want drink I shall give drink. To those who want a head, eyes, or any limb or member of the body, I shall give it just as they wish. To the poor, the destitute and the needy, apart from gifts of sensual pleasure, poison, harm, and gifts given without discernment, I shall provide whatever each of them wants, to their satisfaction." That is what they thought, and they thought of nothing else.

In the same way, all those companies of spiritual friends who abide in the conduct of bodhisattvas thought: "I shall serve a meal to the Tathāgata, and then he will pass into complete nirvāṇa. I shall serve a meal to the Tathāgata, and then he will pass into complete nirvāṇa." Each of them held only this in their hearts. The hairs on all their limbs stood on end, red at the roots like the flowers of the lac tree. Their eyes filled with tears like blood. Overcome by the most painful feeling, they set out with their own offerings, firewood and kindling, chariots, victory banners, parasols and pennants, and carrying vessels prepared with the finest food they went to where the Blessed One was. Having arrived, they bowed their heads at the Blessed One's feet and worshipped the Blessed One with incense, flower garlands, powders, fine powders, parasols, victory banners, pennants and vast canopies. They circumambulated him a hundred thousand times. Shedding tears from their eyes without ceasing, like rain, and showing grief in many ways, they cried out in loud voices: "Alas, the world will become empty! Alas, the world will become empty!" Rolling about at the Tathāgata's feet like a porpoise out of water, they made their request:

"Blessed One, will the Tathāgata, together with his retinue, the Saṅgha of monks, consent to accept the meal I have prepared? Blessed One, out of love for me, may the Tathāgata please accept this final offering!"

So they requested. Then the Blessed One, though he knew all, remained silent. Even when they requested it a second time and a third time, the Blessed One remained silent a second time and a third time. Then those assemblies of laymen lost all hope and sat without saying a word. They became utterly miserable, like parents rolling about in grief when their only son has died and has just been left in the charnel ground. So all those laymen, overcome with the deepest grief, rose, gathered up their offerings, and sat down to one side.

At that time, moreover, there were the laywomen who had taken up the five bases of training, who were endowed with moral discipline, with right conduct and with good qualities, and who held the true Dharma dear: Splendor of Life, daughter of a merchant, and other laywomen as numerous as the grains of sand in three Ganges rivers. In female form, every one of them was certain to free many tens of millions of beings, and every one of them reviled the household life, reflecting:

"This body is a mass compounded of eighty-four harmful constituents.
This body is food for eighty-four tens of millions of kinds of worms.
This body reeks like a king's dungeon dug deep in the ground.
This body is soaked through with a stench worse than a rotting dog's corpse.
This body leaks filth from nine openings.
This body is plastered over with flesh, sinews, bones, blood and skin. It is like a palace-city: its hands and feet are outer gates, ramparts and battlements, its eyes are windows, its head is the pinnacle, and the mind dwells within like a king.
This body, shunned by all the wise and delighting the childish, is the haunt of rākṣasas, the tens of millions of afflictions such as attachment, aversion and delusion. Like a reed, a castor plant, foam or a plantain tree, it has no core. Like lightning, or the ripples of a torrent rushing down a steep mountain, it is utterly unstable.
Like an illusion, a mirage, an echo or the moon's reflection, it deceives. Like a tree on a riverbank undercut by water churned by a violent wind, it stands at the edge of a precipice. And since it is food for wolves, foxes, vultures and crows, who would take delight in bearing such a thing?
It might be possible to take up all the water of the ocean on the tip of a hair and pour it into a cow's hoofprint, but this body, tormented by four hundred and four diseases, has a lack of essence and an impurity that mere words cannot convey.
It might even be possible to use up this whole great earth by making it into

pellets the size of juniper-berry stones, or of mustard seeds, or of the tiniest atoms, but as long as this body exists, its faults will never come to an end. Therefore, to protect the true Dharma, it should be cast away like spittle."

So it was that all those laywomen had trained their minds by meditating on great emptiness, signlessness and wishlessness. Among them were the laywoman called Splendor of Life, the laywoman called Śrīmālā, the laywoman called Viśākhā, and others. All of them wished to hear the Great Vehicle, and they vowed, "Having heard it, we shall teach it to others." They devoted themselves to guarding it. Each of them meditated intensely, reviling the female body as wretched and reviling the body as without essence. All of them thought, "We shall destroy the wheel of saṃsāra." All of them vowed, "Having quenched our thirst with the Great Vehicle, we shall also quench the thirst of others." They thirsted for the Great Vehicle and were free of stinginess toward it. They wished to train in harmony with the whole world. All of them wished to train with the thought, "Having been liberated, we shall liberate others. Having crossed over, we shall carry others across. We shall keep the lineage of the Three Jewels from being cut off. We shall turn the wheel of Dharma." They had donned the great armor and were steadfast in their observance of the trainings. They were endowed with many good qualities, and every one of them had compassion for all beings, as one has for an only child.

They too, very early at sunrise, holding one another by the hand, carried twice as much sacrificial kindling as the laymen had, to build the Tathāgata's cremation pyre. Because the Blessed One had not accepted their food, they fell into the deepest suffering, as if their own child had died. Weeping, they rose and sat down to one side.

At that time, moreover, there were the Licchavi youths, Pure Stainless Essence and the rest, the Licchavi youths of Vaiśālī, both those living inside the city and those living outside it, together with the minor kings of Jambudvīpa and their ministers, as numerous as the grains of sand in four Ganges rivers. Every one of them was skilled in protecting the true Dharma, endowed with moral discipline, with right conduct and with good qualities, and was like a hailstorm to those who disparage the true Dharma and to those who bear the signs of renunciation but are corrupt. All of them held this aspiration: "Whatever wealth we have, our stores of grain, our treasuries and our storehouses, all of it exists to make the ambrosia inexhaustible and to make the ambrosia endure. We shall be diligent in the true Dharma. We shall cut out the tongues of those who disparage the true Dharma and hold wrong views." So they

solemnly vowed. They were resolved, thinking, "Those of corrupt discipline, who do not abide in moral discipline, we shall make wear white garments and set them to the work of householders." They vowed, "We shall serve those devoted to the true Dharma as we would serve a teacher." Though they had done everything to bring benefit and comfort to the Saṅgha, they did not think, "That is enough." They wished to hear the Great Vehicle and were steadfast in their vow, "Having heard it, we shall teach it to others." Every one of them was endowed with these and countless other good qualities.

Among them were the Licchavi youth called Pure Stainless Essence, the one called Purified of Obscurations, the one called Given by the Stainless Waters of the Ganges, and others. These Licchavi youths too held one another by the hand. Each of them carried, as fuel for building the cremation pyre, the finest pine, sandalwood and aloeswood, eight hundred and forty million pieces of sacrificial kindling, and offerings twice as great as those before. Proclaiming their offerings, they went before the Blessed One. Each Licchavi youth was furnished with eighty-four thousand elephants, eighty-four thousand horses, eighty-four thousand chariots and eighty-four thousand crystal jewels. Before each elephant were carried parasols befitting its greatness, victory banners, pennants and great silk canopies. Even the smallest of the parasols measured a full league in circumference.

Even the smallest of the great silk canopies was thirty-two yojanas wide. Even the shortest of the victory banners was a hundred yojanas tall. Even the shortest of the pennants reached a thousand yojanas. So they went before the Blessed One (the Buddha) with these offerings, bowed their heads at his feet, and offered him food, but the Blessed One said nothing at all. Since he did not accept it, they were filled with the deepest sorrow. Their hopes cut off, they rose and, through the power of the Blessed One, were lifted up to the height of seven palm trees, and there they remained.

Then, too, at that time ministers, merchants and householders of Jambudvīpa, as many as the grains of sand in five Ganges Rivers, came there as well. Every one of them had faith in the Great Vehicle, possessed pure moral discipline, rites and virtues, and was like a hailstorm to those who disparage the true Dharma. Among them were the king of householders called Vairocana, one called Jagatpāla, one called Dharmapāla, and others. All of them too outshone the earlier offerings with their own offerings and worshipped the Blessed One with a vast array of offerings. But because he did not accept their food, they were filled with the deepest sorrow. Their hopes cut off, they rose and, through

the power of the Blessed One, were lifted up to the height of seven palm trees, and there they remained.

Then, too, at that time, apart from King Ajātaśatru, the king of Vaiśālī, Stainless Moon Essence, together with his attendants living inside the city and outside it, and the kings of all the cities, mountain villages, great provinces and valleys of Jambudvīpa, as many as the grains of sand in six Ganges Rivers, came with their fourfold armies. Each of these kings had eighteen million soldiers. They had elephants whose temples constantly dripped with musth, and horses swifter than the force of the wind. Their offerings, too, were twice as fine and twice as plentiful as those earlier offerings. Bearing such choice offerings, they came with their fourfold armies. Among their offerings, even the shortest parasol covered an area eighty yojanas wide. Even the smallest pennant reached a hundred thousand yojanas. Even an ordinary victory banner was thirty yojanas tall.

Thus Stainless Moon Essence, king of Vaiśālī, the one called Sunlight, and the other kings arrived at sunrise. They too were like a hailstorm to those who disparage the true Dharma and to the corrupt ones who bear the outward signs of renunciants. By their power they established beings in the true Dharma. Every one of them thought, "Whatever wealth, stores of grain, treasuries and storehouses we have are for the sake of preserving the true Dharma." Every one of them had firmly vowed, "We shall strive earnestly for the true Dharma. We shall cut out at the root the tongues of those who disparage the true Dharma." Every one of them longed for the Great Vehicle and was loving toward the whole world. Their offerings filled the entire region from Vaiśālī to the city of Kuśinagara. Because the shade of their parasols overlapped like scales, the light of the sun did not strike the ground. The fragrance of their food spread for four yojanas. Each of them begged the Blessed One three times to accept the food he had prepared, but he did not accept it, and they were unhappy. They rose and sat down to one side.

Then, too, at that time, apart from the queen of King Ajātaśatru, the queen of the king of Vaiśālī, Beauty of the Three Worlds, and the wives of the kings, merchants and householders of Jambudvīpa, as many as the grains of sand in seven Ganges Rivers, came there. Every one of them, in a woman's form, surely liberated many beings; each was constantly engaged in contemplation of the body, and each had a mind purified by the great emptiness, signlessness and wishlessness. Among them were the queen of the king of Vaiśālī called Beauty of the Three Worlds, the queen called Priyaṅku, and

others. Every one of them had compassion for all beings, as one has for an only child. Holding one another by the hand, they carried fragrant kindling wood with which to light the Tathāgata's funeral pyre. With their own offerings they outshone all the earlier offerings and made offerings to the Blessed One twice as great. The height and breadth of the victory banners, pennants and parasols among their offerings were more than double those that came before. The fragrance of their food spread for eight yojanas. They bowed to the Blessed One and begged him to accept the food, but he did not accept it. Then they circumambulated the Blessed One, tearing out their hair and scattering their ornaments, weeping with harsh cries, filled with the deepest sorrow, like a mother whose only child has died. Through the power of the Blessed One, they sat down to one side right beside the twin sāla trees.

Then, too, at that time, hosts of gods, as many as the grains of sand in eight Ganges Rivers, led by the god called Wide Eyes, came there, and those gods spoke these words:

"Friends, look! Friends, look! The offerings that humans have brought are supremely excellent, and they wish to make every kind of offering and honor to the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha. Because he is to accept the last meal from humans, they are making their request to the Blessed One. Friends, we too should each make offerings to the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, and should present him with a meal at the very end. If only the Tathāgata would partake of the food that we offer, and then pass into parinirvāṇa! Friends, the appearance of a buddha is extremely rare. Rarer still is the consummate perfection of giving that is the gift of the last meal. Alas, if the Blessed One passes into parinirvāṇa, the world will become empty!"

All those gods longed to hear the Great Vehicle, and had vowed, "Having heard it, we shall teach it to others." They had vowed, "Having quenched our own thirst with the Great Vehicle, we shall quench the thirst of others who thirst." They yearned for the Great Vehicle. They had no miserliness concerning the Great Vehicle, and no jealousy, arrogance, concealment or deceit concerning it. To beings who repudiate the Great Vehicle they were like a hailstorm. They had taken up the moral discipline of guarding the true Dharma. They wished to train in harmony with the world. They wished to train with the thought, "Having crossed over, we shall ferry others across. Having been freed, we shall free others. We shall turn the wheel of Dharma. We shall keep the lineage of the Three Jewels from being cut off." They had donned the

great armor, were steadfast in their vows concerning the trainings, and were likewise endowed with immeasurable qualities. Every one of them looked upon the whole world with compassion, as one treats an only child.

They too, at daybreak, in order to build the funeral pyre for the Teacher's parinirvāṇa, brought firewood and sacrificial kindling. All of it was divine substance, twice as fine as the kindling offered by those before them, fragrant, delightful, and rare among humans. Their chariots were yoked to the finest swift horses, covered with white silk, of a form and shape that could not even be depicted in a drawing, and surrounded by curtains hung with nets of bells and little bells. Vast canopies of silk, like great mansions, were raised on patterned poles. Dancers and delightful music led the way before them. They had arranged many delicious foods, and lion thrones with backrests of beryl whose crests were lit by the radiance of jewels, along with footstools made of gold. The ground, too, was adorned with all kinds of sweetly fragrant flowers, with loose blossoms strewn and set in order. Every one of them was followed by the fourfold army.

Each of them, unable to hold back tears like blood and tormented by the utmost suffering, went to the Blessed One for the benefit and happiness of all beings and out of compassion for them, and for the sake of those to be trained, so that there would be explained the supreme secret of the Great Vehicle, the manner of the Dharma door of the many kinds of words spoken with hidden intent concerning the aspects of emptiness. They bowed their heads at the feet of the Blessed One, made many kinds of supreme offerings and honors, and circumambulated him. For the sake of the Blessed One's retinue they spread their own upper garments on the ground. They tore off and scattered their own ornaments, tore at their own hair, wept with harsh voices, and with one voice addressed the Blessed One thus:

"Blessed One, please partake of the food we have prepared, and then pass into parinirvāṇa."

Though they made this request twice and three times, the Blessed One did not accept and said nothing. Losing hope, they rose and sat down to one side.

Furthermore, at that time the nāga kings dwelling in the four directions, the son of the nāga king Vāsuki, Nanda, Upananda and others, nāga kings as numerous as the grains of sand in nine Ganges rivers, came in great haste at daybreak, bringing offerings, each in keeping with his own wealth, that surpassed even the offerings of the gods twofold. They went to the Blessed

One, bowed down, and requested him to accept their meal. But it did not turn out as they had hoped, so they rose and sat down to one side.

Furthermore, at that time Vaiśravaṇa and the other lords of the yakṣas, together with their servants and retinues, as numerous as the grains of sand in ten Ganges rivers, holding on to one another, outshone the earlier offerings of the nāga kings with their own offerings. They set out with a great host and arrived, bowed to the Blessed One, and requested him to accept their meal. But the Blessed One did not accept their meal, and so, displeased, they rose and sat down to one side.

Furthermore, at that time the garuḍa king called Friend of Foes and other garuḍa kings, as numerous as the grains of sand in twenty Ganges rivers, outshone with their own offerings the offerings of the yakṣa kings who came before. They bowed to the Blessed One and requested him to accept their meal. But he did not accept their meal, and so, displeased, they rose and sat down to one side.

Furthermore, at that time the son of Naradatta, lord of the gandharvas, and other lords of the gandharvas, as numerous as the grains of sand in thirty Ganges rivers, came bringing offerings far more excellent than all the earlier offerings. They made offerings to the Tathāgata, played all manner of sweet music, bowed down, and requested the Blessed One to accept their meal. But the Blessed One did not accept, and they too became displeased, rose, and sat down to one side.

Furthermore, at that time Sudarśana, lord of the kinnaras, and other lords of the kinnaras, as numerous as the grains of sand in forty Ganges rivers, arrived. The offering of each one of them surpassed even all those earlier offerings combined. But he did not accept their meal either, and so, displeased, they sat down to one side.

Furthermore, at that time Mahāsudarśana, lord of the mahoragas, and other lords of the mahoragas, as numerous as the sands of fifty Ganges rivers, brought offerings twice as great as the previous ones. As before, the Blessed One did not accept their food, and, dejected, they sat down to one side.

Furthermore, at that time Śambara, lord of the asuras, and other lords of the asuras, as numerous as the sands of sixty Ganges rivers, huge in body and of great radiance, every one of them free of the asuras' hostile disposition, came bringing offerings, each twice as great as the one before. They bowed to the Blessed One. When he did not accept their food, they became dejected, rose,

and sat down near the twin sāla trees, lighting them up with their own splendor.

Furthermore, at that time the lord of the dānavas, Anudatta of the Stainless Waters of the Ganges, and other dānavas, as numerous as the sands of seventy Ganges rivers, huge in body and of great radiance, every one of them free of the dānavas' disposition, brought offerings twice and twice again finer than all the previous offerings. As before, the Blessed One did not accept their food, and, dejected, they lit up the space between the twin sāla trees with their own splendor and sat down to one side.

Furthermore, at that time Bhīṣaṇa, lord of the rākṣasas, and other lords of the rākṣasas, as numerous as the sands of eighty Ganges rivers, every one of them free of the rākṣasas' disposition, lit up the area near the twin sāla trees with masses of great splendor, bowed to the Blessed One, and sat down to one side.

Furthermore, at that time Scent Keeper, lord of the fruit trees, and other lords of the fruit trees, as numerous as the sands of ninety Ganges rivers, brought hosts of offerings exceeding all the previous offerings twice and twice again. They adorned the ground with thickets of many creepers covered in shining flowers, alive with rutting male cuckoos and humming bees, and with unfolding leaves, and sat down to one side.

Furthermore, at that time Mahāmāya, king of the vidyādharas, and other kings of the vidyādharas, as numerous as the sands of a thousand Ganges rivers, brought offerings more than twice as great as the previous ones and sat down to one side.

Furthermore, at that time Sudarśanā and other goddesses who take any form they wish, as numerous as the sands of ten million Ganges rivers, brought offerings more than twice as great as those of the queens of the king of Vaiśālī. They heaped their own ornaments on the ground before the Blessed One and sat down to one side.

Furthermore, at that time Rambhā, Urvaśī, and other daughters of the gods, as numerous as the sands of a billion Ganges rivers, presented offerings far more abundant and splendid than twice and twice again the previous ones, and, as before, sat down to one side.

Furthermore, at that time the host of bhūtas called Revolving Like Venus and others, as numerous as the sands of ten billion Ganges rivers, sat down to one

side as before.

Furthermore, at that time the sons of the gods of the four world protectors, together with as many as the sands of a hundred thousand koṭis of Ganges rivers, brought offerings exceeding twice and twice again the previous ones. They bowed to the Blessed One and begged him to accept their food, but the Blessed One did not accept it, and as before they sat down to one side.

Furthermore, at that time the four wind gods, gods who send forth the winds, together with as many as the sands of a hundred thousand koṭis of Ganges rivers, even out of season adorned the ground with trees, creepers, spreading trees, woodlands, ears of grain, flowering creepers, and coral, and made the glories of the flowers of every season flourish in all directions. With unfolding leaves and red roots they made the twin sāla trees look as though bathed in the yellow rays of the rising sun. Bringing offerings more than twice as great as the previous ones, they made offerings to the Blessed One and, as before, sat down near the twin sāla trees.

Furthermore, at that time the gods who send down the rain, as numerous as the sands of the Ganges, followed by great clouds and herons, poured down from amid flickering lightning streams of rain blue as a peacock's throat. With clouds slowly rumbling thunder, they rained down flowers mingled with a cool drizzle. They bowed to the Blessed One, and when he did not accept their food, they lost hope, and in order to put out the fire that would be kindled for the cremation of the Tathāgata's remains, they stayed right there in the sky.

Furthermore, at that time the perfume elephants Rāhu, Lungtang Hue, Clear Honey Hue, Fragrant with All Desires, and other perfume elephants, as numerous as the sands of twenty Ganges rivers, every one of them devoted to the Great Vehicle, because the Teacher was passing into complete nirvāṇa, pulled up with the tips of their trunks again and again, and carried, herbs of the snow mountains, lotus roots, and stalks each as large as the wheel of a great chariot, and, from great wildernesses, lotuses, blue lotuses, white water lilies, white lotuses, roots, fruits, and many different kinds of pebbles. Swifter even than the force of the wind, trumpeting like summer thunder, they came with great speed. They arranged hangings of plucked lotus petals on the lion throne, made offerings to the Blessed One, and when he did not accept their food, they lost hope and sat down to one side.

Furthermore, at that time the lion called Lion's Roar and other lions, as numerous as the sands of thirty Ganges rivers, every one of them a giver of

fearlessness to all sentient beings, with the great prowess of lions carried flowers and fruits just as the great perfume elephants had, came swiftly, and sat down to one side.

Furthermore, at that time geese, cranes, ruddy shelducks, kādamba geese, zalmo birds, wild geese, cuckoos, bālikas, kalaviṅkas, jīvaṃjīvaka pheasants, and others likewise carried flowers and fruits just as the great perfume elephants had, uttered their own cries, and sat down to one side.

Furthermore, at that time all the cows, buffalo cows and nanny goats on the face of the earth, their udders full of milk, came there in great haste. Near the twin sāla trees they saw a hollow, and into it they let flow, from their milk-filled udders, milk unmixed with grit, sand or salt and free of any taint of heat. They removed the flies from the milk and settled to one side.

Furthermore, at that time the sage Kṣāntivādin and the other sages dwelling in the four continents, all possessed of the five higher knowledges and all devoted to the Great Vehicle, as many as the sands of an immense multitude of Ganges Rivers, came by the power of their own miraculous abilities, carrying kindling for the fire offering and food. They bowed to the Blessed One and settled to one side.

Furthermore, at that time, apart from some of the Saṅgha of monks, such as Mahākāśyapa, and the elder Ānanda and others, every monk and nun living throughout the land came there, without a single exception.

Furthermore, at that time Mount Meru and the other great mountains, together with the mountains in the spaces between the world systems, as many as the sands of countless Ganges Rivers, also came there. They had trees and many creepers giving shade from the heat of the sun, spacious rocks casting broad shade, and streams of water pouring down from the cliffs, and they were filled with valleys of medicinal herbs, pebbles, roots and fruits. The great assemblies of the mighty sons of the gods, together with Mount Meru, also came to make offerings, bowed to the Blessed One, and settled to one side.

Furthermore, at that time the mighty sons of the gods of great radiance who dwell in the four great oceans and in the great rivers, as many as the sands of countless Ganges Rivers, sent ahead of them offerings twice as beautiful as the earlier ones. Just as the light of the sun outshines the light of a lamp, so their own radiance outshone the light of the sun. Just as the light of the rising sun makes all the leaves of the aśoka tree glow a brilliant red, so their own radiance made the waters of the Hiraṇyavatī River glow a brilliant red. They

bowed to the Blessed One and settled to one side.

Furthermore, at that time the sky between the city of Kuśinagara and the twin sāla trees grew thick with mansions like the peaks of the king of mountains, every one of them white as swan's down. The ground was filled with parks and with ponds adorned with lotuses, more beautiful even than the parks of Uttarakuru in the north. In short, it became like the Nandana Grove and the Caitraratha Grove. Yet although those places appeared so delightful, the gods, asuras and humans wept bitterly, because the Tathāgata was about to pass into parinirvāṇa.

Furthermore, at that time the gods of the realm of the Four Great Kings said this to their retinues:
"Friends, look! Friends, look! The offerings that gods, asuras and humans make to the Tathāgata are truly exceptional, and they are striving to offer the Tathāgata his last meal. Friends, we too shall each make offerings to the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha. We shall also offer him his last meal. If the Blessed One accepts the last meal offered by us, through that we will attain the great perfection of generosity."

Having spoken thus, they set out with countless multitudes of attendants, carrying offerings twice those that had come before, and abundant food. They also carried many flowers: māndāravas and great māndāravas, kekerukas and great kekerukas, mañjūṣakas and great mañjūṣakas, santānakas and great santānakas, radiant flowers and great radiant flowers, all-radiant flowers, flowers of boundless light, lovely flowers and great lovely flowers, delight-giving flowers and great delight-giving flowers, supremely fragrant flowers and great supremely fragrant flowers, flowers of wafting scent and great flowers of wafting scent, flowers of all-pervading scent and great flowers of all-pervading scent, flowers of boundless scent and great flowers of boundless scent, petals of divine substance, river flowers, and pārijātas, and other such flowers as well. They went to where the Blessed One was, and just as the brilliance of the sun outshines the glow of fireflies, so their own splendor outshone the light of all others. But the Blessed One did not accept their food, and they settled to one side.

Furthermore, at that time Śakra (Indra), lord of the gods, together with his retinue of the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three, carried offerings twice the earlier ones: many kinds of flowers found in their heaven and suited to the occasion, pleasing flowers, greatly pleasing flowers, and sweet-scented

flowers. They also emanated great mansions, white as lime, with flights of stairs and many rows of windows where pigeons played. They went to where the Blessed One was, bowed their heads at the Blessed One's feet, and to one side, with palms joined, bowed and said this to the Blessed One:
"Blessed One, since we are the guardians of the collection of the Great Vehicle sūtras, out of compassion for us please accept the food we offer."
Although they made this request, he did not accept their food, and they settled to one side.

The second section.

After that, the six classes of gods who dwell in the desire realm came in succession, filling the sky above with offerings and with light that far surpassed what had come before, and went to where the Blessed One was. Among their offerings, even the ordinary parasols each measured in circumference the full extent of the four continents.

Their ordinary banners, too, reached to the edges of the four great oceans, stretching from the eastern ocean to the western ocean. When the wind stirred them, or the wind lifted them, sweet sounds came forth from those banners, like the melodious music of a lute swirling within. They bowed to the Blessed One and asked him to accept their food. But the Blessed One said nothing, so they lost hope and sat down to one side.

Then all the other beings of the successively higher realms, except those born at the Peak of Existence, came with great quantities of vast offerings in order to make offerings to the Blessed One, and, as the others had, they sat down to one side.

Brahmā, lord of the Sahā world, surrounded and preceded by countless gods of the Brahmakāyika realm, outshone with his own splendor the splendor of all the gods. Bearing a great quantity of offerings, he went before the Blessed One. Their ordinary banners hung down from the world of Brahmā and reached all the way to the twin sāla trees. He too asked the Blessed One to accept his food, but the Blessed One did not accept it, and he sat down to one side.

Then Vemacitrin, lord of the asuras, together with a countless retinue of asura servants, with his own light dimmed the light of every god in between, except for Brahmā and Indra. Bringing a quantity of offerings suited to the occasion, and food suited to the occasion, he went before the Blessed One. His ordinary parasol was broad enough to cover a small world system. He too asked the Blessed One to accept his food, but the Blessed One did not accept it, and he

rose and remained to one side.

Then Māra the Evil One, with a retinue of countless consorts, threw open all the gates of all the hells and gave the beings there water, food, and whatever else they wanted. He said to them, "Recollect the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha! Rejoice in the final offering!" And he comforted them, saying, "May you be happy!" Into the cities of the hells, full of weapons and blazing with great fire, he also poured down great waters like a great cloud, so that the hell beings felt a bliss they had never known before. Through the power of the Tathāgata, Māra's state of mind had become like this.

His retinue, too, all cast away their many kinds of weapons: bows, swords, hammers, axes, single-pointed vajras, kampana weapons, iron clubs, iron arrows, śataghnīs, arrows, javelins, single-pointed spears, and the like, and they devoted themselves to the Dharma.

His offerings were such as the earlier gods had not had. His ordinary parasol, in breadth, was as wide as a medium world system. Thus, endowed with great might, and fanned by his consorts with yak-tail whisks, he went to where the Blessed One was. He bowed his head at the Blessed One's feet, joined his palms, and said:

"Blessed One, together with the Saṅgha of monks and the assembly, please accept the food that we offer. Blessed One, from now on we wish to make a vow for the sake of the Great Vehicle. Whenever any son or daughter of good family teaches the Great Vehicle, whether out of fear, or out of desire for gain and honor, or in hope of attainment, or because others urge them to, or to spare the feelings of others, for their sake I wish to proclaim a secret mantra that dispels all fear and all unhappiness:

tadyathā ṭhagke ṭaṭara ṭhagke rorure mahārorure ālamāla tāla svāhā

I have spoken this secret mantra on my own pledge in order to give confidence in the way of the Dharma to preachers of the Dharma who are troubled by confusion and fear, to intoxicate the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), to protect the true Dharma, and to protect myself and others. Those who recite it as a protective dhāraṇī-mantra amid the dangers of elephants, of thickets, of rivers, or of fire, by the mere recitation, just as a tortoise protects its own body, I shall protect from all those dangers, without guile or deceit. And since I will also make them powerful, Blessed One, please now accept this food." So he urged.

Then the Blessed One spoke thus to Māra the Evil One: "Evil One, do not make requests for the sake of food. These words of secret mantra, being for the benefit of all sentient beings, become a gift of Dharma, and so I accept them. A gift of material things is not like that. So, Evil One, do not make requests." Having said this, the Blessed One fell silent.

Two and three times, Māra and the daughters of Māra made their request to the Blessed One, but he did not accept. Losing hope, they sat down to one side.

Then at that time the god Maheśvara (Śiva), preceded by countless gods of immeasurable might, with his own light made the lights of Brahmā, Indra lord of the gods, the asuras, and Māra lose their brightness, like lumps of ink. Carrying vast offerings for the Blessed One, more than double and double again, he went there. Among his offerings, his ordinary parasol was broad enough to cover the great trichiliocosm. Sending such offerings ahead, he went before the Blessed One, circumambulated him many times, and bowed his head at his feet. Then, standing to the side of where the Blessed One was, with joined palms and bowing, he spoke thus to the Blessed One:

"My making offerings to the Blessed One is like a fly making offerings. Because I am like a fly, how could I have the strength to make offerings to the Blessed One? Even so, Blessed One, out of compassion for me, please accept this last meal."

Twice and three times he made this request, yet twice and three times the Blessed One remained silent. His hope cut off, he rose and sat down to one side.

Then, at that time, far to the east of this buddhafield, beyond world systems as numerous as the sands of countless myriads of Ganges rivers, there was a world system called Mind-Captivating Unceasing Sweet Sound. There dwelt the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha called Equal to Space. He addressed his eldest son, the śrāvaka Infinite Great Body:

"Son of noble family, go to the world system of Endurance. There the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha called Śākyamuni will before long pass into parinirvāṇa. Son of noble family, for his sake take wholesome, delicious food from this world system and go. Take great offerings as well, and say this to him: 'May the Tathāgata, the Blessed One, partake of this food and then pass into parinirvāṇa.' Whatever doubts and uncertainties you have, ask that very Tathāgata about them properly, and

he will answer you."

Then the bodhisattva mahāsattva Infinite Great Body said, "Excellent! Excellent!" He circumambulated that Tathāgata and bowed his head at his feet. Then, surrounded and preceded by countless bodhisattva mahāsattvas of great body, he came here to the world system of Endurance.

Then, at that time, this great trichiliocosm moved and moved violently, shook and shook violently, was agitated and violently agitated, whirled and whirled violently, rumbled and rumbled violently, crackled and crackled violently, flashed and flashed violently, swayed and swayed violently. In these and other ways the great earth quaked violently.

Then, within that assembly, the gods, Brahmā, Indra, the world guardians, the asuras, Maheśvara (Śiva) and the rest, saw the ground behave in this way and shuddered. Terrified, their mouths and throats dry, they made ready to flee. Their own radiance could no longer be seen, and their light faded.

Then, from within that same assembly, Mañjuśrī, in youthful form, rose and spoke these words to that host of gods:

"Friends, do not be afraid! Do not be afraid! Far to the east, beyond world systems as numerous as the countless finest particles of the sands of countless myriads of Ganges rivers, there is a world system called Mind-Captivating Unceasing Sweet Sound. There the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha called Equal to Space now dwells, lives and abides. That Tathāgata called his eldest son, a śrāvaka, and said to him: 'Son of noble family, go to the world system of Endurance. There the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha called Śākyamuni is about to pass into parinirvāṇa. Offer the last meal to him and to the Saṅgha of monks. Whatever doubts and uncertainties you have, ask about them properly, and he will answer you.' That Blessed One sent this bodhisattva mahāsattva Infinite Great Body, and he has come here, surrounded and preceded by countless bodhisattvas. It is by his splendor that your light has faded. Rejoice in his coming! And look at the offerings that the Tathāgata Equal to Space makes to our Tathāgata!"

Then that whole assembly, as if seeing their own reflections in the surface of a mirror, saw that Tathāgata dwelling in a distant world system, and that world system as well.

Then Mañjuśrī, in youthful form, spoke these words to the assembly: "Just as you see this world system and this Tathāgata, so also look at the tathāgatas of the ten directions and the other world systems. Such is the greatness of the tathāgatas: even while remaining in their own abodes, they show their faces to you."

The assembly said, "Alas! Even a tathāgata of such greatness will pass into parinirvāṇa! Alas!" And they sat there in dejection.

Then they also saw the bodhisattva mahāsattva Infinite Great Body surrounded by immeasurable bodhisattvas. From every single pore of that bodhisattva's body a great lotus emerged. Each great lotus held seventy-eight thousand cities, and every one of those cities was as large as the land of Vaiśālī. Each was encircled in succession by seven walls and seven moats of the seven precious substances, and each was adorned in succession with seven rows of palm trees. They were prosperous, flourishing and happy, and full of joy. Those walls were all surrounded by great parapets of Jambū River gold, and between all the parapets grew many kinds of young trees bearing fruit and flowers. When the branches of those trees were stirred by the wind, there arose sounds, sweet and delightful like cymbals, charming and enchanting, five kinds of sound from each, and by those sounds the beings there played, rejoiced and took their delight.

All those moats were filled with cool water, clear as crystal, and within them, all around, those beings roamed joyfully in boats of jewels. Those waters were adorned with lotuses, blue lotuses and white water lilies, every one as large as a chariot wheel.

The perimeter all around the moats was also adorned with rows of parks, and in each park there were five ponds, each half a yojana square. The waters of those ponds were covered entirely with lotuses, blue lotuses (utpalas), and white water lilies (kumudas), of many colors and sweet fragrance, each as large as a chariot wheel, and they were adorned with rows of trees in full bloom. All around the parks, geese, ducks, and cranes savored the stamens of the lotuses. In each of those surrounding parks there were also houses, and each house had water four yojanas wide. Their walls were made of gold, silver, beryl, and crystal, and their floors of cat's-eye gem. All of them were lofty mansions hung with pearl necklaces, interspersed with jewel tassels and made radiant by them, adorned with great golden porticoes, windows, and latticework, with floors spread with golden sand. The ponds, too, all had

walkways with golden stairways of eighteen steps, and all held water fragrant with divine sandalwood, adorned along their edges with rows of golden plantain trees.

Within each of those great cities there were eighty-four thousand kings. All of them were surrounded by countless, countless hosts of women, and, endowed with the five qualities of sensual pleasure, they played, rejoiced, and enjoyed themselves in delight. Other beings, too, were just the same: in other places, where the ground was as pleasant to the touch as kācalindi cloth, sprinkled with sandalwood water and strewn with scattered flowers, they played, rejoiced, and enjoyed themselves in delight. In those great cities there was no sound of any other vehicle, only the sound of the Great Vehicle.

On those great lotuses, too, were great lion thrones with legs made of gold, silver, beryl, and crystal, covered with cloth of Kaliṅga, befitting greatness, and entirely draped with the finest things in the three worlds. Those kings sat upon those lion thrones, and other beings studied the sūtras of the Great Vehicle. Before those kings, some wrote out the letters, some read, and some learned to recite.

Thus, although those beings seated on the lotuses that had grown from the pores of the bodhisattva mahāsattva Boundless Great Body possessed the joys of the five qualities of sensual pleasure, they gave them up entirely. Tormented by grief, they lamented, crying out, "Alas, alas!", and sat presenting hosts of offerings twice as great.

Then the bodhisattva mahāsattva Boundless Great Body, surrounded by countless bodhisattvas, displaying such forms of splendor, came bearing great hosts of offerings and the most abundant food. Whoever perceived the fragrance of that food and of those lotuses became free of the afflictions. Through the great power of the bodhisattva, all the world systems became visible. The size of the body of the bodhisattva mahāsattva Boundless Great Body was equal to space, so that no one could see it.

Then the bodhisattva mahāsattva Boundless Great Body went before the Blessed One, the Buddha, bowed his head at his feet, joined his palms, and said, "May the Blessed One please accept the food that I offer." Then the Blessed One remained silent. Although he requested a second and a third time, the Blessed One remained silent, and so that bodhisattva rose and sat down to one side.

In the same way, from the south, the west, and the north as well, there came bodhisattva mahāsattvas called Boundless Great Body, each with a great retinue. The size of their lotuses and cities was in each case twice as great as the one before, and they came equipped with splendor that was in each case twice as great. Having arrived there, they made offerings of lotuses to the Blessed One and, as before, sat down to one side.

In that very place at the foot of the twin sāla trees, across ground the extent of thirty-two maṇḍalas, there was no space at all where beings were not seated. There, those bodhisattva mahāsattvas with such great bodies, together with their own attendants, sat: some in a space the size of the tip of a reed, some in a space the size of the point of a needle, and some sat at ease in a space the size of an atom. The bodhisattvas who dwell in world systems as numerous as the particles of atoms also came in that same manner and sat down.

Of the beings of Jambudvīpa, apart from the venerable Kāśyapa, the elder Ānanda, and King Ajātaśatru, there was no one who did not come there. Even cruel people, venomous snakes, scorpions, spiders, and the like, down to those who practice the sixteen cruel occupations, came there. The dānavas and the asuras, who are always of hostile intent, all gave up their evil deeds and came to regard one another as a son, a mother, or a sister. All the beings dwelling in the great trichiliocosm loved one another as one would an only son, except for the icchantikas, those of great desire.

This Sahā world system, too, through the power of the Tathāgata, became free of clods, stones, gravel, pebbles and thorns. It was filled with trees entwined with jeweled vines, soft and smooth to the touch, and it became like the world system Sukhāvatī. All the beings who had gathered there, while remaining where they were, saw world systems as numerous as the particles of atoms, together with other buddha fields full of splendor, just as one's own reflection appears on the surface of a mirror.

Then the rays of light of many colors that had come forth from the Tathāgata's mouth, blue, yellow, red, white, crimson, crystal-colored and flame-like, did everything they had to do. Then they turned back, entered the Blessed One's own mouth and vanished. Their radiance outshone the light of the entire assembly.

Then the world with its gods, humans and asuras saw those rays vanish into the Blessed One's mouth. They were frightened, and their hair stood on end. "It cannot be that the Blessed One's rays would turn back and vanish without a

cause. Without a doubt, their tasks in the ten directions are complete, and now the Tathāgata will surely pass into parinirvāṇa. If the Blessed One accepts food from no one at all, alas, has he abandoned the four immeasurables toward all beings? Has he resolved to remain fasting? Alas, have the sun and moon set? Has the ship of the sacred Dharma sunk? Alas, alas!" So they sat, lamenting.

Then they wounded their own limbs, and their blood turned the ground to mud. The Hiraṇyavatī River, too, flowed with blood.

Then, from among that assembly, the layman called Cunda, a smith's son from the city of Kuśinagara, rose together with fifteen smiths' sons. He composed his bearing, looked upon the world, draped his upper robe over one shoulder and set his right knee on the ground. He bowed with palms joined in the direction of the Blessed One, and, unable to hold back his tears, he bowed at his feet and said to the Blessed One:

"Blessed One, in order to deliver all beings without fail, I wish to offer the last meal to the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, together with the Saṅgha of monks. I have no protector, no support and no refuge. Since I am destitute and full of hope, I beg the Blessed One to accept the meal I offer and not to pass into parinirvāṇa.

"Blessed One, it is like this. Suppose some very poor householder or brahmin goes to another country. Rousing his enthusiasm, he gradually takes up farming. With a strong plow ox yoked to the plow, he clears his field of stones, pebbles and thorns, and then, full of great hope, he waits for rain to fall from a great cloud. In the same way, Blessed One, in the field of the body, with the plow ox of mind and speech free of the three faults and the four, and with the plow of knowledge, I have cleared away the stones, pebbles and thorns of the many kinds of afflictions, and now I wait for the rain of Dharma to fall from your great cloud of Dharma. When I invite you together with the Saṅgha of monks, then, to dispel my poverty and to benefit all beings, please accept the meal I offer. Since I have no protector and no refuge, I beg the Tathāgata to look upon me as he looks upon Rāhula."

Then the Blessed One, the omniscient Victor, the unsurpassed person, said to Cunda the smith's son, "Cunda, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha accepts your last meal, the great perfection of generosity."

Then those gods, humans and asuras heard that the Tathāgata, together with the Saṅgha of monks, had accepted the last meal offered by Cunda, the great perfection of generosity. They were filled with wonder and amazement, cried

out loudly, "Excellent! Excellent!" and said to Cunda the smith's son:

"O Cunda, smith's son, how fortunate you are! Your gaining a human body has borne fruit. You have gained it well. Cunda, in this world, beauty like that of the udumbara flower is hard to find. Far harder than that is to find the appearance of a tathāgata. Harder still is to find faith. Far harder still is to find the chance to hear the Dharma. And far harder still is to find the chance to offer the last meal to the Tathāgata. Therefore, Cunda, smith's son, you who have attained the perfection of giving the last meal, we bow to you. When, on the full moon of the middle autumn month, the sky is without clouds and one sees the stainless, beautiful disk of the moon, only the moon is plainly visible. In the same way, because the Tathāgata has accepted the last meal you offered, you alone are plainly visible to all beings. We bow to you again and again. Cunda, though you have a human body, you are a god even among gods. You are like Rāhula, the son of the Tathāgata."

Having said this, they also spoke these verses:

"You are not a human; you are a supreme god,
Chief and best of humans, exceptionally noble.
Therefore we make this request of you:
The Teacher is about to pass into parinirvāṇa.
Cunda, out of love for all of us,
For the lasting benefit of beings,
Ask the Teacher here, the boundless protector,
To remain and teach the nectar without ceasing.
Freed from existence, he wishes to pass into nirvāṇa.
If you do not make the request today,
Know that all of us will be ruined.
So, for our benefit, make the request to the Protector."

Then, just as someone who sees both parents, who had died, come back to life and remain alive would be overjoyed, so too Cunda the smith's son was overjoyed. He stretched out his hands, bowed his head to the Blessed One, rose, and spoke these verses:

Oh! Today I have truly gained what is worth gaining.
My birth in the human world has borne its fruit.
Now I shall not be parted from gain and all the rest,
Nor shall I fall into the unbearable hells.
This great gain that I have gained here today

Surpasses even a heap of gold.
Since I have met the hero, the Sugata, the protector,
From now on I have no fear of an animal birth.
Faith in the Buddha, deep-rooted,
I have found today, like the udumbara flower.
I have wholly cast off the terrifying realm of the hungry ghosts,
And destroyed the dreadful seed of birth among the asuras.
To meet today the Tathāgata, whose coming is so rare,
Is like a mustard seed lodging on the point of a needle.
By offering him the supreme perfection of giving,
I shall always rise to the realm of the gods.
Like a lotus growing in water yet untouched by the water,
The great sage is untainted by worldly concerns;
By meeting him I have uprooted every seed of the peak of existence
And crossed, myself, the great ocean of saṃsāra.
Harder even than for a blind turtle in the ocean
To set its neck into the hole of a yoke,
Today I have met the Sugata and offered him a gift;
Thereby I have destroyed every accumulation of affliction.
Though the gods offered him fine food,
The Sugata did not accept it; from me
He accepted an offering like the eraṇḍa flower,
And so I am supreme in the world, endowed with glory and virtue.
Brahmā, Śakra (Indra), and all this world
Have come and reverently make offerings to me.
This attainment of the station of the bull among men
I have won in this very life.

Then, joining his palms, he said this to the Blessed One:

Protector, seeing you about to pass into nirvāṇa,
All this world is tormented by suffering.
Helplessly they cry aloud, "Alas!"
Do not forsake them; regard them always as your children.
Just as the lofty golden peak of Meru
Stands in beauty in the midst of the great ocean,
So you, lord of the Dharma, teaching the Dharma,
Please remain in beauty in the midst of the Saṅgha.

Just as, when the radiant sun has risen,
Its rays dispel the thin clouds,
So, great sage, with your great lamp of wisdom,
Dispel today the sorrow of the multitude.
These beings, their eyes swollen with weeping,
Have sunk to the depths of an ocean of sheer suffering.
Therefore engender in them the faith so hard to find,
Cut off their suffering, and remain for long.

Then the Blessed One said to Cunda: "Cunda, it is so. It is just so. The appearance of a buddha is as exceedingly hard to find as the udumbara flower. Faith too is hard to find. Hearing the Dharma too is hard to find. At the time of the Tathāgata's complete nirvāṇa, the perfect perfection of giving that is the last meal is also hard to find. Furthermore, Cunda, do not weep and do not grieve, but give rise to joy, thinking, 'I have attained the perfect perfection of giving, the last meal offered to the Tathāgata.' And do not make this request to the Tathāgata: 'Blessed One, please remain.' Realize the suchness of the Dharma of the buddhas. Enter into impermanence. Come to understand the nature of formations." Having said this, he spoke these verses:

Though life be very long, it will come to an end.
Here everyone will certainly die.
The world of the living is subject to destruction.
All prosperity inclines toward decline.
Youth is always surely overcome by age.
Fair form, free of illness, is destroyed by illness.
Life is torn out by the roots by death.
In all the world there is nothing permanent.
Power is impermanent, and life too is impermanent;
Beings forever turn upon the wheel of suffering.
In the three worlds there is nothing stable.
Within existence all beings cling to life.
Existence is subject to destruction and ever shaking;
Within it there is no happiness at all.
The fear of aging, death, sickness and decline
Torments them always on every side.
Existence is endless, unstable, without essence;
Know all of it to be foe and adversary.

Circling there, by the net of afflictions
The world is wrapped, like a silkworm.
In the world, that constant ground of harm,
Ever bound up with suffering like a tumor,
In this impure body and in those desires,
Who that seeks his good and wishes to be rid of suffering would delight?
There is no attachment to impermanent desires;
By proper reflection one is freed from desire.
Then, seeing rightly, one is parted from desire;
Having abandoned and cut them off, one becomes liberated.
I have crossed well the great river of existence.
I have passed beyond sufferings and entered into bliss.
Therefore I, infinite and free of elaboration,
Have cleared away all attachment and attained liberation.
For me there is no aging, sickness or death.
For me life never comes to an end.
Though I shall go, blazing like a fire,
Do not think that I shall cease to be.
See the Tathāgata as being like Meru.
Today I shall truly pass into nirvāṇa.
That supreme bliss is my true nature;
It is the domain of the victors, so do not weep.

Then Cunda, the smith's son, said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, it is so. It is just so. Since nirvāṇa is inconceivable even to me, what need is there to speak of other beings of the Lesser Vehicle, who are like flies? Blessed One, oh! today I have become equal to the bodhisattvas, supreme among men, possessed of great fortune and worthy of offerings, such as the youthful Mañjuśrī, and to those whose defilements are exhausted. Blessed One, to give an example: just as a young man newly given full ordination, from the very day he goes forth, is counted as Saṅgha within the Saṅgha and is fully gathered into it, so too I, through the power of the Tathāgata, am counted among the bodhisattva great beings and fully gathered into their number. Blessed One, I wish the Tathāgata to remain for long; I do not wish him to depart into nirvāṇa like scorched food."

Then the youthful Mañjuśrī said this to Cunda, the smith's son:

"Cunda, do not say, 'I wish the Tathāgata to remain for long; I do not wish him to depart into nirvāṇa like scorched food.' One should indeed look at the nature of formations. Whoever looks in that way will perfect the meditation on emptiness. One who wants the sublime Dharma should train in that way."

Cunda said, "Venerable Mañjuśrī, then how could that be? The Tathāgata has become the supreme god of gods. If he were a formation, he would not be fit to be the god of gods. Formations are known to be like water bubbles, and they turn like the wheel of a chariot. The gods are renowned as supremely long-lived, yet the Tathāgata did not last even a hundred years. Therefore, on that view, the Tathāgata would not be fit to be the god of gods.

"For example, a certain man who was a village headman gradually became a great lord, surpassing even the power of the great ministers. He enjoyed the fruit of his own power, gained lawfully. But if his merit is then exhausted and he falls from his power, he is put to work by others and despised. Why is that? Because he has become poor. In the same way, if the Tathāgata were a formation, then, since that is a cause of death, he would not be fit to be the god of gods. Therefore, Venerable Mañjuśrī, do not regard the god of gods, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, as being like formations.

"Moreover, Mañjuśrī, do you conceive of the Tathāgata as having the nature of formations knowingly, or do you conceive of him so out of not knowing? If the Tathāgata were like formations, he would not be fit to be the god of gods who has attained mastery over the Dharma in the three worlds.

"For example, a certain lord of kings has a wrestler who is supreme among a thousand wrestlers. Because no wrestler at all can defeat him, he receives the name 'Victor over a Thousand.' Since he has no rival among wrestlers, if he is granted great authority by the king, would his fame be untrue when one hears that name of his, Victor over a Thousand? No: when one has qualities, one receives the name of one who possesses them. In the same way, the Tathāgata has conquered all the wrestlers: the māra of the afflictions, the māra of the aggregates, the māra who is a son of the gods, and the māra of intrinsic nature. So, like Victor over a Thousand, by virtue of his true qualities he is called in the three worlds the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha. Venerable Mañjuśrī, do not conceive of the Tathāgata as being like formations.

"For example, someone takes birth in a rich family of great wealth but is destined to be short-lived. Astrologers see this and declare, 'This boy is

short-lived.' When his parents hear this, they think, 'He will be of no benefit to our household.' So they do not even count him and show him no love. In just this way, whether it is a man, a woman, a god, or even Brahmā, whoever is short-lived is held in contempt. If the Tathāgata, who is wholly devoted to the Dharma alone, were a formation, he would be despised by the whole world. Among all phenomena, that in which there is no falling back and no exhaustion is taught to be liberation. If things were as you say, that teaching would be meaningless. Venerable Mañjuśrī, do not say, 'The Tathāgata is a formation.'

"For example, there was a young woman who was poor, destitute, without protector, stricken with illness, suffering in the meantime, and burdened by her pregnancy. She went to an ownerless house, and there the girl gave birth to a child. But others who had been living there before drove her out of it. Just after giving birth, the afflicted woman carried her newborn infant and set out for a land with good harvests. On the road she was tormented by gadflies, flies, wind, the heat of the sun, and the harm of scorpions and snakes. She wanted to cross the great Ganges River, but she could not cross it. Still carrying the boy, she died in the Ganges. Through the special merit of her love for her child, after she was parted from her body in death she was born in the world of Brahmā. If one asks by what kind of special merit of love she was born there: she was born through the special merit of the thought, 'Even if I die, let this boy be brought across safe and unharmed.'

"In the same way, Venerable Mañjuśrī, a holy person who wishes to bring forth the sublime Dharma should not view the Tathāgata as a formation, and should not alter his perception either. Even if one does not have such an eye in one's body, one should hold the right view, thinking, 'The Blessed One is inconceivable.' One who teaches instructions that benefit all sentient beings should teach that the Tathāgata is unconditioned. One who brings forth the sublime Dharma should act just as the poor young woman strove, staking her own life, to rescue her child from the Ganges River. In order to employ the means of bringing forth the sublime Dharma, one should give rise to the thought, 'The Tathāgata is unconditioned.' If one sees the Tathāgata as unconditioned, one will realize the meaning of liberation, the aim that one must accomplish oneself."

"Venerable Mañjuśrī, it is like this. A certain man, worn out from travelling on the road, was lying asleep inside a house. Then a great fire blazed up from the roof of that house. Thinking, 'If I am burned by this fire, I am as good as dead,' and possessed of a sense of shame and of conscience, he wrapped himself

tightly in his clothes, and he died with his mind still mindful. As the result of the merit of that thought of shame and conscience, he held the kingship of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three eighty times and the kingship of Brahmā a hundred thousand times. In the human world too he held the kingship of a wheel-turning monarch many times. He was never born in the lower realms, and many times over he obtained nothing but happiness, one state following upon another. In the same way, Mañjuśrī, you should be scrupulous, as excellent people are. Have a sense of shame! Do not make the Tathāgata out to be engaged in the ways of conditioned things.

"Rather than a monk perfect in moral discipline saying of the Tathāgata, who is unconditioned, 'The Tathāgata is conditioned,' it would be better even for him to become a tīrthika and die. Whoever says 'The Tathāgata is conditioned,' though the Tathāgata is unconditioned, speaks falsely. Those who say 'The Tathāgata is conditioned' will go to hell as if to their own home. Venerable Mañjuśrī, do not regard the Tathāgata as resembling conditioned things. From now on, as you wander in saṃsāra, turn away from ignorance and realize solely the knowledge that thinks, 'The Blessed One is unconditioned.' As the result of doing this and meditating on it, you will very swiftly come to possess the thirty-two marks, just like the Tathāgata."

Then Mañjuśrī, in youthful form, said this to Cunda, the smith's son: "Excellent, excellent! May you live long! This is how a son of good family should act. Son of good family, you know the Tathāgata to be permanent, everlasting, unconditioned and stable. Since you know in exactly this way, by doing away with the conditioned, you too before long will become just as the Tathāgata is. Later the Buddha himself will also give praise, saying that the two of us have thus spoken a praise of surpassing excellence.

"Cunda, hasten the Tathāgata's meal! Among all gifts, hastened giving is supreme. What is called hastened giving is this: in order that sprouts may arise from the seeds of every perfection of generosity, when monks, nuns, laymen or laywomen have set out on the road for some purpose and have grown weary, to give them whatever one has, what suits their needs, a gift given with care; that is called hastened giving. Cunda, in the same way, from whatever you have, let this last of meals, whether it be much or little, whether it be special or not, be served to the Tathāgata together with the Saṅgha of monks. The Blessed One is close to departing into complete nirvāṇa."

Then Cunda said, "Venerable Mañjuśrī, are you attached to food, or what, that you urge me on, saying, 'Serve the meal, whether much or little'? The Blessed One practised austerities for six years; can he not now hold out even for a moment? The Tathāgata is the body of Dharma, not a body of food, so does the Blessed One eat food?"

The Blessed One said, "Mañjuśrī, what Cunda has said is so. Cunda, excellent, excellent! You have great wisdom regarding the Great Vehicle. You exert yourself for the Great Vehicle."

Mañjuśrī also said this: "If it is so intended, may the Tathāgata's life be long!"

Cunda said, "Is the Blessed One pleased with me alone, or is he pleased with all sentient beings as well?"

Mañjuśrī said, "Is the Blessed One not pleased with you, with me, and with all sentient beings?"

Cunda said, "Do not say that! Wherever there is gratification, there is distorted perception, and that is where people like us operate. The Tathāgata has no pleasure or delight. For the Tathāgata does not have a love like that of a cow who, out of love for her calf, grazes and grazes and then comes back to the village; rather, he regards all sentient beings just as he regards Rāhula. Such is the domain of the Buddha's wisdom. Venerable Mañjuśrī, just as a donkey cart cannot possibly run alongside a chariot yoked to thoroughbred horses, how could people like us, who are like donkey carts, keep pace with the Tathāgata's wisdom and his words of hidden intent? It is like a garuḍa that flies for many leagues: abiding in the sky, it sees the fish and turtles in the water as clearly as one's own reflection appears on the surface of a mirror, yet children, because their eyes are not clear, cannot describe the power of its sight. In just the same way it is with the Tathāgata."

Mañjuśrī said, "Cunda, that is so. I merely raised that objection in order to speak of the greatness of the bodhisattvas."

Then at that moment rays of light of many kinds spread forth from the mouth of the Blessed One and struck the body of Mañjuśrī, in youthful form. Then Mañjuśrī, understanding this, said to Cunda, the smith's son, "Cunda, the Tathāgata is hastening to pass into complete nirvāṇa. Let the meal be served to the Blessed One in good time. Do not delay! Rays of light do not come forth from the Blessed One's mouth without a cause."

Then Cunda remained without saying anything.

Then the Blessed One said this to Cunda: "Cunda, I am certain to go into complete nirvāṇa. Let food be served to the Saṅgha of monks in good time." This he declared twice, and a third time.

Then Cunda said, "Alas! If the Blessed One does not remain, the world will become empty. All of us, weeping, implore the Blessed One."

Then the Blessed One said to Cunda, "Cunda, do not weep. Do not wound your body like this. Realize that the human body, like a plantain tree, has no core. Understand it to be like a mirage, a swelling bubble of foam, an illusion, a vessel made by a potter, and lightning. Know that the conditioned is the source of countless faults. Look at the nature of the conditioned."

Then Cunda said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, if out of love for me and for all beings the Tathāgata does not consent to remain for a long time, how could I not weep? Please do not depart and leave the world empty."

Then the Blessed One said to Cunda, "It is out of compassion for you and out of compassion for all beings that I pass into parinirvāṇa. This is the nature of reality of the buddhas, and it is the nature of the conditioned. Understand the verse that says, 'All formations are impermanent.' Realize that all phenomena are suffering, because they are mixed with formations. Examine all phenomena as selfless. Reflect that they are unstable, borrowed, and inverted. Know that this body is possessed of endless defects. Regard it as like foam, and do not weep. Do not despair."

Then Cunda said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, even when I see it in that way, the suffering is extremely great and unbearable. Yet I rejoice that the Blessed One passes into parinirvāṇa as a skillful means."

The Blessed One said, "Excellent, Cunda, excellent! A son of good family should regard my nirvāṇa in just that way, as a skillful means. Cunda, know the departure of the buddhas to be like a haṃsa going off in play. Cunda, know the signs of what is long-lived and what is not long-lived. Cunda, all phenomena have the nature of illusion. Among all phenomena, the Tathāgata has the nature of skillful means, and is not stained by them; that is the nature of the buddhas, the blessed ones. Cunda, so that you may surely cross the ocean of existence, quickly bring the food. May gods, asuras, and humans as well, having made their own offerings to me, attain unmoving bliss. You too, give at the proper time to those who are worthy recipients. Do not delay. A worthy recipient, I myself, and what is called the Tathāgata are not different in meaning."

Then Cunda, for the sake of surely delivering all beings, bowed his head, shed tears, and said, "Excellent! Excellent! I shall do just as the Blessed One has said. How the Tathāgata is to be regarded after his parinirvāṇa is not the domain of us, who are like flies, nor is it the domain of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas."

Then, grieving and weeping, together with his servants and retinue, he circumambulated the Blessed One, performed a great act of offering, bowed to the Blessed One and to Mañjuśrī, in youthful form, and went to fetch the food.

The third fascicle.

Then, at that time, the great earth shook and shook violently, moved and moved violently, heaved and heaved violently, rolled and rolled violently, rumbled and rumbled violently, cracked and cracked violently, quivered and quivered violently, swayed and swayed violently. Doing these and other such things, like a person struck down by the affliction of fainting from a bile disease, this great earth, bounded by the poisonous ocean and reaching up to the world of Brahmā, quaked violently all at once. Then all those gods, asuras, and humans were bewildered, terrified, and their hair stood on end; and weeping, with one voice they offered these verses:

O Protector, we bow our heads to you
And make our earnest plea.
O Victor, leader of the herd,
If we are parted from you, we shall have no protector.
When we think that today you will pass into nirvāṇa,
We sink into suffering exceedingly deep.
O Sage, our hearts are lost to us,
Like a milk cow pining for the calf a thief has carried off.
Just as some poor man without a protector,
Struck down by illness and with no physician,
Doing as he pleases and eating harmful food,
Will surely die,
So these beings, struck down by the illness of the afflictions,
Without you, without the nourishment of your Dharma,
Will die like those who commit the faults of wrong view.
Therefore, for its benefit, do not abandon the world.
Like a city bereft of its king,
Like the poor when famine has come,

Like one tormented by thirst in the wilderness,
So shall we be after you have passed away.
Because you, who cherish beings, intend to pass into nirvāṇa,
The earth quakes violently and the directions are confounded,
The great oceans too are churned in turmoil,
And all of us are plunged in suffering and pain.
Great Sage, if today you pass beyond sorrow,
The very sun will fall to the earth,
The great oceans too will dry up,
And all of us, surely, will perish today.
Just as when a strong man drags an elephant
Through a narrow gateway to force it inside,
It is greatly distressed,
So all of us are greatly distressed.
Just as no one wishes an only child to die,
So we do not wish you to pass beyond sorrow.
If you do not hold back from passing into nirvāṇa,
All of us will be left destitute.
Seeing you set out on the road to nirvāṇa,
Even many animals grieve and lament;
How could we not lament?
Do not cast us away like spittle.
Just as the rising sun with its own clear light
Utterly destroys the darkness,
So you, possessor of miraculous powers, dispel the darkness of suffering
And dwell amid the Saṅgha like Mount Meru.

Blessed One, by way of example: suppose a certain king has a son who is dear and precious to him, and after having him trained in the treatises on statecraft, he commands, "Put him to death." In the same way, Blessed One, we too, the sons of the Blessed One who turns the wheel of the holy Dharma, have had right view produced in us. If we are not to be slain as that king's son was, then, Blessed One, for that reason please remain for a long time.

Just as someone who relies on treatises that dispute over scriptures becomes frightened, so do not make us frightened. Knowing reality as you do, do not let us sentient beings go to the hells. Satisfy us with the essence of the nectar of the holy Dharma, and, Tathāgata, please remain for a long time.

Suppose someone is first made to suffer in a king's prison because of harmful deeds, and another asks him, "What kind of pain are you experiencing?" He replies, "It is like this: when I am freed from the feeling of suffering, that will be nirvāṇa, and I shall experience happiness." In the same way, for all of us, if you remain, it is nirvāṇa, like being freed from the king's prison. For that reason, Tathāgata, please remain for a long time.

Blessed One, by way of example: a physician skilled in the eight branches of the science of life teaches the final tantra to his own son, but does not teach it to his disciples, fearing that they would become his equal. In the same way, O King of Dharma, great physician who has no stinginess, do not act like that with the final tantra of the Great Vehicle. Blessed One, please remain for a long time. Likewise, a charioteer skilled in the science of chariots teaches his own son the final tantra, all the techniques of striking a target by its sound, but does not teach them to his disciples. The same should be applied to the other fields of knowledge as well.

Blessed One, by way of example: if a child, an old person, or a sick person strays from the good road and goes onto a bad one, they will suffer greatly. In the same way, Blessed One, beings who go on bad paths will, after they part from the body, experience suffering in the hells. Therefore, Blessed One, guide of the path, please remain for a long time.

The same should be applied in full to the ninety-six wonders and the forty-five verses as well.

Then, at that time, the Blessed One said to the monks, "Monks, do not utter childish laments as gods and humans do; set about your diligence."

Then the gods, asuras, and humans, hearing the words of the Blessed One, which were full of wisdom and led to reality, were stricken with grief, like one whose only son has died and been cast into a charnel ground.

Then the Blessed One spoke to them in verse:

May you all surely be happy.
Do not grieve, do not weep.
This is the Dharma of the buddhas.
All of you, sit in silence.
Do not dwell in heedlessness;
Take delight in heedfulness.

"Whatever doubts, hesitations, or uncertainties you may have about empty and not empty, permanent and impermanent, refuge and not refuge, going and not going, support and not support, everlasting and not everlasting, stable and unstable, sentient being and no sentient being, real and unreal, true and untrue, nirvāṇa and not nirvāṇa, secret and not secret, two and nondual, and likewise about the many kinds of phenomena, ask me about each and every one of them, and I shall resolve them all. I shall also teach you the supreme nectar, and after that I shall pass into complete nirvāṇa.

"Monks, the appearance of a buddha is hard to find. Obtaining a human body is hard to find. Perfect leisure is hard to find. Perfect patience and moral discipline, unbroken and untorn, are also extremely hard to find. Attaining arhatship in the world is as hard to find as gold dust or the udumbara flower."

Monks, the earth is in every way the sustenance of all sentient beings. In the same way, my teaching of the Dharma in its many forms, the secret ambrosial food of the city of liberation, should be regarded as like it. For all sentient beings and for all my sons, the monks, I have firmly established many teachings of the sacred Dharma. Furthermore, for the benefit of all sentient beings, I shall proclaim the greatness of the Tathāgata's qualities, and after also setting down the discourse on the single syllable and its dot, I shall pass into parinirvāṇa.

When those monks heard that the Tathāgata was going to pass into parinirvāṇa, they were stricken with sorrow. Shuddering, their eyes brimming with tears, they bowed their heads at the feet of the Blessed One (the Buddha), circled the Blessed One many times, and then spoke to the Blessed One as follows:

"The Blessed One has taught suffering, impermanence and selflessness, saying, 'Among all footprints, the footprint of the elephant is supreme.' In just that way, by relying on, cultivating and repeatedly practicing the perception of impermanence, all attachment to the desire realm is exhausted, all attachment to the form realm is exhausted, all attachment to the formless realm is exhausted, all ignorance is exhausted, and all excessive pride is cut off completely, without remainder.

"Blessed One, it is like this: in autumn a farmer ploughs deeply and clears away all the tangled roots. In the same way, Blessed One, by relying on, cultivating and repeatedly practicing the perception of impermanence, all attachment to the desire realm is exhausted, all attachment to the form realm

is exhausted, all attachment to the formless realm is exhausted, all ignorance is exhausted, and all excessive pride is completely exhausted, without remainder." The passage beginning "Among all kinds of farm work, the autumn farm work is taught to be supreme" is to be supplied in full, as it appears in the Elephant's Footprint Sūtra.

"Blessed One, it is like this: when a king is dying, he empties his prisons, freeing the beings who have been tormented by the hardships of prison, and only after that does he die. In the same way, Blessed One, please cut the bonds of ignorance of the beings confined in the prisons of the many kinds of ignorance, and only after that pass into parinirvāṇa.

"Blessed One, here is another example. When beings possessed by bhūta and piśāca spirits meet a great physician, they are freed from every affliction caused by those bhūta and piśāca spirits. In the same way, when they meet you, the whole assembly of śrāvakas is completely freed from the bhūta and piśāca spirits of the many kinds of ignorance, and comes to realize the Perfection of Wisdom itself.

"Blessed One, it is like this: a scented elephant, bound by its trainer with a great rope, snaps that rope and runs away. In the same way, Blessed One, we too have cut the great ropes of clinging to a self, clinging to what is mine, jealousy, conceit, stinginess and guile, and have come into the hands of the great elephant trainer, the Tathāgata. We shall completely clear away the fifty-seven elephants of affliction from all sentient beings.

"Blessed One, it is like this: one stricken with a chill fever who goes to a great physician is freed from suffering. In the same way, Blessed One, we, whose bodies were sick with the chill fever of the endless faults of affliction, wrong view and wrong livelihood, came to the great physician, the Blessed One, were completely freed from all suffering, and attained unmoving bliss.

"Blessed One, here is another example. A man drinks rice beer and becomes drunk. He no longer knows himself; he knows neither Dharma nor what is not Dharma; he does not even recognize, 'This is my mother, this is my sister, this is my daughter.' He babbles and vomits, and his whole body is smeared with excrement and urine. Later he sobers up, and understanding clearly what caused all this, he thinks, 'Liquor is in no way fit to drink.' Thinking, 'I have been freed from all wrongdoing,' he firmly impresses on himself that drinking liquor is in no way acceptable, and gives it up. In the same way, Blessed One, this world of living beings, like an actor, has been circling and wandering

through saṃsāra since beginningless time. Not recognizing, 'This is my mother, this is my sister, this is my daughter,' beings act out desirous perceptions with mothers, sisters and daughters, and, just like one drunk on rice beer, they meet with suffering. Then those people who have a sense of shame, like one who has sobered up from drunkenness on rice beer, firmly impress on themselves that this is in no way acceptable, and so they pass completely beyond suffering.

"Furthermore, just as it is impossible for the castor plant to have a core, so too it is impossible for this body to have a self, a sentient being, a life, a person, a manuja, a mānava or an agent. Understanding it thus, we have cultivated and repeatedly practiced the perception of selflessness. It is like this: just as the heap of chaff thrown away by winnowers is not valued at all, so too there is no self in this body. It is like this: just as the khasral flower gives off no fragrance, so too there is no self in this body. In this way we have cultivated and repeatedly practiced the perception of selflessness.

"The Blessed One also declared, 'Monks, all phenomena are selfless; meditate in that way. Those who meditate in that way will abandon clinging to a self. When clinging to a self has been completely abandoned, nirvāṇa will be attained.' Blessed One, since all phenomena are thus selfless, we have cultivated and repeatedly practiced the perception of selflessness. Furthermore, just as no track of a bird can be found in the sky, so too, when one cultivates the perception of selflessness, one becomes free of every kind of view."

The Blessed One said, "Do you understand this way of meditating?"

The monks replied, "Blessed One, suppose one cultivates perceptions other than the perceptions of suffering, impermanence and no-self. A drunken man, reeling about, sees temples, towers, the ground, the sun, the moon, trees and mountains turning round, though they are not turning. In the same way, those worldly beings who have not cultivated the perceptions of suffering, impermanence and no-self should be regarded as like drunkards. Blessed One, we have cultivated them properly."

The Blessed One said, "Monks, now I shall explain the meaning of this example. You do not clearly know, regarding the meaning of the verse, 'This is the meaning, and this is the letter.' A drunken man sees temples, towers, the ground, the sun, the moon, trees and mountains turning round, though they are not turning. In the same way, those who are gripped by many inverted

perceptions and are thoroughly deluded entertain the perceptions 'This is self,' 'This is permanent,' 'This is bliss,' and 'This is pure.' Here, 'self' means the Buddha. 'Permanent' means the dharmakāya. 'Bliss' means nirvāṇa. 'Pure' is a synonym for the Dharma.

"Monks, do not puff yourselves up with arrogance and pride, saying, 'Blessed One, we have cultivated the perceptions of suffering, impermanence and no-self.' If you cultivate the three in that way, then the three kinds of cultivation you have cultivated within my teaching will become meaningless. The three kinds of cultivation by which suffering is to be understood are of a superior kind, superior even beyond the superior.

"To perceive suffering as bliss is an inversion. To perceive bliss as suffering is an inversion. To perceive the impermanent as permanent is an inversion. To perceive the permanent as impermanent is an inversion. To perceive what is without self as self is an inversion. To perceive what has a self as without self is an inversion. To perceive the impure as pure is an inversion. To perceive the pure as impure is an inversion. Without truly understanding these four inversions, you have cultivated what was to be cultivated and practiced it much. You have cultivated bliss as suffering, the permanent as impermanent, what has a self as without self, and the pure as impure. Worldly people also have bliss, self, permanence and purity. Those beyond the world also have bliss, self, permanence and purity, and here the two are at odds with each other. 'The letter' is a term for the worldly. 'The meaning' is wisdom beyond the world."

Then the monks said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, the four perceptions and the other inversions that the Tathāgata has set forth, we have long since seen, and we have also cultivated them. Now, please tell us how we should understand them. Please, Tathāgata, remain for an aeon or for more than an aeon. Whatever the Tathāgata tells us, we wish to do just as he says. If the Tathāgata does not consent to remain, we would not wish to live together in one house with a venomous snake. If the Tathāgata does not remain, we will have no heart to go on living the holy life, and so, following you yourself, we too wish to pass into parinirvāṇa."

Then the Blessed One said this to those monks: "Monks, do not speak like that. Monks, I shall entrust the teaching into the hands of Kāśyapa. Like the Tathāgata, he will be a support for the monks. He will be a refuge for the monks and for sentient beings. Just as a king who is lord of many cities goes to

one city and consecrates a householder as king, so I consecrate Mahākāśyapa in this world system.

"Monks, if you ask how you should cultivate the perceptions of suffering, impermanence, no-self and impurity: monks, suppose that when the summer season has come, people dam up water in a grove, and each, carrying his own swimming gear, plays in the water. Then someone places in that water a precious vaiḍūrya gem of the finest kind. Wanting that vaiḍūrya, they all throw away their floats and dive into the water. Whatever potsherds or pebbles are there, they pick up, thinking, 'This is the gem,' and each of them comes up saying, 'I have found the gem! I have found it!' Sitting on the edge of the pond, the perception arises in them, 'This is not the gem.' The water of the pond, too, is beautiful with the light of the gem, like moonlight, and seeing that beauty they come to perceive its qualities, thinking, 'Ah, the gem!' Then one among them, skilled in means and sharp of mind, truly finds the gem.

"In the same way, monks, whatever you have cultivated and practiced much, taking it to cover everything, saying, 'All is suffering, all is without self, all is impermanent, all is impure,' all of that has become mistaken and meaningless, like the potsherds and pebbles in the pond. Act like the man skilled in means. In each and every thing that you have cultivated by taking it to cover everything, in that very thing there are bliss, self, permanence and purity, and these four should be declared the non-inverted. Therefore, like the gem, cultivate the perception that the suchness of phenomena is permanent."

Then the monks said this to the Blessed One:

"The Blessed One (the Buddha) said, 'Monks, all phenomena are without self; meditate in this way. Those who meditate in this way will abandon the grasping at a self, and once they have abandoned the grasping at a self, they will attain nirvāṇa.' Since this is what you declared, what is the meaning of what you declared? Blessed One, we ask that the Tathāgata please explain its analysis."

The Blessed One said to those monks, "Monks, excellent, excellent! Monks, one who wishes to cut through his own doubts once and for all must ask just as you have. Excellent!

"Monks, suppose that in a certain city a king lacking in wisdom held the throne. That king had a bad physician, and a foolish one at that, who wielded great power and influence from on high and was honored by the king. He held that milk alone was medicine. Not knowing the basis of disease, he clung to a

mistaken milk treatment and gave it to all people for every kind of wind disorder, and gave it as well for disorders of bile and disorders of phlegm. Yet although he did this, the physician remained the favorite, for the king too was a fool who could not tell the difference.

"Then another physician, skilled in the eight branches of the science of life and versed in the later treatises, newly arrived from another land. He went to that physician bearing a gift and said, 'Having heard your name, I have come in order to learn. Please be my teacher.'

"When the foolish physician heard this, he said to the newly arrived physician, 'For forty-eight years serve me with great diligence, enduring hardship. After that, study, and you will become a physician.'

"The newcomer agreed to this, saying, 'I shall do so.' Little by little he won the foolish physician's favor. Then he went to the royal palace and said to the king, 'Great king, you should always apply yourself to all the treatises. If you do so, the king will be worthy of being king.'

"The king replied, 'That is true, and it is pleasing to hear.' And so the king came to distinguish between the foolish physician and the other physician. He banished the bad physician from the realm and honored the other, good physician.

"Then that physician thought, 'Now the time has come,' and said to the king, 'Great king, if you are pleased with me, I would make a single request. If the great king is indeed pleased, please grant it.'

"The king said to the physician, 'Ask for any wealth whatever, even my right hand.'

"The physician said to the king, 'Great king, the milk treatment of that foolish physician is hālāhala poison. Since he did not understand this, please proclaim by decree throughout your entire realm: "Whatever milk treatment the former physician gave is hālāhala poison. Whoever drinks milk as medicine shall be beheaded." If this is not done, beings will die untimely deaths. I want them to live and to be free of disease. Your Majesty, that is the request I make.'

"Then the king said to the physician, 'If that is so, you are asking a small thing. I shall issue the decree.' And he issued it. Then, in accordance with the decree, it became the custom everywhere.

"Then the physician said to the king once more, 'Please issue the same decree again, a second and a third time.' And the physician cured people's diseases

with the sweet, the sour, the salty, the pungent, the astringent, and the bitter tastes.

"Then, some time later, the king was struck by illness. He summoned that physician and commanded him, 'I am close to death. I will give you whatever you wish to request, as befits a king's means.'

"Then the physician said to the king, 'Great king, I spoke falsely. Milk is nectar. I ask that you take food mixed with milk.'

"Then the king said to the physician, 'Have you been driven mad by bile, or are you deceiving me? Earlier you said milk is poison, and now you say milk is the best of medicines. Alas, banishing the former physician has ruined me! Since he too praised the milk treatment, he was a great physician, not a bad one. Your giving the milk treatment is reason enough for you yourself to be banished.'

"The physician said, 'Great king, please do not think of it that way. For example, when one sees on wood or on a wall marks bored by worms that look like letters, the wise do not say, "The worm knows how to write." Even though they look like written letters, they do not take them for a marvel. In the same way, the milk treatment practiced by your former physician should be regarded like letters bored by worms, for he did not even know the distinctions among different kinds of milk.'

"The king said to the physician, 'What! How did that bad physician not know the distinctions among different kinds of milk?'

"The physician said, 'Great king, milk is both nectar and poison. What is called nectar is this: a cow whose calf is not overly strong; who does not drink the dregs of beer; who does not dwell in thickets, ravines, or muddy swamps; whose teats the cowherd has not roughly handled; who has not been fed on cut grass; who stays in her own herd and does not mingle with herds of buffalo; a cow endowed with these and similar good qualities. Her milk, drawn only in due measure without cutting off what remains to flow for the calf, pacifies every disease.'

"Then the king was amazed and said to the physician, 'Teacher, now I know your good milk treatment, and I know the bad one as well.'

Then the king issued a decree, commanding, "Drink milk!" When all the subjects heard that the king had commanded them to drink milk once again, they were thrown into confusion and said, "Has the king been seized by a

graha? Or is he mocking us?" So the people of the city and all the subjects came before the king. When the king saw them, he said, "If this physician says that milk is like that, what objection do you have?"

Then the king, the people of the city and all the subjects were pleased. They paid the physician honor beyond compare and relied on treatment with milk. In just the same way, monks, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, endowed with knowledge and conduct, the Sugata, knower of the world, charioteer who tames beings, unsurpassed, teacher of gods and humans, the Buddha, the Blessed One, appears in the world like the good physician. He goes before all the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), who are like the bad physician, thoroughly subdues them all and utterly defeats them, and pleases many kings. In order to vanquish the tīrthikas he declares, "There is no self. There is no sentient being. There is no life. There is no person."

The self taught by the tīrthikas is like letters carved by a worm. Therefore I taught all sentient beings the teaching that there is no self. Having issued the Dharma decree, "Selflessness is the word of the Buddha," then, according to the capacities of those to be trained and for the benefit of sentient beings, knowing the right time, on that very occasion of teaching that all dharmas are selfless, he truly teaches, like the good physician, that there is a self. It is not the self of worldly people, said to be the size of a thumb or the size of a grain of millet. Nor is it whatever worldly people view as a self. Here, all dharmas are called selfless. Yet all dharmas are not selfless either: the self is suchness itself; the self is permanence itself; the self is virtue itself; the self is the everlasting itself; the self is stability itself; the self is peace itself. Just like the good physician's milk, the Tathāgata too teaches what is endowed with suchness. Let the four assemblies strive in meditating on it!

Monks, furthermore, apart from matters of moral discipline, whatever doubts and hesitations you have, ask me about them, and when I have explained them well, you should be satisfied. I teach the great emptiness of intrinsic nature, which is free from all meditation. Monks, do not say, "The Tathāgata did not teach us the great emptiness of intrinsic nature." Monks, furthermore, apart from matters of moral discipline, whatever doubts and hesitations you have, ask me about them.

Then those monks said this to the Blessed One: "To put questions to the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, is not within our domain; we are not able to do so. The Buddha, the Blessed One, is inconceivable; his

meditative absorptions are inconceivable; your instructions too are inconceivable. Therefore we are not able to ask.

"Blessed One, it is like this. Suppose there is a man who is old and decrepit, worn out, a hundred and twenty-six years of age, stricken by illness, a sick man lying on his bed. Another man places a treasure in his hands and says, 'O man, take this treasure, and when I come back from abroad in ten or twenty years, give it back to me then.' Having entrusted it to him, he departs. The old man has no son. Not long after the man has left, the old man dies. When the man returns, although he has lost a great heap of wealth in this way, there is no one at all to whom he can say anything. In just the same way, Blessed One, whatever we ask apart from matters of moral discipline will not remain long among the śrāvakas, and we have no capacity to ask anything at all."

The Blessed One said to them, "What the monks ask will benefit all sentient beings. That is why I have opened the opportunity to ask questions."

Then the monks said this: "Blessed One, it is like this. Suppose there is a young man, twenty-six years of age, wealthy and possessed of a splendid retinue. Another man places a treasure in his hands and says, 'O man, I am going away on business. When I come back, give this treasure back to me.' That man hides the treasure well and guards it well, and when the other returns he gives it back. In just the same way, Blessed One, if the wealth of the holy Dharma well spoken by the Blessed One were entrusted to all the śrāvakas, such as the monk Ānanda, it would not remain long. Why is that? Because all the śrāvakas, such as Mahākāśyapa, are impermanent. If the wealth asked for by the bodhisattvas is entrusted to the bodhisattvas, it will remain for many hundreds of thousands of years, it will also increase, and it will benefit all bodhisattvas. The bodhisattva mahāsattvas are able to put questions to the Tathāgata, but we, who are like gnats, are not able to put questions to the Tathāgata." Having said this, they sat without saying anything more.

Then the Blessed One said this to those monks: "Excellent, monks, excellent! Monks, you speak thus because you are without defilement. You speak thus as arhats. Excellent! Monks, I too had already thought of the very point you have been thinking. If my Great Vehicle is entrusted into the hands of the bodhisattvas, it will remain for a long time, for two reasons."

Then at that time the Blessed One said to the assembly, "Sons of good family and daughters of good family, long-lived ones, apart from the three bases and

apart from the basis of moral discipline, whatever indecision, hesitation and doubt you have, ask me about it." This he said twice and three times.

Then, from within that same assembly, through the power of the Tathāgata, a bodhisattva great being rose from his seat. He had been born in Stalk Village, and he was a son of a great and eminent brahmin family, of the same clan as Mahākāśyapa. He went to where the Blessed One was, bowed down, circumambulated him a hundred thousand times, and made great offerings worthy of the gods. Then he draped his upper robe over one shoulder, set his right knee on the ground, and said this to the Blessed One: "If the Blessed One will grant me the opportunity to have my questions answered, I would ask the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, about a few points."

The Blessed One said, "Bodhisattva great being, son of a great and eminent brahmin family, of the same clan as Mahākāśyapa, ask the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, whatever you wish. I shall answer each question you ask, and so I shall gladden your mind."

Then the bodhisattva great being, son of a great and eminent brahmin family, of the same clan as Mahākāśyapa, said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, were it not for the power of the Tathāgata and the power of the roots of virtue of all beings, I would not presume to ask. I am like a gnat, while the Tathāgata possesses a great circle like sandalwood. He possesses a great circle like lions. He has a body as unbreakable as beryl and the great vajra. He has an unbreakable retinue. He has a great retinue endowed with an ocean of wisdom. There are also some bodhisattva great beings here who possess immeasurable qualities. If, through the power of the Tathāgata, I were able to put questions to the Tathāgata, who has so immeasurable a retinue, there would be much to do here. Through the power of the Tathāgata, I, who am like a gnat, wish to ask."

Having said this, he spoke in verse:

"O Sage, by what does one gain long life?
By what does one become like a vajra?
Through what does one attain the indestructible?
By what does one gain a firm body and great strength?
By what practice does one come
To reach the far shore of this sūtra?
How does one understand the varied minds

Of living beings, and then teach them?
Great Sage, in what way
Does one gain the vast and become a refuge?
How, though one is not an arhat,
Does one become equal to the arhats?
Blessed One, how is Māra,
The maker of obstacles, drawn into the retinue?
Knowing the words of Māra
And knowing the speech of the perfect Buddha as well,
How does the Guide, with joy,
Also teach the noble path?
Endowed with virtue and with what is right,
How does one teach without distortion?
Great Sage, in what way
Does one become a doer of good? Please teach this.
O Sage, how do bodhisattvas
See the element that is hard to fathom?
O Sage, how is it
That the half letter becomes complete?
How does one come to be like
The conduct of the wild geese and the zalmo birds?
How do Jupiter and Venus
Come to arise in the daytime?
O Sage, how do bodhisattvas,
While the mind is not yet produced,
Come to be fearless here?
How are they like the kata fruit?
How, when they are born in the age of strife,
Do they act without being stained,
And, like a lotus in a realm of faults,
Remain unsullied by faults?
How do bodhisattvas become
Great physicians for the lands?
How do they become ferrymen at every riverbank?
Please explain this to me here.
How do they come to be
Like snakes casting off their old skins?

How are they like a source of many jewels,
And like grain and like trees?
How do those steadfast ones,
Through the awakening of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas,
Display relics?
And how do they teach endless gateways?
How do the steadfast heirs of the Victor, firm in their vows,
Possess an unbreakable retinue?
How do they come to be
Like eyes for the blind of the world?
Great Sage, in what way
Do they display ten million many heads?
How, like the moon in its phases,
Do they teach the Dharma to the worlds?
In what manner, hidden like a rainbow,
Do they display complete nirvāṇa?
How, like gods and like Māra,
Do they become steadfast and heroic?
How, having realized the gateways of the Dharma,
Do they come to know the nature of reality as well?
How do bodhisattvas
Also become free of illness?
For the benefit of all beings,
How do they explain the intended meaning?
How is there virtue with remainder?
How does one come to abandon doubt?
O great intellect, in what way
Does one draw near to supreme awakening?
You who see the subtlest parts
Have spoken of the conduct of bodhisattvas.
The gateways of the many dharmas too,
O Guide, please declare them.
Healer of all beings,
Show the remedy to the two-legged.
Beyond these collections of the Sage
I have no other subject to ask about.
The domain of the steadfast bodhisattvas

Is that of omniscience."

Then the Blessed One said this to the bodhisattva great being, son of a great and eminent brahmin family, of the same clan as Mahākāśyapa: "Excellent, son of noble family, excellent! Son of noble family, it is excellent that you ask about the great secret sūtra of the Tathāgata in the way that omniscient ones question one another. Beyond world systems as many as the sands of countless Ganges Rivers, the omniscient ones who dwell each in his own world system, together with me, at the foot of the tree of awakening, displayed the play of awakening for the sake of awakening. Just as, by awakening alone, they displayed the play of awakening for the purpose of teaching the secret of the Tathāgata, so you too, for the benefit of all beings, are asking about the domain of omniscience, the way of qualities that bear a single name."

Then the one of the same clan as Mahākāśyapa said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, though I do not presume to ask about the domain of omniscience, I do wish to ask a little."

"Blessed One, to give an example: for a gnat to reach the far shore of the sky and the ocean, or to presume to search out the waters of the ocean, is impossible. In the same way, Blessed One, I am like the gnat, while the Blessed One is like the sky and the ocean, endowed with profound wisdom and the Dharma. Blessed One, to give an example: just as a king's crown jewel, being precious, is received upon one's own head, so I too wish to receive rightly the Dharma that you speak. So that my wisdom may grow, I pray the Blessed One to speak. I pray the Blessed One to explain fully what is beyond compare. I wish to ask."

The Blessed One said, "Son of noble family, listen! Listen with a mind that holds on to it, to the karma by which a bodhisattva, a great being, becomes long-lived, and the karma that becomes the cause of awakening. By the fruit of that karma the cause of awakening will arise. Once you have heard it, teach it to others as well. Son of noble family, I too performed that karma and taught it to others, and so I attained unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

"Son of noble family, just as a person might enter a king's prison in order to free his only son, so a bodhisattva who wishes to be long-lived should cultivate the perception of all sentient beings as his only child. If he cultivates it in this way, he will give up all harming, and he will come to possess great loving-kindness, great compassion, great joy and great equanimity. He will

give up taking life, and he will practice the Dharma. Son of noble family, moreover, he will establish countless sentient beings in the bases of training, and he will establish them in the path of the ten virtuous actions as well. If he is able, he follows all beings in order surely to rescue the sentient beings born in the hells, among the asuras, in the world of Yama, and among the animals, and the sentient beings who commit terrible deeds. Thinking, 'Once I am freed, I shall free others,' he comes to possess a mind that holds to this and keeps it in mindfulness. Through the ripening of these good deeds, and through the result that accords with its cause, bodhisattvas, great beings, become supremely long-lived, become lords of wisdom, and become deathless."

Then the bodhisattva, the great being of Mahākāśyapa's clan, said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, with what in mind should a bodhisattva, a great being, cultivate the perception of all sentient beings as his only child? What is the meaning of what you have said? Blessed One, if a bodhisattva, a great being, must cultivate the perception of all sentient beings as his only child, that is a statement I cannot accept. Why is that? Blessed One, what of those sentient beings in this teaching who have corrupt moral discipline, who commit the acts of immediate retribution, and who repudiate the true Dharma? Should one cultivate the perception of an only child even toward sentient beings such as these?"

The Blessed One said, "You of Mahākāśyapa's clan, it is indeed so. I look upon all sentient beings as I do upon Rāhula."

The one of Mahākāśyapa's clan said, "Blessed One, then when the pure assembly of the fully ordained had gathered for the poṣadha of the fifteenth day, and a youth who was untrained, unpurified in body, and not fully ordained hid in a corner of the wall and listened, why did the Blessed One permit Vajrapāṇi, king of the yakṣas, to crush him to powder like fine dust? Alas, that killing by Vajrapāṇi was far too severe! If so, how does the Blessed One regard all sentient beings as like Rāhula?"

The Blessed One said, "Son of noble family, do not say that! That youth was an emanation. Vajrapāṇi, king of the yakṣas, merely displayed this in order to subdue and drive out those who repudiate the true Dharma. Whether someone repudiates the true Dharma or is full of greed, it is not right to kill him. I could not bring myself to take the life even of an ant.

"Son of noble family, moreover, I do not say, 'I shall destroy them,' in the way that kings or great ministers destroy those who repudiate the true Dharma; it

is simply that the fruit of their own non-Dharma ripens upon them visibly. The all-knowing Tathāgata grants fearlessness for their sake and sends forth one or two rays of light. If those rays do not reach them, they will die, and in that case there is nothing the Tathāgata can do.

"Son of noble family, moreover, if you are able to look into what is hard to examine, I will show you yet another reason. In different lands, moral disciplines, rites and good qualities differ. Suppose that there, after the Tathāgata has passed into nirvāṇa, monks wish to bring forth the true Dharma, and the king, because there is no teacher, harms them. If another king then turns that king back, weakens his power, and that king comes to abide in the Dharma, I declare that the other king gains great merit. Why is that? Because he pacifies the basis of the first king's great wrongdoing.

"Son of noble family, moreover, just as a poisonous tree or a weed that grows in a field or a house must be pulled out by the roots, so I permit those of corrupt moral discipline and those who repudiate the true Dharma to be subdued like servants. Those who do not subdue them are very far from my teaching. Those who do subdue them are my disciples and my śrāvakas."

The one of Mahākāśyapa's clan said, "If the Tathāgata speaks in this way, then he does not regard all sentient beings as he does Rāhula after all, and the name by which he is called 'like toward the axe and the sandalwood' will also be lost. How could it be right to subdue those who repudiate the true Dharma? It is not right for the Tathāgata to permit such a thing."

The Blessed One said, "Kinsman of Mahākāśyapa, suppose a householder, a merchant, a chieftain, a minister, or even a king were to place his beloved and cherished sons, who are exceedingly handsome and perfect in appearance, in the hands of a teacher, and were to say to that teacher: 'I entrust these sons of mine to you so that they may be trained in discipline, in ritual, in proper conduct, and in the sciences. You must teach them discipline, ritual, proper conduct, and the sciences. Train them! If three of these four sons of mine should die from beatings, threats, and punishments, while one stays alive and becomes well trained, then it is acceptable even that three die.' If three then died and one became well trained, would the teacher be said to have committed a sinful, nonvirtuous act?"

"No, Blessed One. In that case neither of them would incur a sinful act. And why is that? Because there is no hostile intention there. By acting in that way, much merit will increase."

The Blessed One said, "Son of noble family, in the same way the Tathāgata regards beings who disparage the true Dharma just as he regards Rāhula, and just as sons are placed in the hands of a teacher, he places them in the hands of kings, ministers, and laymen. Then, if those kings, ministers, and laymen punish those heedless, childish ones, would the Tathāgata be said to incur a sinful act?"

"No, Blessed One. If not even the kings, ministers, and laymen incur a sinful act, how could the Tathāgata, who is free of all defilement, be defiled? They punished them unwillingly, in order to safeguard the very qualities and conduct of those beings."

The Blessed One said, "That, then, is cultivating the perception of an only child. Those who cultivate in this way will have cultivated the perception of an only child. Thus a bodhisattva, a great being, should cultivate the perception of an only child toward all sentient beings. If one does so, one will have cultivated meditative absorption toward all sentient beings. Through this one becomes supremely harmless and pure, and through this the bodhisattva becomes long-lived, supremely long-lived, and able to remember former lives."

The kinsman of Mahākāśyapa said, "If they cultivate the perception of an only child toward all sentient beings, do bodhisattvas, great beings, become long-lived?"

The Blessed One said, "Certainly that is so."

The kinsman of Mahākāśyapa said, "Blessed One, if I may offer an example: a storyteller, in the midst of an audience of spectators, tells all sorts of tales about the propriety of honoring one's mother. Then he goes home and harms his mother, who toils at the hardest labors, with sticks, broken bricks, clods, and stones. It is just like that. The Blessed One himself has said, 'If they cultivate the perception of an only child toward all sentient beings, bodhisattvas, great beings, become long-lived, supremely long-lived, able to remember former lives, deathless, everlasting, and stable.' Why, then, is the Blessed One himself so short-lived? Was he speaking deceitfully? Or, although the Blessed One regards all sentient beings as he regards Rāhula, does he not truly regard them so? Alas, the Blessed One has endured hardship upon hardship! Reckoned by human measure, he cannot even reach a hundred years. If the Tathāgata is this short-lived, did the Blessed One, long ago when he was a bodhisattva, cut off so many lives? Since his life is this short, the

Tathāgata himself must surely have committed exceedingly terrible deeds."

The Blessed One said, "Kinsman of Mahākāśyapa, do not lay such a charge against the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha. Do not lay such a charge! The Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, is supremely long-lived. The Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, is supremely stable, supremely peaceful, supremely everlasting, supremely permanent."

The kinsman of Mahākāśyapa said, "Blessed One, in what way is the Tathāgata supremely long-lived?"

The Blessed One said, "Kinsman of Mahākāśyapa, just as the great rivers, such as the Ganges, the Yamunā, the Sarayū, and the Hiṅgula, together with all the other streams, flow into the great ocean alone, in the same way, kinsman of Mahākāśyapa, every river of life there is in the realms of the gods and upon the earth flows into the ocean of the Tathāgata alone. In this way the Tathāgata is supremely long-lived.

"Furthermore, kinsman of Mahākāśyapa, just as the four great rivers issue from Lake Anavatapta, so too all the multitudes of the long-lived arise from the Tathāgata. Just as, among all permanent things, space is supremely permanent, so the Tathāgata too is permanent, like space. Just as, among all soothing things, ghee alone is supremely soothing, so the Tathāgata, who has become peaceful and cool, teaches a Dharma that is like ghee."

Kāśyapa of the Mahākāśyapa clan said, "Blessed One, if the Tathāgata's life is supremely long, then for the benefit of all sentient beings, may the Blessed One please remain for a long time, for an eon or even more than an eon, and like a great cloud, please let the rain of the sublime Dharma fall in abundance."

The Blessed One said, "Kāśyapa of the Mahākāśyapa clan, do not give rise to the notion that the tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas, come to an end. Kāśyapa of the Mahākāśyapa clan, here a monk, a nun, a layman or a laywoman, or even someone outside this teaching, who has gained mastery of the five superknowledges, can remain for an eon or more than an eon. Such a one walks in the sky and lies down in it, blazes like fire from the left side of the armpit, and likewise in other ways displays things such as emitting smoke. He also prolongs the span of his life for as long as he wishes. In short, he displays as much as he wishes and as much as pleases him. These are the qualities of one who has gained mastery of the five

superknowledges. If even one who has attained the five superknowledges thus has power over the mastery of his own life, how could the Tathāgata, who has attained mastery, not possess such power? Why would the Tathāgata not remain for an eon or more than an eon? Understand that the Tathāgata is permanent, stable, and eternal. Understand, too, that in this world the emanated body is not a body of flesh, and that today the Tathāgata is casting off a body that depends on poisons and medicines. Strive also in the supreme teaching called 'permanent, stable, and eternal.'"

Kāśyapa of the Mahākāśyapa clan said, "If the Tathāgata is permanent, what difference is there between the worldly and the transcendent? Worldly people also say, 'Our Brahmā is permanent; he has existed since the beginning of time.' What difference is there from that? If the Tathāgata is permanent, there would be no difference."

Fascicle four.

The Blessed One said, "Son of noble family, suppose, for example, that a merchant or a householder had many cows of various coat colors, of many breeds and lineages, in a single herd and a single pen, many of them, as many as ten million. He entrusted those cows to cowherds and ate delicious butter, while the cowherds looked after the pen and churned curd and milk. Later, the owner of the cows came to the end of his life and died. After his death, bandits roaming the forest stole those cows, and because they had no wives, each of them churned the milk himself. Because it was milk churned by them, not even the smell of butter came from that milk. It did not turn into curd, nor into buttermilk, nor into cream, so how could it ever become butter? It even lost the very nature of milk, and they adulterated it with water, all the while thinking, 'I shall enjoy butter! I shall enjoy butter!'

"Worldly people who are rich in wealth and in teachings that have arisen as an outflow of the Buddha's Dharma are just like that. When the buddhas, the blessed ones, like the owner of the cattle pen, have passed into parinirvāṇa, worldly people who are like bandits twist aside moral discipline, ritual, discipline, the spheres of conduct, and the elements of sentient beings. They think, 'There is a sentient being, there is a life, there is a person,' and thinking, 'Liberation is like this, conduct is like this,' they do not know conduct, sentient beings, liberation, permanence, or suchness. Because they strive after other aims, they do not attain liberation, nor do they find moral discipline, ritual, the spheres of conduct, discipline, permanence, or suchness. Like the bandits'

butter, worldly people do not attain the suchness of the Dharma. They hold that sentient beings emanated by Brahmā are permanent, and they hold, 'Mine is liberation,' and like the bandits' milk, they do not know suchness.

"Because they practice celibacy, because they abstain from others' wives, and because they serve their fathers and mothers, they obtain and enjoy a mere fraction of the happiness of the higher realms, just as the bandits had a mere remnant of spoiled milk. Yet they do not know what serving father and mother really is. They do not know what going for refuge to the Three really is. They do not know what abstaining from others' wives really is. They do not know what permanence really is. In this case, the emanation of the Buddha is impermanent and false, and so worldly people hold, 'The Tathāgata is impermanent, he is not stable.' Therefore, as the remedy for impermanence, one should strive in the teaching that the Tathāgata is permanent.

"Son of noble family, then a universal monarch who is fortunate enough to possess that cattle pen appears in the world, and through the power of the universal monarch's merit, those bandits do not make even a single cow disappear. Then the bandits roaming the forest abandon that cattle pen and depart. Then the universal monarch's precious householder takes charge of the cattle pen, and that precious householder, by his own intelligence, comes to know the method for the true nature of the milk of that pen, and through the merit of the universal monarch, the cows yield twice as much milk. In just the same way, when the Buddha, the turner of the wheel of Dharma, appears in the world and takes into his care all worldly beings, who are like the cattle pen, the word 'permanent' befits the Tathāgata alone. Worldly people who are like bandits, even though they abide by the name and the marks of the Buddha, do not attain it."

The śrāvakas of the Tathāgata are like a precious householder who tends his herd of cattle: they look after the herd of the sacred Dharma, and they draw the milk of the Dharma for the sake of beings who have merit. Son of good family, for that reason the Tathāgata is permanent, stable, and eternal. Worldly people have no permanent dharma, and I say that the word "permanent" belongs to the tathāgatas, the buddhas, alone.

So sons or daughters of good family should understand it in this way: "The Buddha, the Blessed One, is permanent. The Buddha, the Blessed One, is eternal." Those beings who meditate on the two syllables "permanent" will, before long, attain my state, lacking nothing and exceeding nothing. Son of

good family, when meditation on the two syllables "permanent" dies out, at that time the Tathāgata will pass into parinirvāṇa. That is the nature of reality of the buddhas.

Kāśyapa asked, "Blessed One, what is the meaning of what you said, 'the nature of reality of the buddhas'? Blessed One, I wish to understand this discourse, so may the Blessed One please explain this statement in detail."

The Blessed One said, "'The nature of reality' means fully casting off the body. Know that this phrase, 'fully casting off the body,' is an expression of disparagement."

Kāśyapa said, "I ask whether the Tathāgata, having cast off his body, takes on a body again or does not."

The Blessed One said, "Son of good family, do not speak like that. This is an inquiry into the nature of reality. Son of good family, consider the beings without perception. If they lack both the aggregate of form and the aggregate of perception, how do those beings abide? How do they exist? How do they appear? How does their perception operate? Such a question is the domain of a buddha. Son of good family, from now on do not ask, 'How are the form, the abode, the deportment, and the happiness of the gods without perception to be taught?' This is not the domain of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. It is the sphere of the buddhas.

"Son of good family, in the same way the body of the Tathāgata is the domain of the buddhas alone, and not the domain of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. Where the Tathāgata abides and where he appears is not your domain either, so you should rest in the thought, 'The Buddha, the Blessed One, is a body whose skillful means are inconceivable.'

"Son of good family, meditate again and again on the perception of permanence with regard to the Dharma and to the Saṅgha of monks as well. Do not make distinctions among the three bases. Do not meditate on them under the aspect of being impermanent, unstable, not eternal, not at peace, or not liberation. I say that the going for refuge of those sons or daughters of good family who do not meditate in that way on the great nature of the three bases is pure. Thus the meditation on permanence is inconceivable.

"Son of good family, where there is a tree there is a shadow, and where there is no tree there is no shadow. In the same way, the Tathāgata is permanent and is a refuge. If he were impermanent, he would not be fit to be a refuge for

gods and humans."

Kāśyapa asked, "Blessed One, how is it? In the darkness of night, should one say that the shadow of a tree appears, or that it does not appear?"

The Blessed One said, "Kinsman of Mahākāśyapa, why should one say that the shadow of a tree that is there does not exist? Even so, the eye of flesh does not see it. In the same way, the Tathāgata too is permanent, stable, and eternal. Yet although he is eternal, just as the eye of flesh does not see a tree's shadow in the darkness of night, so too, because the Tathāgata enacts his parinirvāṇa, beings imagine that the Tathāgata is impermanent, even though he is permanent, stable, and eternal, just as a tree's shadow cannot be seen in the darkness of night.

"If your parents lack the perception that I, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha are permanent, I say that their going for refuge to the three is not pure. If you teach your two parents that the three bases are permanent, you will gain the name 'a bodhisattva great being, a layman who has gone for refuge to the three.'"

Kāśyapa said, "From this day on, I will declare to my family, down to the seventh generation, and to my two parents, that the Blessed One, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha are permanent. Oh, I will also train in the understanding that the Buddha, the Blessed One, is inconceivable. I will teach it to others as well. And those wicked beings who do not accept it as I teach it, and who speak of impermanence, I will treat like a hailstorm."

The Blessed One said, "Excellent, excellent, son of good family! A son of good family who protects the sacred Dharma must act in just this way. You have done well, son of good family. In this way you have entered upon non-harming. Through the great fruit of the karma of non-harming, bodhisattva great beings live long lives and also remember their former lives."

This concludes the first chapter, the Chapter on the Mass of Non-harming.

"Son of good family, now look upon the Tathāgata as a permanent body, an indestructible body, a vajra body, a body not made of flesh, a Dharma body."

Kāśyapa said, "If the Tathāgata passes into parinirvāṇa, I will not see him that way. If he passes into parinirvāṇa, I will see him as a body that can be destroyed, a body of ashes, a body of flesh."

The Blessed One said, "Son of good family, do not say 'a brittle body like a human's, a body that can be destroyed.' Kinsman of Mahākāśyapa, for many

tens of millions of eons the Tathāgata has possessed an indestructible body. It is not a human body, not a divine body, not the body of any form of existence, and not a body of flesh. The body of the Tathāgata is bodiless, unborn and unceasing. It does not exist. It has no entering, no final end and no abiding. It is without consciousness and without activity. It is utterly pure. It is not anything at all, and it is not appropriated. It is without feet and without abode, without change and without experience. It is unmixed, unknowing and unknowable, and it cannot be cognized. It is inconceivable and unthinkable. It is without consciousness and free from mind. It is the very equality of mind, and it goes into the equality of mind. It has no descent, and coming and going are wholly cut off in it. It is uncut and cannot be cut. It gives no opening. It is not a substance and has not arisen. It is without conduct, without conceptual thought and without name. It is not established, not experience, and not manifest. It is without object, without basis, without darkness and without light. It is not peaceful, not utterly peaceful, and free from peace. It is pure and completely pure. It is nothing at all. It is without grasping, without attachment and without afflictions, free from afflictions. It abides by way of not abiding. It cannot be seized. It has no transference and cannot be transferred. It is not a phenomenon, yet it is not that it is not a phenomenon. It is not a field, yet it is not that it has not become a field. It is inexhaustible, it cannot be exhausted, it is free from exhaustion, it has no exhaustion. It is momentary, free from momentariness, and not momentary. It is undisturbed. It has entirely abandoned letters and dots, entirely abandoned sound, entirely abandoned explanation, entirely abandoned meditation, and entirely abandoned thought. It is not conjoined, and not unconjoined. It is measureless, and not measureless. It has no going and no coming. It is nondual. It has no undertaking and no exertion of power. It is without marks and cannot be realized through marks, yet it is adorned with the marks. It is utterly stable and utterly peaceful, free from torment. It does not fall. It cannot be seen. It is fully discerned. It is suchness. It is reality. By way of not liberating, it liberates all sentient beings. By way of not freeing, it frees. By way of not purifying, it purifies. By way of not releasing, it releases. By way of being a nondual teacher, it is the equal teacher. It is equal to the unequalled, equal to the immeasurable, equal to space, equal to the placeless, equal to the unborn, equal to the unobservable; it has become equal to the unequalled. It is peace, utter peace, close peace, without support. It is measureless. It transforms conduct. It has irreversibly cut off all fixed grasping. It has nothing beyond it. It teaches nonduality. By way of not cognizing and by way of not conjoining, it is

the essential nature of intrinsic nature. It is not long and not round. It is not divided into aggregates, not divided into elements, and not divided into sense sources. It is without the conceptuality of the conditioned, and without any ground for the conceptuality of the conditioned. It has no increase and no decrease. It is immeasurable, and not immeasurable. It is keen, and not keen. It cannot be worshipped, and it is not that it cannot be worshipped.

"Thus the body of the Tathāgata possesses immeasurable and inconceivable qualities. No one has known it, seen it, or heard it; no one has distinguished it or cognized it. It does not exist. It cannot be expressed in words. It is not included within the world. It has not arisen from a cause, nor has it arisen from no cause. That body cannot in any way be cognized by conceptual or nonconceptual characteristics, by bases of characteristics, by characteristics, by enumeration, or by comparison. It has neither gone into nirvāṇa nor not gone. The Tathāgata possesses immeasurable qualities.

"Kinsman of Mahākāśyapa, the body of the Tathāgata is something the Tathāgata himself comes to understand by way of the entities of signs; none of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas are able to do so. How could the Tathāgata, who possesses such qualities and is not a body of flesh, fall ill, be harmed, or be destroyed like a clay vessel? Whatever display there is of destruction, of sickness, and of passing into nirvāṇa, it should be seen as being for the sake of those to be trained. Therefore, from this day on, bear in mind that the body of the Tathāgata is indestructible and hard like a vajra. Teach others as well: 'It is not a body of flesh.' Understand that the Tathāgata is the Dharma body."

The kinsman of Mahākāśyapa said, "Blessed One, that being so, how could there be illness, impermanence or destruction for the Tathāgata, who possesses such qualities? From now on I wish to teach others too that the Tathāgata is the Dharma body, permanent, stable, everlasting and peaceful. How, then, is this body, indestructible like a vajra, accomplished? From what cause is such a body accomplished?"

The Blessed One said, "This body of mine is accomplished through the cause of the merit of protecting the true Dharma. Son of good family, a layman who protects the true Dharma need not take up the five bases of training, nor need he practice the discipline of a layman. To protect the monks who possess moral discipline, proper conduct and good qualities, he should carry bows and arrows, swords, and short broad-bladed spears."

The kinsman of Mahākāśyapa said, "Those monks who do not sit together with guards, but stay alone on a seat spread at the foot of a tree, are the ones called monks. Those who sit together with guards are the ones called shaven-headed householders."

The Blessed One said, "Son of noble family, do not speak of them as 'shaven-headed householders.' Here, a certain monk stays in a new lodging. After eating his food, he sits alone in a secluded place without speaking. He practices meditative concentration and contemplates the intrinsic nature of the body. To the beings who come to him he gives talks on generosity, talks on moral discipline, talks on merit, and talks on the karmic maturation of merit, and he teaches the Dharma of contentment and few desires. Yet he does not roar the lion's roar, he does not keep a lion-like retinue, and he does not teach in order to subdue those who wear the marks of a monk but are corrupt. Such a monk has not set out for the benefit of all people, nor has he set out for his own benefit. Because his afflictions are weak, he is merely someone who has moral discipline and practices pure conduct.

"Another monk, endowed with moral discipline and possessed of virtuous qualities, goes from one place to another, staying in new lodgings, and roars the lion's roar. For the benefit and happiness of all sentient beings he teaches the nine branches of the scriptures: the sūtras, the sung verses, the expositions, the verses, the inspired utterances, the accounts of what happened thus, the birth stories, the extensive teachings, and the marvelous phenomena. And he teaches: 'This sūtra declares that monks who keep improper possessions, such as male and female slaves, cattle, and buffalo, are to be punished, and this applies to our circumstances. In a certain great sūtra as well, the Blessed One had a certain great king punish renunciants who kept improper possessions, and he had those of corrupt morality wear white clothes.' When he roars the lion's roar in this way, those of corrupt morality may stir up trouble against him and even take his life, yet I call that monk one endowed with moral discipline, one who has set out for his own benefit and for the benefit of others.

"For this reason, in order to protect the holy Dharma, I permit kings, ministers, and laymen to protect the monks, and I also permit them to punish the shaven-headed householders. Among these, it is those of corrupt morality who are called shaven-headed householders; that is not a name for those endowed with moral discipline.

"Son of noble family, long ago in the past, countless eons ago, in this very city of Kuśinagara, a tathāgata, an arhat, a perfectly complete buddha called Nandivardhana appeared in the world. At that time this world realm was as vast as Sukhāvatī, and the beings of that time, like the bodhisattvas of Sukhāvatī, were never weakened by famine. That Tathāgata lived for many tens of millions of years and then passed into nirvāṇa in this very city and at this very place. After that, his teaching endured for many tens of millions of years. When forty years of the teaching's duration remained, at the time when the holy Dharma was about to decline, there appeared a monk called Buddhadatta, who had a large following, who roared the lion's roar, and who taught the Dharma of the nine branches of the scriptures. Those of corrupt morality, who kept improper possessions such as male and female slaves, cattle, and buffalo, who taught a false Dharma and whose minds were filled with hatred, heard of him and resolved to kill him. The faction of the immoral gathered together, took up all kinds of weapons in their hands, and went to where that monk was.

"At that time I was a king called Bhavadatta. When the king heard the news, he went to where the monk was in order to protect the holy Dharma, and he did battle with them. As a result, they were unable to harm the one who spoke the Dharma. But on the king's body there was not even a spot the size of a mustard seed that had not been pierced by swords, short flat-bladed spears, single-pointed vajras, and arrows.

"When the monk saw the king in that state, he said, 'Excellent! This is how one who protects the holy Dharma must act. You will become a vessel of immeasurable Dharma.' The king heard the monk's words, and after he died he was born in the world realm of the Tathāgata Akṣobhya. All the beings there who had rejoiced in this, and all those who had joined in the battle, also attained awakening. In Abhirati, the world realm of the Tathāgata Akṣobhya, there also appeared one called the Likeness of the Tathāgata Akṣobhya. The monk Buddhadatta also died, after the king's death, and became the foremost śrāvaka in the teaching of the Tathāgata Akṣobhya. The king became his second śrāvaka. Thus, when the holy Dharma is in decline, one should protect the holy Dharma.

"I was the one who was king at that time. That monk was the Buddha Kāśyapa, and he has passed into parinirvāṇa. Thus the fruit of protecting the holy Dharma is immeasurable. By that pure fruit I too became as though adorned with the many patterned eyes of a peacock's feathers, and I came to delight in

an indestructible body, a Dharma body."

Kāśyapa, who was of the same clan as Mahākāśyapa, said, "The Tathāgata possesses a permanent body, like letters carved in stone."

The Blessed One said, "Son of noble family, therefore one who wishes to protect the holy Dharma should protect any monk, nun, layman, or laywoman, wherever they may be. The fruit of a layman's protecting the holy Dharma is vast. Son of noble family, therefore the monks should travel with armed laymen escorting them in front. In this Great Vehicle, a layman is not to take up the five bases of training; rather, in order to protect the holy Dharma, he should take weapons in hand and protect the monks.

He asked, "What is the case here? Those monks who keep company and travel together with such laymen carrying weapons in their hands: are they teachers, or are they not teachers? Are they to be called immoral, or are they not?"

The Blessed One said, "Son of good family, after the Tathāgata has passed into complete nirvāṇa, internal strife will arise and lands will be laid waste. At that time, when the age has turned evil, many will go forth and shave their heads because of the calamity of famine. They will drive out and kill monks who are perfect in moral discipline, in rites, in good qualities and in conduct. How then are monks who possess moral discipline to travel through villages, towns and mountain hamlets? In such times, when monks who possess moral discipline and have become teachers travel on the road, I permit those who carry weapons in their hands to go there with them, in order to protect their lives.

"I say that when laymen, householders, kings and ministers bear weapons in order to protect monks who possess moral discipline, that too is moral discipline. Yet they should not kill. Weapons are to be borne in order to ward off harm, and that is a moral discipline of supreme skill.

"A teacher is one who teaches the instructions of the Great Vehicle and the correct view; who has given up improper parasols, oil vessels and the various kinds of fruit; who does not attach himself to kings and ministers; who does not speak in flattering and pleasing words to donors for the sake of gain; who is perfect in deportment; who dispels the ways of unruly ascetics; who possesses moral discipline and wholesome qualities; who holds an intellect like the ocean; who does not desire any other appearance, attire, gain or honor; and who is content and shows that he has few possessions. Such a one is called a teacher. He turns back those of the Saṅgha in his own circle who desire a following, gain and honor.

"The Saṅgha, moreover, is of three kinds: the Saṅgha mixed with the immoral, the Saṅgha of the childish, and the Saṅgha that is so by intrinsic nature.

"Of these, he turns back the Saṅgha mixed with the immoral. The Saṅgha mixed with the immoral means those who simply go along with the immoral, who do not punish them, and who share their conduct with them for the sake of material things. Even though they possess moral discipline, by dwelling together with them they come to be counted among the immoral alone. This is called being mixed with the immoral. Because he turns back their improper ways, he is called a teacher.

"The Saṅgha of the childish means forest dwellers, those of weak merit and the dull. At the times of the invitation ceremony and of the poṣadha, they purify only their own circle and do not purify the immoral, but remain mingled with them. This is called the Saṅgha of the childish. Because he dispels the improper ways of these dull ones, he is called a teacher.

"The Saṅgha that is so by intrinsic nature cannot be destroyed even by millions of māras. It is the Saṅgha of bodhisattvas, pure by intrinsic nature. Those who turn back the two kinds of immoral Saṅgha are called teachers.

"One who is called a holder of the Vinaya knows each of the training rules in accordance with those who are to be disciplined. He knows the great severity, and he knows the lesser severity. He does not uphold as authoritative what is not Vinaya; he upholds the Vinaya.

"If it is asked how he knows what accords with those who are to be disciplined: there are bodhisattvas who go into towns in accordance with those who are to be disciplined. Apart from women, the halls of dancing girls, the houses of widows and the houses of prostitutes, they may go into the interior or the forecourt of any house they wish, and for them there is no fixed time for going there. A bodhisattva monk can bear to wander in towns for many years, but a śrāvaka monk cannot.

"If it is asked how he knows the great severity and the lesser severity: the great severity means that whenever the Tathāgata saw an occasion of misconduct arise, after seeing it he laid down a training rule: 'From now on do not commit such things as these four defeats. If you commit them, you cannot be ordained.' That is called the great severity. The lesser severity means that someone here commits one such offense but has not made that training rule firm; even when the Tathāgata sees this up to three times, he lays down

another training rule. This is called fully remediable, and it is called the lesser severity.

"Moreover, he upholds the Vinaya concerning offenses with remainder. He does not uphold the Vinaya that arises from the benefits of improper gifts. He trains in the Vinaya. The immoral one has abandoned moral discipline while keeping the robes, and that is a grave matter. He does not uphold that one's Vinaya either; whatever appears in the Vinaya, with that he is supremely content. From the Buddha's scriptures he teaches what is suited to the circumstances, and what is gathered from them I also call Vinaya. Such a one is a holder of the Vinaya. He knows even a single syllable, and whoever knows a single syllable in this way is a holder of the Vinaya in the world. This is called a holder of the Vinaya with respect to the sūtras. In this way the teaching of the Tathāgata is immeasurable. The Tathāgata is inconceivable."

He said, "Blessed One, even to behold the Tathāgata is inconceivable. He is permanent, stable, eternal and at peace; he is inconceivable. I wish to teach this to others as well."

The Blessed One said, "Excellent, excellent, you who are of the same clan as Mahākāśyapa! The Tathāgata has entered upon holding a body indestructible like a vajra. So one should hold correct view and the training in reverence."

A bodhisattva great being who rightly sees the Tathāgata as possessing a body that is indestructible like a vajra sees the ultimate body clearly, just as a reflection naturally appears on the surface of a mirror.

This is the second chapter, called "The Mass of the Body Indestructible Like a Vajra."

"Furthermore, son of noble family, now grasp correctly the name of this sūtra, its qualities, and its manner. If beings hear the name of this sūtra, it is impossible that they should go to the four destinies. I shall teach the qualities and the manner of this great sūtra just as many buddhas have taught them."

He asked, "How do bodhisattva great beings correctly hold the name of this sūtra? How are they counted among those who hold the name of this sūtra?"

The Blessed One declared, "This sūtra is called the Great Parinirvāṇa. Its pure conduct is virtuous in the beginning, virtuous in the middle, and virtuous at the end. It is good in meaning and good in wording, unadulterated, perfectly complete, perfectly pure, and perfectly cleansed. It is renowned as a vajra-like treasure and as great.

"Son of noble family, just as the eight rivers, the Ganges, the Yamunā and the rest, flow only into the great ocean, so too victory over all māras, such as the māra whose nature is many millions of afflictions of every kind, will converge in this very Great Parinirvāṇa, this casting off of the body and dying. Therefore it is called the Great Parinirvāṇa.

"Furthermore, just as the sciences, such as the three medical sciences, each converge entirely in their own final tantra, so too all the various secret Dharma doors of intentional speech taught by the Tathāgata converge entirely within the Great Parinirvāṇa alone. Therefore it is called the Great Parinirvāṇa.

"Just as in summer a farmer plows with a great plow and sows seed, wishing for the seed to come to fruition, and once it has come to fruition has no further wish, because that is the culmination of all fruition, so too beings, even after they have meditated on the samādhis of all the sūtras, still wish for the essence of other sūtras; but the essence of this sūtra is the culmination of all fruition, and through it all beings will cross beyond all existences.

"Son of noble family, just as all footprints of whatever kind are included within the footprint of the elephant, and the elephant's footprint is called the best among them, called the supreme, called the foremost, so too, son of noble family, all the samādhis of this sūtra, whatever they may be, are included within the Great Parinirvāṇa alone, and among all the samādhis of this sūtra the great sūtra of Parinirvāṇa is called the best, called the supreme, called the foremost.

"Furthermore, son of noble family, just as sowing crops in autumn is called the best of all plowings, called the supreme, called the foremost, so too plowing with the great plow of permanence of the great sūtra of Parinirvāṇa is called the best of all sūtras, called the supreme, called the foremost. It should be applied likewise to everything; here it is applied to the means of the side of purity. The analysis found in the Saṃyukta sūtras of the Śrāvaka Vehicle should also be applied here.

"Furthermore, son of noble family, just as for one struck by a disease of excess bile, ghee and the medicine of the eight sweets alone are especially beneficial, so too for one seized by the disease of excess bile with regard to the Tathāgata's intentional speech, the sūtras of the Great Vehicle and the medicine of the eight sweets of the Great Nirvāṇa alone are especially beneficial. If one asks what the eight sweets are here, they are permanence, stability, eternity, peace, the nature of coolness, agelessness, deathlessness,

stainlessness, and bliss. These are here called the eight sweets. Because it is the great sweet, it is therefore called the Great Parinirvāṇa.

"If bodhisattva great beings abide in that name, those qualities, and that manner, they display nirvāṇa in many forms. Therefore it is called the Great Parinirvāṇa.

"A son or daughter of noble family who wishes to pass into nirvāṇa through this Great Parinirvāṇa should strive at the thought, 'The Tathāgata, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha are permanent.' A son or daughter of noble family who wishes to practice the conduct of the Great Parinirvāṇa should strive at the thought, 'The Tathāgata is permanent.'"

He said, "Oh, Blessed One, the Tathāgata is inconceivable. The teaching of the Dharma is inconceivable. The Saṅgha, endowed with a wealth of qualities, is inconceivable. Likewise this sūtra of the Great Parinirvāṇa is also inconceivable. Those who act in accordance with its instruction are beings who hold it correctly. They are like stūpas. The others are to be lamented; they dwell in the wilderness of ignorance."

This is the third chapter, called "The Reasons for the Sūtra's Name and the Manner of Its Qualities."

"Son of noble family, here bodhisattva great beings teach four kinds of Dharma categories from the great sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa. If one asks what the four kinds are, they are what is called one's own superior intention, what is called the superior intention of others, what is called the force of a question, and what is called the force of a circumstance that has arisen concerning a matter. These are the four.

"Among these, what is called one's own superior intention is when the Tathāgata teaches the Dharma on seeing something. For example, on seeing a pile of wood blazing and shining, he said: 'Monks who, on hearing the various secrets from the Tathāgata, tell others, "This was spoken by Māra," and who say of various words of their own invention, "These were spoken by the Tathāgata,"

Having done so, they say that the buddhas, the blessed ones, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha of monks are impermanent. Rather than say that, it would be easier to embrace this blazing pile of wood from every side and take it into one's lap. Those who say, "This was spoken by Māra," and those who hold to that perverse teaching speak falsely. Rather than speak the words "The

Tathāgata is impermanent," it would be better to touch this blazing pile of wood all over with one's tongue and die. One should not even listen to such words. Those who are unable to affirm that the Tathāgata is permanent are to be grieved for. The buddhas, the blessed ones, are inconceivable. Likewise, one should hold that their teaching and the Saṅgha of śrāvakas who follow them are also inconceivable. What has been said up to "blazing pile of wood" is the category called "speaking according to one's own intent."

"Speaking according to another's intent" is this. Once, while the Blessed One was dwelling and teaching the Dharma, a certain young woman who had newly given birth came before the Blessed One, sat down to one side, and sat there thinking. Then the Blessed One, knowing her thoughts, taught the Dharma, saying: "It is like a woman who, loving her child and skilled in means, knows how much he is able to digest, and lets her little child lick butter from the tip of her finger."

Then the woman said: "Oh, the Blessed One has understood the thoughts of my mind and has spoken without omission or excess. It is exactly as you have instructed me. Blessed One, today I gave the infant butter from the tip of my finger, but it was too much, and so it has not been digested. What will happen, Blessed One? Will this boy of mine be long-lived, or will he be short-lived? Please, Blessed One, Tathāgata, tell me."

He said: "This son of yours will be happy and long-lived."

Then the woman, delighted, said: "By your truthful words I am greatly delighted. In just this way the Tathāgata looks to the capacities of those to be trained and, matching his teaching to their strength to digest it or not, teaches all phenomena as selfless and as suffering. If the Blessed One were to teach beings the secret of permanence without matching it to their greater or lesser strength, then, like butter that is not digested, beings would fall ill."

He said: "Sister, excellent, excellent! A daughter of good family should act just so. Sister, furthermore, when your son is able to take steps, then whatever rich foods are given to him, he will be able to digest them."

"Blessed One, that is true."

He said: "Will he then be satisfied with his first food?"

She replied: "Blessed One, he will not."

He said: "Sister, in the same way, when my śrāvakas are like a little child who eats only a little, then I teach, like the butter, the meaning of suffering,

impermanence, emptiness, and selflessness. When, like your son grown up, they have become great śrāvakas, their strength has grown great, and they desire the Great Vehicle, then I too teach the great sūtra of the Great Parinirvāṇa, which is like a great meal of six flavors. What are the six flavors? The sourness of suffering, the saltiness of impermanence, the pungency of selflessness, the sweetness of bliss, the astringency of self, and the bitterness of permanence. Cooked with these six flavors over the firewood of the afflictions and the fire of illusion, this food, the delicious rice of the suchness of the Great Parinirvāṇa, my śrāvakas will eat.

"Sister, furthermore, suppose you were summoned by someone else, or wished to go to another town to tie someone's topknot. Would you leave behind your bad sons, take your good sons, and show them your secret treasures?"

"Blessed One, that is true. To bad sons who lack proper conduct and have no share in the wealth, I would not show the wealth. But to good sons who maintain the household, carry out the household's affairs, and are fit to be shown the goods, I would show it."

He said: "Sister, in the same way, when he is about to go into the Great Parinirvāṇa, the Tathāgata teaches the śrāvakas, without exception, the words of intended meaning concerning the various secrets, and so bestows faith upon his sons. Sister, suppose you went abroad. Would your bad sons think you had died, though you had not died?"

"Blessed One, that is true."

He said: "Then, when you return, they see you. In the same way, do not conceive of me as impermanent. Do not hold, as one would perceive a death, that today the Tathāgata will pass into parinirvāṇa. In the homes of those who always hold that the Tathāgata is permanent, stable, and everlasting, the Tathāgata dwells." This is called "speaking according to another's intent."

"Speaking by force of a question" is this. Here, someone asks the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha: "Blessed One, what should I do so that, without giving anything at all to anyone, I may gain the good report of being renowned in the world as a giver?" The Tathāgata said this to him: "Offer servants and maidservants to one who is free of attachment. Give daughters in marriage to one who always practices celibacy. Make one who does not eat meat eat meat. Make one who does not drink liquor drink liquor. Give food at the wrong time to one who eats at the proper time. To one who does not wear

garlands and ornaments, give powders, perfumes, flowers, and incense. Know the right time for them and invite them as guests. If you do this, you will become greatly renowned as the king of donors in this world, but your merit will not increase."

The fifth fascicle.

Then the one of the same clan as Mahākāśyapa said this:

"Since urging people not to eat meat is of such great importance, would it not be wrong to allow those who do not eat meat to eat it?"

The Blessed One declared, "Son of good family, excellent, excellent! You have understood my intention. One who protects the true Dharma must act in just this way. Son of good family, from now on I do not permit my śrāvakas to eat meat. Since it is said that the alms food of the land is like the flesh of one's own son, how could I permit the eating of meat? I have taught that eating meat cuts off great loving-kindness."

He asked, "Blessed One, then why did you permit the eating of meat that is pure in three respects?"

The Blessed One declared, "I laid down this rule of meat pure in three respects so as to restrain the training step by step. Today I set it aside."

He asked, "Blessed One, with what intention did you teach the nine aspects of what is done for one's sake, and the avoidance of the ten kinds of meat?"

The Blessed One declared, "Those statements too were laid down in order to restrain people from eating meat."

He asked, "Blessed One, with what intention did you also speak of meat and fish as excellent food?"

The Blessed One declared, "I did not speak of meat and fish as excellent food. What I spoke of as excellent food is sugarcane, sāli rice, grain, wheat, barley, lentils and peas, brown sugar and white sugar, honey, butter, milk, and oils. I have taught that even the various garments that cover the body should be dyed a drab color. So what need is there to speak of craving the taste of meat?"

He said, "In that case, it would also be fitting to make rules against the five products of the cow, sesame, oil, tree sap, conch shell, silk, and the like."

The Blessed One declared, "Do not hold the view of the Nirgranthas, the naked ascetics. I now lay down a training rule for you with a different notion in mind. I

have prohibited even meat of the three kinds. I have also prohibited what you know to have been done for one's sake. I have also rejected meat apart from the ten kinds. I have also rejected the meat of animals that have died.

"Whether one who eats meat is walking or sitting, all living creatures catch his scent and fear him. For example, when a person has eaten asafoetida or garlic, everyone becomes displeased and averse, and in a gathering of many people or in a crowd, those beings know, 'So-and-so has eaten it.' In the same way, all living creatures recognize a person who eats meat. Catching his scent, they are terrified with the fear of death. When he moves about, the beings that live in the water, on dry land and in the sky are frightened, and thinking, 'This one is coming to kill us,' they may even die of panic. For these reasons, bodhisattva great beings do not eat meat. For the sake of those to be trained, they may appear to eat meat, but since they do not even eat ordinary food, what need is there to speak of meat?

"Son of good family, when many hundreds of years have passed after my passing, when stream-enterers, once-returners, non-returners and arhats have ceased to exist, and the true Dharma has utterly perished, there will appear monks who hold the Vinaya and the Mātṛkā, full of various notions, who nourish their own bodies, cherish various kinds of meat, whose elements are disordered, who are tormented by hunger and thirst, who look frightful, who are like cowherds, like fowlers, who bear the mark of dyed robes, who practice the conduct of a cat, who claim, 'I am an arhat,' who are oppressed by many harms, whose bodies are soiled with their own urine and excrement, who feign a fine appearance like a sage, who are not śramaṇas but pretend to be śramaṇas, and who hold counterfeit scriptures that resemble the true Dharma. They will destroy the Vinaya I have laid down, the manner endowed with rite and proper sphere of conduct, the freedom from attachment to what is not allowable, and the words of the reality of liberation. Drawing on the Vinaya and the various sūtras, they will fabricate and speak whatever pleases them, saying, 'In our Vinaya the Blessed One said that the gift of the essence of meat is allowable.' Such śramaṇas, sons of the Śākya, will appear, making things up on their own and speaking in contradiction.

"Moreover, son of good family, there will appear those who accept raw grain that is not allowable, meat and fish, and prepare them as food; who keep vessels of oil, make parasols and make shoes; who attend on kings; who carry divination texts; who are devoted to medical practice; who accept male slaves and female slaves, gold, silver, coral, conch shell, crystal, pearl necklaces and

fruits; who learn sciences, painting and sculpting, planting and cultivating, secret mantras, medicines and children's games, the branches of dance, magical illusion, applications for paralyzing, song and dance, garlands, tooth powders, the boiling of great medicinal oils, the wearing of perfumes and ointments, and affected gaits; and who are devoted to the practices of coquetry. Those who have abandoned these I call monks."

He asked, "Blessed One, then what is to be done? When monks, nuns, laymen and laywomen who live on what others give are in a land where food that has not been examined is plentiful, how are they to purify alms that are mixed with meat?"

The Blessed One declared, "Son of good family, I have taught that, so as not to contradict the Vinaya, one should wash it with water and then eat it. In such a land, food and drink that appear to be heavily mixed with meat should be avoided. Where one vessel merely touches another and the food itself is not mixed, there is no fault. Meat, fish, the meat of wild game, dried hooves, and things smeared with other traces of meat all become offenses requiring expiation; so I say. Earlier I taught this on an occasion when a particular purpose arose. Now, here, I have taught the harm that comes from eating meat. This is what I explain at length at the time of my passing into parinirvāṇa, and this is called teaching by force of a question.

Now, what is called teaching by force of circumstance is this. Monks, nuns, laymen or laywomen ask me: "When the Tathāgata first spoke on only a single point, why did the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, not speak these meanings and words to Prasenajit, king of Kosala? The way the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, taught that gateway of the Dharma was not well spoken." I say that if they speak in this way, it is a fault.

If it is asked, "What is meant by 'protection'? What is meant by 'Vinaya'? What is meant by 'prātimokṣa'?", then know that there are many other faults as well; listen to them.

If it is asked what prātimokṣa means: prātimokṣa means contentment, few possessions, and not accepting. Alternatively, it is called prātimokṣa because it heals with regard to both aims. Because it frees from wrong speech, it is liberation.

Protection is so called because it protects from falling into the four destinies through living by all that is improper, and from being cooked in all the fearful places, such as the Avīci hell.

Vinaya is so called because it brings attainment, because it disciplines, and because it teaches the rites. And because there is no deliverance in accepting impure goods, there is neither accepting impure goods nor giving impure goods. That is what is called Vinaya.

"Then why were the precepts of the Vinaya not laid down all at once?" At that time there were some who had committed the offenses of the four defeats. There were some who had committed the offenses of the thirteen saṅghāvaśeṣa. There were some who had committed the offenses of the thirty forfeiture transgressions. There were some who had committed the offenses of the ninety-one simple transgressions. There were some who had committed the offenses of the four to be individually confessed. There were some who had committed offenses against the many rules of training. There were some who had committed offenses against the seven means of settling disputes. There were some who constantly contravened all the trainings. There were some who committed the acts of immediate retribution. There were some who rejected the sūtras. There were some who had completed the characteristics of the causes that culminate in becoming icchantikas.

Here, monks who do evil deeds and have strayed from all dharmas, even when urged by others, are proud, presenting themselves as learned, and do not confess. Although it was taught that they could be restored, there were some who made themselves beyond restoring. Some conceal their faults the way a tortoise hides its body. Since, by keeping their own faults hidden for a long time in this way, further faults arise and evil accumulates, the Tathāgata, being omniscient, questions the evildoers on each occasion. Laying down one precept at the very beginning, he does not lay down all the precepts at once.

Kāśyapa said: "Does the Tathāgata, knowing this, send them to the utterly terrifying place of Avīci? To give an example: some travelers set out on a road without knowing the straight way. There one road goes off elsewhere, and they leave their road and take the wrong one. Though things go badly for them, they do not realize, 'We have taken the wrong road,' but holding the thought, 'This is the good road,' they press on, and they do not even see travelers coming from the other direction. In the same way, for beings deluded about the Dharma, who have not seen the suchness of the holy Dharma, the Blessed One ought to have shown the road at the very beginning. Since he did not first teach the gravity of transgressions, great and small, the monks have fallen into offenses. So may the Blessed One, the true wayfarer who perfectly

sees the distinctions of the true path, who perfectly sees the benefits of the distinctive qualities of the path of Dharma, the god of gods, please teach the laying down of the precepts for that purpose."

The Blessed One said: "You who share the clan of Mahākāśyapa, do not speak that way to the Tathāgata. The Tathāgata perfectly sees the ten dharmas of distinctive qualities, and since he regards all sentient beings as he regards Rāhula, how could he make monks go to Avīci? If the Tathāgata saw such a cause in even a single sentient being, he would remain in hell for an eon or even longer in order to deliver that being without fail. How then could one endowed with compassion deceive his own children?

"You who share the clan of Mahākāśyapa, suppose there is a weaver in a town or a mountain village. He discards whatever section of the weave on his loom has gone astray. Or suppose there is a universal monarch. At the very beginning he does not train people in the ten virtuous paths of action all at once. Rather, whatever beings resort to what is contrary to Dharma, he subdues each of them with the precious wheel and establishes them in the holy Dharma. In the same way, the Buddha, the Blessed One, does not at the very beginning lay down the precepts of the prātimokṣa all at once. Rather, taking as occasion each circumstance that arose when some monk committed some offense, he lays down a precept. And when those beings who desire the Dharma see each of these, they gain faith, and these are set up as witnesses.

"Thus, having perfectly seen a matter that is extremely hard to examine, just as is the nature of the weaver and of the universal monarch, so too is the nature of the buddhas who turn the wheel of Dharma. In this way the buddhas, the blessed ones, are inconceivable. The teaching of the Dharma is also inconceivable. Likewise, the listeners and those who have faith are also inconceivable. This is what is called teaching by force of circumstance.

"For the sake of circumstances that arise, and because I am passing into parinirvāṇa, bodhisattva great beings teach the Dharma by these four modes of discourse. It should be understood that the great Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra is what is called teaching by force of circumstance.

"As for what is called my own higher intention: since today I explain the teaching of my higher intention, it should be understood that what is called my own higher intention is also the great Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra."

As for "the superior intention of others": I understood the thoughts of the monks and taught, "I am permanent." For this reason the superior intention of

others, too, should be understood to be the great Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra.

As for "in response to questioning": on your account, you who are of the same clan as Mahākāśyapa, a bodhisattva great being endowed with supremely subtle wisdom, I have taught words that no śrāvaka or pratyekabuddha has ever heard before: discourses on the single-syllable drop and various secret words of hidden intent. Therefore "in response to questioning," too, should be understood to be the great Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra.

Some people think, "Put this way it would be deceptive, and put that way it would not be deceptive." For example, a person may call it "space," may call it "emptiness," may call it "nothingness," and may call it "the unobstructed." When he speaks in this way, he does not deceive others. Likewise, if a son or daughter of good family, drawing on this Great Parinirvāṇa, has faith in this permanence taught by the Blessed One and expounds the four kinds of Dharma, they do not deceive others.

When a blazing lump of iron
Is struck, it gradually
Grows cold, yet the fire's heat,
Like something whose whereabouts no one knows,
So too those perfectly liberated,
Who have crossed the mire and river of desire
And attained unshakable bliss:
Where they have gone cannot be designated.

He spoke again: "Son of good family, do not grieve by holding the perception that the tathāgatas become nonexistent. 'Iron' and 'lump of iron' do not differ in meaning. Just as the iron blazing with fire grows cold, so there is no case of the tathāgatas becoming nonexistent. Just as the iron blazing with fire grows cold, the forms of the afflictions are pacified. But if, when the iron blazing with fire grows cold, it became nonexistent along with all its radiating heat, then the Tathāgata too would be impermanent. It is impossible, however, for that iron to become nonexistent along with its glow. Likewise, it is impossible for the Tathāgata, together with this great nirvāṇa, to become impermanent. Just as the fire in the iron grows cold, so the Tathāgata, having exhausted the afflictions accumulated over many countless myriads of eons, becomes permanent, stable, and everlasting. Thus the perfectly liberated Tathāgata is permanent, stable, and everlasting.

"'The mire of desire' means the afflictions. Because he crossed over that mire of afflictions through countless eons, no abode of the Tathāgata can be designated for the Tathāgata who has passed into parinirvāṇa. Therefore:

Those with perfect knowledge and liberation,
Who have crossed the mire and river of desire
And attained unshakable bliss:
Where they have gone cannot be designated."

He asked, "Blessed One, how can this be? Just as iron, even after it has grown cold, becomes hot again afterward from fire, so if the Tathāgata were like that, he would be impermanent."

He said, "The Tathāgata is permanent. Having himself become like fire, he instructs many beings who are like iron through the fire of wisdom, and brings their unreal afflictions to exhaustion."

He said, "Excellent, Blessed One, excellent! Please explain the permanence of the Tathāgata completely."

He said, "Son of good family, here is another example. A universal monarch goes among his circle of queens, and after a moment he comes out into another pleasure grove. He goes there and plays, and when that king has vanished from the circle of queens, one should not give rise to the perception, 'He has died.' Son of good family, in the same way the Tathāgata does not fall away from the nature of reality. As with the king, one should not give rise to the perception that he has passed away, thinking, 'In Jambudvīpa the Tathāgata has become impermanent.' Just as the king goes from the circle of queens to the pleasure grove and plays, so too the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, emerges from the very forms of affliction, which are like the circle of queens. Free of afflictions, the Blessed One goes to a pleasure grove filled with various dhāraṇīs and the various flowers of the limbs of awakening, and there the Tathāgata sports through the various displays of skillful means of his body, which is free of afflictions."

He asked, "I beg you to state the reason for the claim that the Tathāgata definitively crossed the ocean of afflictions over countless myriads of eons. At present, before our eyes, the Tathāgata is shown to have indulged in desires with Rāhula's mother and to have become Rāhula's father. Therefore the Tathāgata has not definitively crossed the river of desire over many myriads of eons."

He said, "Son of good family, do not speak like this: 'At present, before our eyes, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, is shown to have indulged in desires with Rāhula's mother and to have become Rāhula's father; therefore the Tathāgata has not definitively crossed the river of desire over many myriads of eons.' The great parinirvāṇa is called the great permanence. Listen without letting your mind wander elsewhere, and once you have heard it, teach it to others. And do not be frightened by it.

"A bodhisattva great being who abides in this great parinirvāṇa places Mount Meru, king of mountains, so lofty and so vast, inside a mustard seed, and yet does no harm to the beings who live on Mount Meru. Those beings do not know or see it, and do not think, 'Where have we gone? Where have we been carried? Where have we been put?' Other beings, however, know and see it correctly, thinking, 'This bodhisattva great being has put Mount Meru, king of mountains, inside a mustard seed and hidden it.' Then he sets it back in its own place. Such is the domain of a bodhisattva great being who abides in this great sūtra."

Son of good family, beyond even that, the bodhisattva great being who abides in the great parinirvāṇa places a great trichiliocosm, a world system of a billion worlds, inside a mustard seed, and not a single being is harmed. Those beings neither know nor see it, and do not think, "Where have we gone? Where have we been carried? Where have we been put?" Other beings, however, know it correctly and see it correctly, thinking, "This one has done this." Then he puts it back in its own place.

Son of good family, further, the bodhisattva great being who abides in this great parinirvāṇa places a great trichiliocosm in a single pore of his own body, and not a single being is harmed. Those beings neither know nor see it, and do not think, "Where have we gone? Where have we been carried? Where have we been put?" Other beings, however, know it correctly and see it correctly, thinking, "This one has done this."

Son of good family, further, the bodhisattva great being who abides in this great parinirvāṇa, while remaining in this world system, picks up the world systems of the ten directions on the tip of a needle as one would a juniper leaf, and casts them into another world system, and not a single being is harmed. Those beings neither know nor see it, and do not think, "Where have we gone? Where have we been carried? Where have we been put?" Other beings, however, know it correctly and see it correctly, thinking, "This one has done

this." Then he puts them back in their own place.

Son of good family, further, the bodhisattva great being who abides in this great parinirvāṇa takes up the world systems of the ten directions in his right hand and, like a potter's wheel, hurls them far, far beyond as many world systems as there are fine particles of dust, and not a single being is harmed. Those beings neither know nor see it, and do not think, "Where have we gone? Where have we been carried? Where have we been put?" Other beings, however, know it correctly and see it correctly, thinking, "This one has done this." Then he puts them back in their own place.

Son of good family, further, the bodhisattva great being who abides in this great parinirvāṇa places the world systems of the ten directions within his own body, and not a single being is harmed. Those beings neither know nor see it, and do not think, "Where have we gone? Where have we been carried? Where have we been put?" Other beings, however, know it correctly and see it correctly, thinking, "This one has done this." Then he puts them back in their own place.

Son of good family, further, the bodhisattva great being who abides in the great parinirvāṇa places the world systems of the ten directions inside a single atom, and not a single being is harmed. Those beings neither know nor see it, and do not think, "Where have we gone? Where have we been carried? Where have we been put?" Other beings, however, know it correctly and see it correctly, thinking, "This one has done this." Then he puts them back in their own place.

Because the bodhisattva great being who abides in the great parinirvāṇa displays such great miraculous powers as these, in all their various forms, it is called the great nirvāṇa. Since not even all beings together are able to know of the bodhisattva great being who abides in the great parinirvāṇa, "He is like this, he is like that, he has done this, he has done such a thing," then how could you, son of good family, think, "The Tathāgata indulged in sensual pleasures and became the father of Rāhula"?

Son of good family, further, I, now abiding in the great parinirvāṇa, shall display a great miracle in the great trichiliocosm, in those world systems where there are a billion suns and moons and a billion Jambudvīpas. There, the great trichiliocosm should be set out in full in the manner of the Śūraṅgama Samādhi. In the great trichiliocosm, in some Jambudvīpas I appear as if passing into the great parinirvāṇa, yet I do not pass into final nirvāṇa forever

in the great parinirvāṇa.

In some Jambudvīpas I appear to be conceived in the womb at the time of the parents' fertile season, and those two are fully convinced, thinking, "He will be our son." Yet for countless tens of millions of eons I have never once been born of sexual union. Because I have transcended a body born of sexual union, I am not a body of flesh; I am the Dharma body. This entering of a womb through sexual union is nothing more than a means of conforming to the world.

Son of good family, in some Jambudvīpas I also appear to be born as a child into the lap of a mother giving birth, and, like a child born in a pleasure grove, I stand up at once, face north, take seven steps, and say, "I shall become unsurpassed in the world with its gods, humans and asuras." Beings are fully convinced, thinking, "Never before have we seen a child take seven steps the moment it was born. Oh, our son is a son of the gods!" Many other beings also take it as a wonder. Yet for countless tens of millions of eons I have turned away from the state of a child, and so have never once been a child. I am the Dharma body, not a body of bones, sinews, flesh and blood, and this showing of myself becoming a child is nothing more than conforming to the world. Rising from the north, I take seven steps toward the southern quarter and say, "I shall become a field of merit for the whole world."

Taking seven steps toward the west, I declare, "Having abandoned birth, aging, sickness and death, I shall bring this to my last body." Facing east and taking seven steps, I declare, "I shall go at the head of all sentient beings." Taking seven steps in each of the intermediate directions, I declare, "Having vanquished the māra whose nature is the many kinds of afflictions, I shall become an arhat, a perfectly complete buddha." Taking seven steps toward the zenith, I declare, "Swiftly, like space, I shall keep my body unstained by any improper phenomenon." Taking seven steps toward the nadir, I declare, "To put out the hell fires of all the hell beings, I shall send down the rain of Dharma like a great cloud and bring them happiness. For those of corrupt moral discipline I shall be like hail."

In some parts of Jambudvīpa I appear to wear a topknot, and sentient beings take it to be a child's topknot. Yet in the world with its gods there is no one at all who can take hold of my head and cut my hair. Since countless eons ago I have already brought the wearing of a topknot to its end, so it is impossible for a razor to cut my hair. This is merely conforming to the world, for a topknot is something worn only by children.

In some parts of Jambudvīpa I also appear to go to the temple of Maheśvara (Śiva). There, when Maheśvara, Brahmā and the world guardians see me, they bow at my feet and remain with their palms joined. Since countless tens of millions of eons ago I have been the god above the gods of gods, humans and asuras, so I never go to the temple of Maheśvara. Appearing to go there is merely an act conforming to the world.

In some parts of Jambudvīpa I appear to have my ears pierced, yet there is no one who can pierce my ears.

In some parts of Jambudvīpa I appear to wear earrings and bracelets bearing lions, and so sentient beings think, "This child is wearing earrings and bracelets with lions." Yet since countless tens of millions of eons ago I have turned away from childish things, and no earrings or bracelets with lions have been put on me. Appearing to wear them is merely conforming to the world.

In some parts of Jambudvīpa I appear to go to the school where letters are learned, yet in the three worlds I have seen no one fit to be my teacher. I myself am the teacher of all sentient beings. Therefore my name is the Omniscient One. Countless tens of millions of eons ago I passed beyond staying in the school of letters and attained unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening. Nevertheless, sentient beings think, "This boy has gone to school." Understand that this is merely conforming to the world!

In some parts of Jambudvīpa I display elephants, horses, chariots, foot soldiers, all kinds of jewels, treasuries, and sovereign power over a kingdom, and I also appear to act as crown prince. Although since countless tens of millions of eons ago I have abandoned the enjoyment of sense pleasures, sentient beings think, "The crown prince is enjoying sense pleasures."

In some parts of Jambudvīpa I appear to have become a wheel-turning king. Yet countless many tens of millions of eons ago I abandoned that and turned the wheel of Dharma. I cast it away like the flesh of my own son and gave up clinging to the enjoyments of kingship. Nevertheless, sentient beings think, "He is a wheel-turning king." This is merely conforming to the world.

In some parts of Jambudvīpa I appear to grow weary of the world on seeing an old man, a sick man and a dead man, to abandon all pleasures, which are like a theatrical show, and to go forth. Sentient beings think, "Alas, the young prince has gone forth!" Although I completed the work of going forth countless tens of millions of eons ago, appearing to go forth out of weariness is merely conforming to the world. My appearing to receive full ordination is likewise in

order to truly liberate the world.

I also display stream-entry, once-returning, non-returning, arhatship and so forth, and the successive meditative absorptions, and sentient beings think, "Alas, he has very swiftly become an unsurpassed arhat!" Although I completed the work of an arhat countless tens of millions of eons ago, my appearing to sit on spread grass at the foot of the tree of awakening and to subdue Māra is in order to truly liberate the world. Sentient beings think, "Having defeated Māra, he has attained unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening." Yet countless tens of millions of eons ago I defeated the afflictions in all their forms, the divine māra, and the māra of intrinsic nature, and realized the supreme nectar.

I display the acts of defecating, urinating, breathing in and breathing out, yet in my body there is no circulation, no corresponding process, and no ripening. Sentient beings think, "He is like an ordinary human." This is merely conforming to the world. Sentient beings think that I eat food, yet my body is never weakened by hunger. This is merely conforming to the world.

Countless tens of millions of eons ago I accomplished the Perfection of Wisdom and fully abandoned craving, and yet I appear to lie down and sleep. Nevertheless my body has no sleep, no hiccups, no yawning, no aching back and no headache. Lying down to sleep is merely conforming to the world.

I appear to stand, to walk, to blink, to stretch my legs, and to engage in the bodily postures, yet my body has no such afflictions. I appear to wash my feet, to anoint myself with oil, to use water, to chew a tooth-stick, and to apply eye salve, yet my body has no such afflictions. Feet the color of lotus petals, the fragrance of the utpala lotus coming from the mouth, and eyes of incomparable beauty: these too are merely to conform to the world. Sentient beings take it that everything is just as it is with humans.

I appear to pick up rags from the rubbish heap off the ground and wash them, yet I have no need of that. Sentient beings take me to be a human being. Showing myself as the father of Rāhula, and showing Śuddhodana and Māyā as my father and mother, are also for the sake of the world. It is said, "Having experienced the pleasures of the world, he renounced them and went forth into the forest; the prince called Gautama, having distinguished between the desirable and the undesirable, between pleasure and what is not pleasure, seeks the bliss of nirvāṇa." This too is in order to deliver childish beings.

The Tathāgata is not born of sexual union. Showing that he became the father of Rāhula, and showing his own father and mother, are merely to conform to the world. Gods, humans, and asuras take him to be a human tathāgata.

Son of good family, in some parts of Jambudvīpa I show myself again and again as if passing into complete nirvāṇa, yet, since my passing into complete nirvāṇa is permanent, I do not pass into complete nirvāṇa. At times sentient beings take it that the Tathāgata has died, but the Tathāgata is at all times permanent, stable, and everlasting. Showing the passing into complete nirvāṇa is the nature of reality of the buddhas.

In some parts of Jambudvīpa I show myself taking birth, and sentient beings take it that I have been born. Although I completed what was to be done countless tens of millions of eons ago, there too I show myself reaching the culmination, attaining the goal of every stage. This is merely to conform to the world.

In some parts of Jambudvīpa I show myself as one of corrupt moral discipline who has incurred a defeat, and sentient beings think, "Alas, he has incurred a defeat!" Yet I have never at any time been negligent.

In some parts of Jambudvīpa I show myself drawing the blood of the Tathāgata with evil intent, killing an arhat, killing father and mother, and myself causing a schism in the Saṅgha, and sentient beings think, "Alas, this being commits the five acts of immediate retribution!" Yet I do not commit such acts, and in the world with its gods no one at all is able to split the Saṅgha.

In some parts of Jambudvīpa I show myself rejecting the true Dharma and as an icchantika, and sentient beings think, "Alas, this being rejects the true Dharma and is an icchantika!" Showing myself as an icchantika is for the sake of future sentient beings. Worldly people are always icchantikas, but a buddha is not an icchantika.

In some parts of Jambudvīpa I show myself upholding the true Dharma, and sentient beings think, "Ah, he takes the side of the true Dharma!" This is the intrinsic nature of the buddhas; since it is the nature of reality, there is nothing very wondrous in it.

In some parts of Jambudvīpa I show myself as if I were a māra creating obstacles, and sentient beings think, "Alas, it is Māra the Evil One!" Yet just as a lotus is not sullied by water, I am not sullied by the faults of a māra.

In some parts of Jambudvīpa I show myself attaining awakening in the form of a woman, and doubting sentient beings think, "A woman attains awakening." Though the Tathāgata is always male, in order to tame sentient beings he shows himself as both. In the same way he shows himself entering upon many forms as skillful means, and all of these too are merely to conform to the world.

In some parts of Jambudvīpa I show myself taking birth in the four destinies, yet I do not perform the karma for that. Entering birth as an animal is also merely to conform to the world.

In some parts of Jambudvīpa I show the form of Brahmā, and having shown myself obstructing the sentient beings who have faith in Brahmā, I establish them in the true Dharma. Yet I do not perform his karma, and sentient beings take me to be the lord Brahmā. In the same way, in the abodes of all the gods, I take on their forms and obstruct, and so establish all sentient beings in the true Dharma, and sentient beings take me to be the lord of the abodes of all the gods.

In some parts of Jambudvīpa, in order to deliver prostitutes, I show myself going to the houses of prostitutes, yet no fault of desire arises in me. Like a lotus in the water, I am not sullied by the faults of desires. In order to deliver sentient beings attached to desire from the river of desire, I appear at every crossroads and junction, yet I do not perform that karma, and sentient beings think, "This is a wanderer."

In some parts of Jambudvīpa, in order to lead common women to the true Dharma, I go to places of music and entertainment, yet I do not perform that act.

In some parts of Jambudvīpa, in order to deliver children, I go to the schools where writing is learned, act as schoolmaster, and teach the children.

In some parts of Jambudvīpa, in order to deliver those beings, I drink liquor, play at dice, and delight in distractions. Although I do these grave acts, I do not commit that grave act, while sentient beings think, "This one does that act."

In some parts of Jambudvīpa, in order to deliver vultures and crows, I go to the charnel grounds, yet no perception of looking upon them enters me there.

In some parts of Jambudvīpa, in order to establish the true Dharma, I also show myself as a householder.

In order to protect the upholders of the sacred Dharma and the world guardians, I am honored as a minister among ministers. In order to teach the sacred Dharma correctly to the young, I am honored as a youth among youths. In order to teach correctly the royal ways of the king of the sacred Dharma, I am honored as a king among kings.

In some parts of Jambudvīpa, during an intermediate eon of disease, I give medicine to beings and so lead them to the sacred Dharma, and beings perceive it as an intermediate eon of disease. In some parts of Jambudvīpa, during an intermediate eon of famine, I satisfy hungry and weakened beings with food of ambrosia and so lead them to the sacred Dharma, and beings perceive it as an intermediate eon of famine. In some parts of Jambudvīpa I display an intermediate eon of weapons, and when beings gather and the time comes for them to kill one another, I lead them to the sacred Dharma, and beings perceive it as an intermediate eon of weapons. In some parts of Jambudvīpa, in order to teach the perception of impermanence to beings who hold the perception of permanence, I display an eon of burning, and beings perceive it as an eon of burning.

In some parts of Jambudvīpa I teach speech and language to beings, and, drawing them on by means of speech and language, I bring them to certain liberation. In some parts of Jambudvīpa, in order to liberate beings with certainty, I transform myself into the four elements, and in order to remove the diseases of beings, I transform myself into every medicine and every tree.

In some parts of Jambudvīpa I also appear to go forth among all the wonder-working sects, and everywhere I serve as preceptor and am honored. Although the Tathāgata has, from countless tens of millions of eons ago, already reached the final end of the true meaning of going forth, he appears to go forth among all the wonder-working sects, in order to liberate them with certainty.

Although the Tathāgata always abides in the body of his intrinsic nature, in order to liberate all beings with certainty he also serves as master in all the arts and crafts, and displays all vidyā-mantras, secret mantras and magical emanations. Having crushed the arrogance and pride of all the wonder-working sects, he shows them correctly that they are without core, like cotton, and he leads them to the sacred Dharma. This is acting in conformity with the world. There, beings who hold the perceptions of views perceive, "This being is a worldly one," but the Tathāgata is not worldly; he is one who

sees the Dharma that transcends the world.

In some parts of Jambudvīpa, in order to liberate with certainty by acting in conformity with the world, I also appear as a male or female servant, and beings perceive, "This is a male servant, this is a female servant." That is appearing in a low caste. In some parts of Jambudvīpa I have displayed all the activities of the world, and beings perceive, "This being is devoted to worldly affairs." Yet although he displays this, the Tathāgata does not perform those deeds; acting in conformity with the whole world is for the sake of liberating the world.

In the same way, in Uttarakuru, in Pūrvavideha in the east, in Aparagodānīya in the west, and in the twenty-five realms of existence as well, one should apply each of these in the same manner, by way of acting in conformity with the worldly; and the account of the great trichiliocosm too should be applied according to the manner of the Śūraṃgama samādhi.

Because the Tathāgata displays all great deeds, this is called the Great Parinirvāṇa. The bodhisattva great being who abides in it establishes beings in all great deeds, in great miracles and in fearlessness, and therefore he is called the great permanent one. One should not ask how he does it.

It should be understood that the tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas act in conformity with the world, as in taking up the skillful means of appearing as the father of Rāhula. Because they crossed the river of desire many tens of millions of eons ago, the Tathāgata is therefore permanent, stable and everlasting.

He asked: "Here you have said that, just as no place can be designated where a lamp that has gone out has died, so too the state of the Tathāgata's nirvāṇa is like that. If that is what you teach, how is the Tathāgata permanent, stable and everlasting?"

The Blessed One said: "Son of good family, I have not said that nirvāṇa is like the state of a lamp. Son of good family, suppose some man or woman fills a vessel, whether large or small, with butter or sesame oil and lights a lamp. The flame of that lamp burns as long as there is sesame oil, and when the sesame oil is used up, the lamp goes out. In that example, the exhaustion of the afflictions is taught as resembling the going out of the lamp, while the Tathāgata is permanent, like the vessel. If the exhaustion of the afflictions is like the lamp and the sesame oil, does the vessel also cease to exist at the same moment as the lamp?"

He replied: "Blessed One, it does not. The vessel does not cease to exist. But then, is the Tathāgata also to be likened to the vessel? If the Tathāgata is like the vessel of sesame oil, would it not follow that you have declared that the Tathāgata too will perish?"

The Blessed One said: "The Tathāgata is not like the vessel. Whatever is supremely permanent, that is the Tathāgata; therefore nirvāṇa is forever supreme bliss. Furthermore, son of good family, what resembles the state of the lamp is the arhat. Therefore the attainment of arhatship, the state of nirvāṇa, is called the supreme fruit. All arhats are free of attachment to material things: they are without material things, they are final like the state of the lamp, and they delight in being without material things. The non-returner too I have taught, with words of hidden intent, to mean being without material things; but that is not the state of nirvāṇa."

He asked: "What is the meaning of what you have called the non-returner?"

The Blessed One said: "Whoever does not take up renewed existence is called a non-returner."

He asked: "Blessed One, it is called the non-returner. Yet if even the one who is a non-returner were still to take up renewed existence, why is it that the non-returner does not again take birth in this body, which is impure by nature and filled with a host of worms?"

The Blessed One said: "He does not take up that body, but he takes up a body as one takes a poison used as medicine. Therefore he is called a non-returner. The word 'non-returner' is a term for the body. The word 'returner' is a term for going back and forth."

He asked: "Blessed One, how is this? Is there something secret in the teaching of the Blessed One? Please do not keep it secret by saying, 'words of hidden intent, words of hidden intent.' Blessed One, how is this? Is the speech of the Buddha like a conjurer's mechanical device, or like the illusory woman of a mechanical device made by a magician?"

The Blessed One said: "There is nothing secret in my teaching. The speech of the Buddha is like the full moon of autumn: it is flawless, not sealed with signs, free of confusion, free of what is secret and of what is a great secret, and it is clear.

The sixth section.

"Son of good family, suppose there is a householder with servants and wives, who possesses ten million in wealth and has an only son who is dear, precious, cherished and pleasing. He calls the son back from the boy's teacher and, out of love for the son, diligently teaches him the half-letters himself. Even though the son has diligently learned the half-letters, can he explain the distinctions by way of the meaning of grammar? And even if he could explain them, would he come to know the meaning of grammar from having learned the half-letters? Does the householder keep secrets from his own son?"

He replied: "Blessed One, that is not so. Because of the son's skill in understanding, because his mind is sharp or dull as it is, and because he lacks skill in understanding, it comes to look as if something were kept secret from him. But whatever unhappiness, deceit and stinginess there might be toward him, that should be understood as secrecy. Whatever is endowed with the perception of an only son, out of faith and joy, is not called secrecy."

The Blessed One said: "Excellent, excellent, son of good family! Son of good family, you have done well. Whatever is endowed with hatred, deceit and stinginess is secrecy. Because of that, and out of love, that householder does not teach it. Just so, like that householder, I possess the cultivated perception of all sentient beings as an only son, yet because those childish ones cannot bear it, I do not teach them the words of my intent. Like the half-letters, I teach the nine-limbed scripture. Like grammar, I have taught the ten powers, the four noble truths, the noble eightfold path, and the grammar of the most extensive Great Vehicle.

"Further, son of good family, when the son has learned the half-letters and become fit for the science of language, if at that time the householder does not teach him the meaning of grammar, then, because he is being stingy, that is called secrecy. If he teaches him the meaning of grammar, the child will come to master grammar completely. Just so, as long as the śrāvakas have not become vessels for the Great Vehicle, I teach them the nine-limbed scripture. If I were to keep the training of the Great Vehicle secret from sentient beings who have become vessels, then it would be fitting to say of me, 'He has kept it secret, as with grammar.' Now I teach, as one teaches grammar, that the Tathāgata is permanent and stable, and like the householder, the Tathāgata brings his own children to completion. In this way, just as one brings a son to completion in all the sciences, so he brings them to completion.

"Further, son of good family, suppose the great clouds of summer roar with rumbling thunder and pour down great rain, and yet the seeds of some beings do not sprout. Is that the fault of the great clouds? Do the great clouds not rain? Just so, although today I teach the Great Parinirvāṇa, the great secret, without leaving anything out, those sentient beings who have not become vessels do not hear it."

And he said further:

"Those who have no full accumulation,
Who give no thought to food,
Like the birds in the sky,
Their tracks are hard to follow."

If one asks what the meaning of this teaching is:

"Who are those that have no full accumulation?
Who are those that give no thought to what they eat?
Whose tracks are hard to follow?
When one has gone, and gone to where?
Their tracks are hard to follow."

"Here, jewels and the like are the accumulation. The word 'full' is a term for a particular kind of particle. The word 'full' means 'gathered together,' and here it is a term for having acquired fine goods. 'Accumulation' and 'wealth' have one and the same meaning. Whoever fully accumulates wealth, that is called their full accumulation. Full accumulation is of two kinds: conditioned full accumulation and unconditioned full accumulation. The śrāvaka is of the type of conditioned full accumulation. The Tathāgata is of the type of unconditioned full accumulation.

"The Saṅgha is of two kinds: the conditioned Saṅgha and the unconditioned Saṅgha. The conditioned Saṅgha is the Saṅgha of śrāvakas. Since the Saṅgha of śrāvakas has no full accumulation at all, how much less could it hold on to bad goods such as male and female servants, or to treasuries and storehouses? Because it is not proper, it does not accumulate even so much as salt or a sesame seed. As for those who say, 'The Blessed One has permitted us to keep male and female servants and the like,' their tongues may well be struck dumb. Those śrāvakas are of the type that has no full accumulation; they are those who fully know food. Those who have no attachment to food are those who fully know food. Their tracks on the path of destinies are hard to follow. They very swiftly come to abide close to buddhahood."

"Their path is hard to trace," said the Tathāgata.

He spoke again: "If even in the conditioned Saṅgha there is no hoarding, how could there be any in the unconditioned Saṅgha? The unconditioned Saṅgha is the Tathāgata, so how could the Tathāgata teach a secret Dharma? Whatever is kept secret is hoarding. What cannot be traced is unmoving bliss; this is the meaning of nirvāṇa. In it there is not even space. It is not made by years, days and months. In it there are no comets, no hosts of stars, no mountains, no seasons and no clouds. It is the cutting off of the stream of birth. It is the abandoning of death, sickness, old age and the twenty-five states of existence. It is freedom from every form of suffering and from the afflictions. The Tathāgata, permanent, stable, blissful, unmoving and without abode, is parinirvāṇa. In order to go there, today the Tathāgata goes to the great city.

"'Great' and 'greatness' have one and the same meaning. 'Great' is a term for what surpasses others. Here, if a certain person comes to have an immeasurable lifespan, that person is counted as a great man, and if he also possesses the Dharma, that person is the highest of all men. Again, here a person becomes unique through the eight realizations of a great man. Among many great men, the one who has the eight realizations of a great man is the great man even among all great men. Because I have explained it in this way, it is called greatness.

"As for 'nirvāṇa with remainder,' that which heals is called nirvāṇa. Why is that? Son of good family, suppose a certain man is struck by a poisoned arrow and wounded by a falling stone. A great physician who draws out arrows treats that wounded man. He removes the poisoned arrow, makes him well and restores him unharmed, as he was before. Then the physician leaves the man and goes to stay in another land, another town or another house, wherever there are wounded people and wounds to be treated. In the same way the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete buddha, the great physician who draws out arrows, heals the arrows of all the sentient beings of Jambudvīpa who for countless tens of millions of eons have been badly wounded, struck by the poison of the afflictions, attachment, aversion, delusion and the rest. He heals them with the medicines of the roots of virtue found in the various collections of the Great Vehicle sūtras. And having healed them, he turns them back from sorrow, and wherever there are wounded beings, there the Blessed One truly appears. Therefore the Great Nirvāṇa rests on the true meaning.

"'The Great Parinirvāṇa' is a name for the city of liberation in all existences. That he appears as a perfectly awakened buddha wherever there are those to be trained is the well-known sense of the word; it is the evident sense. The true meaning is what is called the Great Parinirvāṇa."

Kāśyapa asked, "Blessed One, what is this? Is it to be said that the physician, having healed all who are wounded, appears in whatever other land, city, district, royal palace or surrounding area there are wounded people?"

He replied, "Son of good family, do not say that he heals the sickness of every wounded creature. He does not heal other beings who cannot be healed. Why is that? Because their sickness is incurable. In the same way the Tathāgata heals every sickness except the incurable sickness of those of great desire, the icchantikas. Those who have passed into nirvāṇa are the ones who have been healed."

Kāśyapa asked, "What is liberation like? Does it have form, or is it without form?"

He replied, "One kind has form, and one kind is without form. That without form belongs to the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. That of the buddhas, the blessed ones, has form. That liberation is both form and formless, yet it cannot even be called form."

Kāśyapa asked, "Why is that?"

He replied, "Kinsman of Mahākāśyapa, it is like the bodies of the gods of the sphere of neither perception nor non-perception: they are both form and formless, yet they cannot even be called form."

Kāśyapa asked, "If the gods of neither perception nor non-perception are both form and formless, and yet are not form, please explain how they exist and how they move about."

He replied, "This is the domain of the buddhas, not the domain of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, so leave it aside. In the same way, liberation too is both form and formless, yet it is not form; therefore it is the domain of the buddhas, not the domain of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas."

Kāśyapa said, "Blessed One, may the Tathāgata explain liberation by way of the Great Parinirvāṇa."

He replied, "Excellent, son of good family, excellent! What is called liberation is freedom from all bonds."

He spoke again: "Because what is called liberation is unborn, it is utterly free from all bonds. It is not born in the way a child is born from the coming together of father and mother. Liberation abides in its own domain. 'Unborn' means this: just as the essence of butter remains by nature in its own essential nature, so the Tathāgata did not arise from the union of father and mother, and yet, for the sake of those to be trained, the Tathāgata displayed both a father and a mother. Liberation is the Tathāgata, for it is the arising of what has not arisen. Suppose seeds of beans or peas are sown in the first month of spring, in the summer season, or in the last month of autumn; sprouts will come up from them. Liberation is not like that. What has not arisen is liberation. Liberation is the Tathāgata, the unarisen. The Tathāgata is simply unarisen, and the Tathāgata should not be thought of as a sprout that comes into being and then ceases to be."

The Tathāgata is by his very nature unarisen; therefore he is "unarisen." "Unarisen" means unmade. As for "unmade": people make cities, the spires of monastic dwellings, and gatehouses, but liberation is not like that. Whatever is unmade is liberation, and that is the Tathāgata.

"Unconditioned, unconditioned" means this. A potter makes a vessel, and afterward it comes to be destroyed, but liberation is not like that. Liberation has no birth and no cessation. Whatever is liberation is the Tathāgata, and he has neither birth nor death. That which is unborn, which does not perish, which is without aging, without death, and unconditioned, is the Tathāgata. Therefore the Tathāgata goes to the Great Parinirvāṇa.

"Without aging and without death" means this. White hair, aging, sickness, the condition of death, and such notions of a conditioned nature are not liberation. That in which none of the things just mentioned exists is liberation, and therefore it is called "without aging." Whatever is liberation is the Tathāgata. In the Tathāgata there is no white hair, no aging, and no conditioned change. Therefore, since the Tathāgata has a body without aging, how could one regard him as dying?

"Without sickness, without sickness" means this. Its nature is such that there is no body in it that is afflicted by the four hundred and four adventitious diseases and burdened with many faults. Therefore liberation is without sickness. Whatever is liberation is the Tathāgata. Since there is not even a trace of sickness in the Tathāgata, how could there be sickness in the Dharma body? Therefore the Tathāgata is without sickness.

"Deathless, deathless" means that in which there is no death, as there is for a human body. That is liberation. For it there is not even the expression, "After this much time it will come to the end of exhaustion," or, "It will come to the end of death." Freedom from death is liberation. Whatever is liberation is the Tathāgata. It is impossible that one endowed with such qualities should be said to die. How could a body as hard as a vajra be impermanent? Therefore the deathless is the Tathāgata.

As for "afflicted, afflicted": liberation is not spoiled by foul, impure slime. Liberation is clear, like a white kumuda flower. Whatever is liberation is the Tathāgata. His teaching of the various faults of desire should be seen as skillful means. Therefore the Tathāgata is not afflicted.

"Undefiled, undefiled" means "without a wound," and that is liberation. Whatever is liberation is the Tathāgata; therefore it is called undefiled.

"Without harm, without harm" means this. A hungry person who sees no one preparing food is harmed, but liberation is not like that. Whatever is without harm is liberation. Whatever is liberation is the Tathāgata.

"Peace, peace" means this. Worldly people call the image of a god "peaceful, peaceful," but that is false; it is not liberation. Whatever is peaceful by nature is liberation. Because it is the supreme peace of all sentient beings, it is called peace. Whatever is peace is liberation. Whatever is liberation is the Tathāgata.

"Bliss, bliss" means this. One who is afraid of bandits travels the road in safety, but liberation is not like that. In that which is blissful by its very nature there is not even the name of fear. Therefore uncontrived bliss is liberation. Whatever is liberation is the Tathāgata. The one who brings bliss to all sentient beings is the Tathāgata.

As for "without rival, without rival," "without rival" means this. A king is suspicious and afraid for his life, but liberation is not like that; liberation is by its very nature, from the beginning, without rival. "Without rival" is like a universal monarch: there is no one else at all who could make him afraid; it is impossible. Likewise, for liberation there is no other phenomenon that could become its match; it is impossible. Whatever is liberation is the Tathāgata. When the Tathāgata turns the wheel of Dharma, there is no other sound. Therefore the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete buddha, is without rival. Whatever is liberation is the Tathāgata.

"Sorrowless, sorrowless" means that in which there is no sorrow. When a king's kingdom is seized by another, troublemaking king, and his realm is conquered and laid waste, he is struck by great sorrow; but nirvāṇa is not like that. Just as a king who cannot be overcome by others, having become free of enemies, is without sorrow, so too those who have attained liberation are without sorrow. Whatever is liberation is nirvāṇa. Whatever is nirvāṇa is the Tathāgata.

"Free from sorrow, free from sorrow" means this. A woman hears that her son has gone to war and been killed, and when she sees him come back she becomes free from sorrow; but nirvāṇa is not like that. Liberation is always free from sorrow. Whatever is liberation is the Tathāgata.

As for "dustless, dustless," "dust" means earthen dust and mud. In springtime, the wind rising in the afternoon stirs up the dust, but liberation is not like that. "Dustless" means this: just as a king's crown jewel is pure, so that which is by nature dustless is liberation. Whatever is liberation is the Tathāgata.

"Free from dust, free from dust" means this. Gold that has been thoroughly refined, free of sand and stone, has become by nature a precious substance; likewise, the nature that is purified of faults is liberation. Whatever is liberation is the Tathāgata.

"Not fragile, not fragile" means this. An earthenware pot of curd cracks, but liberation is not like that. Like a vessel of iron or of vajra, what is not fragile is liberation. Whatever is liberation is the Tathāgata.

"Having the nature of not being hollow, having the nature of not being hollow" means this. When the fruit of the castor plant is roasted and spread out on a rooftop in spring, it crackles all over and splits all over. Liberation is not like that. "Having the nature of not being hollow" means this. A pot of iron and vajra cannot be pierced even when a thousand charioteers shoot arrows at it. In the same way, that which has the nature of not being hollow is liberation. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Owing nothing, owing nothing" means this. A poor man runs into debt and falls into the hands of a rich man. Although he is tormented, he has nothing at all to repay with, and so he is let go. Liberation is not like that. "Owing nothing" means this. A man who possesses ten million in wealth is in debt to no one. In the same way, the supreme one who possesses many tens of millions of dharmas is liberation. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Having the nature of owing nothing, having the nature of owing nothing" means this. A poor man has no wealth anywhere in his own house, and the thought "I shall take out a loan" weighs on his mind. Liberation is not like that. "Having the nature of owing nothing" means this. A householder who possesses ten million in wealth does not depend even on the sun and the moon. Such a prosperous householder does not even hear the words "The sun is blazing" or "The moon has risen." Such a supremely happy householder, born into the lineage of a wheel-turning king, does not take loans from others to provide for later times. Nor do others say of him, "This man takes loans from others and lives on them." That is impossible. In the same way, it is impossible that liberation would take up some other abode of liberation. Therefore that which has the nature of owing nothing is liberation. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Harmless, harmless" means this. By indulging in what is too hot in spring, in what is too sweet in summer, and in what is too cold in winter, one is harmed by these faults, and harms arise from them. Liberation is not harmed by many illnesses in that way. Further, as for "harm": drinking milk after eating meat and fish leads to death. Liberation does not have a harmful nature. "Harmless" means this. By eating suitable food one tastes delicious flavors, and it is as though one has eaten the nectar of immortality. In the same way, liberation is by nature like the nectar of immortality. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Having a harmless nature, having a harmless nature" means this. A man full of pride, puffed up and intoxicated with pride, thinks, "I will not die," and tries to seize a snake or a tiger. Seized by it, he dies an untimely death. In the same way, one who is full of pride does not attain liberation. "Having a harmless nature" means this. Through the splendor of the precious bell-metal of a wheel-turning king, poisonous creatures of ninety-six kinds, such as beetles, snakes, kaṇabha insects and spiders, merely catch its scent from far away. Frightened by the natural scent of that precious bell-metal, they lose their poison. In the same way, liberation is by nature free of the twenty-five faults of existence. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Free of danger, free of danger": liberation is not like the blue and green colors of cardamom. "Free of danger" means this. Just as space is free of danger, liberation is like that. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata. "Having the nature of being free of danger, having the nature of being free of danger" means this. A lamp on its stand becomes a danger. Liberation is not like that.

"Having the nature of being free of danger" means this. Just as the light of the moon is no danger to any sentient being, liberation is like that: its character is to be no danger to any sentient being. Therefore freedom from danger is liberation. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Having nothing at all, having nothing at all" means this. A man has friends and enemies. Liberation is not like that. "Having nothing at all" means this. It is impossible that a wheel-turning king should have an enemy, and liberation is like that. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata. "Having nothing at all" means this. When white cloth is dyed for some purpose, it turns blue or red. Liberation is not like that. "Having nothing at all" means this. It is impossible for the flower of the nāgakeśara tree to become foul-smelling or to turn blue. Liberation is like that: it is impossible to say that there is anything at all in it, just as that flower has only its one single scent. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Wondrous, wondrous" means this. A lotus growing in water is no great wonder. Liberation is not like that. "Wondrous" means this. Seeing a lotus flower blooming in the midst of fire gives rise to joy. In the same way, when there is liberation, joy arises. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Marvelous, marvelous" means this. A child's teeth grow in later. Liberation, however, does not change, whether its time has come or not. "Amazing" means this. It is impossible that icchantikas, those of great desire who have fallen into that state, should become buddhas. And it is impossible to say that when someone comes to have faith in the true Dharma or becomes a layman, at that time liberation is exhausted. That element is by nature marvelous. Therefore liberation is called marvelous. As in the case of the icchantika, the Tathāgata is inexhaustible. For one who focuses on the mind of the roots of virtue, phenomena do not arise, and that non-arising is liberation. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Immeasurable, immeasurable" means this. A heap of grain or a heap of śāli rice can be measured. Liberation is not like that.

"Immeasurable" means this: just as the water of the ocean is immeasurable, liberation too is immeasurable in the same way. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Of measureless nature, of measureless nature" means this: the karmic maturation of a single sentient being is of measurable nature, but liberation is not like that. "Of measureless nature" means this: just as the emergence of

sentient beings from the bounds of saṃsāra is measureless, liberation too is like that. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Supreme, foremost and chief, supreme, foremost and chief" means that there is no other liberation that is supreme, foremost and chief beyond it. Just as there is no other great body of water like the great ocean, so too is liberation: liberation itself is supreme, foremost and chief. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Highest, highest" means this: just as above space there is no other space, nor any other thing that surpasses space, so above liberation there is no other thing that is liberation. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Utterly highest, utterly highest" means this: just as the lion's station is beyond all other beasts, so liberation is beyond all phenomena and is solely luminous. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Superior, superior" means this: just as among all the directions the north is called supreme, liberation too is like that. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Unsurpassed, unsurpassed" means this: just as among all lands, the land of the northerners is called the unsurpassed land, liberation too is like that. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Certain, certain" means this: for gods and humans death is certain, while life is not certain. Just as the death of gods and humans is certain, liberation is of a nature that is certain and abiding. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Not unstable, not unstable" means this: reeds, castor plants and bubbles are unstable, but liberation is not like that. "Unstable" is like the essence of butter. Liberation is not unstable. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Not of a perishable nature, not of a perishable nature" means this: flies settled on a wall, some sticking, some sitting, some moving about, some playing; liberation is not like that. "Not of a perishable nature" means this: just as on a wall where a painter has painted pictures they cannot settle and do not stick, so liberation is not tainted by any fault whatsoever. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

As for "limitless, limitless," liberation is not like a cluster of villages. "Limitless" means this: just as space has no limit, the limitless kind of bliss is liberation. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Indemonstrable, indemonstrable" means this: just as the track of a bird does not appear in the sky, so liberation is difficult to examine. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Profound, profound" means that it is of a nature entered into only with the greatest toil. Just as the virtues of parents who undertake hardships are most profound, since they are entered into with the greatest toil, so liberation is profound. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Very hard to see, very hard to see" means this: just as it is very hard for a person to see the top of his own head, so liberation is very hard to see even for all the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Without dwelling, without dwelling" is a designation for houses and for space, but liberation is not like that. Here "without dwelling" is a designation for having no occasion: that in which the twenty-five harms of existence are absent is liberation. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Free of afflictions, free of afflictions" means this: whereas an emblic myrobalan can be held in a person's fist, in liberation, by comparison, nothing whatsoever can be grasped. "Free of afflictions" means this: just as nothing whatsoever can be grasped in an illusion conjured by a magician, liberation too is like that. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Flawless body, flawless body" means this: a human body may come to be free of moles, warts, leprosy, skin disease and blemishes, but liberation is not like that. "Flawless body" means this: just as milk is by nature of a single color, liberation too is of a single characteristic. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Pure, pure" means this: when the fruit of the ketaka is rubbed into water mixed with the stain of turbidity, the water becomes pure in nature, but liberation is not like that. "Pure" means this: just as rainwater in the sky is of a single taste and completely pure, liberation too is like that. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

As for "released, released," liberation is like the stainless moon on the fifteenth day, not like the moon covered by clouds. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Peace, peace" means this: a being stricken with an epidemic fever comes to be free of the fever, but liberation is not like that. As for "peace," liberation is

like a being who is without illness and without harm. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Equality, equality" means this: when two rams butt one another their strength is equal, but liberation is not like that. Just as mother and child speak in harmony, liberation too is like that. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

As for "fully pacified, fully pacified," once one has attained that supreme abode, it is impossible to desire any other abode. "Not knowing satisfaction" means this: when one is weak, after eating the finest food the wish to drink buttermilk arises, but liberation is not like that. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

As for "severance, severance," whatever is the severance of desire within, which is like the noose of craving, that is liberation in the sense of severance.

That which is liberation is the Tathāgata.

"The far shore, the far shore": just as a river has two banks, the near bank and the far bank, liberation is not like that. Liberation is the far shore. That which is liberation is the Tathāgata.

"Like a river": only the river itself can serve as the example; in the world there is no other river that can serve as the example. "River" here refers to the ocean. Since among all rivers the ocean alone is truly the river, the ocean is counted under the term "river." It is called a river because it roars with a great sound. Liberation is like the far shore of the river that is the ocean. That which is liberation is the Tathāgata.

"Excellent, excellent": that in which there is no harsh taste like that of the kośātakī fruit. Liberation is not like the kośātakī fruit; liberation is like grapes. That which is liberation is the Tathāgata.

Just as a physician, having steadied the patient's mind with every remedy and medicine, dispels all illnesses, so too liberation is free from all faults. That which is liberation is the Tathāgata.

"Intense longing, intense longing": just as in a small village there is no room for great crowds of people to enter, liberation is not like that. That which is liberation is the Tathāgata.

"The exhaustion of existence and of delight" is like being free of illusions and magical apparitions. Whereas among men and women who are given to sexual

union there is talk passing back and forth, liberation is not like that. That which by nature has the character of its own essence, free from attachment, aversion, and delusion, is liberation. That which is liberation is the Tathāgata.

"Taming thirst, taming thirst": that in which there is not the slightest trace of craving. The absence of the craving of hungry ghosts is craving for the Dharma. Craving for the Dharma means compassion for all sentient beings. Liberation is not like the craving of hungry ghosts. To be free of grasping at self and at what is mine is liberation. That which is liberation is the Tathāgata.

"Cessation, cessation": this is liberation, in which there is no clinging to existence. That which is liberation is the Tathāgata.

"Abode, abode": this is liberation, which definitively delivers and protects from all existence. That which is liberation is the Tathāgata.

"Refuge, refuge": this is like one who, having gone for refuge to the Tathāgata, seeks no other refuge. Just as going for refuge to a king is not stable, liberation is not like that. Stable bliss is liberation. That which is liberation is the Tathāgata.

"Ally, ally": just as a forest wilderness is utterly frightening, liberation is not like that. It is like the ally that the king of beasts has and that other beasts lack. Just as the king of beasts has no fear of any of the terrors of death, so liberation is an ally. That which is liberation is the Tathāgata.

"Bliss, bliss": this is like an island of jewels. Likewise, liberation is a source of the Dharma. That which is liberation is the Tathāgata.

"Without peril, without peril": a man, terrified and frightened by a tiger, runs into a well, and then from inside the well he cries, "Who can get me out?" Liberation is not like that well. "Without peril" is like this: when a ship is wrecked, one finds another ship, crosses the great ocean completely, and comes to be safe and happy. In the same way, liberation is without peril. That which is liberation is the Tathāgata.

"The destruction of abodes" means the exhaustion of occasion. Just as curd comes from milk, fresh butter comes from curd, clarified butter comes from fresh butter, and the finest essence of ghee comes from clarified butter, so liberation is the complete severance of all abodes, abiding in its own nature like the finest essence of ghee. That which is liberation is the Tathāgata.

"Subduing pride, subduing pride": just as a king, a lord of the earth, has pride that needs subduing, thinking, "I am supreme among all kings," liberation is

not like that. Liberation is without pride and without grasping at pride. That which is liberation is the Tathāgata.

"Subduing intoxication, subduing intoxication": that in which not even the name of sexual desire exists is liberation. That which is liberation is the Tathāgata.

"Subduing ignorance, subduing ignorance": just as, passing from milk through one stage after another, each impurity and fault is exhausted and from that only the finest essence of ghee emerges, so from ignorance only knowledge emerges. That which is ignorance is liberation. That which is liberation is the Tathāgata.

"Solitude, solitude": that in which there is no other phenomenon as companion, just as in the elephant forest a single elephant roams alone and dwells alone. Liberation too is like that. That which is liberation is the Tathāgata.

"Complete abandonment, complete abandonment": this teaches the apprehension of selflessness, and it is entry into the tathāgatagarbha, the buddha-nature. Just as the stalks of the castor plant (eraṇḍa) and of the reed have no core whatsoever apart from their fruit, so all the bodies of gods, humans, and asuras, apart from the tathāgatagarbha, are all without core, like the castor plant and the reed. To completely abandon all coreless existence is liberation. Liberation makes itself known to oneself. That which is liberation is the Tathāgata.

"Rejection, rejection": just as one rejects uncooked food because the food is not digested, so it is the cutting off and abandoning of all existence. Thus liberation is wise. That which is liberation is the Tathāgata.

"The qualities of pratyekabuddhas, the qualities of pratyekabuddhas": just as the flower of the nāga tree is not the flower of the pakhal, liberation too is like that. That which is liberation is the Tathāgata.

"Element, element": that element is the element of all sentient beings. That life is the life of all sentient beings. Liberation too is like that. That which is liberation is the Tathāgata.

"Source, source": this refers to that in which there is a gateway of emergence. Having meditated on selflessness, one enters the path of the self; that is liberation. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Virtue, virtue": it is like the way that, for those who are to be instructed, nothing equals the word of the teacher. "Virtue" means what is good; that is liberation. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Beyond the world, beyond the world": this is the supreme abode among all phenomena; that is liberation. Just as among all nourishing essences the finest is cow's milk, so what is beyond the world is liberation. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Unmoving, unmoving": just as the post that holds a door bolt cannot be shaken by the winds of the four directions, so liberation too is firm and unmoving. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata. The waves of the ocean are by nature unstable, but liberation is not like that. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Abode, abode": even a king's palace, a fine mansion hung with banners and without flaw, is something fabricated. Liberation is not like that. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Certain, certain": just as the gold of the Jambū River is flawless and can be worked into anything, so too is liberation. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata. Liberation is not like the conduct of children. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Thoroughly refined, thoroughly refined": just as one who has gained sovereignty over a kingdom is mighty and lives at ease, so the complete abandonment of the aggregates is liberation. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Final, final": this is the exhaustion of the impure afflictions. Liberation is like a man who has come out of the king's prison. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata, the bliss that is not contrived.

"Abandoning attachment, aversion, and delusion, abandoning attachment, aversion, and delusion": this is the casting off of the three. Just as a man bitten by a venomous snake vomits up phlegm in order to save himself, so the exhaustion of the phlegm of the afflictions is liberation. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Abandoning the afflictions, abandoning the afflictions": the exhaustion of the afflictions, which are like a venomous snake, is liberation. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Abandoning the aggregates, abandoning the aggregates": having cast off all suffering, great bliss is liberation. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"The exhaustion of attachment, aversion, and delusion, the exhaustion of attachment, aversion, and delusion": having exhausted the three and torn them out by the root is liberation. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Having abandoned all the aggregates, having abandoned all the aggregates": this is having abandoned all faults, because one sees well. That is liberation. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"The meaning of having abandoned all conditioned things, the meaning of having abandoned all conditioned things": this is liberation, the accomplishment of all virtue. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Cutting off paths, cutting off paths": having meditated on selflessness, one grasps selflessness in an unbroken way; having meditated on a self, one grasps a self in an unbroken way; and having meditated on both sides, one holds that whatever is the buddha element exists. That holding is liberation. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Emptiness, emptiness": this is when, though one searches, nothing at all is found. What is called "nothingness" is found among the Nirgranthas too, but liberation is not like that. As for what is called emptiness: take pots of honey, ghee, sesame oil, water, and curd. Whether there is curd in it or not, it is called a curd pot; and likewise, whether there is honey or water in it or not, it is called a honey pot or a water pot. Is it then called an empty pot? When those contents are absent, is the pot itself empty? If it has shape and it has color, how can it be called empty?

Liberation is not empty in that way. Liberation too possesses perfect form and color. Yet just as a curd pot, though it is not empty, is called empty because it has no curd, so liberation too, while not being empty, is called empty. If one asks how it can be called empty while it has form: it is called empty because the forms of the afflictions, the twenty-five designations of existence, suffering, worldly customs, rites, and the arising of spheres of activity are absent from it. Just as a curd pot is without curd, so liberation is called empty. Yet just as the form of the pot remains unmoved, in liberation there are great bliss, joy, permanence, stability, eternity, supramundane qualities, rites, and spheres of activity.

The permanence, stability, and eternity of liberation are not like the form of a pot. A pot will break, for it is merely something established by way of causes. Liberation, because it is not made, will not break. Whatever is liberation is the uncontrived element, and that is the Tathāgata.

"The exhaustion of craving, the exhaustion of craving": at the very moment of becoming a buddha, there is no craving or other desire such as "May I become Indra," or "May I become Maheśvara (Śiva)," or "May I become Brahmā, lord of the Sahā world." It is impossible for such a thing to be said to exist or to arise. Whatever is the exhaustion of craving, that is the Buddha. That is liberation. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

"Cessation free from attachment, cessation free from attachment": here, clinging to all craving, and desire without residue, with nothing remaining and nothing left over, together with all attachments of every kind, become pacified forever. This is liberation, the cessation of all bonds. Whatever is such a cessation, that is liberation. Whatever is liberation, that is the Tathāgata.

As for what is called "nirvāṇa, nirvāṇa": a herd of deer that has escaped from a hunter's hands, fearful and terrified of death, runs by whatever means it can, reaches a sage's hermitage, and there finds ease and catches its breath. Just as they catch their breath and find ease, so too many beings, with respect to inexhaustible nirvāṇa, slip free and escape from the hands of what conditions becoming and of all the foes that take the form of afflictions. Fearful and terrified of death, they run by whatever means they can and go to the hermitage of the sage of the Dharma, the dwelling place of the Tathāgata, the Sage, the refuge without equal, and there they catch their breath. The time when they catch their breath and find ease is nirvāṇa, the nirvāṇa that is inexhaustible.

Fascicle Seven.

Then the kinsman of Mahākāśyapa said this to the Blessed One (the Buddha): "If that is so, then since there would be no arhats, perfectly and completely awakened buddhas, omniscient ones, they would not attain the supreme bliss of nirvāṇa by relinquishing the body, and those who go for refuge to the Three would not attain nirvāṇa."

He declared: "Suppose a man has recovered from a faint, and people go to him and ask, 'Have you recovered, and are you well?' Having recovered, he says, 'I have recovered and am well.' Just as he has recovered from his faint, so when one is freed from all twenty-five states of existence, one has attained the

parinirvāṇa of a buddha. What is called supreme bliss is the many forms of supreme bliss found there, together with the perception of the inexhaustible. That is parinirvāṇa. That is liberation. That which experiences supreme stability, immovability, bliss and permanence is liberation. Whatever is liberation is the Tathāgata."

Then the kinsman of Mahākāśyapa said this to the Blessed One: "Should one say that what is unborn and unceasing is liberation, and that it is the Tathāgata?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, it is indeed so. That is liberation. That is the Tathāgata."

He said: "Then, since the element of space too is unborn and unarisen, should one say that liberation is like it, and that the Tathāgata too is like it?"

He declared: "It is not so. Liberation is not like the element of space."

He said: "Then what is it like?"

He declared: "Son of good family, when the jīvaṃjīvaka bird or the kalaviṅka bird sings, would one say that it sings like a crow?"

He said: "No, Blessed One. The cries of other birds are not even fit to serve as an example for their song. The cawing of a crow does not come to even a hundredth part of the song of the jīvaṃjīvaka or the kalaviṅka, nor even a thousandth part; it cannot bear comparison by number, by fraction, by example or by cause. Those birds are beyond compare. Blessed One, the speech of the Tathāgata is beyond compare by way of cause."

He declared: "Excellent, son of good family, excellent! Son of good family, it is right that you should explain it so. Excellent! Therefore whatever is liberation is the Tathāgata. No other cause or example for liberation exists in the world with its gods, humans and asuras. Although it is without example, for the sake of those to be trained it is shown through examples: 'Its qualities are like this, they are like that.' The example of liberation is the Tathāgata. Why is that? Whatever is the Tathāgata is liberation, and whatever is liberation is the Tathāgata; here no division into two can be made, and no distinction can be made.

"Son of good family, even where there is no example, an example may be taken for the sake of a cause. One says, 'Ah, lovely-faced one, you are like the full moon,' and 'The fine elephant is like a snowy mountain.' But is the face like the moon, or is the moon like the face? Is the elephant like the mountain, or is

the mountain like the elephant? Son of good family, in the same way, you should understand that liberation too, though without example, is here shown through examples by reason of a cause, in order to set beings free for certain. The suchness of the Dharma too should be understood as the suchness of the Dharma by reason of a cause."

He said: "Why does the Tathāgata teach in two ways?"

He declared: "Son of good family, here is another example. Suppose a certain man takes up a sword, thinking, 'I shall kill the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha,' and tries to kill him, while the Tathāgata does not do the slightest wrong in return, but remains undaunted and joyful. Would that man be called one who commits an act of immediate retribution, or not?"

He said: "In terms of the actual thing, one would not say that he had committed an act of immediate retribution. Why is that? Because the accumulated elements are not destroyed, in terms of the actual thing he does not commit an act of immediate retribution. In the body of the Tathāgata there is not even a trace of accumulated elements. Since it is the element of the Dharma (dharmadhātu), how could it be killed? Therefore, merely from forming the intention and from seeking to do it, he is said to commit an act of immediate retribution. Here, by reason of a cause, one should understand the suchness of the Dharma."

He declared: "Excellent, son of good family, excellent! I too had in mind to speak those very words. Son of good family, here is another example. Suppose a certain evil man thinks, 'I shall kill my mother,' and lies in wait in a field of millet and lentils in a wilderness. When his mother comes there, he says, 'You have not brought my broth properly!' and sharpens an axe to kill her. While he is sharpening the axe, his mother, frightened, hides inside a pile of straw. Then he takes up the axe and strikes the pile of straw, thinking, 'Now my mother is dead.' Fearing other people, he does not examine the straw carefully. Then the mother comes out from inside it and goes away. Then, thinking, 'My mother is dead,' he rejoices. Would he be called one who commits an act of immediate retribution, or not?"

He said: "One would not say that he killed his mother."

Again he asked, "Why is that? Is it the actual basis of the cause of a heinous act that one must ask about?"

The Blessed One said, "It is by destroying the aggregates of one's father or mother that one is said to commit a heinous act of immediate retribution. Therefore that person has not committed a heinous act. But since he began to give rise to the intention to kill his mother, it is like committing a heinous act. As long as the substance of the aggregates, the elements and the sense bases has not been destroyed, the heinous act is not said to be complete. Here one should understand the reality of phenomena by way of causes."

He said, "Excellent, Blessed One, excellent! In this way, by way of causes, one both understands and does not understand."

The Blessed One said, "Son of noble family, in just the same way I speak of liberation by way of causes. In terms of causes, nirvāṇa, endowed with immeasurable qualities, is utterly incomparable. Likewise, going to the Great Parinirvāṇa is also endowed with immeasurable qualities. Today the Tathāgata will pass into parinirvāṇa, and therefore that is the meaning of the Great Parinirvāṇa."

He said, "The Tathāgata is not something that comes to an end. The Tathāgata should be regarded as one whose life knows no exhaustion."

The Blessed One said, "Excellent, son of noble family, excellent! One who protects the true Dharma ought to speak in this way. One who wishes to resolve his own doubts ought to act in this way. Thus the bodhisattva great beings teach the Dharma in these four ways."

This concludes the fourth chapter, on bodhisattvas teaching the Dharma in four ways.

In this sūtra of the Great Parinirvāṇa there are four persons who have attained the way of the true Dharma, who bring forth the true Dharma, and who serve as a support. They appear in the world for the benefit of many people and for the happiness of many people. What are the four?

A person who is by nature fully afflicted appears in the world for the happiness of many people and for the benefit of many people; this is the first person. A person who possesses the fruit of stream-entry and the fruit of once-returning is the second. The non-returner is the third. The arhat is the fourth. These four persons are the supports.

Among them, the one called an ordinary being is this. Having himself come to possess moral discipline, proper conduct and good qualities, he brings forth the Dharma. Those who possess the root of the Tathāgata he causes to

flourish from the very beginning, and he also understands the meaning. He explains the meaning, saying, "This Dharma belongs to those of few desires; this Dharma does not belong to those of great desires." He teaches the eight thoughts of a great being. When a fault has occurred, he has others confess it, in order to lift them out of it. And while practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, he is skilled in words spoken with hidden intent and brings forth the true Dharma. This is the first person. Although he is counted among ordinary beings, he is not an ordinary being who lacks learning. This ordinary being of the eighth rank, a bodhisattva great being, has been prophesied by the tathāgatas, with a secret prophecy, to become a buddha.

Among them, those called stream-enterers and once-returners are these. Having attained, it is impossible for them to be parted from inquiring into and upholding the true Dharma, and impossible for them to teach others self-fabricated words not spoken by the Buddha, various writings, or the acquiring of male and female servants. Although they are counted among stream-enterers and once-returners, they are not stream-enterers and once-returners. In this way the bodhisattva great beings who have attained the first, second and third grounds are prophesied, by a direct prophecy, to become buddhas in the abode of the buddhas.

The one called a non-returner is this. Having attained that Dharma, it is impossible for him to be parted from it. It is impossible for him to teach others improper, self-fabricated sūtras not spoken by the Buddha, with their various words and writings, or the acquiring of male and female servants and the like. It is impossible for the adventitious secondary afflictions to harm him, and impossible for the inner afflictions to harm him. It is impossible for him to conceal the element of the Tathāgata and teach the Dharma. It is impossible for the adventitious diseases that depend on the venomous snakes of the four elements to harm him. He is not one who speaks of a self, yet he also refutes those who proclaim no-self; he has fully abandoned the worldly self, and by worldly activities he also accords with the world. It is impossible for him to make any vehicle other than the Great Vehicle blaze forth. He does not hold a body of eighty kinds of worms and great defects. Having fully abandoned desirous thoughts, even if something arises in a dream, it is impossible for semen to be emitted from his body. When he sees the terrors of death approaching, it is impossible for him to be afraid. Such a person is called a non-returner, and is the third person.

Moreover, he is called a non-returner because he definitely does not return; yet that person is not said to have attained non-returning. He also has the qualities taught before, and even if he is born here, he is not stained by the faults taught before. That bodhisattva great being, although he moves about in the manner of coming and going, is counted among the non-returners. By the prophecy given the moment he generates the mind of awakening, he is prophesied to buddhahood, and immediately after generating that mind, without long delay, he becomes a buddha. Such a person is the third person.

The arhat whose defilements are exhausted is the fourth person. "Arhat" means one who is without afflictions, who has laid down the burden, who has done what was to be done for his own aim, who has accomplished the aim, and who has attained the ten grounds.

It further enlarges on the meaning: such a one is foretold with the prophecy of the forbearance toward unproduced phenomena. He manifestly emanates forms according to what he is able to do and forms according to what he wishes. And with whatever body he wishes to become a buddha, with that very body he becomes a tathāgata, an arhat, a perfectly complete buddha. One endowed with these qualities is called an arhat. In this great Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra, these four persons appear in the world for the benefit of many people and for the happiness of many people. Like the Tathāgata, they are teachers of gods and humans, and all four are authoritative persons. They have become a support for the world.

He said: "These four persons are not authoritative for me, nor are they a support. Why is that? When the Blessed One, on the occasion of the householder Ghoṣila, spoke about subduing Māra, he said: 'Even if a god, a māra, or Brahmā should come in the guise of a buddha's body like mine, the body adorned with the thirty-two major marks and the eighty excellent minor marks, endowed with a fathom-wide aura, and with the face adorned by the ūrṇā hair, I permit you to subdue him. Say this: "Evil One, do not set yourself up like this as an arhat, in the form of an arhat. Evil One, even if you lie down in the sky, make fire blaze from your left side and pour down water from your right side, blaze like fire with splendor and give off smoke, I will not listen to your words. I will not trust you. Even if you teach something like the nine-limbed scriptures, I will not have faith in you."

Sons of good family, if you have such doubts, subdue even me. Sons of good family, it is like this: suppose that at night, in the darkness, the lady of the

house or a maidservant notices that a thieving dog has come in, and says to it, "You thieving dog, get out quickly, before I kill you!" As soon as the thieving dog hears this, it runs off and from then on never comes to that house again. In the same way, you should subdue Māra the Evil One as one would the thieving dog, and say to him, "Evil One, do not act like this! Get out quickly, before I bind you with the five bonds!" The moment he hears this, he will turn back like the thieving dog. Those who subdue Māra in this way are the holy ones; they dwell in the very presence of nirvāṇa.'

Since the Blessed One declared this when he spoke about subduing Māra on the occasion of the householder Ghoṣila, why, Blessed One, do you establish the four persons as supports? I do not listen to them, and I do not trust them."

The Blessed One said: "Son of good family, it is so. What I said is exactly so. Nevertheless, what I said about subduing Māra, I said for the sake of the childish followers of the Śrāvaka Vehicle who have the eye of flesh. I did not speak about subduing Māra for the sake of the followers of the Great Vehicle. Although among the followers of the Śrāvaka Vehicle there are those who have the divine eye, they are counted as having what is called the eye of flesh. Although among the followers of the Great Vehicle there are those who have the eye of flesh, they are counted as having what is called the eye of a buddha. Why is that? Because they hold the reality of the sūtras of the Great Vehicle, the Buddha Vehicle.

Further, son of good family, suppose there is a hero, famed throughout the region, courageous and valiant, and certain cowardly men rely on him. When that hero teaches courage to the cowards, he instructs them: 'O man, if you wish to become a hero, walk upon a bed of sword points. Whenever you fight, fear no one at all. Whether it be a god or a fierce one, regard them as mere grass. Strive in courage and valor. When you see certain wicked troops who have changed into the garb of heroes, carrying heroes' weapons, drawing their swords from the scabbard, coming on as if to grind everything to dust, striking sword against sword so that sparks fly, and entering the marketplace raising war cries, do not flee.' When those who are wicked troops see these men, they take them for heroes and scatter like thieving dogs, while those who are good troops, fearing disgrace, hold their ground. Just as those wicked troops, frightened by them, scatter, so the Tathāgata too trains the followers of the Śrāvaka Vehicle in heroism, teaching them: 'Do not fear Māra the Evil One, who is like a cowardly troop; be valiant, like one who has been taught courage, and Māra will be dismayed.'

Further, son of good family, some hero of a great family, or some son of a hero, though no one has taught him courage and he has no teacher at all, is courageous by his very nature; as is the way of a son of good family, he is courageous in keeping with his own heroic lineage as its condition. In the same way, followers of the Great Vehicle, whether men, women, boys, or girls, who on hearing the various words of the sūtras spoken with a hidden intent are not frightened or terrified, are those who in the past served and honored many buddhas. Therefore they understand this Great Vehicle and come to have firm faith in it. When they see a māra, or even ten million māras, the followers of the Great Vehicle are not frightened and do not regard it as the least bit remarkable. It is like a snake charmer who, by the power of antidotal medicine and of mantra, renders venomous snakes harmless and so has no fear of them. In the same way, even ten million māras are deprived of their arrogance by the splendor and power of the mantra that is the words of the Great Vehicle sūtras.

Further, son of good family, venomous nāga serpents frighten elephants, tigers, leopards, and dogs merely by looking at them. Some even die; some, fearing death, flee merely on hearing their sound. Yet there are also people who ride about on venomous nāga serpents, garuḍas, elephants, lions, and tigers.

Some people, when they see such nāgas, garuḍas, lions and rākṣasas, lose all their nerve. Like those timid people, the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas are frightened when they see Māra. Māra has no fear of them, and he goes on doing the work of Māra. Those of the Great Vehicle ride upon Māra. They subdue his great splendor, his great strength and his courage, and they teach the Dharma. Those mighty māras, who are like the nāgas and the rest, are frightened, and at once they come to delight in the true Dharma. They even say, "From now on we will not obstruct the true Dharma."

Those of the Śrāvaka Vehicle are frightened by the forms that the afflictions take. Those of the Great Vehicle regard the afflictions as slight. In this way, those of the Great Vehicle are heroic. That, then, is the reason given earlier: it was for the sake of those of the Śrāvaka Vehicle that I taught the subjugation of Māra. Thus the great Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra is supremely hard to accept.

Ah! Those who have faith when they hear this great sūtra and the words "the Tathāgata is permanent" are doing what is supremely difficult. They are as rare in the world as the udumbara flower. After I have passed away, this great

sūtra will be very hard to find. In times to come, those beings who strive to hear this great sūtra will be shunned by many beings.

He asked, "For how long will it be shunned by beings? What kind of beings will bring forth the true Dharma?"

The Blessed One said, "Son of noble family, after I have passed away it will circulate in Jambudvīpa for four thousand years. After that it will disappear beneath the earth.

"Son of noble family, suppose there is a land where sugarcane, sāli rice, grain, honey, sugar, cow's milk and the essence of butter are plentiful. In that very land there are also others whose karmic ripening is inferior and who have made no merit. They say, 'If this bodily constitution of ours takes good food, it will fall ill,' and so they eat coarse grain, millet and wild millet. In that same land, some others do not even want to hear the names of coarse grain, millet and wild millet, and they eat only sugarcane, sāli rice and grain. In the same way, some other beings do not even want to hear this great Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra. Just as those who have made no merit eat coarse grain, millet and wild millet and dislike sugarcane and sāli rice, so those of the Śrāvaka Vehicle will dislike the Great Vehicle. Some others, who make merit by listening to it, will become followers of the Great Vehicle, like those who eat sāli rice.

"Son of noble family, suppose there are kings who live in wild mountain country, in ravines and poor lands. Although they do have sugarcane and sāli rice, they think, 'These grains are rare; it would not do for them to run out.' So they do not eat them themselves but eat coarse grain, millet and wild millet. They fill carts with sugarcane, sāli rice and grain and offer them to the great king. Then other beings there, though they had never before seen sāli rice and the like in their own land, eat them through the power of the king's wealth.

"Son of noble family, in the same way, wherever those four persons who act as leaders of the Dharma dwell, when even a single bodhisattva mahāsattva appears in the world, or wherever he may dwell, there, for his sake, they have the sections of the Great Vehicle sūtras written out for payment and cause them to be copied. When the copies are finished, they put the volumes into covers and honor them, whether for gain and respect, or for the practice of the Dharma, or to make a support for worship. They serve that bodhisattva mahāsattva, and many people come to enjoy the nectar of the Great Vehicle. Just as people eat sāli rice through the power of the king, so, through the power of that bodhisattva mahāsattva's majesty, beings will hear a drop of

words, even a single syllable, that they have never heard before.

"Wherever the great Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra circulates, that place becomes vajra in nature, and those beings too become vajra in nature. So I declare. When ordinary beings of little merit hear the Great Vehicle, they do not grasp the meaning of the sections of the Great Vehicle sūtras. Those beings who hear it and do not grasp its meaning are to be pitied, like those who eat wild millet."

He asked, "After the Tathāgata has passed away, it will remain in Jambudvīpa for four thousand years and then disappear beneath the earth. After how long will it appear again?"

The Blessed One said, "Son of noble family, when eighty years remain at the end of my true Dharma, as the true Dharma is about to vanish, this great Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra will appear in Jambudvīpa. It will rain down the rain of the true Dharma for forty years, and then it will vanish."

He asked, "In the time when the true Dharma vanishes, when those who keep moral discipline have died out, when what is not the true Dharma spreads, when there is no practice, at the time this great sūtra of the Great Parinirvāṇa appears, what kind of people will listen to it? What kind will keep it? What kind will read it? Who will protect it, hold it, make offerings to it and teach it? What kind will have it written out? Blessed One, Tathāgata, Arhat, Perfectly Complete Buddha, please explain this for the benefit of all sentient beings. There are bodhisattvas who wish to train properly. If they hear this, they will practice so as never to fall away from unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening."

The Blessed One said, "Son of noble family, excellent, excellent!

Son of good family, it is excellent that you ask about this matter. Son of good family, those who have given rise to the mind set on awakening in the presence of as many buddhas as there are grains of sand in the Hiraṇyavatī River will, in a later time, put the awakening mind into practice. They will not fail to put it into practice, and they will not reject the sūtras either.

Those who have given rise to the mind set on awakening in the presence of as many buddhas as there are grains of sand in the Ganges River will, in a later time, not give rise to a mind that rejects this peerless teaching. They will have faith in it, and through their words they will make all people understand it in detail.

Those who have given rise to the mind set on awakening in the presence of as many buddhas as there are grains of sand in two Ganges Rivers will, in a later time, again give rise to the mind set on awakening, and they will not reject this teaching.

Those who have given rise to the mind set on awakening in the presence of as many buddhas as there are grains of sand in three Ganges Rivers will, in a later time, not reject the peerless teaching. They will receive the scripture, listen to it, and ask about it, but they will not understand its meaning.

Those who have given rise to the mind set on awakening in the presence of as many buddhas as there are grains of sand in four Ganges Rivers will, in a later time, again give rise to the mind set on awakening. They will not reject the peerless teaching. They will receive the scripture, listen to it, and ask about it, and they will understand one sixteenth of its meaning, but they will not understand its meaning completely.

Those who have given rise to the mind set on awakening in the presence of as many buddhas as there are grains of sand in five Ganges Rivers will, in a later time, not reject the peerless teaching. They will receive the scripture, look into it, and ask about it. Having written it down, they will also keep it themselves, and they will understand one eighth of its meaning, but they will not understand its meaning completely.

Those who have given rise to the mind set on awakening in the presence of as many buddhas as there are grains of sand in six Ganges Rivers will, in a later time, not reject the peerless teaching. They will receive the scripture and ask about it. Having written it down, they will also hold it, and they will understand one quarter of its meaning, but they will not understand its meaning completely.

Those who have given rise to the mind set on awakening in the presence of as many buddhas as there are grains of sand in seven Ganges Rivers will, in a later time, not reject the peerless teaching. They will receive the scripture and ask about it. Having written it down, they will also hold it, and they will understand half of its meaning, but they will not understand its meaning completely.

Those who have given rise to the mind set on awakening in the presence of as many buddhas as there are grains of sand in eight Ganges Rivers will, in a later time, not reject the peerless teaching. They will receive the scripture, listen to it, ask about it, write it down and hold it, keep it, read it, teach it, keep

it safe, guard it, and explain it. Out of compassion for the whole world, they will make offerings to the volumes and honor them, and they will cause others to do so as well. They will regard it as one regards a revered teacher, and they will understand its meaning completely. They will teach that the Blessed One is permanent, stable, eternal, unmoving, and supremely blissful, and that all sentient beings possess the buddha-nature.

Thus, beings who in the past have served many buddhas will bring forth the true Dharma and will take the side of the true Dharma. Those who now give rise to the mind set on awakening will, in a later time, bring forth the true Dharma and take the side of the true Dharma, for at that time such beings will appear. Son of good family, in the future you must not regard in that way the beings who bring forth the true Dharma. Know that those who now give rise to the mind set on awakening will in the future also give rise to the mind set on awakening and bring forth the true Dharma.

Son of good family, there are those who, when I pass into nirvāṇa through the Great Parinirvāṇa, will feel no displeasure but will rather rejoice, thinking, "This Buddha who obstructs our gain and honor is going to die, and we are glad!" Thinking thus that the Buddha will die, they rejoice and feel no displeasure. Know that at that time they will grow lax, and that those who bear the mere marks of the Dharma robe will reject the sūtras.

Those sentient beings who are endowed with immeasurable qualities will have faith when they hear the Great Vehicle. For those sons of good family who long for the true Dharma, the countless evil deeds they have committed will be purified by no more than headaches, the torment of fever, piercing pains, and slander.

Furthermore, in a later time they will be despised by others. Their complexion will become poor, and their bedding, seats, and food will be poor. They will be without gain. They will be born into poor families, into common families, and into families of wrong view. They will suffer disturbance from kings, disturbance in the land, and disturbance among the things they hold dear. They will not meet virtuous spiritual friends. They will lack clothing, food, bedding, seats, and medicine and remedies for the sick. Their gain will be slight, and they will be afflicted by weakness from hunger and thirst. They will have to please common people. Kings, ministers, and the people of the palace retinue will not take up their talk on the Dharma, nor take the side of those who preach the Dharma. Even the ministers and officials whom they hope will

be their allies and protectors will leave them without any recourse, and will not take the side of the true Dharma. Even if they are good-looking, they will not seem attractive; even if they are pleasing to behold, they will appear unpleasant to behold. Thus, those of my śrāvakas who teach the great sūtra in the world are doing what is difficult.

Son of good family, it is like even very dense frost, which remains until the sun has risen, but as soon as the sun rises, it melts away completely. In the same way, son of good family, the countless evil deeds of those beings also remain until the sun of the Great Parinirvāṇa has risen, but when the sun of the Great Parinirvāṇa rises, those evil deeds will be completely purified.

Son of good family, here is another example. Suppose someone wishes to go forth from home into homelessness, but has not yet taken even the novice's precepts. At that time a certain person invites the Saṅgha of monks, headed by the Tathāgata, to a feast. That householder also puts on the Dharma robes and goes into the town together with the Tathāgata's śrāvakas, and when he is given a seat, he is counted among the Saṅgha of the Tathāgata's śrāvakas. In just the same way, son of good family, a bodhisattva mahāsattva who trains in this sūtra is counted among the bodhisattva mahāsattvas who have attained the ten grounds.

Those who stand outside this only hear it: they are lured by material things, or they want something to talk about, or they desire gain, honor and verses. Yet if they do not reject the sūtra, then, apart from those who reject it out of pride, those other beings will gradually attain the perfect and complete awakening of the buddhas, the arhats.

Son of good family, therefore the four persons taught earlier are the ones to rely on. They could not possibly teach of a sūtra not spoken by the Buddha that it was spoken by the Buddha; there is no occasion for that. Therefore they are the ones to rely on. If even a single one of these four persons is present, make offerings to him and protect him.

He asked, "How should one make offerings to him?"

The Blessed One declared, "That person gives up his own life to bring forth the sacred Dharma. Therefore learn from him how to protect the sacred Dharma, and once you have learned it, make offerings to that teacher. In the Śrāvaka Vehicle too I taught:

Whether he is old or whether he is young,
The one from whom you come to understand the Dharma,
Like a brahmin tending his fire offering,
To him you should bow with reverence.
Whether he is old or whether he is young,
The one from whom you come to understand the Dharma,
As one does toward the god Mahendra (Indra),
To him you should bow with reverence."

He asked, "It is right to make offerings to a teacher. But it is not right for an elder monk endowed with moral discipline to bow to a junior monk, and this needs to be examined. If an elder monk learns from a junior, must he then bow to the junior? If he must bow to the junior, then that elder would no longer be a monk endowed with moral discipline.

There is something further to raise. Suppose the elder monk is immoral and the junior is endowed with moral discipline, and one comes to understand the reality of the Dharma from the elder. Must the junior, even though he has understood, bow to the immoral elder?

There is something further to raise. If one comes to understand the Dharma from someone who lives as a householder, must one bow to that householder? It is not right to show such excessive deference. Householders are not worthy of the offerings of those who have gone forth, nor are they fit recipients of gifts. In this teaching, it is right for the young to make offerings to their elders. What is called an elder worthy of offerings is one who has received full ordination and who abides in the Vinaya, the rites and the proper sphere of conduct. The Blessed One has also said that the immoral are like stones in a field. So would you now also say:

Whether he is old or whether he is young,
The one from whom you come to understand the Dharma,
As one does toward the god Mahendra,
To him you should bow with reverence?

These two statements need to be examined. Otherwise, to act in this way would become an occasion for censure. Blessed One, are you deceiving the monks who are endowed with moral discipline? There are many faults in this. Since the Blessed One has declared in many sūtras that the immoral are to be punished, did the Tathāgata say this with some special intention?"

The Blessed One declared, "The verse

Whether he is old or whether he is young,
The one from whom you come to understand the Dharma,
As one does toward the god Mahendra,
To him you should bow with reverence

I taught for the sake of the bodhisattvas of the future. I did not teach it for those of the Śrāvaka Vehicle.

Son of good family, as I taught earlier, there will come a time when the sacred Dharma declines, when those endowed with moral discipline dwindle, when the faction of the immoral flourishes, when definitive liberation and freedom from attachment are exhausted, and when many take possession of improper goods such as male and female servants. At that time, even a single one of the four persons will go forth from home into homelessness within a Saṅgha that possesses many improper goods such as male and female servants. He will know the distinctions between what is allowable for them and what is not, and between what accords with the Vinaya and what does not. He will know their negligence and the bases of their many faults, and he will know that this conduct is not the conduct of the Blessed One. Then, having regard for place and time, he will learn the nine branches of scripture from the junior monks. Although he knows that they have incurred defeats, he thinks, 'I must bring forth the sacred Dharma,' and so he remains silent, thinking only of that. He appears in the world solely to protect the sacred Dharma.

Son of good family, suppose that in some country a king dies and none of his sons is capable of being king. A caṇḍāla from that very king's realm, who has cymbals that resound like thunder, seizes the kingdom by force together with other caṇḍālas and rules as king. That caṇḍāla is also wealthy by nature. Then, while the caṇḍāla rules as king, the brahmins and householders living there think, 'It is not right for us to be ordered about by a caṇḍāla,' and they abandon the country and go to a land where one of royal caste rules as king. Some other brahmins and householders cannot bring themselves to abandon their own country, and just as a tree withers right where it grew, they too, like trees, stay on in that very country.

Then that caṇḍāla thought, "Many people will flee," and he had caṇḍālas guard all the roads. To hold on to the people who remained, he also proclaimed: "Whatever pure brahmin who has mastered the Vedas wishes to enjoy half of my kingdom, let him serve as my royal chaplain (purohita)!" The great drum was beaten in the city in this way for seven days. Yet the pure brahmins said,

"Who would serve as priest to a caṇḍāla?" and no one would agree.

Then that caṇḍāla gave this command: "If no one will agree to do this, then all the brahmins shall eat food together with caṇḍālas in caṇḍāla households, and sleep there! If they will not agree, I shall force them to do that as well. But if someone agrees, I will give him even half of the kingdom. And the nectar of the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three, which makes whoever drinks it become a god, and which is rare in the world, he shall drink together with me and become a god."

Then a certain young brahmin, pure, wearing a topknot, master of the Vedas, a youth living the celibate life, heard that command. He undid his own topknot, went to the caṇḍāla, bowed to him, and said, "Whatever Your Majesty commands, I shall do." Then that king installed him as royal chaplain. The brahmins mocked him, saying, "This wicked one has agreed to be chaplain to a caṇḍāla! This wicked one!" Then, just as he had said, the king gave him half of the kingdom and ruled together with him.

Then on one occasion the brahmin said to the caṇḍāla king, "Great king, I abandoned the ways of a brahmin and agreed to serve as your chaplain, thinking that I would teach you the sciences one by one, yet you still do not trust me."

The king replied, "Why should I not trust you? I trust you, who have such fine qualities. Now let us drink this vase of nectar of the king who died, sharing it equally, half and half."

Then, after the minister had drunk first, he skillfully poured another drink into the nectar, and when the king drank it, he fainted and lay there as if dead. Then the brahmin made the son of the former king, a capable prince, king, and said, "Take this kingdom and do not let it go to ruin. The caṇḍāla is not fit to be king of this kingdom; you yourself are fit to be king. It is impossible for a caṇḍāla to rule as king."

Then he gave the caṇḍāla a medicine to revive him from his faint, and when he had brought him round, he banished him and inflicted on him the punishment for rebels. When that brahmin had thus restored the kingdom and banished the caṇḍāla, he did not fall from his brahminhood. The brahmins and householders said, "This is a bodhisattva, a great being," and they cried, "Excellent! Excellent!" and honored him.

In the same way, after I have passed away, a bodhisattva will use every kind of means in order to bring forth the true Dharma. In a Saṅgha that hankers after bad goods and is given to bad conduct, he will even appear to conform to the immoral. There will be one who is able to take from those immoral ones their robes, their books, and their requisites and give them to monks who keep moral discipline. There will be one who is able, relying even on administrators, chiefs, and grain collectors, to do away with those who accept the eight improper things. There will be one who is able, just as the brahmin did with the caṇḍāla king, to join with them in granting leave, in the poṣadha, and in joining palms, while carrying out acts that afflict them and subduing those who go against the Dharma. And there will be one who is able to turn even the lax into a pure Saṅgha and to teach the collections of the Great Vehicle sūtras for the benefit of many beings. It was for the sake of such a bodhisattva, a great being, that those verses were spoken.

When he acts in this way, because he brings forth the true Dharma, the brahmins and householders are pleased, and thinking, "Though he is a brahmin, he has established the kingdom and the true Dharma," they honor him. Whoever teaches in this way is truly a bodhisattva, and since he acts in conjunction with skillful means, one should not find fault with him. If one finds fault with him, one will in turn incur a fault oneself: it becomes like an offense that ought to be confessed, and yet, under the sway of pride, one does not confess it. Although that bodhisattva teacher may appear exceedingly lax, he incurs no fault. This intentional statement was taught for the sake of bodhisattvas:

Whether he be old or whether young,
the one from whom you come to understand the Dharma,
as a brahmin does his fire of offering,
to him bow down with reverence.
The one from whom you come to understand
the Dharma taught by the perfect Buddha,
as is done to the god Mahendra (Indra),
to him bow down with reverence.

These lines were not taught for the sake of śrāvakas; they were taught for the sake of bodhisattvas.

He asked, "Blessed One, what of this? May such lax bodhisattvas be given full ordination, or may they not?"

The Blessed One said, "Son of good family, do not speak like that. That itself is their full ordination, and whatever offenses of theirs they confess are confessions that are accepted. Son of good family, it is like an old, cracked pond, from which all the water leaks away. Why is that? Because the people who act in accordance with the Dharma dwindle, while the people who do not act in accordance with the Dharma increase."

If someone repairs that pond, water will no longer leak out of it. In the same way, the bodhisattva also sees that there are no monks endowed with moral discipline, that the practice of the Saṅgha has declined, and that laxity toward the vehicle has spread. Because monks then perform full ordination, the invitation ceremony at the end of the rains (pravāraṇā), the restoration ceremony, and acts of homage with joined palms and bowing together with the lax, moral discipline and ritual leak away, like a leaking pond. But, son of good family, the bodhisattva who wishes to bring forth the true Dharma, and the person endowed with moral discipline, are like the repair of the pond: it is they who are truly fully ordained. Having purified themselves through stainlessness and confession, they repair it by means of the very reality of the sūtras and the Vinaya, as one repairs a pond.

The eighth fascicle.

He asked, "In the sūtra spoken by the Blessed One on the simile of the four kinds of mango fruit, how should those endowed with moral discipline and those whose discipline is corrupt be recognized?"

The Blessed One said, "Son of good family, those endowed with moral discipline and those whose discipline is corrupt are to be recognized from the great sūtra, the Mahāyāna sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa."

He asked, "How are they to be recognized?"

The Blessed One said, "Suppose a certain householder farmer, at the very beginning, clears away the stones and weeds from his fields of sāli rice, grain, and millet, and makes them clean. From then on, until the crop has come to fruit, he counts it all as field with his fleshly eye. But when it has come to fruit, he knows precisely the difference between husk, empty ear, fruit, and kernel, thinking, 'This is grain; this is not grain.' In the same way, the eight great matters are the faults of the Saṅgha. Having removed them like the stones and weeds of the field, one thereafter counts, with the fleshly eye, those within the Saṅgha among the monks endowed with moral discipline. Whoever it may be, so long as he has not become faulty and the fruit of his qualities has not

become evident, one cannot tell with the fleshly eye, 'This is fruit; this is bad grain.' In the meantime, like the field, they are all counted equally as members of the Saṅgha. Why is that? Because the fault of a field is its stones, and the fault of the Saṅgha is the eight great matters. The Saṅgha that is free of the worst of faults, which are like venomous snakes, is called a field. Whatever monk has become like a pure field is to be honored like a god and made a recipient of offerings. Before he has come to fruit, the fleshly eye cannot discern faults and qualities.

"Furthermore, son of good family, suppose that within the enclosure of a village there are many kāraka trees, and among them there is also a single tinduka tree. That tinduka tree bears fruit, and those kāraka trees bear fruit as well. Then a poor young girl who gathers fruit picks the tinduka fruit, and picks about ten times as much kāraka fruit, thinking it is tinduka fruit. She fills a basket with them and sells them in that same village. Then children, thinking that both kinds of fruit are tinduka fruit, buy them, eat them, and die. Then the discerning people who wish to eat tinduka fruit question the young girl carefully: 'Sister, from which direction did you get these?' She shows them the place, and when she has shown them, they see that there are many kāraka trees there and only a single tinduka tree. Realizing, 'These were taken from there,' they search for the tinduka fruit, and failing to find it, they are frightened and terrified of the kāraka fruit. Out of that very fear they reject the fruit and go back without buying.

"In the same way, son of good family, in whatever Saṅgha the eight great matters are knowingly practiced, if monks endowed with moral discipline are living among those who practice them there, and one sees them there like a tinduka tree standing in a kāraka grove, then even though they are endowed with moral discipline, a wise layman should not bow to them and should not make them objects of offering. If he wishes to bow to them, he should first ask, 'Do you accept the eight great matters, or do you not accept them?' and only then bow. He should ask, 'Do you perform the invitation ceremony and the acts of the restoration ceremony together with those who accept them, or do you not?'

"Suppose they reply, 'The eight great matters of the Saṅgha are accepted, for the Blessed One too, out of compassion for all beings, accepted gold and silver in the grove of Prince Jeta.' And suppose some among them do not accept them, saying, 'We do not perform the invitation ceremony, the restoration ceremony, or acts of homage with joined palms and bowing together with

those who accept them. We do not even drink their gruel, and we accept neither gain nor honor from them.' And suppose others say, 'If even the Buddha, the Blessed One, the god of gods, accepted them, what is there that cannot be tolerated in the Saṅgha's accepting them?' Even if they speak in this way, one should say, 'Surely you have not performed the invitation ceremony, the restoration ceremony, or acts of homage with joined palms and bowing together with them?' Those who will not heed such words are the ones who know the true sūtras. Those who accept, who are like the children, should be known to be beings of the hells; those beings are like the children who died."

Furthermore, son of noble family, it is like this. In the incense markets of a great city, merchants sell māduraka incense, many other kinds of incense, and medicines. The buyers there do not know what the medicine that comes from the snow mountains is like, so they ask, "If you have even a little māduraka incense from the snow mountains, give it to us." The merchant takes something made to imitate incense from the snow mountains, says, "This is incense from the snow mountains," and hands it over. They fully believe, "This comes from the snow mountains," and so they accept the counterfeit incense. In just the same way, whether the monks are of corrupt discipline or possess moral discipline, the layman who has only the eye of flesh thinks of them, "These are the true Saṅgha of śrāvakas. These are the true Saṅgha. These are the harmonious Saṅgha," and he should bow to them and should give them gifts. For a layman with the eye of flesh, it is hard to tell whether something is genuine or counterfeit, just as it is hard in the incense market with the medicine from the snow mountains. Likewise, those who lack the divine eye cannot tell the difference, and so, just as with the medicine from the snow mountains, they cannot discern, "This one has moral discipline. This one has corrupt discipline. This Saṅgha is free from the faults of the eight great matters." Who possesses moral discipline and who has corrupt discipline is the domain of those who have the divine eye. It is not the domain of those who have only the eye of flesh. But if one sees that they are impure, then one should not bow to them and should not give them gifts until they have confessed the offenses they have committed that can be confessed. As for monks who accept the eight great matters, until they have confessed their own confessable offenses and so have become pure, like the medicine from the snow mountains, one should not bow to them simply because one trusts that they wear dyed robes. Nor should one give them gifts.

Then this was said: "Excellent, Blessed One! Excellent! This word of the Blessed One is well spoken, and I shall receive it on the crown of my head like a precious vajra. On this the Blessed One has said: 'Monks, these four are the reliances. What are the four? Monks, your reliance is the nature of reality (dharmatā), not the person. Monks, your reliance is the definitive meaning, not the provisional meaning. Monks, your reliance is wisdom, not consciousness. Monks, your reliance is the meaning, not the letter.' And it was well spoken when you said, 'For us these four reliances are authoritative; the four persons are not authoritative.'"

The Blessed One declared: "The nature of reality means the parinirvāṇa of the Tathāgata. That the Tathāgata is permanent, stable, and everlasting: this is the nature of reality of all buddhas. I say that those who see the Tathāgata as impermanent do not know the nature of reality. I say that they are mere persons. I say that they are not authoritative. The four persons other than these are authoritative. As for the four persons who are skilled in words spoken with hidden intent, who know the secret reality of the Tathāgata, and who know that he is permanent, it is impossible for them even to give rise to the thought, 'The Tathāgata is impermanent,' because those four persons are themselves tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas. If I say that other beings too, persons skilled in all the words of hidden intent that the Tathāgata is permanent, are authoritative and have become reliances, then how could those four not be reliances?

"'Monks, your reliance is the nature of reality' refers to the direct knowledge of the śrāvakas, and it means, 'Do not forget the nature of reality!' The nature of reality means that one should strive toward the truth that the Tathāgata is permanent, and not strive toward persons. It means that if persons of corrupt discipline who are greedy for material gain say, 'The Tathāgata is impermanent,' those persons are not authoritative.

"As for 'Monks, your reliance is the definitive meaning, not the provisional meaning': the definitive meaning is the Great Vehicle teachings. When one hears the words of hidden intent, the secret of the Tathāgata, it is called definitive because there is no fault of doubt. It means having crossed the great ocean of wisdom and having come forth from it. The definitive wisdom, the Great Vehicle, refers to unobstructed wisdom. Obstructed wisdom is that of the followers of the Śrāvaka Vehicle. Definitive wisdom is called great wisdom and the Great Vehicle. Because those bodhisattvas who rightly realize that the Tathāgata is permanent make it certain, the words of bodhisattvas are

authoritative, whereas the provisional meaning is not so. 'The Tathāgata has a body of flesh, and he passed into parinirvāṇa like a fire whose fuel is exhausted': this is the Śrāvaka Vehicle, and it is not authoritative. Those sūtras were taught according to those who were to be trained. The Śrāvaka Vehicle is like half-formed letters, and it makes distinctions; it does not serve as a master. The followers of the Śrāvaka Vehicle are counted among the provisional meanings. Whatever knowledge does not comprehend the greatness of the Tathāgata as taught from wisdom is the Śrāvaka Vehicle. Therefore the provisional meaning is not authoritative. Those four persons are authoritative, for they are the definitive meaning and not the provisional meaning. Therefore they have become reliances, and they are the definitive meaning.

"'Monks, your reliance is wisdom' is a figurative expression of the Tathāgata. The Dharma body is not something to be measured. The body of skillful means is not something to be measured.

When one considers the body of skillful means, in what way are there aggregates, elements and sense sources in the body of the Tathāgata? Yet if there were none, where would the mass of relics have come from? Therefore, because of the relics, stūpas arise in the world, but the Dharma body does not arise.

The statement "the Tathāgata is a body of flesh" is taught from what consciousness examines, and consciousness is not a valid authority. That is why it is said that consciousness is not a valid authority. Those beings who conceive of him in that way are not valid authorities either, and sūtras of that kind are not valid authorities either.

In the saying "Monks, your reliance is the meaning," "meaning" is the clear meaning. "The clear meaning" is the illuminating meaning. "The illuminating meaning" is the meaning that is not feeble. "The meaning that is not feeble" is the meaning that the Tathāgata is permanent. "The meaning that the Tathāgata is permanent" is the meaning that the Dharma is permanent. "The meaning that the Dharma is permanent" is the meaning that the Saṅgha is permanent. That is the meaning, and that is the reliance.

"Not the letter" refers to self-fabricated writings connected with discontent, failing to reduce one's possessions, great desire, hypocrisy and flattery, and to sūtras of various words not spoken by the Buddha. They claim that the Blessed One, out of love for us, so that his children would not be afflicted when famine

came, spoke training rules permitting male and female servants and the like and many kinds of stores of provisions, and that he said: "I permit male and female servants and the like, the amassing of gold, silver, cattle, buffalo and grain, trading, plowing fields, and so forth." Such statements are called "the letter," and sūtras and Vinaya of that kind are not valid authorities. Therefore the persons who recite the letter are not valid authorities either, and that is why it was said, "Monks, your reliance is the meaning."

"Meaningless" refers to the view that in the three bases there exists impermanence, such as destruction, falling, scattering and disintegration. This is called meaningless, and this is called the letter. Therefore it was said, "Monks, your reliance is the meaning, not the letter."

Those on the side of the meaning are the followers of the Great Vehicle. Therefore the followers of the Great Vehicle are valid authorities, but those outside this who rely on the letter are not so. Therefore, although they are not a reliance, they have been set forth for the sake of those who have only fleshly eyes.

He asked, "Should the four persons spoken of earlier be called reliances?"

The Blessed One said, "Noble son, that is so. The four should be known to be reliances. I say that the four who are not those are māras."

He asked, "Why is that so?"

He said, "Because they uphold sūtras spoken by Māra."

He asked, "What is that like?"

He said, "It is like the four māras who rise up against the Tathāgata and say, 'This was spoken by Māra, not by the Buddha. These beings accord with Māra, not with the Buddha.'"

He said, "Blessed One, I wish to understand what is spoken by Māra and what is spoken by the Buddha."

The Blessed One said, "Noble son, when seven hundred years have passed after my passing, Māra the Evil One will break my teaching apart piece by piece and destroy it. When the true Dharma declines, Māra the Evil One, who is defiled, will transform himself as if he were undefiled, and, just as one conceals the signs of what one is doing, he will destroy it in the guise of a monk, the guise of a nun, the guise of a layman, the guise of a laywoman, and in the guise of a stream-enterer, a once-returner, a non-returner, an arhat, a

pratyekabuddha and a buddha. He will speak thus: 'The Buddha died and passed from the abode of Tuṣita, and when King Śuddhodana and Queen Māyā came together, he was born from the act of sexual union, in accordance with the particular time of her menses.' But it is impossible for the Tathāgata to be born from sexual union. They say that he was born in name only, and that by the virtue of austerities practiced in the past he came to be worshiped and praised by the world with its gods, humans and asuras, and that he says, 'I became a buddha by giving away wives and various kinds of desirable things as gifts.' Such statements should be known to be sūtras and Vinaya spoken by Māra.

"The Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, by the force of those to be trained, shows himself as though he were born, but he is not born from sexual union. Statements that say, 'The Tathāgata's showing himself as though he had both a father and a mother is conforming to the world,' should be known to be sūtras and Vinaya spoken by the Tathāgata.

"Whatever beings take as valid authority the sūtras and Vinaya spoken by Māra should be known to be in accord with Māra. Whoever take as valid authority the sūtras and Vinaya spoken by the Buddha should be known to be bodhisattvas.

"The statement that when the Tathāgata appeared in the world he was shown taking seven steps in each of the directions and intermediate directions is not to be believed; sūtras and Vinaya of that kind should be known to be spoken by Māra. Statements that say, 'The Tathāgata's being shown, when he appeared, taking seven steps in each of the directions and intermediate directions is the Tathāgata's assuming a body of skillful means,' should be known to be sūtras and Vinaya spoken by the Buddha.

"Whatever beings take as valid authority the sūtras and Vinaya spoken by Māra should be known to be in accord with Māra. Whoever take as valid authority the sūtras and Vinaya spoken by the Buddha should be known to be bodhisattvas.

"The Tathāgata went to the temple of the gods, and when he arrived he paid homage at the feet of the gods, while the gods did not bow their heads at the Tathāgata's feet. After making offerings to the gods he became the Tathāgata and attained manifest awakening. The gods came first and he came later, and that is why he is called the manifestly and perfectly Awakened One." Statements such as these should be known to have been spoken by Māra.

"When they saw the Tathāgata going to the temple of the gods, all the gods, Īśvara, Maheśvara (Śiva), Brahmā, Śakra (Indra) and the rest, joined their palms reverently and touched his feet with the crowns of their heads." Statements like this should be known to be sūtra and Vinaya spoken by the Tathāgata.

Those beings who take as authoritative the sūtras and Vinaya spoken by Māra should be known to be in accord with Māra. Those who take as authoritative the sūtras and Vinaya spoken by the Buddha should be known to be bodhisattvas.

"The Tathāgata, when he was crown prince, indulged freely in sensual pleasure with the daughters of the neighboring kings." Statements such as these should be known to be sūtra and Vinaya spoken by Māra.

"The Tathāgata cast aside even women like the divine maiden Rambhā as if they were spittle, and went forth from home into homelessness." Sūtra and Vinaya of this kind should be regarded as spoken by the Buddha.

Those beings who take as authoritative the sūtras and Vinaya spoken by Māra should be known to be in accord with Māra. Those who take as authoritative the sūtras and Vinaya spoken by the Buddha should be known to be bodhisattvas.

"The Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened Buddha, out of compassion for the whole world, accepted, in Prince Jeta's Grove, the park of Anāthapiṇḍada, precious metal, gold, male servants, female servants, cattle, buffaloes, goats, sheep, chickens, pigs, dogs, cats, snakes, mongooses, copper, brass, jewels, pearls, conch, crystal, coral, gold dust, silver, household utensils of every kind, fields, markets, scales, engaging in trade, boys, girls, treasuries and storehouses." Statements like this should be known to be sūtra and Vinaya spoken by Māra.

"While he was dwelling in Prince Jeta's Grove, among the reeds, in the grove of castor plants, at the foot of a picumarda tree, he spoke concerning the brahmin Sheep Glory and Prasenajit, king of Kosala, and declared: Those who keep precious metal, gold, male servants, female servants, cattle, buffaloes, goats, sheep, chickens, pigs, dogs, cats, snakes, mongooses, copper, brass, jewels, pearls, conch, crystal, coral, gold dust, silver, wealth, and household utensils of every kind; who keep fields, markets, scales, who engage in trade, who keep boys, girls, treasuries and storehouses; who roll up their own sleeves and prepare food, who cook and have others cook; who practice omens, the

science of bodily marks, divination texts, the recitation of chants, and the reading of bird omens; who observe Rāhu, the sun, the moon, Venus and the courses of the other planets, the flower chariot, the lines of the hand, and dream omens; who examine the marks of men, women and neuters; who teach the sixty-four arts, the eighteen fields of learning, the work of craftsmen and all the crafts; who tell tales; who sprinkle scented powders; who wear flowers, incense, perfumes, garlands and unguents; who kiss heads; who are hypocritical, flatter, know no contentment, have great desires, delight in bustle and love to chatter; who prepare wealth, grain, meat, fish and poisons; who keep scented sesame oil, medicine tubes, parasols, shoes, palm-leaf fans, water vessels, satchels and clubs; who gather fruit; who indulge in tooth powder, medicated butter, fine refined powders, kakkola and pungent fruits; who rely on the king and rely on others; who cannot bear heat; who keep silence; who are much given to thinking like women; who talk a great deal, weep, judge good and bad, and disparage others; who affect a special gait; who wear white clothes and fine cloth; who busy themselves with building mansions and lofty shrines and the like; who acquire what is not allowable and bad articles; who proclaim the praises of donors; who indulge in liquor; who go to the houses of prostitutes: to those who do such things, who are not holy and who are of bad conduct, I permit that white clothes be given and that they be made to do worldly work. Or else I permit them to be driven out of the region, as stones are cleared from a field of śāli rice." Sūtra and Vinaya of this kind should be known to be spoken by the Buddha.

Those beings who take as authoritative the sūtras and Vinaya spoken by Māra should be known to be in accord with Māra. Those who take as authoritative the sūtras and Vinaya spoken by the Buddha should be known to be bodhisattvas.

The Tathāgata does not go to any of the abodes of the gods, of Brahmā, the bhūtas, the Desiccator, Kumāra, the Grandfather of the World, Kātyāyana and the rest, in order to crush their pride; he does not go, and it is impossible that he should go. He does not go forth among any of the wonder-workers. He is not a teacher of the imaginings of all beings. He does not keep any secret mantras or vidyā-mantras. He does not engage servants, male servants or female servants, and he does not arrange reconciliations or quarrels. He does not hold men, women, physicians, kings or ministers dear. If the Tathāgata were like that, he would not be the Tathāgata, and he would have to be called one of wrong view.

"The Tathāgata is like the axe and the sandalwood tree: he neither punishes anyone nor does anyone any good. Therefore the Tathāgata is called one who sees the middle path." A statement such as this should be known as a confusing sūtra spoken by Māra.

"The Tathāgata goes to all the abodes of the gods. He goes forth into homelessness among all the heterodox orders. He shows the thoughts of all sentient beings. He makes use of secret mantras, vidyā-mantras, and medicines of every kind. He goes into assemblies and into places of music. He gathers in servants, maidservants, and all sentient beings. He also displays the various bodies of youths, maidens, the queens' retinue, palace attendants, country folk, householders, brahmins, hungry ghosts, the destitute, men and women. And when he goes here and there to free the whole world from suffering, he understands without being stained by views, just as a lotus is not soiled by water. This is how he acts in accord with the whole world." A statement such as this should be known as the sūtra and Vinaya spoken by the Buddha.

Those sentient beings who take as authority the sūtras and Vinaya spoken by Māra should be known as conforming to Māra. Those who take as authority the sūtras and Vinaya spoken by the Buddha should be known as bodhisattvas.

"Thus in our Vinaya, misdeeds, wrongdoings, light offenses, heavy offenses, and gross offenses are by their very nature to be abandoned, and therefore the Blessed One said that they are to be abandoned. Such things accord with our Vinaya but do not accord with your Vinaya, so why should we go against our own Vinaya and adopt yours? Your Vinaya is a fabrication, while our Vinaya was spoken by the Blessed One. It is well known that the Blessed One made nine seals from the nine-limbed scripture; the Blessed One sealed it with those nine seals. We have never before heard so much as a single sound, word, letter, or dot of what is called the Vaipulya. How many sūtras did the Blessed One teach? Did he teach ten sūtras? In our scriptures there is not even the sound of the word Vaipulya. All of these were made by Devadatta, who ruins every meaning and then argues. The Vaipulya was fabricated by its own authors and is therefore not authoritative, whereas our Vinaya is sublime. Ours is like this! Ours is like this!" This rejection of the Vaipulya compositions in order to ruin the teaching should be known as the sūtra and Vinaya spoken by Māra.

"In the future, too, monks will appear who speak a false Vinaya and false sūtras, saying, 'Our Vinaya is like this. In our Vinaya the Blessed One said such and such.' From the nine-limbed scripture of the Great Vehicle, I taught the Later Section, the Great Vehicle Vaipulya. Those who practice together with me in my presence are not ones who speak a false Vinaya and false views. My teaching has abandoned everything improper; it is completely pure, stainless, like the full moon. I have taught the meanings of each sūtra, each Vinaya, and each basis of training in numbers like the sands of the Ganges River, and these too I have taught through many different verbal synonyms. Whoever says, 'Whatever bases of training are not found in our Vinaya, those the Blessed One did not teach,' a fault will arise for every one of them. 'Even though we are unable to uphold them all, whatever concerns contentment and devotion to few possessions, and whatever is fit to be the word of the Buddha, all of that he taught in the manner of the Great Vehicle, out of benefit and compassion for all sentient beings. Therefore we too shall expound what is called the Vaipulya.' I am the teacher of those who make such a pledge; of those who do not, I am not the teacher. They have not gone forth for my sake; all of them are sons of tīrthikas." A statement such as this should be known as the sūtra and Vinaya spoken by the Buddha. Proclaim it thus!

Those sentient beings who take as authority the sūtras and Vinaya spoken by Māra should be known as conforming to Māra. Those who take as authority the sūtras and Vinaya spoken by the Buddha should be known as bodhisattvas.

"The Tathāgata does not possess immeasurable qualities. He is impermanent. He has passed into complete nirvāṇa. He has become empty. He teaches selflessness. He does not act in accord with the world." A sūtra that says such things should be known as the sūtra and Vinaya spoken by Māra.

"The Buddha, the Blessed One, is inconceivable and possesses inconceivable, immeasurable, countless qualities. He is permanent. He is stable. He is everlasting. This is what I say." One who speaks thus should not be said to have incurred defeat, like a palm tree whose top has been cut off. What need is there to mention all four of what the Blessed One called the four defeats? If even any one of the four defeats occurs, one becomes like a broken stone. This was said in the complete text of the Last of the Later Sections, in the passage on superhuman states. Why is that? It refers to claiming, "I have attained the fruit."

What I taught in the Later of the Later concerning the case of a monk brought down in regard to the superhuman qualities is this. Suppose a certain monk lives here who has few desires and is content. When the king or the king's great ministers see him, they think he has attained the fruit. They praise him by many means, composing it in verse, saying, "This venerable one, once he has parted from the body and died, will become a buddha." That monk hears this from them directly and says, "Do not praise a person who has not attained the fruit as if he had attained it. The Buddha has censured the craving for greatness. The Buddha has praised keeping silent. As long as I live I take no delight in such things, so do not set me in the craving for greatness like this. I myself know that I have not attained the fruit."

The wise king thinks, "This venerable one has attained the fruit; he is a buddha," and proclaims it among the learned throughout the world. He also has his queens' retinue and his princes learn the sūtras as though they were poetry. Even when this is done, much merit grows for the king and ministers who give the praise. I say that this monk is simply one who leads the holy life and keeps moral discipline, and that he has not incurred a defeat. Nor has he committed the offense concerning superhuman qualities. I say he keeps moral discipline and has few desires. Even though he has been praised in this way, his mind is clear with faith and he accords with the Buddha's scriptures, and I say that such a monk has not the slightest fault.

Moreover, a certain monk here teaches the great sūtra of the tathāgatagarbha. He says that all sentient beings have the buddha-element, and each carries that element in their own body. Once sentient beings have exhausted every form of the afflictions they become buddhas, except for those of great desire (icchantikas). Then some king or king's minister says to him, "Monk, will you become a buddha or not? Do you have the buddha-element or not?" The monk replies, "Venerable sir, who could know whether I will become a buddha or not? Even so, the buddha-element is present in my body." Then the other says to the monk, "Monk, if you are not an icchantika, think, 'I shall become a buddha.'" And the monk says to him, "Venerable sir, that quality is certainly present in my body." If he says this, and someone asks whether that monk should be said to have committed the offense concerning superhuman qualities or not, the answer should be: "Although he said the element is present, it is present only in those endowed with generosity, moral discipline, knowledge, and the Dharma."

Moreover, after going forth a monk may reflect, "Ah, will I become a buddha or not?" Or he may think, "It is clear that I shall attain buddhahood." If he thinks this, much merit grows for him, even though he has not attained the fruit. If it were not so, every monk would be guilty of claiming superhuman qualities. And why? Because for eighty koṭis of eons I gave up keeping unsuitable possessions. I lived in supreme contentment with few requisites and meditated that the tathāgatagarbha is present. Having awakened fully and perfectly, I became the Buddha, the Blessed One, endowed with great compassion, who teaches a hundred thousand sections of the Dharma.

Teaching of this kind should be known as the sūtras and the Vinaya spoken by the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha. Those sentient beings who take as authoritative the sūtras and Vinaya spoken by Māra should be known as followers of Māra. Those who take as authoritative the sūtras and Vinaya spoken by the Buddha should be known as bodhisattvas.

Now suppose it is said: "There are no four defeats. There are no thirteen offenses entailing suspension from the Saṅgha. There are no two undetermined offenses. There are no thirty downfalls requiring forfeiture. There are no ninety-one simple downfalls. There are no four offenses to be confessed individually. There are no many trainings. There are no seven means for settling disputes. There are no misdeeds. There are no grave offenses. There are no acts of immediate retribution, and there are no icchantikas. If monks went to hell for transgressing the training rules just listed, when those rules do not even exist, that would be the teaching of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas). For those to whom these rules do not apply, it follows that they will go to the higher realms. The Blessed One proclaimed the training rules in the Vinaya only to frighten people. Whoever wishes to engage in unchaste conduct should give up the dyed garments and the Dharma robes and put on white clothes. Having done so, he may think to himself, 'Because my own good qualities are few, I indulge in sensual pleasures of little worth, but there is nothing wrong in it. Even while the Blessed One was alive, monks indulged in sensual pleasures and still reached the higher realms and liberation. So have I not entered into the nature of reality? This has existed by custom since ancient times.' A monk who reflects in this way will attain liberation even if he has incurred a defeat. It is the same for transgressing the five precepts and for keeping every kind of unsuitable possession. The Tathāgata did say that by committing a misdeed one will burn in hell for eighty thousand years, counted even in the years of the gods of the Heaven of the

Thirty-Three, or longer still. Yet that too was only to frighten. Nor is the fault of a grave offense, one degree lower than a defeat, anything severe. Many holders of the Vinaya have spoken falsely about it, but the Tathāgata said that it carries no force."

Sūtras and Vinaya of this kind should be known as spoken by Māra.

Among all the bases of training, a misdeed (duṣkṛta) is a minor one. Yet even when such a minor misdeed has occurred, someone denies it, saying, "It did not happen to me," and hides the offense he has committed as a turtle hides its limbs. One should not associate with a person like that. A person who has broken the single rule against speaking falsehood has abandoned the world beyond, and there is nothing he will not do. This means that there is no improper conduct whatsoever that he would not resort to. Since the Buddha's teaching is subtle in this way, how could it fail to restrain grave offenses? If someone does not restrain even that much, he is utterly unrestrained.

If one asks what one holds to in guarding moral discipline: the buddha element exists. With the single conception of becoming a buddha in the manner of the ninefold scripture, to say, "All sentient beings have the buddha element," and to say, "In the extensive sūtras (vaipulya) there is the supreme selflessness," is not to reject the sūtras in the manner of the ninefold scripture. Otherwise, it would be so.

He said, "If the ninefold scripture teaches definitively that all sentient beings have the buddha element, how does that not become a view of a person? How should I hold it, just as I have heard it? If it were so, it would also amount to claiming a superhuman quality."

The Blessed One replied, "Just like someone who says that in the ocean there are no jewels of various kinds endowed with the eight qualities is someone who says that in the great ocean of wisdom of the extensive ninefold scripture there is no buddha element. This speech of the Buddha is not their domain. The Buddha's speech, by way of the reasons and signs that all sentient beings have buddha-nature, is evidently not the domain even of all the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. In the Great Vehicle, there is no destruction of self and life force either. Therefore the Buddha is called the Middle Way.

"Those who say, 'There is the buddha element in my body, and I will attain buddhahood, but I must exhaust the afflictions,' are my śrāvakas. As for the other kind, I say that he has committed the offense of claiming a superhuman quality. Because I have taught in this way, someone says, 'Since the Blessed

One sees from the buddha ground at which the holy Dharma is attained, I too shall become a buddha, a blessed one.' If one asks whether one who says this commits the offense of claiming a superhuman quality, he does not commit that offense. I say that he will gradually become a buddha. Thus the speech of the Buddha is subtle and profound."

He said, "Here some king may say, 'How is it that a monk is said to have committed the offense of claiming a superhuman quality?' An answer to this is needed."

The Blessed One replied, "Here there are monks who, for the sake of gain and honor, or for material things, put on false manners and flatter. They think, 'How should I act so that others will know me as one who lives on alms? If I act in that way, I will obtain gain.' Having become deluded by nature and greedy for praise, they think, 'Though I have not attained the fruit, I shall make others know that I have attained the fruit. I shall make others know that I am a stream-enterer, a once-returner, a non-returner, an arhat. I shall get the laymen sitting before me to speak words by which all people will know that I am such a one.' Attending in this way, not for the sake of attaining the Dharma, but for gain, honor, veneration as a teacher, prostrations, and material things, they put on the manner of arhats in looking at one another, in half-closing their eyes, and in their gait. They carry their robes, their outer robe, and their alms bowls. They sit on new beds and seats, thinking, 'I shall make people say of me that I am a good monk, an ascetic monk. Moreover, I will have a retinue and disciples. Then, together with whole companies of followers, I will obtain requisites of food to eat, to chew, to lick, and to drink. Women too will honor me.' With such a conception in mind, they make it known to household members and servants. A monk or a nun who conceals things in this way, I say, has committed the offense of claiming a superhuman quality.

"Again, here some monk, with the thought, 'I shall bring forth the holy Dharma,' sits on beds and new seats and thinks, 'Though I am not an arhat, I shall make it known that I am like an arhat, so that all people will think, Oh, this monk is truly virtuous and good. Because I am known in this way, and many monks become my retinue, even non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) will become lay followers. Those of corrupt morality will also be humbled. Then I shall bring forth the holy Dharma. I shall show the greatness of the Tathāgata. I shall proclaim the extensive sūtras. I shall surely free all sentient beings. I shall distinguish what is Vinaya from what is not Vinaya. In me there is the seed of

becoming a buddha, called buddha-nature, and I shall attain buddhahood. I shall destroy the forms of affliction. You laymen also have the buddha element; we shall all become buddhas and attain the ground of the Tathāgata. We shall exhaust the forms of affliction.' One who thinks in this way is a bodhisattva by way of his conception of the holy Dharma, and I say that he has not committed the offense of claiming a superhuman quality.

"If even by committing a misdeed one is cooked in hell for eighty thousand years and more, reckoned in the years of the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three, what need is there to speak of a grave offense? In this Great Vehicle, one should not associate with one who has committed a grave offense."

"Grave offense" means this. Suppose that, in order to look after a stūpa of the Blessed One, a flower garland belonging to someone else has been tied on it, and it has grown old. If a monk takes it because he needs the thread, and, being shy of the monks, takes it without asking them, he becomes guilty of a grave offense. And if he takes it thinking, "Something like this makes no difference at all," one should still not associate with such people. If someone tears down a stūpa with the intention of stealing, he too becomes guilty of a grave offense, and one should not associate with such people.

Suppose that here some householder or minister, with a mind set on the Dharma, wishes to honor the relics, or needs bricks, and so tears down an old stūpa and takes its bricks. If that householder or minister then finds gold or silver in the stūpa and places it in the hands of some monk, and that monk takes it, makes it his own property and quarrels over it, that is not good for the monk. Those lay followers abide in the Dharma. That monk cannot be trusted, and one should not associate with him. He should be known as a eunuch. He should be known as a hermaphrodite.

"Hermaphrodite" means one who has both sexual organs. When male desire arises, such a person has sexual relations with women, and when female desire arises, with men. That is why such a person is called a hermaphrodite, and one should not associate with that person either. If, then, one should not associate even with people like these, how could one even look upon those who commit offenses against the five bases of training?

Fascicle nine.

First of all, monks, following the Dharma of a renunciant, should have compassion even for ants. Following the Dharma of a renunciant, they should

also give up any drink that smells of liquor. Following the Dharma of a renunciant, they should not give rise to the thought of lying, even in a dream. Following the Dharma of a renunciant, they should not give rise to the thought of meeting a woman, even in a dream.

He asked, "How is it? If one meets a woman in a dream, does that amount to the fault of unchaste conduct?"

The Blessed One said, "It does not. If one who has intelligence and mindfulness does not give rise to the thought of unchaste conduct toward foul-smelling sense pleasures, then, because he has reviled the afflictions and talk of women, his conceptual thinking has been completely cut off, and so it is impossible for that thought to arise. Even if he meets a woman in a dream, when he wakes the next morning he feels regret, like a monk in a time of famine who has eaten food made of his own son's flesh. How then could the notion 'That is pure' ever arise in him? And even if the thought does arise, he should crush it again."

A Dharma teaching that says such things should be known to be the sūtras and Vinaya spoken by the Buddha. Those sentient beings who take as authoritative the sūtras and Vinaya spoken by Māra should be known to be siding with Māra. Those who take as authoritative the sūtras and Vinaya spoken by the Buddha should be known to be bodhisattvas.

Suppose it is said: "The Blessed One has permitted sitting in the heroic posture, remaining silent, leaping from precipices, eating poison, fasting, binding oneself, killing oneself, having others carry out malicious deeds, reciting vidyā-mantras and secret mantras, and practicing the arts of concoction. The Blessed One has permitted the sons of caṇḍālas, eunuchs, hermaphrodites, and all those with defective limbs to go forth. The Tathāgata gave up the five products of the cow, honey, sesame oil and the like, silk, conch, shoes, grain and the like, and, seeing that all trees have life and perception, passed into complete nirvāṇa." What says such things should be known to be sūtras and Vinaya spoken by Māra.

Dharma activities such as remaining in the heroic posture and walking are not included in this. "Eating poison, leaping into fire, fasting, leaping from precipices, binding oneself, killing oneself, having others carry out malicious deeds, reciting vidyā-mantras and secret mantras, and practicing the arts of concoction: these I have not permitted. The five products of the cow, honey, sesame oil and the like, silk, conch, shoes, grain and the like I have permitted,

without perceiving them as meat, with the perception that no tree has life, and without perceiving them as having minds. Those who see it otherwise are śrāvakas of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas). Those who act in accordance with my word are my śrāvakas; this I declare. I do not say that the four elements have life and perception." Sūtras and Vinaya that say such things should be known to be the sūtras spoken by the Buddha.

Those sentient beings who take as authoritative the sūtras and Vinaya spoken by Māra should be known to be siding with Māra. Those sentient beings who take as authoritative the sūtras and Vinaya spoken by the Buddha should be known to be bodhisattvas.

"Son of noble family, I have now explained in detail the difference between what Māra speaks and what the Buddha speaks."

He said, "Blessed One, only now have I truly entered upon the Buddha's word."

The Blessed One said, "Excellent, excellent, son of noble family! You have done well, son of noble family; the wise should act just so."

He also said, "Son of noble family, 'This is suffering' is not to be called the truth of the noble ones. If one asks what that suffering is, what is called suffering exists also in cattle, donkeys and the like, and in hell beings. If that suffering were the truth, it would be their truth as well. As for what is called suffering, oh, what is called the knowledge of suffering is this: the Tathāgata is permanent; he is the Dharma body, not a body of flesh. To know the greatness of the Tathāgata in this way is the knowledge of suffering. Until they have attained that, sentient beings imagine that what is not Dharma is Dharma, and so for a long time they experience suffering in the wheel of saṃsāra, a place of intense suffering, and then go to the lower realms."

When one knows that the Tathāgata is permanent, then however one hears those two syllables, one will go to a happy destiny, and after that one will also attain liberation. One then realizes for oneself, "This is the bliss of miraculous power. It is through the mere cause of having heard the words 'the Tathāgata is permanent' that I have come here. For as long as I did not know the Tathāgata to be permanent, for all that time I circled among sufferings." To say, "Now I know suffering," this is the truth. The meditation on suffering of others is meaningless.

As for "This is the origin of suffering": not knowing the suchness of the Dharma as suchness, people accept many impure goods, such as male and female

servants, for the needs of the Dharma, and they take what is not Dharma to be Dharma. In this way they cause the true Dharma to decline and to disappear. Because they do not know the means by which the true Dharma is made to endure, they hold that there is no such thing as the true Dharma perishing, and as the result of that they wander among the sufferings of saṃsāra. Afterwards they attain the higher realms and liberation. To know, "Because I did not know the reality of the origin of suffering, by which the higher realms and liberation are attained, I became a cause of the destruction of the true Dharma, and through wrongly spoken words I have been afflicted for this long": this should be called knowing the origin of suffering. That of others is not like this.

As for "This is the cessation of suffering": it is not the kind of meditation on emptiness which, meditating on utter emptiness in which everything is exhausted, makes buddha-nature nonexistent. If meditating on the cessation of suffering were that, then even all the heterodox have an emptiness that runs contrary to the meaning, and they too would be said to have the cessation of suffering. All sentient beings have buddha-nature, but it is not clearly manifest. When the afflictions are exhausted, then you will see the entry into buddha-nature. When you come to know, "Through the karmic fruit of generating a single thought, I attain the permanence and bliss of the lord of the Dharma," that is to meditate on what is to be meditated on as the cessation of suffering. By meditating on buddha-nature as selfless and meditating on utter emptiness, sufferings do not cease; it becomes like a moth flying into the flame of a lamp. Not so: sentient beings who meditate on buddha-nature as existing stop the aspect of affliction even while the afflictions are still present. Why is that? Because of the condition of buddha-nature. Knowing this is called, according to the word of the perfectly complete Buddha, the true word of the cessation of suffering. Anything else is meditating on what is not meditation.

As for "This is the path leading to the cessation of suffering": it refers to the Tathāgata, the Dharma, the Saṅgha and liberation. Thus, the thing that has become inverted with regard to them through the four inversions is liberation. To think that in liberation too there is nothing at all is in this way to dwell in illusion and to wander among the sufferings of saṃsāra, and through the fruit of that wrong meditation one comes to experience suffering for a long time. "Now, through the fruit of generating a single thought that the Tathāgata, the Dharma, the Saṅgha and liberation are permanent, stable, everlasting and

indestructible, I attain the fruit of permanent sovereignty. Having held the four inversions, suffering, selflessness and impurity, taking what is not Dharma to be Dharma, I experienced the fruit of wrong views." This is called the path leading to the cessation of suffering.

Those who meditate on impermanence in order to accomplish the meditation on the three bases as permanent are meditating on a false meditation. Those who meditate on them as permanent in this way are my śrāvakas; I say that they know the Four Noble Truths. These are to be understood as the Four Noble Truths.

It was said: "Blessed One, only now do I understand that one should meditate in the manner of this path of the Four Noble Truths."

The Blessed One declared: To perceive suffering as bliss is an inversion. To perceive bliss as suffering is an inversion. Here, to say "the Tathāgata is impermanent" is wrongdoing and suffering. To say "the Tathāgata has passed into parinirvāṇa like a fire whose fuel is exhausted" is wrongdoing and suffering. To meditate oneself, thinking "it is not suffering," and to say "the Tathāgata is impermanent," this is an inversion. To perceive bliss as suffering is an inversion: to think, "If one meditates that the Tathāgata is permanent, one may come to hold a view of a person," and so to think, "this meditation is suffering," is the inversion of those who perceive bliss. This is the first inversion.

To perceive the impermanent as permanent is an inversion. To perceive the permanent as impermanent is an inversion. Here, to think, "If one meditates on utter emptiness, one's life will become short," and therefore to meditate on impermanence as not empty, thinking, "Through the fruit of that meditation I will become long-lived," that too is an inversion. This is the second inversion.

To perceive what is without self as self is an inversion. To perceive what has a self as without self is an inversion. Here, to meditate on selflessness, saying, "Worldly people say there is a self, but unlike the worldly, in the Buddha's word there is no self; there is not even the name of buddha-nature," this is the third inversion.

To perceive the impure as pure is an inversion. To perceive the pure as impure is an inversion. Here, the Tathāgata is permanent; yet to take what is not a body of flesh to be a body of flesh, bound together with flesh, blood and sinews, and to say "it is impure,"

To think that the Dharma and the Saṅgha too will disappear once liberation is attained is the inversion of taking the pure as impure. My whole body is impure, and since there is nothing at all that can be called pure, to meditate thinking, "My body is pure," is grasping the impure as pure. To think, "I too shall go to where there is nothing at all," is to meditate on the pure as impure. It is a factor that causes delusion, and this should be understood as the fourth inversion.

He said, "Blessed One, only now have I come to hold right view; until now I held wrong views. Blessed One, how is it? In the twenty-five kinds of existence, should we say that there is a self, or that there is not?"

The Blessed One said, "'Self' means the tathāgatagarbha. The buddha-element is present in all sentient beings. But it is obscured by the various forms of the afflictions, so although it is present in themselves, sentient beings cannot see it.

"It is like this. Suppose that in a great city, in a poor household, there was an inexhaustible treasure of gold. A poor woman lived there, and she did not know that there was a treasure beneath the ground of her own house. Then a man skilled in means said to the woman, 'Mother, come here. I will pay you wages. Go and work in my field.'

"She answered him, 'Sir, I will not go. If you show my son the treasure, then I will go.' So she spoke words grounded in reason.

"He said to her, 'Mother, as soon as my son is born of you, I will give you an inexhaustible treasure of jewels and gold.'

"Then she said to him, 'How could you ever give that? You are only making fun of me.'

"Then he said to her, 'There is a treasure in your own house. But if even you yourself do not know it, how could anyone else know to look for it?'

"Then she entreated him, saying, 'I wish to obtain it.' So he dug the treasure out from inside that house and gave it to her. When she saw it she was filled with wonder and went to him for refuge.

"In the same way, son of good family, the tathāgatagarbha is present in all sentient beings. They simply cannot see it, just as the poor woman had a treasure of her own. Son of good family, I shall rightly teach that the tathāgatagarbha is present in all sentient beings. The poor woman did not know of her great treasure and had to be shown it. In the same way, sentient

beings neither know nor see that the tathāgatagarbha is present in all beings, because it is obscured by the forms of the afflictions. The Tathāgata shows it to them, and, delighted, they go to the Tathāgata for refuge."

He said, "Blessed One, now I understand that the buddha-element exists. I shall regard the Tathāgata, who gives the instructions, as like that man skilled in means, and I shall regard all sentient beings as like the poor woman."

The Blessed One said, "Son of good family, here is another example. Suppose there was a woman whose son, still very small, fell ill. The woman called a physician, and the physician gave the child medicinal ghee mixed with sugar. Then he instructed the mother, 'Lady, do not give the child the breast until the medicinal ghee has been digested.'

"So that the child would not suckle, the woman smeared both her breasts with a paste of ground neem leaves. She told her son, 'My child, my breasts are smeared with poison. My child, do not suckle.'

"The little boy was thirsty and wanted to suckle. But when he smelled the neem leaves on her breasts, he cried, and he stayed apart by himself until the course of treatment was over.

"When the treatment was finished, the woman washed both her breasts with water and said to her son, 'O my child, now you may suckle.' But the boy thought there was still poison. He would not suckle, and he sat there crying, refusing even to look.

"Then she spoke to him again: 'Earlier your medicinal ghee had not yet been digested. To keep you from suckling, I smeared both my breasts with neem paste. I did not let you suckle because I feared it would harm you and you would die. Now you may suckle.' She let him suckle, and slowly he began to suckle.

"In the same way, son of good family, earlier, for the sake of those to be trained, I acted as one does when a child's medicinal ghee must be digested. I wanted the monks to destroy worldly views. I wanted to show rightly the greatness of what transcends the world. I wanted to show rightly that the worldly notion of a real self is false. And I wanted the body to be purified through meditation on selflessness. So I said, 'Monks, meditate on all phenomena as selfless. When you meditate in this way, you will abandon clinging to "I." When clinging to "I" has been completely abandoned, you will attain nirvāṇa.' Just as the child's mother smeared her breasts with neem

paste, so I too said, 'Meditate on all phenomena as selfless, as emptiness.'

"Later the child's mother washed her breasts and said to her son, 'Earlier I did not let you suckle, so that your medicinal ghee could be digested. Now suckle.' In the same way, in order to turn beings away from worldly ideas, I taught as I did and said, 'There is no self.' Now I teach, 'The tathāgatagarbha exists.'

"Monks, do not be frightened as the child was. The child looked into it and then suckled at his mother's breast again. In the same way, monks, you too should examine this, thinking, 'We have the tathāgatagarbha,' and strive in meditation. This is what I have now taught."

He said, "Yet when a child is just born, it has little understanding, or none at all. It does not make sense that it should then become clear-minded. If there were a self, it would make sense for the child to have understanding and intelligence from the start. And if its understanding is weak, it does not make sense that it should later become clear. Therefore I say that there is no self. Why is that? If the self were permanent, it would make no sense for one who has been born to die."

"If the tathāgata-element were permanent, why do differing distinctions appear in it? Distinct differences of birth also appear, arising from the distinctions of karma by which one becomes a brahmin, a kṣatriya, a vaiśya, a śūdra, or a caṇḍāla, or comes to a birth among animals. If there were a self, a self without distinctions would be sameness itself, and in that case there would be no element in it. If there is an element, why does one engage in the ten paths of nonvirtuous action, such as killing, stealing the wealth of others, and sexual misconduct? Why does one become intoxicated by drinking liquor? If the element of sentient beings were permanent, then the deaf too ought to hear with their ears, the blind too ought to see, and the mute too ought to be eloquent. If the self, the element of sentient beings, were permanent, in which part of the self do the masses of phlegm, of the embryonic mass, of blue and of yellow reside? And in what place among them does that self reside? Or does it reside everywhere, like moisture? If that were so, then when a man's ears and nose are cut off in battle, the limbs of that self too ought to be impaired, or it ought to become maimed."

He declared: "Son of noble family, suppose a certain king's wrestler had a precious vajra fastened between the eyebrows on his forehead, and that wrestler contested his strength with another wrestler. As the two were wrestling in the customary way, the other wrestler butted him with his head,

injured his forehead, and drove the ornament between his eyebrows entirely inside. The wrestler did not feel it, and thought, 'Where can I have put my vajra?' He summoned a physician and had him treat the wound. That physician was skilled in means and sharp of mind. Knowing that the wound had come from the jewel, he thought, 'The vajra has sunk inside the forehead and is lodged there.' He asked the wrestler, 'O man, where has that jewel of yours gone?' The wrestler said to the physician, 'Alas, physician, I must have lost the vajra that adorned my brow. Oh dear, I do not know whether I put it in a box or where I put it; even when I search in the chest I cannot find it. Oh dear, curse it, it is gone! If it has vanished like a bubble on water, has it become like an illusion?' Then the physician said to him, 'O man, do not grieve like this. That vajra of yours has sunk into the wound and is shining there amid the flesh, blood and pus. You were simply so absorbed in wrestling that you did not feel it.' Though the physician said this, the wrestler did not believe him, and said to the physician, 'Then why did it not come out with the pus and blood? Or is it caught on a sinew? Do not say such things.' Then the physician drew out the vajra and showed it to him, and when he saw it he was amazed.

"In the same way, all sentient beings possess buddha-nature, but sentient beings do not know it. Through the fault of relying on nonvirtuous friends, and being overwhelmed by attachment, aversion and delusion, sentient beings are born as hell-beings, animals, hungry ghosts, asuras, caṇḍālas, brahmins, kṣatriyas, vaiśyas and śūdras. Because they do not know it, through the power of their own faults and through attachment, aversion and delusion, sentient beings become dull-witted, deaf, blind, maimed, withered on one side, stained with various impurities, with yellow eyes, with the color of lentils, with the color of kuraṇṭaka flowers, with reddish-yellow eyes, and take various forms in the twenty-five kinds of existence.

"Just as that wrestler, though the vajra was in his own body, through impaired perception imagined it lost, so worldly sentient beings, not realizing the reality of the self, falling under the sway of nonvirtuous friends, and not understanding words spoken with a hidden intent, meditate on no-self even though the self exists. Those who do not meditate on no-self meditate on a worldly self. Just as those who say 'a worldly self exists' do not realize the reality of the self, so it is too with the supramundane: through relying on nonvirtuous friends and not knowing the final import of words spoken with a hidden intent, even while meditating 'there is no self, there is no self,' they do not know the reality of no-self. They think: 'Where is the self? Where does it

reside? Is it like a pot inside a pot? Or does it pervade like moisture? Or is it like the ornament on the bewildered wrestler's brow?' To them, like the physician, the Tathāgata declares: 'The self does not reside everywhere; like the precious vajra it is luminous, and it is obscured by the aspects of the afflictions.' When he has declared this, sentient beings come to believe it, and all that remains is to exhaust the afflictions. Then, like the vajra, they will see the buddha-nature. Son of noble family, in this way the buddha-nature is immeasurable.

"Furthermore, son of noble family, on the snowy mountains, for example, there is an elixir-element called the Bee Essence. Though it is hidden by a dense forest of gelpa trees, it is revealed by its fragrance. In the past a certain wheel-turning king, for its sake, set up pipes on every side, and from that elixir-element there came, from the mouths of some pipes, a sour juice; from some, a salty taste; from some, sweetness; from some, pungency; from some, bitterness; and from some, astringency. Such an elixir-element hovers in the air within the forest. From that single-tasting elixir arise various different tastes, yet these tastes do not mix with one another, and that elixir-element remains all-pervading, like the disc of the moon."

"Although it remains there in this way, when other beings enter that forest of gelpa trees and dig with hoes, beings of little fortune do not obtain it, whereas a wheel-turning king obtains it by the power of his merit. In the same way, son of noble family, the tathāgatagarbha is like that elixir-element, and it remains obscured by the various forms of the afflictions. Although, as the cause of becoming a buddha, it has a single taste, through the karmic maturation of beings it turns into many tastes, and males, females and neuters come into being.

"That tathāgata-element is the very nature of the person. Therefore, when a life is cut off, the living being is not killed. If the living being were killed, the life-principle would be made utterly nonexistent, and it is impossible for the life-principle to become utterly nonexistent. Here, what is called 'the life-principle' is the tathāgatagarbha. That element cannot be destroyed, killed or made utterly nonexistent, and until buddhahood is attained it cannot be seen as completely pure. Therefore there is no person who kills living beings."

Kāśyapa said, "One cannot say that there is none. If there were none, it would follow that killing living beings is no wrongdoing."

The Blessed One declared, "One should say that there is. How so? Destroying the outer, accumulated element, which is like the gelpa tree, is called taking life. Therefore, through taking life, the killer goes to the lower realms because of the mass of wrongdoing. And through the maturation of bad karma, beings take rebirth as brahmins, kṣatriyas, vaiśyas, śūdras and caṇḍālas, as birds and as wild animals, under the names of the three different sexes, with different dispositions, and in the twenty-five states of existence.

"Worldly people conceive of the self as being the size of the fruit of the śyāmāka plant, the size of a grain of rice, the size of a thumb, and so on. That is a false conception. The transcendent conception is the conception that the buddha-element exists, and that is the conception of ultimate truth.

"Again, son of noble family, suppose a man who knows how to work a mine digs for treasure with a hoe or some other digging tool. He can grind all the stones and gravel to powder, but he can never cut a vajra even slightly. Just as no weapon whatever can cut the precious vajra, in the same way, son of noble family, the tathāgatagarbha, the self of the one who takes birth, cannot be cut by any weapon, even by tens of millions of gods and māras, whereas the accumulated element can be ground to powder like stones and gravel. The tathāgatagarbha, the life-principle, is like the precious vajra. So when people's lives are cut off, their living is destroyed, and therefore, by destroying the accumulated element, living beings are killed.

"Son of noble family, in this way the Buddha's teaching of the Vaipulya is supremely subtle. It is the supreme nectar, and it is also the supreme poison."

Kāśyapa said, "Blessed One, with what intention did you declare that the Vaipulya is both the supreme nectar and the supreme poison?"

The Blessed One declared, "Son of noble family, do you wish to know this intentional statement?"

Kāśyapa said, "Blessed One, I wish to know the supreme utterance of intentional statements."

Then the Blessed One spoke these verses:

"Some who drink nectar do not die;
Some, if they drink it, die.
Some, even drinking poison, do not die;
Some, if they drink it, die.
In this Great Vehicle,

Wisdom free of attachment is nectar,
And that supreme, unequaled wisdom
Is also taught to be poison.
For one who eats after digestion,
The essence of ghee, honey
And sugar are like nectar;
For one who eats undigested, they become poison.
Likewise the Vaipulya, the supreme nectar,
For those unskilled in intentional statements
And possessed of childish minds,
Becomes a poison hard to bear.
Pratyekabuddhas and śrāvakas too
Are always just like that:
For them the Great Vehicle, the supreme medicine,
Is like drinking cow's milk.
The fearless bodhisattvas,
Those steadfast, supreme among humans,
Surely go forth by the Great Vehicle.
Kāśyapa, having understood it thus,
Go now, today, for supreme refuge
To the deathless, the permanent, the expanse of the element.
That element of the supreme nectar
Is my element, the element of beings.
If you always go for refuge to me,
The three refuges become the element itself.
Because the element is present in my body,
Enter into this very self!
The Buddha, the Dharma and the Saṅgha
Are the nature of my element;
These three are the supreme jewels."
So the Blessed One spoke in verse.

Kāśyapa said:
"How one goes for refuge to the fearless one,
I have not understood.
Nor do I know the Three Jewels;
How does one go to what is without self?

Even if one goes for refuge to the Buddha,
How does one find relief?
For what reason do people
Go for refuge to the Dharma?
By what does one become free,
And by what does one not?
If one goes for refuge to the Saṅgha,
How do the three refuges become supreme?
In the future, how does one attain
Buddhahood itself, perfect and true?
For the sake of what is to come, the three bases of refuge,
What are they like?
I see them as a ladder;
Apart from wisdom there is nothing else.
When no son has yet been born,
How can one even speak of a 'son'?
If a son is conceived, he will be born,
And then thought and action have their purpose too.
Sage, what you teach
The unintelligent do not understand;
All of them, in the prison of saṃsāra,
Wander round as on a single wheel.
Therefore they do not become laymen
By the mere name alone.
Sage, explain it to me in detail;
Please cut through my doubts swiftly.
Tathāgata, endowed with great wisdom,
Please show what your intention is."

The Blessed One declared:
"Bodhisattva, great being,
Mahākāśyapa, holy and supreme,
I shall teach that intention too;
I shall cut through your doubts.
By going for refuge to the Buddha,
One attains the state of a layman.
None of those gods

Are then his refuge.
If one goes for refuge to the Dharma as well,
Here one gives up doing harm.
If one goes for refuge to the Saṅgha too,
Likewise one becomes a layman."

Therefore those outside of this
Are not worthy of offerings to him;
And so those who are without fear
Will obtain the three bases of refuge.

He replied:

Therefore to the three entities that overcome fear
I shall go for refuge.
This is the path of the holy ones;
This itself is the nature of reality of the buddhas.
Great Sage, at all times
The three bases are sameness itself.
I too, just like you,
Shall be unsurpassed in this abode.

This path is praised by the Sugata;
To go there is to abide truly.
From it the all-seeing eye too surely arises.
This path is praised by the Sugata;
Therefore I too shall enter
This path of the buddhas, this supreme and vast path.
Even if Māra should bestow ambrosia this very day,
I shall not go for refuge within the realms of existence.

Then the Blessed One said to him: "Do not hold it as the childish followers of the Śrāvaka Vehicle do. Go for refuge to the one alone. In this wisdom there are no three refuges, nor is there any gathering of Dharma and Saṅgha. The Buddha himself is also the Dharma and also the Saṅgha; the Tathāgata himself is the three bases. In the Śrāvaka Vehicle the three bases are set out in order to remove the worldly views of the childish. If you conform with worldly people, then go to the three bases of refuge in that way, and resolve thus: 'Having gone for refuge to the Buddha, may I become of one body with him. Then, having become a buddha, may I carry out the vast deeds of the Tathāgata.

Having become equal to the Tathāgata, I shall not bow with joined palms to the buddhas. May I become like a great refuge for all sentient beings. Without giving up the Dharma body, I shall pay homage to the relics of the Buddha and to stūpas. May I become like a stūpa for all those sentient beings who do not wish to pay homage. May my body become an object of homage for all sentient beings. Having gone for refuge to the Dharma, may I become the Dharma body. May I lead all sentient beings who cultivate dharmas that are not reality, passing them along one after another as an arrow is passed from one to the next. Having gone for refuge to the Saṅgha, may I become like a refuge for those saṅghas that are like flies. By way of engaging in going for refuge, may I become like the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha for sentient beings. May I become like an eye for those saṅghas that are like the blind. May all the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, who are like flies, come to me for refuge.' Make your resolve in this way.

"Son of good family, in this way the bodhisattva great beings appear to the childish like an inexhaustible heap of evil, while to the wise those very same ones are like buddhas. For example, when a true hero fights in battle, he thinks: 'I shall defeat all the heroes and make them all come to me for refuge.' And for example, when the time comes for the succession of the king, a prince, surpassing all the other princes, thinks: 'I shall be king. I shall become lord of all the princes. I shall make them come to me for refuge. I shall not give rise to an inferior resolve.' Whether they be heroes, kings, or ministers, those of such a nature, who are exceedingly supreme and preeminent, accomplish deeds befitting their own qualities. Son of good family, in the same way the bodhisattva great being possesses a mind that will go beyond the three bases. Therefore, like a prince and a hero, generate courage without fear. I have taught that the three bases are not distinct, and that among the three the Tathāgata is supreme. Just as among all the parts of the body the head is chief, so the Buddha is chief. And just as the head does not remain apart from the body, nor do the hands remain apart, nor do the feet remain apart, in the same way the Buddha does not remain apart, the Dharma does not remain apart, and the Saṅgha does not remain apart. Nevertheless, the division into distinct ones is taught like the rungs of a ladder in order surely to deliver the childish. In the reality of the Dharma, do not view the three as divided into distinct ones. Do not hold to words that bring confusion, as the childish do. Make your mind sharp like a razor-edged sword. Become endowed with great wisdom."

Then the bodhisattva great being, the kinsman of Mahākāśyapa, said to the Blessed One: "Great Hero, Blessed One, even though I understood, I asked in order to request that you explain the stainless conduct of bodhisattvas. Blessed One, oh! You have spoken excellently of the conduct of bodhisattvas, the unsurpassed Great Vehicle, the Vaipulya, which is like a razor-edged sword. Oh, it has been well set forth! Having heard the explanation of the conduct of bodhisattvas, I too wish to teach it to all sentient beings. Whatever sentient beings they may be, those who have strong faith in this sūtra in order to realize the tathāgatagarbha are themselves the three refuges. They go for refuge to themselves and have no need of the three bases. Why is that? Because the tathāgatagarbha, the buddha-element, is present. Having examined thoroughly, one should declare, 'The buddha-element is present in my body.' Having understood in this way, such a one will not even go to the three refuges, for that itself becomes the refuge of the Dharma and the Saṅgha, and it is a place to which the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas always pay homage. Therefore one should undertake the practice of the Great Vehicle. Thus the buddha-element, the thirty-two major marks, and the eighty excellent minor marks are inconceivable."

The Blessed One said: "Excellent, son of good family, excellent! One of sharp wisdom must act in this way. Son of good family, furthermore, I shall explain the entry into the tathāgatagarbha. If the self were stable and everlasting, there would be no end to suffering; and if there were no self, all pure conduct would be meaningless."

If all phenomena are without self, then that becomes a view of annihilation. If the self is stable, that becomes a view of permanence. If all phenomena are impermanent, then that becomes a view of annihilation. If all phenomena are permanent, that becomes a view of permanence. If all phenomena are nothing but suffering, that becomes a view of annihilation. If all phenomena are bliss, that becomes a view of permanence. If one meditates on everything as permanent, one will come to grasp at annihilation. If one meditates on everything as annihilated, one will quickly come to grasp at permanence.

Leeches, for example, quickly feed on a person's head and quickly let go of the other spot. In the same way, if one meditates on permanence, one grasps at everything and so becomes like the leech. Therefore, one should meditate on the other phenomena that are nonvirtuous as suffering. One should meditate on the other phenomena that are virtuous as bliss. One should meditate on the other phenomena, such as the forms of the afflictions, as without self. As for

nirvāṇa, because it has no basis and no abode, one should meditate on the other phenomena, such as buddha-nature, as having a self. One should meditate on the other phenomena, such as wealth and enjoyments, as impermanent. One should meditate on the other phenomena, such as the qualities of the Tathāgata, as permanent. The three bases and the reality of liberation are not like the feeding of the leech.

Know that the speech of the Buddha is this Middle Way. The Buddha, the Blessed One, taught the Middle Way, which abandons both extremes, annihilation and permanence. Fools are confused about the speech of the Buddha. They quickly fall into views of the two extremes, just as those whose stomach heat is weak eat a great deal of butter. "It exists" is not established, and "it does not exist" is not tenable either.

Physicians, for example, even when the bodily elements such as bile are disturbed and at odds with one another, pacify the bile in a bile disorder, remove the wind where wind predominates, and clear away the phlegm in one who suffers from phlegm. For a combined disorder they apply the remedy for a combined disorder. They do not set the elements at odds with one another, and they also bring about well-being. In the same way, like a physician, gradually remove the endless diseases that are the forms of the afflictions, and heal the true element as well. The true element is buddha-nature, which is called the buddha element. Therefore, abandoning all other elements, apply yourselves diligently to what is permanent and stable.

The wise should not be attached even to existence. "It does not exist" also comes from speaking falsely. And remaining silent, one should not assert "it exists" either. Nor should one dispute; one should know these, by their intrinsic nature, as the nature of reality.

Fools who do not understand words spoken with a hidden intent constantly dispute, because I have taught suffering even though such seeds of bliss are present in my body. Grasping at everything, the childish think and imagine, "His body is not stable." When impermanence is taught, the childish grasp it as, "It is impermanent, like a potter's vessel." The wise, knowing that such seeds of the Dharma body are present in my body, do not grasp at everything.

When selflessness is taught, the childish take it as, "The teaching is that there is no self." The wise know that a self exists conventionally, and they have no doubt. When it is taught that buddha-nature is empty, the childish cultivate the crooked view of annihilation, which is terrifying. The wise know that what

is permanent, stable and eternal exists as a mere illusion. When liberation is taught, the childish take it as, "Having attained liberation, the buddhas cease to exist." The wise know that buddhas come and go, and they say, "The lion among men has come."

The childish take as two the statement, "Conditioned by ignorance, formations." The wise know that ignorance and knowledge are not two separate things. The childish take as two the statement, "Conditioned by formations, consciousness." The wise know that formations and the absence of formation are not separate, that they are not two. Likewise, the childish take everything virtuous and nonvirtuous as two separate things. The wise know them to be not two, so it is said. The childish take the blameworthy and the blameless as two. The wise know them, likewise, to be not two, so it is said; that is the nature of the wise. The childish take what are called the path and the non-path as two. The wise know them to be not two, so it is said; that is the nature of the wise. The childish take as two the statement, "All phenomena are black and white." The wise know them to be not two, so it is said; that is the nature of the wise.

The childish meditate on all phenomena as suffering and bliss, two separate things. The wise meditate on them as not two, so it is said; that is the nature of the wise. Those of childish mind meditate on buddha-nature as, "All conditioned things are impermanent." The wise know it to be not two, so it is said; that is the nature of the wise. The childish, when the Buddha speaks of selflessness, take all phenomena as being without self. The wise know that self and selflessness are not two; that is the nature of the wise.

The immeasurable buddha-nature praised by the buddhas I have taught in the Sūtra Gathering All Merit, and it should be understood that self and selflessness are not two. Son of noble family, remember how in the Sūtra Gathering All Merit, and in that very Light of Entering Nonduality from the great Perfection of Wisdom Sūtra, I taught that self and selflessness are not two.

Fascicle ten.

For example, from milk comes curd, from curd comes butter, from butter comes ghee, and from ghee comes the cream of ghee. In that case, does the curd arise simultaneously with the substance of the milk? Or does the curd arise by itself? Likewise, does the butter arise simultaneously with the substance of the curd? Or does the butter arise by itself? Likewise, does the

ghee arise simultaneously with the substance of the butter? Or does the ghee arise by itself? Likewise, does the cream of ghee arise simultaneously with the substance of the ghee? Or does the cream of ghee arise by itself? Or does that richness come from something else? If it comes from something else, then from what does it come?

If curd arose without milk, milk would be unnecessary. If that were so, curd would possess an intrinsic nature of its own; yet both the cause of curd and its characteristic marks are evident. Therefore it does arise in succession, one from another; and yet one should not say that it arises in succession, one from another, simultaneously with those substances. And if it does not arise simultaneously with those substances, does that mean it is utterly nonexistent?

The ghee that comes from the cow does not come from anything else, and that nature is present in all of them. Yet it is not manifest, because it remains obscured by faults and intermingled with them. Through a fault in the cow's food, the milk tastes of a foul smell of blood; when the cow eats sweet grass, the milk comes out sweet; when it eats pungent grass, the milk comes out pungent. In the snow mountains there is a kind of grass called Unctuous. When the cow eats it, the milk comes out purely of the nature of the cream of ghee: neither white, nor blue, nor red, nor bluish gray, it comes out purely of the nature of the cream of ghee.

Just as milk thus becomes ill-colored or well-colored according to the different kinds of grass, so too, although ignorance and knowledge are not two, through the fault of the karma of sentient beings that very thing which is knowledge becomes like ignorance. All virtuous and nonvirtuous phenomena, too, are simply nondual.

Therefore, just as was taught before, buddha-nature has a nature like the cream of ghee, but the faults of the forms of the afflictions make it appear otherwise.

For example, the water of the ocean serves only the single purpose of saltiness, and yet one should not say that it serves only the single purpose of saltiness, for within the ocean there is also what is called the ocean of milk. In the snow mountains, too, because there are medicines, the mountains are spoken of in terms of their good qualities: although there is poison in the snow mountains as well, medicine is mentioned as the chief thing. Likewise this body is similar: although it holds the poison of the four elements, which are

like venomous snakes, it contains the king of medicines, buddha-nature. Therefore buddha-nature is an element uncontrived from the very beginning, while the afflictions are adventitious. Whoever wishes to become a buddha should destroy the forms of the afflictions.

For example, when thunder rumbles in the sky, mushrooms swiftly spring up, whereas in spring there is not even the name of mushrooms; they are brought forth by the thunder. In the same way, buddha-nature, obscured by the forms of the afflictions, appears as though it were selfless. But those who hear this great sūtra, immediately upon hearing this Great Parinirvāṇa, give rise, like the mushrooms, to the knowledge of buddha-nature. All other sūtras and all samādhis are like the season of spring: through hearing all those sūtras and all those samādhis one does not truly know that buddha-nature exists. Just as mushrooms spring up under the summer rains, so from this great Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra come forth all the secret words of the hidden intent. Immediately upon hearing this sūtra, just as mushrooms spring up under the summer rains, all sentient beings will truly know that buddha-nature exists. Because it unfolds the great meaning, it is called the Great Parinirvāṇa. Those who train in this great Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra are the ones who repay my kindness.

It was said: "Oh, Blessed One, buddha-nature is extremely difficult for all śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas to see, extremely difficult to comprehend, and extremely difficult to accept."

The Blessed One said, "Son of good family, so it is. Son of good family, so it is. I too say exactly that."

It was asked: "How is it difficult to see?"

He said, "Son of good family, suppose there were a hundred blind people. Wishing to see with their eyes, those blind people seek out a great physician who is an eye doctor. That physician treats their eyes and removes their cataracts. Then he holds up one of his fingers and says to each of them, 'Man, look at my finger! It will then be clear whether or not your treatment has succeeded.' Yet although the treatment has been carried out, however he holds up his finger, those people do not see it. Then he shows it to them two or three times, and they see it dimly, as though not seeing it.

"In the same way, son of good family, the bodhisattva mahāsattvas who have attained the ten grounds and have undergone every treatment of purification are also like this. Although they have been purified in this way, they are like

those people: when I have shown them two or three times that buddha-nature exists within themselves, they see it dimly, as though not seeing it. And having seen it, they say: 'For so long we too have been turned about by the single wheel of selflessness. How then could śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas ever see it?' Son of good family, in this way, entry into the treatise on my element is difficult to see."

"Son of noble family, here is another example. Suppose a certain person sees geese flying in a line across the sky. Having seen them, he falls into doubt and thinks, 'Is this just the sky, or are those geese flying?' When he examines carefully, he sees, though only dimly, that they are geese in flight. In the same way, even the great bodhisattvas who have attained the ten grounds think, 'We see only dimly that each of us has the tathāgatagarbha (buddha-nature).' How much less, then, could any śrāvakas or pratyekabuddhas see it!

"Suppose a person traveling on a road has his bile disturbed, so that his sense of direction is confused. When he examines carefully, he sees the road and the shapes around him only dimly. In the same way, even the great bodhisattvas who have attained the ten grounds, when they examine carefully, see only dimly that in their own bodies there is the uncreated element, the tathāgatagarbha.

"Suppose a certain traveler, tormented by thirst, finds no water in a remote wilderness. As he sits there longing for water, he sees white cranes perched on the branches of trees and thinks, 'Is this a mansion, or is it the sky?' When he examines carefully, he sees, though only dimly, that they are white cranes. In the same way, son of noble family, even the great bodhisattvas who have attained the ten grounds see only dimly that the tathāgatagarbha is present in their own bodies, present as it truly is.

"Son of noble family, suppose a person sailing in a ship on the ocean sees, from many leagues away, a white mansion within a city, and thinks, 'Is this the sky, or is it a mansion?' When he examines carefully, he sees it only dimly. In the same way, even the great bodhisattvas who have attained the ten grounds see only dimly that the buddha element is present in their own bodies, present as it truly is.

"Son of noble family, suppose a young prince living a life of pleasure has spent the night until it fades watching performances of music. When he gets up, his eyes are dazzled by the sunlight, so that when he looks carefully he sees even his own belt only dimly. In the same way, even the great bodhisattvas who

have attained the ten grounds see only dimly that the buddha element is present in their own bodies.

"Suppose a certain attendant of the king, on a pitch-dark night thick with clouds, leaves the royal palace to go to his own home. In a flash of lightning he sees a herd of oxen coming toward him, and he thinks, 'Is it a cloud? Or a house? Or a gatehouse? Or a building with an upper story?' When he examines carefully, he sees them only dimly. In the same way, even the great bodhisattvas who have attained the ten grounds, though the buddha element is present in their own bodies, see only dimly, thinking, 'The tathāgatagarbha is present in my body.'

"Suppose a certain monk, conscientious in keeping moral discipline, looks at water in which there are no living creatures, yet by his own mind sees creatures in it, and he thinks, 'Are these living creatures? Or is it dust? Or is it dust that has suddenly blown in, or is it a creature?' When he examines carefully, he sees only dimly. In the same way, even the great bodhisattvas who have attained the ten grounds see only dimly that the tathāgatagarbha is present in their own bodies, present as it truly is.

"Suppose a person is walking here and there early in the morning when clouds have suddenly gathered, and he sees some children and thinks, 'Is that an ox? A buffalo? Or a vulture?' Only afterward does he see, dimly, that they are children. In the same way, even the great bodhisattvas who have attained the ten grounds see only dimly that the tathāgatagarbha is present in their own bodies, present as it truly is.

"Suppose an image of a bodhisattva painted on a large cloth is spread out in the darkness of night, and people with eyes examine it and think, 'Is this an image of the Buddha? Or a piece of red cloth? Or is it an image of Maheśvara (Śiva) and Brahmā?' Only afterward do they see, dimly, that it is the image of a bodhisattva. In the same way, son of noble family, even the great bodhisattvas who have attained the ten grounds see only dimly that the tathāgatagarbha is present in their own bodies, present as it truly is.

"Son of noble family, thus the tathāgatagarbha is extremely hard to see. It is the domain of the Tathāgata, not the domain of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. Son of noble family, thus my teaching is to be understood by the wise; it does not accord with the whole world."

He asked, "If that is so, how can those who have only fleshly eyes see this subtle aspect?"

The Blessed One said, "How could even the gods of the sphere of neither perception nor non-perception see it? This is the domain of the Buddha alone, not the domain of any śrāvakas or pratyekabuddhas. They should develop faith by following this sūtra. If they do so, they too will come to have right view. Son of noble family, thus all śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas too should have faith, in the manner of this great Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra, that the tathāgatagarbha is present in their own bodies, and they should strive to accord with the sūtras. The tathāgatagarbha is the domain of the Tathāgata, not the domain of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas."

He said, "Blessed One, among worldly people too there is the designation of a person as the element of sentient beings."

The Blessed One said, "Son of noble family, suppose there were two men who were friends. One was a king's son and the other a poor man. Out of mutual affection the two would go to each other's homes and play together. Then the poor man saw the king's son's sword, which was of a beautiful color, and after that the king's son took the sword and went off to another country.

"Later, while the poor man was sleeping at night in a shelter for the homeless, he talked in his sleep, crying out, 'Sword! Sword!' The town watchmen heard his words and reported it to the king. The king had the man summoned and said, 'Hey, what is this sword of yours like, and where did it come from?'

"The man told the king what had happened and said, 'Your Majesty, if I have stolen it, then please have these hands and feet of mine cut off. I only saw it while I was playing together with my friend. I never so much as touched it.'

"Then the king said to him, 'What are that sword's shape and color like?'

"He replied to the king, 'Your Majesty, that sword is like a goat's horn.'

"Then the king released the man, saying, 'Man, do not be afraid, do not be afraid! Go quickly, wherever you please. Even had you once seen that sword here in this royal palace, you would still not have seen it. How then could a king's son have found it in a market in his own country? It is hard to find even for a king.'

"Then the king asked his purohita and his ministers, 'Have you seen that sword?' and then he died. Though all the great ones searched for the sword, they did not find it. Then another king's son was installed on the throne, and he found that sword. The others ruled as kings without ever finding it. Thus the kings who succeeded one another did not see that sword, and they imagined,

'That sword is like this, like such-and-such. It is like a sheep's horn. It is like a goat's horn.' Some imagined it however they pleased.

"In the same way, the bodhisattva great being too appears in the world like that king's son of the far-off land: he teaches the reality of the self and then passes away. Then those of small intelligence think, 'All sentient beings have a self like this.' Seeing wrongly, they teach it to those without wisdom, like something dreamt in a dream. Worldly people too, hearing it put that way, imagine that there is a self-element in their own bodies, yet they do not know the nature of that self. Thus, having heard the bodhisattva's words, they grasp them wrongly, and just as the sword was imagined to be like a goat's horn, so they imagine it in many ways. Worldly people falsely imagine that something called a thumb-sized person, or something the size of the fruit of the śyāmāka plant, or the size of a grain of rice, dwells in the heart and blazes. That view of theirs is a wrong view handed down from one to another. It does not lead to benefit, and it does not lead to happiness. Therefore I taught selflessness. Even so, worldly people still wrongly imagine that there is a self.

"Son of noble family, therefore now, in my teaching, like the true sword, I shall explain the buddha-nature, saying, 'The self is like this.' Whatever is well spoken and accords with the Dharma should be understood to be transcendent, even though it belongs to worldly people. Among the things of the world, the supreme dharma in every respect should be understood to be an emanation of a bodhisattva. Know that whatever treatises, vidyā-mantras, or secret mantras there may be, all of them were spoken by the perfect Buddha."

He asked, "How did the Blessed One teach the alphabet?"

The Blessed One said, "As for the whole alphabet, the half-letters were emanated first, and through the letters they become the dhāraṇī of vidyā-mantras, of secret mantras, of the suchness of phenomena, and of all the aggregates. Moreover, I emanated it so that one who learns the alphabet, the way of the true Dharma, will distinguish between Dharma and non-Dharma. It was not for the sake of non-Dharma."

He asked, "What is the meaning of what is called a letter?"

He said, "The fourteen sounds are called letters, because all the letters are certain. It means imperishable. If one asks what is meant by the indivisibility of what are called the fourteen sounds of the letters, it means non-leaking. 'Letter' means the Tathāgata. The Tathāgata is the indivisible vajra body. In

the Tathāgata there is nothing called leaking from the nine openings, nor are there even the nine openings themselves. Therefore the meaning of non-leaking is the Tathāgata. Because it is certain, it is called a letter. It means uncreated.

"ā means auspicious; it is a term for the three foundations. Again, ā is a designation for the wisdom of the noble ones. If one asks who the noble ones are: those in the world who are rich, who are without attachment, and who are content with whatever is suitable, and those who definitively liberate all sentient beings from the whole ocean of existence, are called noble ones.

"ā teaches religious custom. Since it is called engaging in accordance with rites, with the sphere of conduct, with discipline, and with the world, its meaning is not different. Again, if one asks what meaning ā unfolds: it is that, by relying on the noble ones, all sentient beings come to know that rites, the sphere of conduct, father and mother, the teacher, and discipline are precious, and come to know, 'This is the nature of reality.' Those who are noble ones are the sons or daughters of noble family who have entered the Great Vehicle. Monks endowed with moral discipline and those bodhisattva great beings are called noble ones. Again, ā teaches law. Law means saying, 'O man, come here! You have done what is improper. From now on, do not act like that!' It means calling such improprieties to mind at that time.

"i means 'this.' This teaching is the holy life, stainless and utterly pure like the full moon.

"This teaching is the Blessed One's. Do this! This is meaningful. This is meaningless. This was spoken by Māra. This was spoken by the Buddha." It means that one should come to know things in this way, thinking thus.

ī stands for Īśvara, the Lord. My teaching belongs to Īśvara, to Maheśvara (Śiva), and to Brahmā, and it is extremely rare. Īśvara is the protector of the Dharma. Because he protects the Dharma, he is a king, and therefore he is called a world guardian. This great Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra was requested by the lords for the sake of other beings. It was upheld by the lords. It was expounded by the lords. The lords make the sublime Dharma blaze supremely. It was for the sake of the lords that I taught it. And what did I teach? I taught the sūtra of the Great Parinirvāṇa. Therefore it is the Vaipulya of those who possess lordship, and those who are jealous of it are to be rooted out, as weeds are cleared from a field. Because it unfolds many meanings such as these, I taught ī.

ū stands for the Later Section. This collection of sūtras teaches the last of the later sections of the meaning of all the sūtras. I have taught the single letter, the single drop, that none of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas had ever heard before. This great collection of sūtras is supreme and sublime. Just as the beings of Uttarakuru are endowed with merit, so those who listen to this great collection of sūtras have gone beyond the world; they should be known as bodhisattvas, great beings. Therefore it is called "great," which is the meaning of "the Later Section." Therefore I taught ū in this way.

ū means something like a cow's udder. Just as a cow's milk is delicious, the taste of this sūtra is just the same. Those who reject the teaching of buddha-nature in this collection of sūtras are like cattle. Just as the ungrateful who intend to kill themselves are deeply to be pitied, so beings who reject buddha-nature and teach selflessness should be known as deeply to be pitied. Therefore it is called ū.

e means that the statement "the Tathāgata has passed into nirvāṇa" is the nature of reality of the buddhas. Therefore it is called e.

ai means the Tathāgata. Since ai means both coming and going, and since he has come just as he has gone, it is called ai.

o stands for the afflictions. Because they become medicine, one passes from being a human to becoming a Tathāgata. Therefore it is called o.

au stands for the Great Vehicle. Since au is the last of all fourteen sounds, the Great Vehicle is called the last of the later sections of all the tantras. Therefore it is called au.

aṃ means turning back everything that is improper in my teaching, and giving up gold and silver. Therefore, in the sense of turning back, it is called aṃ.

aḥ stands for the supreme vehicle. Therefore it is called aḥ. In the same way, the culmination of all the sūtras and all the tantras spoken by the Buddha is the Great Vehicle.

ka means looking upon all sentient beings with compassion, as upon Rāhula. Since one should think, "I shall work for the benefit of all sentient beings," it is called ka.

kha stands for the secret of the Tathāgata. Because those without discernment cannot know it, it is called kha.

ga stands for the essence. Because all sentient beings possess buddha-nature, it is called ga.

gha means that the Tathāgata is called permanent. Therefore the Tathāgata is permanent.

ṇa means that formations are called impermanent. Therefore it is called ṇa.

ca stands for conduct. Because all sentient beings are to be brought to full maturity, it is called ca.

cha means that the Tathāgata dwells radiantly beneath the single parasol of the white dharmas. Therefore it is called cha.

ja means that, like ja, liberation does not decay. Therefore it is called ja.

jha means swiftly shaking off the afflictions. Therefore it is called jha.

ña is a term for knowing the Dharma of suchness. Therefore it is called ña.

ṭa means that, like ṭa, the Tathāgata displays his incomparable body in certain parts of Jambudvīpa. Therefore it is called ṭa.

ṭha stands for the Dharma body. Because, like ṭha, it is fully complete, it is called ṭha.

ḍa means that the Saṅgha is called youthful. Because it will not decline, it is called ḍa.

dha stands for shamelessness. Because one is ungrateful toward one's teachers, it is called dha.

ṇa means that the outsiders are not noble compared to this. Therefore it is called ṇa.

ta means turning back from falling into any form of existence. Therefore it is called ta.

tha stands for ignorance. Because one is wrapped up in it like a silkworm, it is called tha.

da means "Take delight in striving in the Great Vehicle!" Therefore it is called da.

dha means that the three bases are as firm as Mount Meru and will not decline. Therefore it is called dha.

na means that the three bases are extremely firm, like the post that holds the bolt of a city gate. Therefore it is called na.

pa stands for perversion. Because one becomes utterly confused about the three bases not declining, it is called pa.

pha stands for the destruction of all worlds. To say, "When the world is destroyed, the three bases will be destroyed," is to destroy one's own fruit, for one falls away from practice. Therefore it is called pha.

ba is a synonym for the powers of the tathāgatas: because they possess the ten powers, it is called ba.

bha means that the bodhisattvas carry the burden of the true Dharma. Therefore it is called bha.

ma means that to carry one's own burden without fail is the way of the bodhisattvas. Therefore it is called ma.

ya: because the bodhisattvas must accomplish the four aims, it is called ya.

ra: because, having dispelled the fear of attachment, aversion and delusion, one enters the Dharma, the meaning of suchness, it is called ra.

la: because, having moved upward from the Śrāvaka Vehicle, one is to take up the Great Vehicle, which is itself unmoving, it is called la.

va: because the supreme bodhisattvas teach all the world's spells, secret mantras and medicines, it is called va.

śa means being free of the three thorns. Therefore it is called śa.

ṣa means complete: because whoever hears this great sūtra hears the whole of the Vaipulya, it is called ṣa.

sā means the mind that brings forth the true Dharma. Therefore it is called sa.

ha means joy and grief, as one thinks, "Ah, I have reached the end of saṃsāra!" and "Alas, the Tathāgata is passing into parinirvāṇa!" Therefore it is called ha.

kṣa means Māra. Even millions of māras cannot divide the Saṅgha, yet the Tathāgata displays acting in conformity with the world. Again, kṣa means displaying a mother and so on in order to conform to the whole world. Therefore it is called kṣa.

With the four letters ṛ ṝ ḷ ḹ, the four meanings are elaborated: showing the Buddha, the Dharma, the Saṅgha, and the remedy. Conforming to the world is the remedy, as for example when Devadatta divided the Saṅgha. When the

division of the Saṅgha is displayed, other forms too are emanated in order to lay down the bases of training. When the wise see that skillful means being shown, they should not be frightened, but should have confidence, thinking, "This is conforming to the world." Therefore they are called ṛ ṝ ḷ ḹ.

Those that arise from the two lips, those that come from the root of the tongue, those that come from both mouth and nose, the long ones, and those drawn out at length, are combined together with meaning. By combining the letters together, they come to function. The tongue, the teeth and so on are elements of the body, and that element is by nature completely pure. Likewise, all the various aggregates, elements and sense sources are included alike in the pacification within the suchness of the Dharma. By being combined through the splendor of that element pervaded by the tathāgatagarbha, they come to function. Therefore they are called the half-letters.

All treatises, all secret mantras and all dharmas are designations made by combining the alphabet. Therefore one sees the Tathāgata and liberation as they truly are. To abandon the very notions of uttering letters and of conceptualizing, and the notions of letters and syllables, is the Tathāgata and liberation. Therefore liberation is release in every respect and utter release.

Those who rightly understand, thinking, "That very Tathāgata appeared solely for the sake of the meaning of the dharma of the half-letters," are called knowers of letters. Others are called knowers of half-letters. If one asks who are without letters, they are those who rely on what is not the Dharma. Even if they rely on the Dharma, all those who do not distinguish the Tathāgata as permanent, the three bases, eternal liberation, sūtra and non-sūtra, Vinaya and non-Vinaya, what Māra has said and what the Buddha has spoken, all of them I call "without letters within."

"Therefore, son of noble family, you should learn the half-letters in these ways. If you do so, you will be counted among those called knowers of letters."

He said, "Blessed One, I shall be counted among them. Understanding it in this way, I shall train in the half-letters. Blessed One, only now have I found a supreme teacher such as you. Blessed One, only now have I entered the school of writing and reckoning."

The Blessed One said, "Excellent, excellent, son of noble family! One who wants the true Dharma must aspire in this way. Son of noble family, what are called zalmo are of two kinds: the zalmo of suffering, impermanence and selflessness, and the zalmo that keep company with geese. The latter refers to

birds."

He asked, "How are suffering, impermanence and selflessness called zalmo?"

The Blessed One said, "It is because some dharmas are impermanent while some are permanent, some are suffering while some are happiness, and some are selfless while some have a self. For example, sugarcane, sālu rice, grain, millet, wild millet, beans, lentils, peas and the other kinds of grain, from the time of flowering until the time of fruit, are included within impermanence. Once they are free of husk, they come to benefit all beings and are counted as grain. Therefore they are called permanent. Why is that? Because it has become their nature."

He asked, "Blessed One, how is it, then? Do those things not cease to exist later? Is the Tathāgata called permanent in the same way that they do not cease to exist later?"

The Blessed One said, "Although one may use the example that the Tathāgata is like Mount Meru, even Mount Meru, the king of mountains, will be destroyed by the eon of destruction. Do not hold the Tathāgata to be like that. Apart from nirvāṇa, there is nothing whatsoever in all the world that will not be destroyed. Therefore, in a manner that accords with the world, follow conventional designations."

He said, "Excellent, Blessed One, excellent!"

The Blessed One said, "Son of noble family, in the same way, this great sūtra of the Great Parinirvāṇa, the fruit of cultivating the meditation of all the sūtras and all the samādhis, is included within impermanence for as long as sentient beings have not heard it. Once they have heard this precious sūtra, sons or daughters of noble family, even though they still have afflictions, are included among those without afflictions, and they also come to benefit all sentient beings. Why is that? Because they know that the tathāgatagarbha, the buddha-nature, exists within themselves. And once they know it to be supremely permanent, they will enter into it.

"Furthermore, son of noble family, take for example a mango tree or a palmyra tree. From the time of its flowers until the time of its fruit, it is included among impermanent phenomena. Once its fruit has ripened, it comes to benefit all sentient beings and is included among permanent phenomena. Son of noble family, in the same way, this great sūtra of the Great Parinirvāṇa, the fruit of cultivating the meditation of all the sūtras and all the samādhis, is

included within impermanence for as long as sentient beings have not heard it. Once they have heard this precious sūtra, sons or daughters of noble family, even though they still have afflictions, are included among those without afflictions, and they also come to benefit all sentient beings. Why is that? Because they know that the tathāgatagarbha exists within themselves. And once they know it to be supremely permanent, they will enter into it.

"Furthermore, son of noble family, take for example a gold mine or a copper mine. Until the time it is dug, it is included within impermanence. Once the grit, the stones and the impurities are gone, it comes to benefit all sentient beings and is included among permanent precious substances. Son of noble family, in the same way, this great sūtra of the Great Parinirvāṇa, the fruit of cultivating the meditation of all the sūtras and all the samādhis, is included within impermanence for as long as sentient beings have not heard it. Once they have heard this precious sūtra, sons or daughters of noble family, even though they still have afflictions, are included among those without afflictions, and they also come to benefit all sentient beings. Why is that? Because they know that the tathāgatagarbha exists within themselves. And once they know it to be supremely permanent, they will enter into it.

"Furthermore, son of noble family, take for example sugarcane or sesame. Until the time they become juice and oil, they are included within impermanence. Once the sugarcane pulp and the sesame dregs are gone, they come to benefit all sentient beings and are also included among permanent substances. Son of noble family, in the same way, this great sūtra of the Great Parinirvāṇa, the fruit of cultivating the meditation of all the sūtras and all the samādhis, is included within impermanence for as long as sentient beings have not heard it. Once they have heard this precious sūtra, sons or daughters of noble family, even though they still have afflictions, are included among those without afflictions, and they also come to benefit all sentient beings. Why is that? Because they know that the tathāgatagarbha exists within themselves. And once they know it to be supremely permanent, they will enter into it.

"Furthermore, son of noble family, all rivers, for example, are gathered into the ocean. Son of noble family, in the same way, all the sūtras, all the samādhis, and the Great Vehicle are gathered into this sūtra of the Great Parinirvāṇa. Why is that? Because in it the tathāgatagarbha is clearly taught in its utterly complete and final form, and whatever is supremely ultimate is called the cause. Therefore it is said that some phenomena are impermanent

and some phenomena are permanent."

He said, "It is stated that the Buddha, too, is pierced by the thorn of grief. Yet the grief of the perfect Buddha is not like the grief of humans, nor like the grief of gods, nor like the grief of Māra. The Buddha does not grieve even in the way of one born as an animal. What, then, is it like?"

The Blessed One said, "What, then, is the perception of those beings who are without perception? If they had no perception, it would not be right for them to be alive, yet those without perception are alive. How could those who have no aggregates, elements or sense sources have perception? For example, although gods dwell in trees, it is not evident whether those gods dwell in the branches of the trees or in their roots. In the same way, the teaching too is profound, and the Tathāgata too is profound. To grieve constantly out of loving-kindness, as one would for Rāhula, is like the grieving of the gods of the sphere of neither perception nor non-perception. These things are the domain of the buddhas; such is the way of the buddhas. What the nature of reality of the buddhas is like, what their bodies are like, what the speech of the self-arisen ones is like, and what their minds are like, only the buddhas know. How could there be grief in the very nature of mind? And yet, if there were no grief, that would contradict the existence of the Vaipulya teaching. If one were to say that there is no grief, the statement 'He regards beings as he regards Rāhula' would become false. The statement 'All phenomena are false' was taught as inconceivable."

In the same way, the Buddhas, the Blessed Ones, are inconceivable. The Dharma too is inconceivable. The teaching too is inconceivable. So this is the true nature of reality of the Buddhas. Wherever there is space, there is no house to dwell in, no pillar, and no dust; it remains simply in the essential nature of space. Seeing this, those of childish nature should transform their minds so that they become just as space is.

Since this is inconceivable, how could there be sorrow in it? And if there were no sorrow, the saying that he regards beings as he regards Rāhula would become meaningless. The sorrow of the Tathāgata is like space. An illusion has no further mind behind it; in the same way, the statement that the Tathāgata has sorrow is no more than a manner of illusion. So how could there be sorrow in one who has passed into parinirvāṇa? Sorrow exists for what is impermanent, for it comes from the minds of such beings. Therefore the Tathāgata is permanent. If sorrow exists for what is impermanent, then, since

the Tathāgata is not impermanent, he cannot be understood either as having sorrow or as having none. The Tathāgata is free from sorrow.

The lowly know the lowly, but the lowly do not know the middling. The middling know the middling, but the middling do not know the superior. The superior know the lowly, the middling, and the superior. The śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas know no more than their own stage. The Buddhas understand everything. Therefore the perfectly complete Buddhas are called those who have no obscuration to their wisdom.

So it is that they display illusions of many kinds in the realms of the gods and upon the earth. Knowing that the Buddhas, the Blessed Ones, teach in this way in accordance with the world, even childish beings with fleshly eyes should abide in the knowledge of the wise, in order to attain unobstructed wisdom. So "sorrow" and "freedom from sorrow" are what the perfect Buddha has examined; they are not the domain of the childish. Therefore some dharmas have a self and some dharmas have no self, and this is taught as being like the waterfowl.

Furthermore, son of noble family, the sphere of activity of the Buddha should be shown to be like geese moving on. For example, in summer, when the waters of the rivers are greatly swollen, geese and waterfowl move away from the plains and make their nests on firm ground in order to tend their eggs, and they go to wherever their feeding grounds are. That is their nature. In the same way, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, too, having been born, establishes many tens of millions of beings in the true Dharma. Like the geese and the waterfowl, once he has accomplished the benefit of all those there are to be trained, he appears wherever there are others to be trained.

So it is said that some dharmas are suffering and some are happiness. Whatever formations there are, they are suffering and perishable. Whatever is nirvāṇa is supreme happiness; because formations have been abandoned, it is endowed with happiness.

He asked, "How is that?"

The Blessed One said, "It is just as it is."

He asked, "How is it happiness for beings who have attained nirvāṇa?"

The Blessed One said, "Son of noble family, in my teaching, aging and death arise from formations. Heedfulness is the abode of the deathless.

Heedlessness is the abode of death. Those endowed with heedfulness do not die. Those endowed with heedlessness are like those who are forever dead. Whatever is endowed with heedlessness is formation, and that is supreme suffering. Nirvāṇa is the deathless. Those endowed with heedlessness have become formations, and they are supremely suffering. Whatever is nirvāṇa is deathless, I say. Those endowed with heedfulness have not become formations; although they engage with formations, they are without aging, without death, and indestructible, I say.

"Now, who are those endowed with heedlessness, and who are those endowed with heedfulness? Worldly people are endowed with heedlessness and are like the dead. Those who have gone beyond the world are without aging and without death. Those endowed with heedfulness have attained nirvāṇa, the supreme happiness. Therefore I have taught that some dharmas are suffering and some dharmas are happiness.

"As for some dharmas having no self and some dharmas having a self: a person standing on the ground who lacks the divine eye does not see the track of a bird flying through the sky. In the same way, those who dwell in the afflictions do not themselves see that there is a supreme essence within them. Therefore I taught, with words of hidden intent, that there is no self. People who lack the divine eye do not see the self, even though there is a self within them; this is due to the afflictions, I say. Those dharmas that are formations of an afflicted kind are called impermanent. Therefore I have taught that some dharmas are impermanent. For this reason it is said:

One endowed with wisdom, standing on the mountaintop,
Clearly sees the childish, standing on the ground.
One who stands upon the palace of wisdom,
Though free of sorrow, sees that beings are in sorrow.

It is like this: having cut off the afflicted kinds of mind, the wise one dwelling on the mountaintop sees the childish, who are bound up with the afflicted kinds of mind."

He asked:

"Who are those who stand upon the roof of wisdom's house?
Who in the world is free of sorrow?
For one free of sorrow, passed beyond sorrow,
How could any sorrow come to be?

If the Buddha, the Blessed One, has passed into parinirvāṇa, how do the childish see him? And how does he dwell upon the palace of wisdom? A person standing on a mountaintop is able to see, but that is possible only if he is present. So how does one who has passed into parinirvāṇa see?"

The Blessed One said, "The palace of wisdom is nirvāṇa. The one free of sorrow is the Tathāgata. Those in whom sorrow predominates are beings. They are full of sorrow, while the Tathāgata is free of sorrow. 'Mountain' means liberation, because it is firm like Mount Meru. 'Ground' means the formations.

All childish beings are those who stand on the ground. "The wise one" refers to the perfect Buddha, because the Tathāgata is free of sorrow and steadfast. Among those who sorrow, the Buddha is the one without sorrow, and he removes the barb of sorrow from sentient beings.

It was asked: "If the Tathāgata has not passed beyond sorrow, then he still has sorrow, and he would be called one who is not perfectly awakened."

He declared: "There is a reason. Wherever there are those to be trained, there the perfect Buddha appears, and there he shows himself as if taking birth. Therefore the Tathāgata is permanent, and the Buddha is said to be like the shelduck and the zalmo bird."

The eleventh section.

"Son of noble family, consider the moon. When it appears in the daytime, in some places it seems to be setting, and sentient beings then take it that the moon has set. Yet the moon does not cease to exist. It rises over another continent, and there too the moon has not been born. Sentient beings take it that the moon has risen. Though the moon seems to set, it is not destroyed, and though it seems to rise, it is not born. It is only that it cannot be seen because Meru, king of mountains, hides it. By its nature the moon has always already arisen, for such is the nature of luminaries.

"In the same way, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, in some parts of Jambudvīpa within the great trichiliocosm world system appears to be born from the union of a father and mother, and sentient beings take it that he has been born. Yet for the Tathāgata there is no birth. In some parts of Jambudvīpa he appears to pass into parinirvāṇa, yet for the Tathāgata there is no death. Sentient beings take it that he has died. Though the Tathāgata seems to set and to be born, there is neither birth nor death for him. By the power of those to be trained, he moves about just like the moon.

"In some continents the moon appears as the fully rounded full moon, and sentient beings take it that the moon is full. In some continents the moon appears as a new crescent shaped like the letter ta, and the people of Jambudvīpa take it that today is the first day of the moon. Then they take it to be a half moon. Then, thinking that it is the fifteenth day, they take it to be the full moon. Some take it to be a half moon. The moon becomes half, yet it neither rises nor sets; the moon appears in these ways because of the condition of Mount Meru.

"Son of noble family, in the same way, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, in some parts of Jambudvīpa appears to pass into parinirvāṇa, and sentient beings take it that the Tathāgata has passed into parinirvāṇa. In some parts of Jambudvīpa, like the new moon, he appears to be born, and sentient beings take it that this child has been born. Like the moon on its second day, they take it that he goes before the gods. Like the moon on its third day, they take it that he goes to the school where writing is learned. Like the moon on its eighth day, he shows the going forth. Like the full moon, just as its light dispels darkness, he destroys millions of māras and abides in radiant brilliance. Like the waning moon, he shows the parinirvāṇa. Just as the moon is encircled by the planets, he is adorned with the thirty-two major marks and the eighty excellent minor marks. There, some take it that he has set and some take it that he is born, yet there is neither birth nor cessation, for the Tathāgata, like the full moon, is permanent at all times. Therefore the Tathāgata is called permanent and steadfast.

"Consider again the moon. It appears everywhere: in water, in wildernesses, in houses and cities, in basins filled with water, in wells, and elsewhere, even as far as a thousand yojanas, in every place where sentient beings go, it appears in all of them. There the childish think in their minds, 'This moon follows behind me alone.' When they see it inside the house, they wonder, 'Now that it appears here, is this the same moon, or is it some other one?' Among them, some children take the moon to be the size of a basin. Those of middling understanding take it to be about the size of a cartwheel. The best know that the moon is round and about fifty yojanas across. Animals see the moon as the size of a firefly; animals of every kind of birth examine the moon with their own consciousness and so see it each in their own way.

"In the same way, when the Tathāgata appears in the world, he appears everywhere. Some sentient beings take the Tathāgata to be like the moon, thinking, 'Out of love for me he dwells in the innermost part of my house.'

Animals see him as having a body like that of their own kind of birth. Mute sentient beings see the Tathāgata as mute. The deaf and the maimed also see him as like themselves. Those of different languages, perceptions, and scripts also take him to be like themselves, thinking, 'He speaks my language, he agrees with my perceptions, he eats my food.' Those with large bodies also take it that the Tathāgata is like them. Some take him to be a śrāvaka or a pratyekabuddha. Some see him as having gone forth among all the various sects of wonder-workers. Some take it that the Tathāgata has appeared in the world for their sake.

"Just as the moon, abiding in its own nature, pleases all according to their individual natures, so too the Tathāgata, while being the Dharma body, assumes a body of skillful means like a medicinal tree against poison and delights sentient beings. Through acts in accord with the whole world, he shows many thousands of birth stories. Therefore, because he shows birth everywhere, the Tathāgata is called the moon of the birth stories. Therefore the Tathāgata is permanent and steadfast."

Son of noble family, here is another example. When the moon and Rāhu, lord of the asuras, meet, worldly people think, "The moon has been seized by the planet." Yet Rāhu does not seize the moon, nor is he able to eat it. All that happens is that Rāhu's hand covers the moon so that its light does not appear. The moon suffers no wound, and no affliction either. To the extent that Rāhu's hand covers the moon, to that extent the moon's light does not appear. When Rāhu releases the moon, it looks as if it had come out of his mouth, and people think, "The moon is suffering." While the moon remains just as it is by nature, it shows itself as being together with Rāhu. This is the way of the world. Even millions of Rāhus could not kill or destroy the moon; it is the moon itself that displays things in this way.

In the same way, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha himself, makes a display like the moon. For the sake of the future, in order to teach the deed of immediate retribution that is drawing blood with malicious intent, he also displays such things as the extreme of the icchantikas and the various kinds of schism in the Saṅgha. Not even a hundred thousand koṭis of māras could draw blood from the body of the Tathāgata. In the body of the Tathāgata there is no blood, no bone, and no sinew, and not even a trace of suffering. Sentient beings think, "The three foundations are ruined! The Tathāgata has been wounded." Although the Tathāgata abides just as he is by nature, he makes such a display in accord with the world.

It is like this. Among people, one person strikes another with a whip or a stick and draws blood, or with the intention to kill he kills him. After that, the Tathāgata, intending to make that deed weighty, lets blood be drawn from the Tathāgata with malicious intent; then, understanding that person's mind, he truly teaches the deed of immediate retribution. In this way the Tathāgata, for the sake of the future, teaches the distinctions of karma.

For example, a certain physician teaches his son the various names of roots: "These are the five roots; this is the bitter one." He introduces them by way of the distinctions among the roots. The boy, having been trained in this way, comes to know the distinctions among the roots. Then, when the physician has died, the boy says, "Alas, father! Alas, father! You taught me the distinctions among the roots: this root is like this, the leaves are like this." In the same way, the Tathāgata too emanates manifestations of all the bases of training. He teaches what is curable and what is incurable, the deeds of immediate retribution, the rejection of the sūtras, and the extremes of the icchantikas, meaning, "In the future it will be like this." Then, after the Tathāgata has passed into parinirvāṇa, the monks, like the physician's son, will know, "The Tathāgata declared this in the sūtras: this deed is such and such."

For example, when an eclipse comes over the moon, people know that the moon is eclipsed once in six months. The gods above know the moon's eclipse as happening as if every day. Why is that? Because their year periods are long and the year periods of humans are short. Son of noble family, in the same way gods and humans think, "The life span of the Tathāgata is short." Just as the higher and higher gods perceive the moon being eclipsed moment after moment, in the same way, to the higher and higher gods, he displays, moment after moment, even millions of passings of the Tathāgata into parinirvāṇa. One should know that he displays even millions of the māras of the afflictions, of the aggregates, of the gods, and of the Lord of Death; that he displays even thousands of births; and that he displays many acts in accord with the world. Thus the Tathāgata is immeasurable, and therefore he is permanent and stable.

For example, the moon is pleasing to the minds of all sentient beings and beautiful to behold, and for that reason it is called "the moon." It is not pleasing to the minds of those who have come under the sway of desire and who indulge in attachment, aversion, and delusion. In the same way, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, is by nature pleasing to

the minds of sentient beings who long for the Dharma, and supremely beautiful to behold. To others, who have hostile minds, he is not pleasing. Therefore the Tathāgata is like the moon.

For example, the sun changes and shifts through three seasons, traveling through the three times of winter, summer, and spring. In winter the sun moves very quickly. In summer the sun moves at a middling pace. In spring the sun lingers long as it moves, and its light is very hot. The Tathāgata likewise displays three kinds of birth in the three worlds. Among short-lived sentient beings he displays a supremely short life span, and sentient beings think, "The Buddha's life span is short." To those of the Śrāvaka Vehicle he displays a short life span, like the winter sun. To bodhisattva great beings he displays a middling life span, like the summer sun. To buddhas he appears to remain for an eon or more than an eon, like the spring sun.

Son of noble family, from this Great Vehicle I shall truly teach words of hidden intent, the rain of the Tathāgata's secret, sacred Dharma. In the future, whoever teaches the beneficial instructions of the sūtra collection of the sacred Dharma, the Great Vehicle, are like clouds in the summer sky; they should be known to be bodhisattva great beings. Śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, when they hear the words of hidden intent, are like those struck by a winter chill. For that reason I taught a short life span and that which will certainly be experienced. From the vast abode of the buddhas, where the life of the Buddha is taught, I taught permanence and stability, like the spring sun.

Like the sun, I never fall anywhere, and I also follow the nature of the sun and moon. In this way the Tathāgata appears perfectly in the three worlds. This is the nature of reality of the buddhas.

Furthermore, son of noble family, when Venus, Jupiter, Mars, the comet, the other planets and the rest move together with the sun and the moon, sentient beings cannot see them. Yet these do not turn back, nor do they fall, because their light is very faint and is outshone by the far greater light of the sun and moon. In the same way, the Tathāgata always appears as if born together with the host of planets that are the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, and also shows himself passing into parinirvāṇa. Yet those śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas are neither impermanent nor unstable. Although they are permanent and stable, sentient beings cannot see them, just as with the planets by day. Being like the sun in this way is the nature of reality of the

pratyekabuddhas.

For example, when the sun and moon are covered by clouds they are not seen, and sentient beings take it that they do not appear; yet the two of them do not thereby cease to exist. Son of noble family, in the same way, when the Tathāgata does not remain in the world, it seems, like the sun and moon covered by clouds, as though the three bases are being destroyed. Yet the three bases do not cease to exist. Though they remain permanent, stable and everlasting, they are not stained by faults. This is the nature of reality of the buddhas.

Son of noble family, for example, on the day of the new moon, when the moon is neither waxing nor waning, at a time when neither sun nor moon is present, a comet called Endowed with Fierce Splendor rises, and in a single instant vanishes without the whole world noticing. Son of noble family, in the same way, when the buddhas do not remain, the pratyekabuddhas too arise like the comet rising on the day of the new moon, establish many tens of millions of sentient beings in the sacred Dharma, and then vanish. The comet, too, is always present, but sentient beings cannot see it. Likewise, although the pratyekabuddhas are always present, sentient beings cannot see them. To reveal themselves perfectly and to make themselves unseen: this is their nature of reality.

Son of noble family, just as, for example, when the sun rises the fog disappears, in the same way, when this great Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra appears, even by merely hearing it the heaps of evil from the defeats and from the deeds of immediate retribution swiftly disappear. Thus this great Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra, this inconceivable domain, is immeasurable, because it teaches the buddha-nature. Therefore sons of noble family and daughters of noble family should strive in this way in understanding the sūtra, thinking, "The Tathāgata is permanent. The sacred Dharma will not decline. The Saṅgha will not cease to exist." If they do so, they too, like me, will live in the state of a buddha.

He asked, "Blessed One, what are bodhisattva great beings like?"

The Blessed One said, "Whether they have generated the mind or have not generated the mind, they become bodhisattva great beings."

He asked, "How is that?"

The Blessed One said, "Son of noble family, just as, for example, ice frozen in winter cannot be melted even by the heat of the sun, in the same way, as regards the fruit of cultivating what is to be cultivated in all the sūtras and all the samādhis, even those who have generated the mind do not attain awakening, and those who have not generated the mind do not attain awakening either. Why is that? Because, like the winter sun, their diligence is weak.

The supreme fruit of cultivating what is to be cultivated in the sūtras is like this: when the summer sun is hot, even before the sun has risen, it melts even ice that froze hard during the night, and it warms even the great ocean. In the same way, whatever sons of noble family or daughters of noble family, as soon as they hear this sūtra of the Great Parinirvāṇa, whether they take it up out of rivalry, or are made to do so by others, or are urged on by others, or do so for the sake of gain, honor, or verses, even if they think, 'I have no need of awakening,' or have no wish to generate the mind, the cause of awakening will nonetheless enter every pore of the body of such a person, like the summer sun. Therefore I say that those sons of noble family are bodhisattva great beings.

Thus this great sūtra of inexhaustible awakening is a great heap of merit, and therefore it is called great. It is first, vast and splendid like the summer sun, and therefore it is called the Great Parinirvāṇa. Why is that? Because it teaches that the buddha-nature is permanent.

Furthermore, son of noble family, the light of the stars and of fireflies does not surpass the light of the sun and moon and shine out brilliantly. The light of the sun and moon surpasses all lights and shines radiantly. In the same way, the other lights do not surpass the light of the great Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra, the cultivation of what is to be cultivated in all the sūtras and all the samādhis, and do not shine out brilliantly. The light of the great Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra surpasses all lights and shines out brilliantly. Entering the pores of all sentient beings, even if they think, 'I have no need of the awakening mind,' and have not generated it, they will certainly obtain the cause of awakening. Therefore it is also named the Great Parinirvāṇa."

He said, "Please explain the reason for this statement, that even if they hold that they have no need of the awakening mind, it enters every pore of the bodies of all sentient beings and the cause of awakening is actualized."

"Blessed One, in this teaching there are those who commit defeats, those who commit the acts of immediate retribution, those who reject the sūtras, and also icchantikas. If, even without generating the mind of awakening and while holding it to be unnecessary, they still come to have a cause of the awakening of the awakened, then what distinction is there in what the Buddha has taught? Otherwise it should be explained that those four do not exist. Or else it should be explained that by this their evil is purified."

The Blessed One said, "Apart from the icchantikas, everyone, merely by hearing this great sūtra of the Great Parinirvāṇa resound in their ears, comes to have a cause of awakening. Those who have honored countless buddhas are able to hear the great Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra, and because their roots of virtue are not meager, they obtain a cause of awakening. Therefore, because it rightly teaches buddha-nature, this great sūtra is of great power."

He asked, "How does one who has not generated the mind of awakening, and who holds it to be unnecessary, come to have a cause of the awakening of the awakened?"

The Blessed One said, "Those who hold generating the mind of awakening to be unnecessary and who disparage the sūtras are threatened in their dreams by a great rākṣasa of terrifying form, who says to them, 'Quickly generate the mind of awakening, before I kill you!' Then, frightened and terrified in their dream, they wake, and in the morning they generate the mind of awakening. After they die, whether they are cooked in the hells, or are born from the world of hungry ghosts into the heavens, they remember it, and after that they become bodhisattva great beings. Thus this great sūtra of the Great Parinirvāṇa is of great power: even in those who hold awakening to be unnecessary and have not generated the mind, it produces a cause of awakening. That is the cause; that is the condition. In this Great Vehicle nothing is without a cause. Therefore my teaching is called 'spoken by the Buddha.'

"Furthermore, son of noble family, when a great cloud sends down rain from the sky, the great earth becomes filled with water. Yet on high ground, even when heavy rain has fallen, not even a little water remains; it flows down to wherever the land slopes, and having flowed there it stays, and it benefits all beings. In the same way, the rain of the true Dharma falls from this great sūtra, yet in the icchantikas no cause of awakening arises; it cannot possibly arise. In others it produces one, like water on sloping ground.

"Furthermore, son of noble family, suppose a great cloud were to rain a thousand times on scorched seeds of lentils, chickpeas, peas, or grass. Still they could not grow sprouts; it is impossible for sprouts to come from them. In the same way, even if icchantikas hear this Great Parinirvāṇa, they cannot possibly obtain a cause of awakening, because their roots of virtue are exhausted, and so they are like scorched seeds.

"Son of noble family, when a kataka fruit is put into muddy water, it removes the mud and makes the water clear. In the same way, this great sūtra of the Great Parinirvāṇa, like the kataka fruit, removes the mire and turbidity of the karma of beings' defeats and acts of immediate retribution and sets them on the cause of awakening, the icchantikas excepted. Yet the kataka fruit only makes turbid water clear; even if it were worked for a thousand years, it could not draw water out of the mire itself. In the same way, since the roots of virtue of icchantikas are exhausted and they have become baseless, even if they hear this Great Parinirvāṇa for ten million years, they are utterly unable to produce a cause of awakening, because they have no virtue.

"Son of noble family, consider the antidote tree, the great king of medicines. Whether it is mixed with buttermilk, molasses, ghee, milk, or water, or made into powder, paste, or soup, or smeared on the mouth, or burned as a fumigant, or applied to the eyes, or smelled, seen, or touched, it removes the diseases of all beings. That tree does not think, 'It is fine if my leaves are taken, but not if my roots are taken,' or 'It is fine if my roots are taken, but not if my leaves are taken,' or 'It is fine if my trunk is taken, but not my bark,' or 'It is fine if my bark is taken, but not my trunk.' Although it forms no such thoughts, it is simply medicine, and it removes all diseases.

"Son of noble family, in the same way this great sūtra of the Great Parinirvāṇa removes the diseases of evil karma of all beings, whether they are those who commit defeats, those who commit acts of immediate retribution, or those outside this teaching. Even in those who do not hold awakening to be necessary and have not generated the mind, it produces a cause of awakening. Why is this? Because the medicine of the antidote tree for all evils is the great sūtra of the Great Parinirvāṇa. Whether their bodies have been anointed or not, if they merely hear the name of this sūtra and know that this sūtra exists, all the diseases of evil will be cleansed.

"But the incurable disease called anargala cannot be cured, whatever is done. Why is this? Because it is a disease that ends in death; it is not a disease of

untimely death. In the same way, the icchantikas cannot be placed in awakening by this sūtra, because they are without a cause and are dead.

"Just as poison does not take hold in the palm of a hand that has no wound, but does take hold in one that has a wound, so here too a cause of awakening does not arise in the icchantikas. Here, 'wound' means the cause of awakening; 'poison' means supreme bliss; and the palm with no wound is the evil icchantika.

"A vajra jewel of great splendor, for example, cannot be broken by anything, and it smashes every other kind of thing, yet it does not cut a sheep's horn."

In the same way, even this great Sūtra of Nirvāṇa cannot establish in awakening the icchantikas who commit extremely evil deeds, because they have no cause for it, just as a vajra cannot pierce a ram's horn.

For example, the sallakī tree, the doṅka tree, the kanakaprabha, the silk-cotton tree, the valmīki, the karṇavalya, the skandastava, the ketakī, the pattraka, the vīraṇa and the rocana may be felled, chopped into pieces, carried off and laid in a house. Yet as soon as they meet the moisture of water they quickly sprout. Their leaves unfold, they bear clusters of buds, they put out branches and stems, and they come to be counted among what are called trees. In the same way, in this teaching too, those who commit defeats and those who commit the deeds of immediate retribution have become like a tāla palm with its crown cut off. Yet as soon as they hear this sūtra, even though they do not hold that they must generate the resolve, those supreme persons will be born into awakening, like the sallakī tree, the doṅka tree and the rest.

For example, khadira and tinduka trees, once they are cut, do not grow again, like burnt seeds. In the same way, icchantika beings, even though they hear this sūtra many times, are not born into awakening, like burnt seeds.

For example, though rain has fallen from a great cloud, water does not collect on ground that is slick. In the same way, though the rain of Dharma falls from this cloud of the great sūtra, the cause of awakening does not take hold in the icchantika, because he is slick like a vajra.

The icchantikas do not see the good that has been done; they see only the evil of reviling and disparaging.

"Well done" means awakening. "Does not come" means does not meet. "Intention" means virtue. If one asks to whom the virtue that far surpasses intention does not come: good karma does not come to the icchantika. If one

asks to whom a virtuous mind does not come: the one known as an icchantika is a being without virtue, under the sway of pride; it does not come to that icchantika. If one asks what the root factor is: it is the rejection of the sūtras. Therefore the rejection of the sūtras is a thing to be dreaded; be afraid of it!

For that reason the wise and steadfast
Are afraid, since on the great road there are conditioned things.
The childish have no fear of the great road;
Through the power of pride they go to an unbearable destiny.
Therefore those of poor understanding do not attain it,
Like monkeys grasping at the moon.
Like a lord of men setting out upon the great road,
The wise and steadfast will attain it.

If one asks by whom what has been done is not seen: it is not seen by the evil icchantika. Until the very end of saṃsāra he does not see what has been done. I have taught its meaning in brief; since it is supremely to be dreaded, be afraid of it!

If it were possible that at some time all sentient beings, of one accord and one-pointed mind, should fully and perfectly awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, then it might also be possible for the evil icchantika to fully and perfectly awaken to supreme awakening. That is what is meant by not seeing what has been done. Hero, you should understand it in this way.

If one asks whose deeds are not wasted: the deeds of the Tathāgata are not wasted. If all sentient beings dwelling in saṃsāra were to fully and perfectly awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, then the deeds of the Tathāgata would be wasted. For then, having passed forever into final nirvāṇa, the Buddha would become impermanent, like a lamp, or like a fire whose wood is used up.

In the same way, the evil deeds of the icchantika are reviling and disparaging. If a bodhisattva abandons the merit that is the cause of awakening, that too is called reviling and disparaging the Great Vehicle. If he does not abandon it, he will then bear the name "perfect Buddha," for that is the nature of reality of the buddhas.

Milk and evil deeds
Do not turn at once;
They are like fire covered with ash,
Which burns a child who steps on it.

The icchantika, a lone blind man who imagines he is an arhat, wishes to travel the great inexhaustible path. Imagining that he is an arhat endowed with loving-kindness, he wishes to refute the Vaipulya.

One who is held to be an arhat, having refuted the Śrāvaka Vehicle, says: "I am a bodhisattva, a teacher of the Vaipulya. All sentient beings possess the qualities of buddha-nature. There is the Buddha." And he prophesies their buddhahood, saying: "You and I must shatter the forms of affliction like a water pot. Without doubt, one must cultivate awakening. Such is the instruction of the sūtras."

For example, a king's messenger, pure, loyal, skilled in speech and of great majesty, stakes his own life among enemies and delivers the king's words in full. In the same way, the wise one who cherishes the Vaipulya stakes his own life among the childish and prophesies buddhahood, because all sentient beings have buddha-nature.

The forest dweller who rejects the sūtras, the childish fool who imagines he is an arhat, is looked upon as though he were an arhat and as though he were a great being. That evil icchantika monk lives in the forest and reckons himself to be like an arhat. He says: "Monks who live in the forest do not accept invitations from others for the four requisites. The Vaipulya was spoken by Māra. The Blessed One is impermanent. The Dharma and the Saṅgha too will cease to be. Such omens of the disappearance of the true Dharma are appearing." And he says, "This is well explained in the Great Vehicle." One who speaks in this way what is not the true Dharma does not turn at once, like milk; but like one who steps onto fire covered with ash, these childish icchantikas will later be burned.

Thus the Buddha's teaching, the Great Vehicle, is subtle, and this sūtra is like the kataka fruit.

Son of good family, a closed lotus flower opens when the light of the sun touches it. In the same way, as soon as they hear this great Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra, even all the sentient beings who hold that they need not generate so much as the mere name of the awakening mind will, whether they wish it or not, have the cause of awakening enter every one of their pores. The icchantikas too have the tathāgatagarbha, yet in them it remains thickly covered, as though veiled. A silkworm winds itself all around, and once it has sealed itself in, it cannot come back out. In the same way, because of the fault of their karma, the tathāgatagarbha cannot be brought forth from within the

icchantikas. Therefore, to the very end of saṃsāra, they do not obtain the cause of awakening.

Son of good family, lotuses, utpalas, kumudas and white lotuses grow up out of the mud, yet the mud does not stain them. In the same way, in this great sūtra those of the Great Vehicle, even though they still have afflictions, are counted among those without afflictions. Why are they not stained? They are not stained because of the blessing of the tathāgatagarbha.

When a cool breeze rises, it enters every pore of all sentient beings, whether they wish it or not, and soothes all their heat. In the same way, this great sūtra also enters every pore of all sentient beings and, whether they wish it or not, establishes them in the cause of awakening. The only exception is the icchantikas, who do not hold that generating the awakening mind is needed.

Son of good family, a physician skilled in the eight branches of the science of life heals all the sick, yet he cannot heal those who are incurable. In the same way, all the sūtras and samādhis heal all who are stricken with the disease of attachment, aversion and delusion, and remove every thorn of the afflictions, yet they cannot heal those who commit defeats or those who commit the deeds of immediate retribution.

A physician who knows the Later Section of the eight branches of the science of life heals the diseases of all sentient beings, yet even he cannot heal a disease when the time of death has come. In the same way, this great Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra also removes every disease of affliction in all sentient beings and sets sentient beings in the cause of awakening. The only exception is the icchantikas, who are like those whose time of death has come.

Those blind from birth do not know even the light of the sun and moon, so how could they see clearly? A great physician treats the eyes of those whose sight is dim, and they come to see, but the one blind from birth is the exception. In the same way, this great Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra treats the eyes of all the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, who are like the blind, and swiftly lets them see with the eye of the Great Vehicle. It sets in awakening even those who commit defeats and those who commit the deeds of immediate retribution while holding that they need not generate the awakening mind. The only exception is the icchantikas, who remain utterly blind from birth.

Son of good family, a great physician who knows the Later Section of the eight branches of the science of life removes the diseases of all sentient beings by the treatments of pouring medicine into the nose, giving it to drink internally,

rubbing it on the body, and fumigating with smoke. There are those who have no protector, and those who think, "We need no medicine," and so do not resolve to seek it. He lays them in houses or among the grasses, and by the power of mantras, medicines and antidotes he removes their poisons and diseases. When pregnant women wish to give birth but cannot deliver, by the power of antidotes he lets them give birth easily, and he keeps the child free of disease as well. In the same way, when this great Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra is made into a book and kept in the homes of any sentient beings, they too are made happy by the power of the Great Vehicle, and through this great sūtra they even become bodhisattva mahāsattvas. It sets in awakening even those who commit defeats and those who commit the deeds of immediate retribution while holding that they need not generate the awakening mind. The only exception is the icchantikas, who are like the dead.

He asked, "Those who commit defeats and the terrible deeds of immediate retribution are like a palm tree whose crown has been cut off. If they hold, 'We need not generate the mind set on awakening,' then how, without generating that mind, will the cause of awakening arise in them?"

The Blessed One said, "Son of good family, whether in a dream or after death, when they are being boiled in the hells, they think, 'We have done what is not good. If there were some way to be freed from here, then, having seen this terrible fear, wherever we are born, there we would generate the mind set on awakening.' Such a thought of bringing forth the sublime Dharma bears great fruit.

"Consider a child who, once his strength has grown, comes to understand himself and says, 'When I was in my mother's womb, this physician, by the power of mantra and antidote, kept my mother well, so this life of mine is due to your kindness. Alas, my mother carried me in her womb for twelve months and was sorely afflicted, and then she gave birth to me with great hardship. She washed me when I was smeared with the slime and blood of the womb, she gave me milk when my lips and mouth were wet and dribbling, and she nursed me by every means she had. She did what is supremely difficult. Now, since I was born through your kindness, I must make offerings to you as to a guru, and I shall act accordingly.' In the same way, those who commit defeats and those who commit the deeds of immediate retribution, at the time of death, through the fruit of not having forgotten mindfulness, will be born in the world of the gods. Then, those who commit defeats and those who commit the deeds of immediate retribution, again through the fruit of not having forgotten

mindfulness, become a cause of awakening in the hells or in the human world. The only exception is the icchantikas."

For example, a physician, or a physician's son who knows the Later Section, uses antidotes and the power of vidyā-mantras to subdue venomous snakes, harmless ones, the nāga called Bird-Choker, and others. He brings them under his control as though they were on his own path, and he makes them free of poison, except for nāgas that are exceedingly fierce. In the same way, this great sūtra, which is like an antidote, also subdues those who commit defeats, and the sinful, supremely fierce nāgas who commit the acts of immediate retribution and hold that there is no need to generate the mind of awakening. It establishes them in the great state of awakening. Therefore, because it brings about the happiness of all sentient beings, the Great Parinirvāṇa is called "the Great Antidote, whose nature is good qualities." The exception is the fierce and terrible nāgas who are icchantikas.

For example, a physician prepares a poison medicine that draws out darts, a king among medicines, and smears it on a great drum. If that drum is beaten within the palace grounds, then by the power of its sound the darts of everyone who hears it will all be drawn out. But for those there who are close to the time of death, they will not come out. Why is that? Because their karma has a terrible ripening. In the same way, wherever the sound of the great Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra is heard, it draws out the darts of attachment, aversion and delusion from all the sentient beings who dwell within the palace grounds of formations, and it also makes them free of formations. Those who dwell within the palace grounds may think, "The darts will not come out," but how could they ever think, "The darts will come out"? Likewise, the others also have no thought that the darts of attachment, aversion and delusion will come out; their minds dwell on desires. In the same way, it produces the cause of awakening even for those who commit defeats and those who commit the acts of immediate retribution and hold that there is no need to generate the mind of awakening. The exception is the icchantikas, who are like those who have come to the time of death.

Son of noble family, for example, in the darkness of night the sentient beings of Jambudvīpa do not set about work such as plowing. They stay where they are and wait for the sun to rise. Then, once the sun has risen, they set about plowing and the rest. In the same way, those of the Great Vehicle, having heard and meditated on all the sūtras and samādhis, wait for the sun of the great Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra to rise, just as beings who want to plow wait

through the night. Then, having heard the words of intended meaning in this great sūtra, they begin their work in the field of the sublime Dharma. And just as, once the fields have been plowed, a great rain falls, the crops grow and the year turns out well, so too, once the field of the sublime Dharma has been plowed, the rain of Dharma heard from the great cloud of the great sūtra of the tathāgatagarbha falls. Then the crop of the great prophecy grows, bringing liberation from the eight kinds of epidemic, happiness, good years and delight. Just as grain comes to full ripeness in the first month of spring, so it will be like the full ripening of the crop of the great prophecy given to the eighty great śrāvakas in the great Sūtra of the White Lotus of the Sublime Dharma. The exception is the icchantikas.

The twelfth fascicle.

Son of noble family, for example, a great physician sends pills of medicine or antidotes many leagues away for those seized by bhūtas or bitten by snakes, saying: "Take this medicine quickly, and once you have taken it, give them the treatment. If you do this, the grahas of gods, nāgas, yakṣas and rākṣasas there will disappear. If you do not take it, I must go myself, for it would not do for it to be wasted in the meantime." Then, as soon as the patient sees the physician or the physician's messenger from far off, all harm is pacified by the splendor and power of that mantra, and he too becomes well. In the same way, suppose a monk, a nun, or anyone else outside this teaching knows, or hears from another, that a written copy of this powerful great Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra is kept in a certain place. That becomes for them a cause of awakening. And however many who commit defeats or acts of immediate retribution, and are seized by the grahas of bhūtas and piśācas, may hear of it, all of them, like those who see the great physician, will be freed from harm and will become bodhisattva great beings. Why is that? It comes about through the power of the great sūtra on the permanence of the Tathāgata. That being so, how could those who read this great sūtra written in a volume, or hear it, or write it out, fail to become bodhisattva great beings? The exception is the icchantikas. Just as the deaf do not hear sound, so the icchantikas cannot hear this sūtra, because they lack the cause for it.

Furthermore, son of noble family, for example, a physician who knows the Later Section of the eightfold Āyurveda sees a great king and predicts: "Great king, you will be struck by an illness grave enough to bring you to death." The king said to him, "How do you know that a serious illness will arise, without having seen it?" Then the physician said to the king, "If you do not believe me,

take some medicine and it will become clear." Even so, the king would not agree to drink the medicine. Then the great physician, by the power of his knowledge, made hemorrhoids break out at the king's anus.

Then the king saw those hemorrhoids and was frightened and dismayed. He shuddered and thought, "The physician's words were true." Knowing that the hemorrhoids had appeared, he thought, "Oh, how wondrous is the physician's power of knowledge!" and he honored that physician as one reveres one's father and mother. In the same way, this great sūtra of the Great Parinirvāṇa easily places in the cause of awakening even all those sentient beings who hold that there is no need to generate the mind of awakening, just as the great physician did for the king. Whether in their dreams or at the time of their death, the cause of awakening will enter those beings without their knowing it. The icchantikas are the exception. Even the great physician, thinking, "This cannot be cured," does not treat a fatal disease accompanied by terrible karma. The icchantika is like one who is bound to die.

Son of noble family, consider this example. A physician who knows the Later Section of the eight branches of the science of life first teaches his son the branches of that tantra, the medicines that grow on the plains, in the water, and on the mountains. While the son is only learning the first branches, he does not teach him the Later Section. When he has finished learning the eight branches of the science of life, then he teaches him, from the Later Section, the methods for accomplishing mantras and medicines. In the same way, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, also first teaches his sons, the monks, the first branches: purifying the forms of the afflictions, meditating on the body as without essence, and the three kinds of meditation that are like the medicines of the plains, the water, and the mountains. Here, "the plains" means the many kinds of bodily suffering. "The water" means that this body is impermanent, like a bubble on water. "The mountains" means the selflessness of the forms of the afflictions. Therefore the Tathāgata teaches, "This body is without self." If the monks have not seen the meaning of the nine-branched scriptures, he does not teach them this supreme Great Vehicle. But now, like the great physician, to those monks who have completed the work of understanding the meaning of the nine-branched scriptures of the Tathāgata, he teaches, from the Later Section of buddha-nature, that buddha-nature is permanent. Thus, when they hear the great Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra taught by the Tathāgata, it becomes the cause of awakening even for those beings who hold that there is no need to generate the mind of

awakening, except for the icchantikas.

Son of noble family, in this way the great Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra is inconceivable. Just as the great physician is supreme among physicians, so this sūtra is the supreme king of sūtras.

Furthermore, son of noble family, in order to ferry beings across, a boat comes from the far shore to the near shore and goes from the near shore to the far shore. In the same way, the Tathāgata, the Great Parinirvāṇa, having passed into parinirvāṇa, goes forth to ferry beings across, like a boat going to the far shore. Wherever there are those to be tamed, there he displays himself as a perfect buddha. Therefore, just as a boat goes wherever it wishes to ferry beings across, so too is the Tathāgata. For this reason he is called the Great Boatman. Hence the Tathāgata is permanent and stable. When there is a boat, the boatman ferries people across; the Tathāgata exists permanently, and he will go on ferrying beings across and taking birth.

Furthermore, son of noble family, consider this example. When a great ship sailing on the great ocean meets with wind, it travels straight ahead and covers many leagues in a single instant. If it does not meet with wind, it stays in one place for many years, or else it capsizes. In the same way, when beings who have fallen into the great ocean of ignorance meet with the king of winds, the great Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra, they swiftly reach the far shore of awakening, like the ship. Those who do not meet with this king of winds, the sūtra, are lost in the wheel of saṃsāra, like a ship capsizing in the great ocean.

Furthermore, son of noble family, consider this example. When there is no wind in a perilous place on the great ocean, beings in dire straits think, "This is surely death." Then, without their knowing it, the king of winds carries them off in an instant, and they think, "Oh, how wonderful it is that we have been saved!" In the same way, this king of winds, this great sūtra, places in the cause of awakening, without their knowing it, those beings dwelling in the great ocean of ignorance who hold that there is no need to generate the mind of awakening.

Furthermore, son of noble family, consider this example. When a snake sheds its old skin, has it died, or has it ceased to exist?

He replied, "No, Blessed One, it has not."

The Blessed One said, "Son of noble family, in the same way, the Tathāgata too, like one shedding an old skin, casts off his body of skillful means, the old

trunk of a poisonous plant. Does the Tathāgata thereby become impermanent?"

He replied, "No, Blessed One. Just as a snake changes its skin, in some Jambudvīpa he casts off one body of skillful means and displays another body of skillful means."

The Blessed One said, "Son of noble family, therefore the Tathāgata is permanent.

"Furthermore, son of noble family, consider this example. A goldsmith smelts gold from a gold mine, and once it is free of impurities, whatever form of fine ornament one wishes and commissions the goldsmith to make, he makes it just so. In the same way, the Tathāgata, by skillful means, emanates forms of whatever kind those to be tamed in the twenty-five states of existence wish for, and so liberates beings. Therefore the body of the Tathāgata is limitless and permanent.

"Furthermore, son of noble family, consider this example. A mango tree, or a jambu tree, changes under the influence of the three seasons. Sometimes its buds burst open and its leaves sprout.

At times their leaves flourish and their shade is cool. At times they shed their leaves and look like dead wood. When that happens, are those trees to be called dead?"

He replied, "No, Blessed One, they are not."

The Blessed One said, "Noble son, in the same way the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, for the sake of those who are to be trained, displays three kinds of bodies of skillful means in the three worlds. He appears as though he were born, as though he were living and remaining, and as though he passed into parinirvāṇa. When he displays these, is the Tathāgata therefore impermanent?"

He replied, "No, Blessed One, he is not."

The Blessed One said, "Noble son, therefore the Tathāgata is permanent. Noble son, in this way both the body of the Tathāgata and the words of the Tathāgata's hidden intent are hard to understand.

"For example, suppose a certain king commands his minister, 'Bring the saindhava!' The word saindhava is used for salt, for a drinking vessel, for a sword, and for a horse. All four of these are called saindhava. Since one word

has many meanings, when the king says 'saindhava' while he is taking his meal, the minister understands that saindhava means salt, and offers him salt. When the king says 'saindhava' after he has finished his meal, the minister understands that it means a drinking vessel, and offers him a drinking vessel. When the king says 'saindhava' as he is going to the pleasure garden, the minister understands that it means a horse, and offers him a horse. When the king says 'saindhava' at the time of battle, the minister understands that it means a sword, and offers him a sword. In this way the ministers grasp the four kinds of the king's words of hidden intent.

"Noble son, in the same way, this Great Vehicle also contains what are called the four kinds of impermanence. Followers of the Great Vehicle are like the minister, and they should understand these in the same way. When the Tathāgata has appeared in the world and teaches that the Buddha passes into parinirvāṇa, followers of the Great Vehicle should understand, 'He is teaching impermanence,' and they should cultivate the perception of impermanence. When the Tathāgata teaches that the true Dharma will decline and perish, they should understand, 'He is teaching suffering,' and they should cultivate suffering. When the Tathāgata tells the monks and nuns, 'My body is afflicted by great and endless illness,' and 'The Saṅgha will be destroyed,' they should understand, 'He is teaching selflessness,' and they should cultivate the meditation on selflessness.

"When the Tathāgata teaches that liberation is signless, empty, and nothingness, they should understand that he is teaching that liberation is free of the twenty-five kinds of existence. That is why it is called empty. Because there is no suffering in it, it is the complete absence of suffering, it is supreme bliss, and it is signless. Because there is nothing in it that is impermanent, unstable, not eternal, or not of a peaceful nature, liberation is permanent, stable, eternal, and peace, and that very liberation is the Tathāgata.

"When the Tathāgata teaches that all sentient beings possess buddha-nature, then one should cultivate the meditation on true permanence. I say that whichever monks meditate in this way are my śrāvakas. I say that, like the king's minister, they are skilled in words of hidden intent. If even the ways of a king contain words of hidden intent, how could my teaching lack words of hidden intent? Many wise people should understand it in this way. My teaching does not accord with any of the world.

"Noble son, further, consider palāśa, aśoka, and karṇikāra trees. When rain is scarce, their flowers become poor and their fruit becomes poor as well. The other flowers that grow in water and on dry land also become short-stemmed, poor in color, weak in luster, and faint in fragrance. In the same way, in the future, flowers and medicinal plants will decline in luster, fragrance, and so forth.

"Noble son, likewise, after I have passed away, in a future time when an evil age arrives and the true Dharma is perishing, because sentient beings will have little merit, just as flowers lose their luster when rain is scarce, so only about half of the verses that explain in the world the meaning of the verses of hidden intent of this great Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra, and only about half of its words and its scattered phrases, will be handed down. Evil monks, too, lacking the strength themselves, will cast aside the words of hidden intent, the secret verses, the words of nectar, and will recite other things instead. Like thieves who carry off loads of chaff and throw away jewels of great worth, lax monks will throw away the verses of this sūtra, its words of hidden intent.

"Alas! A future time will come that is supremely dreadful and supremely terrifying. Alas! The sentient beings of the future will have very little good fortune, and they will not listen to this great sūtra. Those who do listen to it are bodhisattvas, great beings. They will grasp the meaning of reality and will not cling chiefly to the letters. They will teach others exactly as much as the meaning of the sūtra is, and will not teach what is meaningless.

Son of noble family, it is like this. A cowherd woman, wanting to make a profit, adulterates the milk by mixing in water and molasses. She carries the jug of milk away from the cattle pen and sells it to a fellow cowherd woman. That fellow cowherd woman in turn adulterates the milk with twice as much water and sells it to a dealer. That dealer in turn adulterates it with twice as much water and sells it to a fellow dealer. That fellow dealer in turn adulterates it with twice as much water. Then, in a city or a marketplace, a man who has come to buy wants to make milk porridge for the festival of setting his son's topknot. Thinking, "This is hard to come by," he buys the milk. He cooks the porridge with that watered milk, and that supreme food turns out weak in flavor. Even so, among all tasty things the essences of the cow are foremost, and among them milk is the finest, so that supreme food is still a thousand times more delicious than pungent fare.

Son of noble family, in the same way, after I have passed away, before many hundreds of years have gone by, when eighty years remain of the time the true Dharma endures, this great Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra will circulate in Jambudvīpa. At that time, while the sūtra is circulating, evil and utterly negligent monks, who rob the flower of the true Dharma of its fragrance, will tamper with the volumes. When they read this sūtra, they will drop the negating syllables such as na, ma and ku from the secret words of hidden intent, whose meaning and wording are hard to understand, and recite something else in their place. Those monks, who keep improper possessions in order to secure their own gain, are on the side of Māra. Just as the cowherd woman adulterated the milk with molasses water, they will corrupt this sūtra.

Furthermore, through people not knowing how to read, through bad preachers of the Dharma, through the faults of poor writing, through people not abiding in the Dharma, through their not serving their teachers with respect, through its being slighted by bad people, through unfavorable times, through the long passage of time, and through the faults of transmission from hand to hand, what circulates will have only about half of its words and meaning, and no more than a small remnant of the sūtra will survive. The supreme food cooked with milk bought second hand from the dealer turned out flavorless, and yet that supreme food is still the best of all tasty things. In the same way, though only a little of this great sūtra will remain, it is still a thousand times more important than all the sūtras of the Śrāvaka Vehicle. Why is this? Because all sūtras and all samādhis are the power of parinirvāṇa, it is called the supreme Great Parinirvāṇa. It is a great name.

Son of noble family, furthermore, a son or daughter of noble family should meditate so as to take on the nature of a man. Why? Because the nature of woman is the source of everything contrary to the Dharma, being its cause. For example, the urine of a fly will never moisten the great earth, nor ever saturate it. In the same way, women are never sated with desire. Suppose the great earth were rolled into pellets the size of juniper berries or of mustard seeds. Even if a woman were to indulge her desire, full of attachment, with as many men as there are pellets, she would not be sated, just as fly urine does not moisten and saturate the earth. Women are not sated with desire.

Son of noble family, furthermore, listen to how women are not good. Even if a woman were to indulge her desire, full of attachment, with as many men as there are grains of sand in the Ganges River, or with numbers beyond reckoning, multitudes upon multitudes, she would not be sated, just as fly

urine does not moisten and saturate the earth. Women too are not sated with desire.

Son of noble family, furthermore, the great ocean is never filled, though the rain falling from great clouds and the waters of the rivers pour into it. In the same way, women are never sated with desire.

Son of noble family, furthermore, when flowering trees such as the aśoka, the dongka tree and the pāṭala are in full bloom, the bees are never sated with the nectar of the flowers. The bees drink the nectar skillfully, delicately and deeply. In the same way, women drink up men's wealth, their desire and their semen, and like the bees they are never sated.

Therefore, son of noble family, having heard this Great Parinirvāṇa, one should cultivate a mind free of attachment to the nature of woman, and cultivate the resolve to take on the nature of a man. Why? Because this sūtra rightly teaches the nature of a man, which is the tathāgatagarbha. The nature of a man is what is called a person. The nature of the Tathāgata is the man. Even those in the world who are men are not of the nature of a man, because they do not know that they themselves possess the tathāgatagarbha. Those who do not know the tathāgatagarbha, I say, are women. Those who rightly know, "I possess the tathāgatagarbha," belong among the supreme of men. Even if they are women, they belong among the supreme of men. Thus this great Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra is immeasurable, because it teaches the tathāgatagarbha. A son or daughter of noble family who wishes quickly to realize this point of the sūtra should strive at the tathāgatagarbha.

He said, "Blessed One, it is so. Blessed One, it is indeed so. I too, now, in order to meditate on the tathāgatagarbha, abide in the nature of a man. It has been made plain. I have understood the hint."

The Blessed One declared, "Excellent, son of noble family, excellent! One who conforms to the world should view it in this way."

He said, "Blessed One, this is not conforming to the world."

The Blessed One declared, "Excellent, son of noble family, excellent! Just as the bee feeds on the flowers of the trees, so should one partake of the food of the profound Dharma."

"Son of noble family, here is another example. A little fly's urine cannot soak the great earth. In the same way, in the future this great sūtra will be like a fly's urine: it will circulate in the world only a little. At the end, when the true

Dharma is being destroyed, it will be used up, as a fly's urine sinks away into the great earth. This is the seventh sign of the disappearance of the true Dharma, and the wise should know that there are other signs as well.

"Son of noble family, here is another example. At the close of summer, the first month of winter is called autumn. When the autumn season arrives, the clouds let fall their rain to ripen what has not yet ripened, and then they quickly scatter. In the same way, this great sūtra, like the autumn clouds that rain down and quickly scatter, will go to the south and pour down the rain of Dharma of all the words of intended meaning of the Great Parinirvāṇa. Then the bodhisattva great beings of the south will know that the true Dharma is being destroyed. Like clouds when winter draws near, they will go to Kashmir and sink into the earth, and all the true Dharma of the Vaipulya sūtras of the Great Vehicle, the supreme nectar, will disappear. The bodhisattva great beings, the best of humans, should understand: 'Although this sūtra known to the Tathāgata has now come into our hands, the true Dharma will disappear.'"

He said, "So that all sentient beings may easily understand that the element of the tathāgatas, the pratyekabuddhas, the śrāvakas and the bodhisattvas is not different, may the Blessed One please explain it clearly and thoroughly."

The Blessed One said, "Son of noble family, suppose a householder or a householder's son owns many herds of cattle. He has cows of different colors, and among them are also blue cows, and he has a single herdsman graze them. Then on one occasion, in order to make offerings to his own god, the householder gathers all the herds together and has them milked. Seeing that the milk is all white, like the color of a conch shell, he is amazed and thinks, 'These cows here are of different colors, yet the milk of these blue cows is not blue, and the milk of the white cows is just the same: it is like the color of a conch shell.' Later he understands, and thinks, 'This should be seen as having come about from the cause of the maturation of the karma of beings.'

"Son of noble family, in the same way the nature of all śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas and tathāgatas is like milk. Why? Because they have exhausted the defilements. All sentient beings take the nature of śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas and tathāgatas to be different, and their forms to be different, but they too will gradually come to know, just like the householder.

"Son of noble family, just as from a gold mine or a copper mine there comes forth the very nature of gold, free of stone and grit and beyond price, in the same way all śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas and tathāgatas are like gold, one in

value and one in nature. Why? Because they are free of the afflictions, which are like stone and grit. Therefore there is no distinction in this buddha wisdom. That all sentient beings have the buddha element is also like this. Just as the householder came to understand the milk, they too, having heard the sūtra of the tathāgatagarbha, will exhaust every form of affliction and realize the buddha element."

He said, "Blessed One, what does this mean? Are all sentient beings and the tathāgatas not different? If the Tathāgata were to teach in the way he has just taught, there would be a great fault in it, so I ask you now to state the reason. Leaving aside all sentient beings and the pratyekabuddhas, if that is so, why do Śāriputra and Maudgalyāyana pass into parinirvāṇa by the parinirvāṇa of the śrāvakas? Why do the pratyekabuddhas pass into parinirvāṇa by the parinirvāṇa of the pratyekabuddhas? Why do the bodhisattvas pass into parinirvāṇa by the great parinirvāṇa of the bodhisattvas?"

He replied, "The Great Parinirvāṇa of the buddhas does not belong to the śrāvakas, the pratyekabuddhas or the bodhisattvas. In this Great Parinirvāṇa there is no place for anyone other than the buddhas."

He asked, "How is that?"

He replied, "Over a great many countless ten millions of eons, the Tathāgata displays the appearance of a tathāgata. If one asks what difference there is, then, between the tathāgatas, the śrāvakas, the pratyekabuddhas and the bodhisattvas: son of noble family, I have taught that the arhats have no place in the secret nirvāṇa of the Tathāgata, and that is what is without place. Therefore, in the manner of this great Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra, the Great Parinirvāṇa is without any place. Therefore it is called the Great Parinirvāṇa."

He said, "It seems they are indeed different."

He replied, "It is as it appears."

He said, "The śrāvakas, the pratyekabuddhas and the bodhisattvas will also pass into parinirvāṇa by the Great Parinirvāṇa. Just as rivers flow down into the ocean, that is also their destination. Therefore they too are called permanent."

He replied, "They are, in my sense, supremely permanent."

He asked, "Blessed One, how can the element be both not different and different?"

He replied, "It is different."

He asked, "How so?"

He replied, "For example, cow's milk is supremely sweet, and the element is like that. The element of the śrāvakas and the pratyekabuddhas is like curd. The element of the bodhisattvas is like butter. The element of the buddhas is like the essence of butter. Thus the Tathāgata, who teaches the instructions of the Great Parinirvāṇa, has taught it as fourfold."

He asked, "What is the element of all sentient beings like?"

The Blessed One said, "Like milk that is mixed with blood just after a calf has suckled, that element, mixed with the blood of the afflictions, pervades the tathāgata element, which is like the essence of butter."

He asked, "The Blessed One has prophesied that a caṇḍāla living here in the city of Kuśinagara will, in this world system, become one tathāgata among a thousand buddhas, the Tathāgata called Utterly Joyful, and that through a single generation of the mind he will quickly become a buddha within such and such a time. Since he has been prophesied to buddhahood, why have the two, Śāriputra and Maudgalyāyana, who will become buddhas even more quickly, not been prophesied to buddhahood?"

The Blessed One said, "Among śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, and bodhisattvas, there are some who make aspirations for a long time in order to uphold the sacred Dharma, and there are some who make aspirations for swiftness. By the power of the latter's aspiration, I prophesy them very swiftly to the supreme state of buddhahood.

"Furthermore, noble son, suppose a great merchant went to a city of caṇḍālas to sell a priceless jewel. When the caṇḍālas, who could not tell its worth, saw that jewel, they would ridicule it and disparage it. Even though the merchant told them, 'It is precious,' they would not understand, and would say, 'This is glass.' Noble son, in the same way, even if I were to prophesy the śrāvakas swiftly to buddhahood, to the state of a buddha, I would be like the merchant selling a rare gem. Those who are like the caṇḍālas are the foolish śramaṇas who will appear in the future: lazy, having abandoned the roots of virtue, destitute of livelihood, tormented by hunger and thirst, afflicted by famine, caring only for their own bodies, seeking after a livelihood, and unsteady. When they hear that my śrāvakas have been prophesied, they will mock and revile them, and, not understanding, they will slander them, saying, 'They are immoral.' To them, these śrāvakas of mine are not śramaṇas, just as it was with the caṇḍālas and the merchant. Therefore, noble son, I prophesy to

buddhahood those beings who have aspirations for swiftness. Those who are engaged in upholding the sacred Dharma I prophesy, as they wish, to the state of buddhahood after a long time."

He asked, "How do bodhisattva mahāsattvas come to have a retinue that cannot be divided?"

The Blessed One said, "If the supreme bodhisattvas, thinking, 'I shall uphold the sacred Dharma,' make that practice firm, they will have a retinue that cannot be divided."

He asked, "From what do wicked and terrifying beings, whose tongue, palate, and throat are burnt, come about?"

The Blessed One said, "Those who do not know the three foundations become wicked and terrifying beings whose tongue, palate, and throat are burnt. For example, when humans and animals with burnt tongues eat the six tastes, namely sweet, sour, salty, pungent, bitter, and astringent, they cannot distinguish one taste from another. In the same way, ignorant beings who do not know the three foundations to be permanent are wicked and terrifying, and are called those whose tongue, palate, and throat are burnt.

"Furthermore, noble son, I say that those who do not know the Tathāgata to be permanent are the foremost of the blind. I say that those who know the Tathāgata to be permanent, even though they have fleshly eyes, have the divine eye. Furthermore, noble son, I say that those who, having heard this sūtra, know and understand the Tathāgata to be permanent have the divine eye. I say that those who, even though they have the divine eye, do not know the Tathāgata to be permanent, have fleshly eyes. Even for many more tens of millions of eons, they will not be able to see or show what their own head and tail are like. Therefore, because they are without the meditation on the Tathāgata as permanent, I say they have fleshly eyes.

"Furthermore, noble son, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Complete Buddha is like a father and mother to the whole world. Why is that? Because he teaches the Dharma to all beings, two-legged and many-legged, each according to their own domain, and with a single word all beings understand, each according to their own domain, and they think, 'Ah, he is teaching the Dharma so that we may realize our own natures and perceptions.'

"Furthermore, noble son, suppose a householder or a merchant speaks as if he were mute with his own son who is sixteen months old, and by that means the

son learns human speech. Would that father then be called mute?"

He replied, "No, Blessed One. It should be seen that he does so for the sake of the son."

The Blessed One said, "Noble son, in the same way the Tathāgata too speaks as if he were mute. If he displays such a form in order to establish all beings in the sacred Dharma, would the Tathāgata then be called mute?"

He replied, "No, Blessed One. Since the Tathāgata always roars the lion's roar, his speaking as if mute should be regarded as acting in accordance with the world."

Then, at that time, various rays of light spread forth from the Blessed One's own mouth, and those rays struck Cunda, the son of the smith. He thought, "Ah, a gift that hereafter can no longer be offered to the Tathāgata is rare indeed." Very hastily he took food enough to satisfy the Tathāgata together with the Saṅgha of monks, and, together with his own retinue, he hastily brought vessels of stainless Jambū River gold adorned with tall, radiant jewel bosses, and some silver vessels adorned with various precious stones, filled with food combined with various relishes, together with many articles of offering. Coming out from the midst of the city, he set out for where the Blessed One was.

Then the mighty sons of the gods surrounded Cunda, the smith's son, and said to him, "Cunda, do not offer the food yet. Leave the Tathāgata be for a moment."

Then the Blessed One (the Buddha) once again sent forth his rays of light. The rays struck the sons of the gods, and they let Cunda go.

Then all the gods and others gathered there made a great offering to the Blessed One. Together with Cunda they went before the Blessed One and said, "If the time for the monks' midday meal has come, please give your permission."

Then the monks, knowing that the time for the midday meal had come, composed themselves in good deportment, took their alms bowls in their hands, and sat down.

Then Cunda, the smith's son, set out lion thrones of every kind, beyond what words could describe, as though fit even for the world realm Sukhāvatī. He also prepared the food, and then said to the Blessed One, "May the Tathāgata please remain for an eon, or even longer than an eon."

The Blessed One said, "Cunda, if you want me to stay long, the time has come for the final perfection of generosity. So offer it quickly!"

Then all the gods and humans and the bodhisattvas said, "Oh, how fortunate Cunda is! See how the Tathāgata has resolved to eat the food that he has offered! We have no such good fortune. The food we prepared has been for nothing."

Then from all the pores of his body, from each and every pore, the Blessed One manifestly emanated a buddha. In each assembly he showed a tathāgata together with a Saṅgha of monks, all appearing to partake of the meal. The Tathāgata himself ate the food offered by Cunda. The food Cunda had prepared from eight nalita measures of Magadhan śāli rice, by the Tathāgata's power, was also made to fill the whole Saṅgha of monks with food.

Then Cunda too became joyful, thinking, "The Tathāgata, together with the Saṅgha of monks, has eaten my gift and will pass into complete nirvāṇa."

Everyone in that assembly thought, "The Tathāgata has accepted the food we offered and has not accepted Cunda's. Having eaten the food we offered, the Tathāgata will pass into complete nirvāṇa." And they became supremely joyful.

In that great assembly, where the tathāgatas sat partaking of the meal, the offerings appeared in spaces no larger than the tip of a splinter. Some appeared to be seated on spots no larger than the point of a needle, and to have food and offerings all alike.

Then at that time the gods, humans, and asuras wept and wailed, crying, "Having eaten the food that each of us offered, the Tathāgata is passing into complete nirvāṇa. From now on, to whom shall we offer food? We are parted from our protector and shall be without a protector."

Then the Blessed One spoke these verses to that whole assembly.

The thirteenth fascicle, the last.

"Since this is the very nature of the buddhas,
Do not grieve and do not weep.
When I pass beyond sorrow,
Ten million eons will have run their course.

Hear from me of my passing beyond sorrow,
Which is permanent, blissful and supreme.

I do not eat food,
And I have no itching or burning at all.

I shall explain the rejoicing
That brings benefit and happiness to all beings.
Having heard it, come to know
That very permanence of the perfect Buddha.

When owls and crows
Dwell together on a single tree,
And like siblings and like children
Always please one another,
Then, as on Rāhula, his son,
Will the Tathāgata gaze on beings,
And the one supreme among all beings
Will die, passing beyond sorrow for good.

When snakes and mongooses
Dwell together at the foot of a single tree,
And like siblings and like children
Always please one another,
Then, as on Rāhula,
Will the Tathāgata gaze on beings,
And the one supreme among all beings
Will die, passing beyond sorrow for good.

When the flowers of the saptaparṇa
Take on the scent of vārṣikī jasmine,
And from karaka trees
Tinduka fruits come forth,
Then, as on Rāhula,
Will the Tathāgata gaze on beings,
And the one supreme among all beings
Will die, passing beyond sorrow for good.

When the sinful icchantikas
Fully and manifestly awaken to awakening,
And, having attained supreme bliss,
Have cast off every fault,
Then, as on Rāhula,

Will the Tathāgata gaze on beings,
And the one supreme among all beings
Will die, passing beyond sorrow for good.

When all sentient beings
Come to dwell in harmony of intention,
Perfect buddhas in supreme awakening,
Having cast off every fault,
Then, as on Rāhula,
Will the Tathāgata gaze on beings,
And the one supreme among all beings
Will die, passing beyond sorrow for good.

When with a mere drop of a fly's urine
The earth, bounded by the four oceans,
Together with its forests and mountains,
Is filled to the full,
Then, as on Rāhula,
Will the Tathāgata gaze on beings,
And the one supreme among all beings
Will die, passing beyond sorrow for good."

"Therefore, you who possess the Dharma and revere the Dharma, do not grieve! Do not weep! The Tathāgata has mastery over himself. So do not hold the perception of impermanence, but see rightly that he is permanent, eternal, and supremely stable. Protect yourselves with this concealment and protection of the secret mantra of the three permanent bases. Through the secret mantra of the three permanent bases, even trees burned by lightning will grow again, and come to have branches, sprouting buds, and unfolded leaves. If, among the fourfold assembly, people hear from one another this talk of rejoicing that the three bases are permanent, then even if they hold that there is no need to generate the awakening mind, because the three bases are supremely permanent, it will arise as a cause of awakening. This is called rejoicing in the Buddha."

"Those monks or nuns who teach beings this rejoicing that arises from the permanence of the Three Jewels are worthy to eat the alms of the land. The others are not worthy. By the truth of the Dharma through which what this rejoicing brings forth becomes happiness throughout all the world, may those

who long for the sublime Dharma be free of obstructions and free of harm!"

Then the world with its gods, asuras and humans came to understand that the Tathāgata is permanent. With minds of great joy, virtuous minds, minds free of obscuration and minds without partiality, their faces like blossoming lotuses, they performed a great divine offering, scattering flowers, powders, incense, scented ointments and the like. They also played cymbals and other instruments.

Then the Blessed One said to the bodhisattva mahāsattva, the kinsman of Mahākāśyapa, "Son of noble family, what marvel have you seen here today?"

He replied, "Blessed One, I have seen a marvel such as I have never seen before. I saw the food offered by each assembly being eaten by a tathāgata, one for each, together with a saṅgha of monks. In this assembly, even on spaces no larger than the tip of a needle, on seats arranged just so, many tathāgatas of great size sat at their ease, and I saw them seated there teaching the thirteen verses of rejoicing. All beings do not know this magical display; each one thinks, 'The Blessed One is seated here eating the food that I offered.' The supreme among humans, the bodhisattva mahāsattvas such as Mañjuśrī the youthful, truly understand this extraordinary wonder: that of the food Cunda prepared from eight nālikas of Magadhan śāli rice, not even a speck was eaten by the saṅgha of monks, and that the Tathāgata did not eat the food. They think, 'This was done merely as a skillful means.' The assemblies of śrāvakas do not understand, 'Oh, the Tathāgata is immeasurable and permanent!'"

Then the Blessed One said to Cunda the smith's son, "Cunda, what marvel have you seen?"

He replied, "Blessed One, before, I saw many tathāgatas endowed with the thirty-two supreme marks and the eighty excellent minor marks. Now each of them has transformed himself, and here they appear as bodhisattva mahāsattvas of great bodies. The Tathāgata has become a single body, like a medicinal tree, and is surrounded by the bodhisattvas."

The Blessed One said, "Those former buddhas were emanations, made in order to benefit all beings, to make them happy, to delight their minds, and to make their merit inexhaustible. Apart from the bodhisattvas, beings do not know this magical display. Thus the conduct of bodhisattvas is immeasurable. Thus the bodhisattva mahāsattvas are immeasurable. Bodhisattvas, the supreme among humans, have the power of a buddha's miraculous

transformations. Cunda the smith's son, too, is a bodhisattva mahāsattva who has attained the ten grounds. Such is the ultimate culmination of the supreme among bodhisattvas."

The kinsman of Mahākāśyapa said, "Blessed One, it is just so. I rejoice in Cunda, the supreme human among the bodhisattvas. Blessed One, now it is fitting that you grant permission for the explanation of the sūtras. Blessed One, how is it? Do all the sūtras have a meaning with remainder, or a meaning without remainder?"

The Blessed One said, "They have a meaning with remainder, and they also have a meaning without remainder."

He said, "In the lines,

Giving is praised everywhere;
Giving is nowhere disparaged,

how is this explained as a meaning with remainder? What is the meaning of the verse? What is the difference between those who possess moral discipline and those whose moral discipline is corrupt?"

The Blessed One said, "Except for one, giving is praised everywhere."

He asked, "What is the exception?"

The Blessed One said, "Whoever is reckoned in this sūtra as having corrupt moral discipline."

He said, "Blessed One, today I ask the Blessed One only this; please tell me quickly."

The Blessed One said, "Except for the icchantikas, giving is praised everywhere."

He asked, "What are icchantikas like?"

The Blessed One said, "Whether a monk, a nun, a layman or a laywoman, whoever rejects the sūtras with evil words and afterward does not even ask forgiveness has entered the path of the icchantika. Those who have incurred the four defeats and those who commit the five acts of immediate retribution, who, although they know, 'We have entered a fearful state,' do not regard it with fear, do not take the side of the sublime Dharma, make no effort with the thought, 'We shall uphold the sublime Dharma,' and even speak in dispraise of it, have also entered the path of the icchantika. Those who say, 'There is no Buddha, there is no Dharma, there is no Saṅgha,' have also entered the path

of the icchantika, I declare. Except for those icchantikas, giving is praised everywhere."

He asked, "Then who are those called people of corrupt moral discipline?"

The Blessed One said, "Those who commit the four defeats, those who commit the five acts of immediate retribution, and those very ones who reject the sūtras."

He asked, "Blessed One, how is it? Are they forever nothing but people of corrupt moral discipline?"

The Blessed One said, "There is a reason here, and therefore some are so permanently and some are not so permanently. There are those who do not dwell together with those who bear the sign of the dyed robe, who regard it with fear, thinking, 'Alas, we have incurred a defeat; we have committed a wrong,' who practice with the thought, 'We shall uphold the sublime Dharma,' and who think, 'We shall speak the praises of those who hold to the side of the sublime Dharma.'

"The factions of what is not the Dharma should be subdued; the incomparable sūtras should be recited." Those who strive with this thought, I do not say that they are of corrupt moral discipline. Why is that? Son of noble family, just as when the sun rises the passing dust is cleared away, so too, when the sun of this great sūtra rises, the countless heaps of evil committed by the sentient beings who cultivate it in this way are exhausted. Thus bringing forth the true Dharma has great fruit.

As for those who commit the deeds of immediate retribution and those who reject the sūtras: suppose they become remorseful and anguished, thinking, "Alas, this rejection of the sūtras that we have committed will be our ruin; we have done wrong," and they give rise to the thought, "Our refuge is this very sūtra; we see no other place to cling to." Then for half a month, or a month, or for however long it lasts until they have gone for refuge to the sūtra, what is given to them is of little fruit. When they have gone for refuge to the sūtra, then they too become worthy recipients of offerings. If one who commits a deed of immediate retribution also feels remorse and thinks, "Alas, I have done what is improper; I shall bring forth the true Dharma," then he too should be known as not being a perpetrator of a deed of immediate retribution, and even if only a little is given to him, it bears fruit. But what is given to those others, the utterly immoral, has not even the slightest fruit.

Son of noble family, listen further to what one who commits a defeat should do. If one who commits a defeat comes to understand the suchness of phenomena, the tathāgatagarbha, and thinks, "I shall bring forth the true Dharma," then what is given to him becomes exceedingly excellent.

Son of noble family, suppose a pregnant woman, when her country was in turmoil, went to another land and gave birth to a baby boy inside a temple. When she had recovered, she took the boy, and after her own country had become peaceful she set out to return. She came upon a great river, and while crossing that water together with her child she became exhausted in the water. Thinking, "Better that I should die; I shall save this boy," she strove for his sake, and she died together with her son. Although she had previously committed extremely dreadful deeds, through the fruit of her love for her son and her thought of saving him she was born in the higher realms. In the same way, those among the perpetrators of defeats and the perpetrators of deeds of immediate retribution who bring forth the true Dharma, although they previously committed evil deeds, through the fruit of bringing forth the true Dharma become, like that woman, worthy recipients of the offerings of all sentient beings. So great is the fruit of bringing forth the true Dharma.

He asked, "Blessed One, if someone who has fallen into being an icchantika later confesses before the three bases and asks forgiveness, will what is given to him be of great fruit?"

The Blessed One said, "Son of noble family, do not say that. Suppose some person ate a mango fruit and threw the stone on the ground. Afterward he thought, 'The kernel inside may be tasty,' so he discarded the outer stone and ate the kernel, and finding its taste unpleasant he threw it away again. Then he thought, 'Alas, I have ruined the seed and spoiled it.' He put the seed back inside the stone, dug the earth, placed it in, and poured milk and butter over it. But even if a great rain were to fall, the ruined and spoiled seed would not grow; it cannot possibly grow. Then, thinking, 'This seed has been spoiled and will not grow,' he grew weary and sat there without saying a word. In the same way, the icchantika has no seed; it is impossible for an icchantika to give rise to the thought of confessing and asking forgiveness. Therefore, for such an icchantika, giving is not of great fruit in every case. The fruit of what is offered to arhats is also distinct. The fruit of what is offered to pratyekabuddhas is also distinct. The fruit of what is offered to the tathāgatas is also distinct. Therefore the fruit of giving is not great in every case."

He asked, "Why has the Blessed One taught the meaning of this verse in two ways?"

The Blessed One said, "It arises from a cause. Formerly in Rājagṛha there was a layman without faith who delighted in the Nirgranthas. At the time when he asked me what giving leads to, in order to guide him I taught him the verse that says, 'Giving is praised everywhere.' That was taught for the sake of the bodhisattvas, as words whose meaning is to be interpreted; the meaning of the verse was not taught as the same at all times. The word 'all' should be understood as fitted to the occasion, with words left unstated. The bodhisattvas, supreme among humans, should root out the immoral just as one clears a field.

"Further, son of noble family, I formerly taught this verse:

All rivers and all waters flow crookedly;
All forests are nothing but trees;
All women are deceitful;
All lords are happy.

The minds of women are deceitful and frightening."

Thereupon Mañjuśrī Kumārabhūta rose from his seat, bowed his head at the feet of the Blessed One, and addressed the Blessed One in turn in verse:

Not all waters flow crookedly;
Not all forests are trees;
Not all women are deceitful;
Not all lords are happy.

"Therefore, the Blessed One's teaching of that Dharma door in that way was not well spoken. I beg you to tell me what reason there is for this."

"In this great trichiliocosm world system there is a separate continent, the western one called Godānīya. There is a river there named Flowing Straight, which runs straight like a carpenter's chalk line from the western ocean to the eastern ocean. If the Blessed One has declared, on the authority of the Vaipulya scriptures, that the word 'all' has a meaning that allows for exceptions, then in which sūtra of the Vaipulya scriptures is this river called Flowing Straight explained? May the Blessed One, who speaks the truth, please tell me.

Suppose, for example, that a guide who knows a mine of treasure, but is not skilled in mining, says, 'There is no gold here,' even though there is gold in

that very place. From his saying so, one should understand that he knows only certain particular parts of the place.

The saying 'All forests are nothing but trees' also has a meaning that allows for exceptions, for there are many kinds of forest, such as forests of gold and of beryl. In the same way, the saying 'All women are deceitful' also has a meaning that allows for exceptions, for there are many women who possess moral discipline, who are free of desire, and who are without avarice. The saying 'All lords are happy' also has a meaning that allows for exceptions. The word 'lord' refers to universal monarchs and to the buddhas, who are supreme lords; yet they too fall under the power of death and transmigration and are subject to exhaustion. These lords such as Brahmā are also subject to falling. Therefore I say that they are not lords. The lord who is permanent and stable is nirvāṇa, the lord of supreme bliss."

The Blessed One said, "Mañjuśrī, suppose a physician is treating the illness of a householder's son. He boils medicine in ghee and has him drink it, and the patient asks to drink a great deal of ghee. The physician then says to him, 'Although one who has strength may be allowed to drink a great deal of ghee, for he is able to digest it, you have no strength, so do not drink too much ghee. Ghee does cure illness, but if you drink a lot of it, that very thing will make you die suddenly.' When he says this, has that physician, who wishes to help and is compassionate, spoiled the true meaning?

In the same way, the Buddha, the Blessed One, in order to dispel the pride of kings, ministers, and queens, and to produce in the queens of Prasenajit, king of Kosala, fear of committing adultery with others and disenchantment with it, the Tathāgata, like a physician, spoke this verse beginning 'The waters of rivers flow crookedly,' with reference to King Prasenajit. In saying that rivers flow crookedly, the Tathāgata is not mistaken. Should he ever be mistaken, heaven and earth would be overturned. Therefore, in using the word 'all,' he spoke of what allows for exceptions as though it allowed for none. Mañjuśrī, excellent leader of the herd of bodhisattvas, it is excellent, excellent that you thus expand wisdom for the benefit of all sentient beings."

Then Mañjuśrī the youthful again addressed the Blessed One in verse:

"What one has done and left undone
One should examine; but what others
Have done and left undone,
And the faults of others, one should not examine.

That the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, taught that Dharma door in this way was not well spoken. Why is this so? I beg you to tell me the reason you said it. In the ninefold scripture the Blessed One said: 'Here the Nirgranthas are all hell beings, and the ninety-six heterodox schools have entered a bad path. All the children of the Buddha have entered upon nirvāṇa. All who are upright, who possess moral discipline and ritual observance, and whose senses are tamed, go to the higher realms and have the Dharma as their domain.' Thus he spoke in praise of himself, in disparagement of others, and in censure of others. Since the Blessed One has in this way spoken of the faults of others, how is it that this is not called the faults of others?"

Then the Blessed One said this to Mañjuśrī the youthful: "Son of noble family, if you ask with reference to whom and for what reason I taught, 'One should not examine the faults of others,' it was taught with reference to Ajātaśatru. The Buddha, the Blessed One, does not teach what contradicts the meaning without a cause; he teaches with a cause. Formerly, after Ajātaśatru had killed his father, he came before me and asked a question in a contemptuous manner: 'What is this? Is the Blessed One omniscient, or is he not omniscient? If he is omniscient, why did he ordain Devadatta? If you saw that for many thousands of lifetimes he has followed after you and done you harm, how did you, the omniscient one, not see that now too he would come to attack you?' When he said this, I taught him the verse, 'One should not examine the faults of others.' And I said, 'Now, great king, purify the great and violent poison of the act of immediate retribution that you committed in killing your father. O king, without looking at the faults of others, understand it in this way.'

Furthermore, one should indeed examine faults: one should make it one's main concern to examine the flaws of those who rely on moral discipline and ritual observance. That is the teaching of the Buddha. Those who examine the faults of others should know that what oneself and others have done and left undone belongs to oneself and to others. Those who in this way always see correctly what others have done, I declare, are my śrāvakas."

Then again the Blessed One said this to Mañjuśrī the youthful:

"All are afraid of punishment;
To all, life is dear.
Taking oneself as the measure,
One should not strike, one should not kill."

Then Mañjuśrī the youthful said this to the Blessed One:

"Not all are terrified of punishment,
nor is life dear to all.
Taking oneself as the measure,
one should understand how to act through skillful means.

Therefore the Dharma door that the Blessed One (the Buddha) taught in that way was not well spoken. For:

Arhats and wheel-turning kings,
the precious elephant, the precious woman,
the precious householder, and the horse:
these cannot be harmed by anything at all.

In the world with its gods, humans, and asuras, no one dares to harm these. Even fierce and powerful enemies cannot possibly harm them. They are not frightened even by gods, by māras, or by Brahmās. Therefore these beings are called 'those who cannot be harmed by anything.' A man who is wholly heroic at the front line of battle, a wife who is wholly unswerving toward her husband, a lion, a thoroughbred horse of Sindhu, and a monk endowed with moral discipline: even though these can be harmed, they are not afraid of anything at all.

"As for the words 'All are terrified of punishment,' here the meaning carries an unstated qualification, so it is a condensed statement. The words 'Taking oneself as the measure' also carry an unstated qualification, for it is well known in the world that arhats are not the same as oneself. Suppose someone of small understanding thinks, 'This teaches that arhats perceive a self and that arhats perceive a life-force.' Such a person has placed the arhats in a lowly state. By doing so, through the evil view that perceives a life-force, the fruit of delusion, he will swiftly be born in Avīci hell. Moreover, even if one were to form the intention to kill arhats, it is impossible for them to be killed by such beings. Even if many beings turned against them, they would not dare to kill them."

The Blessed One said, "Out of compassion for living creatures, I regard them as like myself. With respect to harmlessness, the arhat should be regarded as immeasurable and incomparable, and one should not form the intention to kill such beings. Thus the Buddha does not, without a reason, teach what contradicts the meaning. This verse was taught with reference to a deer hunter of Rājagṛha. Having killed deer, he invited me to an offering of food that included meat. I accepted his invitation and, regarding him as I regard

Rāhula, I spoke this verse:

All are terrified of punishment;
to all, life is dear.
Taking oneself as the measure,
do not strike, do not kill.

Look far ahead and live long! Come to understand the meaning of the sign of harmlessness!

"Excellent, excellent, Mañjuśrī, bull among men among the bodhisattvas! It is excellent that, for the benefit of all sentient beings, you have asked about this statement made with a hidden intention."

Then Mañjuśrī the youthful addressed the Blessed One in verse:

"If one makes offerings to both father and mother
in the manner of worshiping a mother,
and is also respectful toward one's teacher,
how could one go to the terror of Avīci?"

Then the Blessed One spoke in verse:

"Here, craving is called the mother,
and delusion is called the father.
Whoever honors these two things
goes to the terror of Avīci."

Then the Blessed One again spoke this verse to Mañjuśrī the youthful:

"All that is under another's power is suffering;
all that has power over itself is happiness.
All that is under the power of pride is endless;
all joy is good."

Then Mañjuśrī the youthful said to the Blessed One:

"The Dharma door that the Blessed One taught in that way was not well spoken. Suppose that here a certain householder entrusts his son to a teacher of children. What then? Is that boy not called 'under another's power'? If one says of him that he is not under another's power, it contradicts the meaning, and if one says that he has power over himself, that also contradicts the meaning. This matter is extremely hard to examine. Suppose that here a certain prince has become incorrigible. He will not learn anything at all and wanders about as he pleases and at his own whim. If one calls him 'one who

has power over himself,' it greatly contradicts the meaning, while if one says he is under another's power, it does not contradict the meaning. This matter is extremely hard to examine.

"Furthermore, the expression 'under power' is used because if he came under his own power he would commit evil deeds and perish. So this statement carries an unstated qualification. Therefore it is not the case that all that is under another's power is suffering, nor that all that has power over itself is happiness.

"The words 'All that is under the power of pride is endless' also carry an unstated qualification, and it is not the case that all that is under the power of pride is endless. Suppose that here someone goes forth under the power of pride. What then? Is that renunciant called 'one under the power of pride, endless in all'? He is without pride, endowed with merit, possessed of moral discipline and proper conduct, and guards his senses. Therefore it is not the case that all that is under the power of pride is endless.

"The words 'All joy is good' also carry an unstated qualification, and not all joy is good. In this teaching, those who have incurred a defeat, even though they themselves see it as permissible to sit together with those who bear the sign of dyed robes, will be born among the beings of the hells. To call such joy good would contradict the meaning. Making those who keep committing defeats wear white clothes is accomplishing the very best of what is good, a vast benefit. Those who have committed a defeat are called not good, and those who bring about ruin are called not good."

"Therefore, if not all joy is good, with what intention did the god of gods, the Buddha, the Tathāgata, say that?"

Then the Blessed One said this to Mañjuśrī the youthful: "A buddha does not speak against the meaning without a cause. He speaks with a cause and with a condition. In Rājagṛha, Subhadrā, the daughter of the householder Kotaka, went to her father's house and conceived the wish to go forth. She went to the Tathāgata, thinking, 'To be a woman is to be under another's power, while to be a man is to be one's own master.' She took refuge in the Tathāgata, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha of monks. The Blessed One understood her thought, and so he spoke that verse: 'All that is under another's power is suffering.'

"Excellent, excellent, Mañjuśrī, bull among men among the bodhisattvas! It is excellent that you have asked me about these words spoken with a hidden intention, for the benefit of all beings."

Then the Blessed One again addressed Mañjuśrī the youthful in verse:

"All depend on food.
All who are free of avarice waver.
Through a fault in food one falls ill.
To keep company with those of pure conduct is happiness."

Mañjuśrī said, "Blessed One, what is this? After eating Cunda's offering, did you fall ill through a fault in the food?"

Then the Blessed One said this to Mañjuśrī: "Not all beings depend on food. Not all who are free of avarice waver. Not everyone falls ill through a fault in food. Nor is keeping company with those who practice the Dharma always happiness. Mañjuśrī, when you are struck by illness, then I too am struck by illness.

"Arhats and pratyekabuddhas,
Bodhisattvas and tathāgatas,
Are always without food;
That is the very nature of the buddhas.

"Arhats, pratyekabuddhas, bodhisattvas, and tathāgatas do not eat food, yet they accept many hundreds of thousands of offerings. They also teach the instructions on how offerings are to be received. In order to deliver beings with certainty from the ocean of the hells, the animals, and the hungry ghosts, they praise the perfection of generosity, yet they do not eat.

"One should not regard the Buddha as being like all other beings, saying, 'The Tathāgata became weak by practicing austerities for six years.' Those who have crossed the river of desire are steadfast; those heroes do not move within the domain of human beings. In the same way, the power and the domain of my śrāvakas are also inconceivable.

"The words 'All beings depend on food' should be understood as a statement that admits exceptions. The words 'All who are free of avarice waver' also admit exceptions, for there are some holy beings who, sparing toward themselves, go to an unwavering happiness. The words 'Everyone falls ill through a fault in food' also admit exceptions, for there are also sudden illnesses, such as being pierced by a thorn. The words 'Keeping company with all who practice the Dharma is happiness' also admit exceptions. Among worldly people too there are many kinds of practices that accord with those who hold to a dharma, and they have various undertakings. But if someone

were to keep company with those whose bodies are tormented by various kinds of fasting, would he find happiness? If that were so, it would contradict the meaning.

"Therefore, understand that a buddha does not teach against the meaning without a cause, but teaches with a cause and with a condition, according to those who are to be trained. The supramundane Dharma is supreme happiness.

"This verse was taught in connection with a brahmin called Sheep Glory, of the city called Ujjayinī. The brahmin Sheep Glory was keeping a four-day fast when he came to me, and in order to dispel his view about the four-day fast, I taught this verse beginning 'All beings depend on food.'"

Then the bodhisattva mahāsattva, the kinsman of Mahākāśyapa, said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, what does 'all, without exception' mean? And what does 'all' mean?"

He replied, "The sense of 'without exception' is as in the statement, 'Everything on the side of virtue is permanent and is bliss.' Thus a son of good family who longs for the Dharma should reason out that some statements admit exceptions and some do not."

He said, "Oh! The Tathāgata regards all beings as he regards Rāhula. I am overjoyed."

He replied, "Excellent, excellent, son of good family! One must examine things in fine detail in this way."

He said, "Blessed One, now please explain how the merit of the great Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra arises."

He replied, "Because this domain of the Buddha is inconceivable, not even all the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas are able to speak of the name of this sūtra, even as mere words, to those who listen."

Then the gods, humans, and asuras, with one voice, addressed the Blessed One in verse:

"Inconceivable Buddha, who teach the inconceivable Dharma,
The Dharma and the Saṅgha rely on you always.
Therefore, until the monks Kāśyapa and Ānanda
Have come, Protector, we beg you to remain.
Ajātaśatru, king of Videha,

Your supreme friend, great and of like mind,
Has also not yet come; do not depart for good.
Omniscient one, cut through our doubts."

Then the Blessed One said this to them:

"My supreme eldest son Kāśyapa
And wise Ānanda will cut through your doubts.
Look upon my face, and know the permanent
And the impermanent; do not grieve."

Then that whole assembly made great offerings to the Blessed One and made aspirations for unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. There, beings as numerous as the grains of sand in countless myriads of Ganges Rivers generated the mind of awakening and attained the state of the first bodhisattva ground.

Then the Blessed One spoke to Mañjuśrī the youthful and to the great and eminent brahmin, the kinsman of Mahākāśyapa. Having empowered Cunda the smith's son for awakening, he said to these three bodhisattvas:

"Sons of noble family, be heedful! Be heedful! I have been struck by a severe illness of the back. Young men, I wish to lie down for a while within the palace of skillful means, so let me lie down. Mañjuśrī, you must teach the Dharma to the whole assembly. Roar the lion's roar! Until the elders Mahākāśyapa and Ānanda arrive, I entrust this teaching to you. When they come, entrust it to the two of them."

When he had spoken these words, the Blessed One, for the sake of those to be trained, showed himself as one who is ill, and lay down on his side in a separate sleeping chamber.

This completes the chapter called "Requested by the Assembly of Gods, Humans, Asuras, Kinnaras, Vidyādharas, Rākṣasas, and Others," from the great Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra, which has twenty-five thousand chapters. This sūtra is the heart of all the scriptures of the sacred Dharma. Like the Later Section, it is a unique source of teachings that are difficult to realize, and it teaches the tathāgatagarbha.

It contains three thousand nine hundred ślokas. It was translated and finalized by the Indian preceptors Jinamitra and Jñānagarbha and the chief editor and translator, the monk Devacandra.

Translator's Notes

• This Tibetan version was translated from the Chinese. The cry rendered "we are overwhelmed" is literally "covered." The Chinese parallel has a cry of pain at this point, and the precise sense of the Tibetan is uncertain. "Thoroughbreds" renders a term normally standing for Sanskrit ājāneya. Kotaka, the name of Subhadrā's father, is romanized as the Tibetan spells it, since its Sanskrit form is not certain.
• The name of the lay leader (Tibetan: "King Renowned for Stainless Light") and that of the layman "Excellent Giver" could not be confidently identified with Sanskrit forms, so their meanings are translated. "Hue of acacia blossoms" renders the obscure color term bab la, tentatively taken as the babla (acacia) tree; this is uncertain. "Pyre for the cremation" interprets gdung zhugs la bzhen pa as building the funeral pyre for the Tathāgata's body.
• The animal to which the grieving laymen are compared is the śiśumāra, usually understood as the Gangetic dolphin or porpoise; "out of water" is added to make the image clear. The line "I shall serve a meal to the Tathāgata, and then he will pass into complete nirvāṇa" could also be read as each layman wishing to be the one whose meal is the last before the parinirvāṇa. Several of the textile names (dyed woolens, cloth of mule hair) are uncertain.
• The personal names Splendor of Life, Pure Stainless Essence, Purified of Obscurations, and Given by the Stainless Waters of the Ganges are translated from their Tibetan meaning, since their Sanskrit forms could not be identified with confidence. The line about the body reeking "like a king's dungeon dug deep in the ground" renders an obscure Tibetan phrase whose exact image is uncertain.
• Several personal names could not be identified with confidence and are rendered by meaning: the king of Vaiśālī "Stainless Moon Essence," the king "Sunlight," the queen "Beauty of the Three Worlds," and the god "Wide Eyes." Jagatpāla and Dharmapāla are reconstructions of "Protector of Beings" and "Protector of the Dharma." Vairocana is the standard equivalent of the Tibetan name.
• The word rendered "arrogance" in the list of faults (jealousy, arrogance, concealment, deceit) is written □□□□□□□□, which makes little sense; it is taken as a slip for a word meaning pride or haughtiness. The garuḍa king's name, □□□□□□□□□□□□, could not be confidently identified with a Sanskrit form and is translated by meaning as "Friend of Foes." The gandharva lord's father, □□□□□□□□, is tentatively given as Naradatta.
• Several names are rendered from their meaning because no Sanskrit form could be identified with confidence: the fruit-tree lord "Scent Keeper", the bhūta host "Revolving Like Venus" (taking ba sangs as the planet Venus), and the perfume elephants "Lungtang Hue", "Clear Honey Hue" and "Fragrant with All Desires". The dānava lord's name may in fact be two names, "Stainless Waters of the Ganges" and "Anudatta". The asura lord's name is rendered Śambara, taking bde mchog as a rendering of Śambara rather than the tantric deity. "Zalmo" and "bālika" are bird names that could not be identified. The phrase ja hong khar 'dug pa, describing the sun's rays on the sāla trees, is obscure, and its sense is given only approximately.
• "An immense multitude of Ganges Rivers" renders a Tibetan large-number term that denotes a specific vast numeral. Śakra's flowers are taken as those growing in his heaven, though the phrase could also mean flowers available there at the scene.
• The weapon written in Tibetan as "śa ta ka ni ha" appears to transliterate a Sanskrit weapon name; it is rendered as śataghnī, a "hundred-killer" missile, which seems the likeliest identification. "Kampana" for □□□□□□□□□□□ is likewise a transliterated weapon name.
• The names of the eastern buddha, bodhisattva and world system are rendered by meaning, since their Sanskrit forms cannot be established with confidence. "Equal to Space" may reflect Gaganasama or Ākāśasama. "Infinite Great Body" corresponds to the bodhisattva called "Boundless Body" in the Chinese parallel. "Mind-Captivating Unceasing Sweet Sound" takes mu

tug as "unceasing." The text calls Infinite Great Body first a śrāvaka and then a bodhisattva mahāsattva; both are kept as given. "World system of Endurance" renders the name of our world, Sahā.

• The bodhisattva's name, rendered here by meaning as Boundless Great Body, has no securely attested Sanskrit form; the Chinese parallel calls him Boundless Body. "Thirty-two maṇḍalas" is translated literally; the Chinese parallels give a measure of distance here, so "maṇḍala" may stand for a unit of area. In the list of birds, the syllable after "cranes" does not fit as written and is probably a copyist's slip; it has been left out of the translation. The phrase "those of great desire" is taken as the Tibetan rendering of icchantika, as the context and parallels indicate.

• "The three faults and the four" most likely refers to the ten nonvirtuous actions: three of body, four of speech and three of mind. The Tibetan phrasing is compressed, so the exact grouping of faults with body, speech and mind is left as the text gives it. Sku□□□□□□ is rendered as Cunda, the smith's son known from the parinirvāṇa narratives.

• This Tibetan version (Toh 120) was translated from Chinese, which accounts for some unusual phrasing. The line rendered "Within existence all beings cling to life" is terse and its exact sense is uncertain. In "ever bound up with suffering like a tumor," the word read as "tumor" could also mean "rice grains" or "fruit"; the sense is uncertain. The simile "like scorched food" is literal; its intended sense in this context is unclear.

• The term rendered "a great lord" here translates the same Tibetan used elsewhere for Maheśvara (Śiva). In this simile it plainly means a powerful worldly lord, not the deity. The fourth māra is given in this text as "the māra of intrinsic nature" rather than the usual māra of death. It has been translated as written. The word for "rescue," which in wrathful rites means "liberate," has its ordinary sense here.

• The phrase rendered "can he not now hold out even for a moment" reads gzhes mi spyod, whose exact sense is unclear; the rendering follows the context of Cunda's objection. "Whether it be special or not" reads khyed par, taken as khyad par.

• "Please do not depart and leave the world empty" renders the terse humble phrase □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, taking □□□ as "go" in humble speech; it might also be read as a statement that the world will be left empty. "Like a haṃsa going off in play" is a tentative reading of □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□; the word □□□ is unclear. "Borrowed" for □□□□□□ could also be understood as "a mere reflection."

• The verb □□□□□□□ in the verse "If you do not hold back from passing into nirvāṇa" is unusual; it has been read in the sense of desisting or refraining. □□□□□□, rendered "grieve and lament," is likewise an uncommon term. "Final tantra" renders □□□□□□□□□□□ (uttaratantra), the concluding and most advanced section of a technical treatise, here applied by analogy to the final teaching of the Great Vehicle.

• The phrase rendered "the discourse on the single syllable and its dot" is obscure in the Tibetan. It may refer to the anusvāra dot, or more broadly to a teaching condensed into a single syllable. The word rendered "conceit" is uncertain in the Tibetan. "Khasral flower" keeps the Tibetan plant name, because the species could not be identified with confidence; the point of the simile is that the flower has no scent. Manuja ("born of Manu") and mānava ("son of Manu") are standard terms in lists of names for a supposed self.

• □□□□ / □□□□□□□ in the four inversions is rendered "pure / impure," corresponding to śubha / aśubha, the fourth quality (purity) of the dharmakāya in this sūtra's doctrine. The opening question of the Blessed One is terse; it is rendered as asking whether the monks understand this way of meditating. □□□ in the list of things seen turning is rendered "towers"; its exact sense here is not certain.

• "Versed in the later treatises" renders □□□□□□□□□□□, probably the supplementary section of a classical medical treatise. Two items in the list of the cow's qualities are uncertain: "whose

teats the cowherd has not roughly handled" (□□□□□□□□□□□□) and "who has not been fed on cut grass" (□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□). Both are given by best sense.
• The king's question "khyed gsher ci yod" is idiomatic and not fully clear; rendered "what objection do you have?" The term rendered "millet" is the Tibetan khre rgod, a small grain used here, as in parallel passages, for a minutely small self.
• The bodhisattva's birthplace is translated literally as "Stalk Village"; the Chinese version of this sūtra places Kāśyapa Bodhisattva in a village called Tāla, but the Tibetan word does not plainly render that name. The birds paired with the wild geese (Tibetan zal mo) could not be identified with confidence; the Chinese parallel names sārasa and kācilindika birds here. "The element that is hard to fathom" refers to the buddha nature, and "the half letter becoming complete" alludes to the sūtra's teaching on half and complete letters, taken up later in the text. The kata fruit is the water-clearing nut.
• The speaker, literally "the one of the same clan as Mahākāśyapa," is the bodhisattva Kāśyapa of this sūtra, distinct from the disciple Mahākāśyapa. The phrase rendered "even of an ant" reads literally "rgyu sogs pa" in the Tibetan, which makes little sense. It is taken here as a scribal slip for a word meaning ant or tiny creature, as in the parallel passage of the Chinese version. "Like toward the axe and the sandalwood" refers to the Buddha's equal regard for one who cuts him with an axe and one who anoints him with sandalwood.
• The interlocutor, literally "one of the same clan as Mahākāśyapa," is the bodhisattva Kāśyapa of this sūtra, not the elder Mahākāśyapa himself; he is rendered here as "kinsman of Mahākāśyapa." The river name Hiṅgula follows the Tibetan spelling and is not securely identified; it may correspond to the Sindhu or another river in the parallel Chinese lists.
• "Kāśyapa of the Mahākāśyapa clan" renders a Tibetan phrase meaning literally "one of the same clan as the great Kāśyapa." It refers to the bodhisattva interlocutor Kāśyapa, not the elder Mahākāśyapa. "A body that depends on poisons and medicines" is a literal rendering of a compressed phrase. The Chinese parallel speaks instead of the Tathāgata casting off a "poison-tree body."
• The interlocutor here is the bodhisattva Kāśyapa, addressed as "kinsman of Mahākāśyapa" (literally "of the same clan as Mahākāśyapa"). The Tibetan does not name him in this piece. I have supplied his name for the speaker, following the surrounding text. The phrase rendered "lacking nothing and exceeding nothing" (lhag chad med pa) could also be read as a noun, "the state without remainder," set beside "my state." The phrase "expression of disparagement" (smad pa'i tshig) is rendered literally. Its exact force in this Tibetan rendering, which was made from the Chinese, is unclear.
• "Need not take up the five bases of training" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□, literally "is not to take"; the sense, as in the parallel Chinese version, is that such a protector of the Dharma is exempted from these observances, not forbidden them. A few items in the long negative list (for example □□□□□□□□□□ "without feet" and □□□□□□□□□□ "nothing beyond it") are terse and admit other readings.
• The king's name □□□□□□□□□□ is rendered Bhavadatta from its Tibetan components (bhava, datta); the Sanskrit form is not certain. The sentence about Abhirati literally says that "one called the aspect (or form) of the Tathāgata Akṣobhya" appeared there; the sense is obscure, and it is rendered literally as "the Likeness of the Tathāgata Akṣobhya." The phrase □□□□□□□□□□□□ is taken as the immoral "stirring up trouble" against the preacher, which is what the narrative requires.
• The questioner here is the bodhisattva Kāśyapa, addressed by the Buddha as being of the same clan as Mahākāśyapa. The terms rendered "great severity" and "lesser severity" are uncertain in sense; they appear to distinguish the irremediable offenses (the defeats) from remediable ones. The phrase rendered "a grave matter" is literally "a great basis," and its exact sense is unclear.

• The list of "eight sweets" as written contains nine items (permanence, stability, eternity, peace, coolness, agelessness, deathlessness, stainlessness, bliss); it is translated as it stands. "Saṃyukta sūtras" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, most likely the Saṃyuktāgama. The fourth category, "the force of a circumstance that has arisen concerning a matter," is a tentative rendering of an unusual phrase. The "final tantra" of the medical sciences renders □□□□□□□□□□, the concluding section of a medical treatise.
• The recurring address □□□□□ is not a normal Tibetan word; it appears to be a loan, probably reflecting a Chinese form of address for a woman, since this text was translated from Chinese. I have rendered it "Sister." In □□□□□□□□ I read □□□□□ plus □□□, "Sister, me." The phrase □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, literally "would come to seek water," is rendered "would fall ill," since the context is the sickness of an infant who cannot digest. "The one of the same clan as Mahākāśyapa" most likely refers to the bodhisattva Kāśyapa, who is the interlocutor in this part of the sūtra.
• "The Vinaya and the Mātṛkā" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□; here □□□□ is the Abhidharma matrix (mātṛkā), not the class of goddesses. "Like fowlers" renders □□□□□□□□□□, which is obscure as written; the Chinese parallel has "like hunters," and I read it as a word for a bird-catcher. "Prepare them as food" for □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is tentative; the Chinese parallel speaks of monks cooking food with their own hands. "Offenses requiring expiation" renders □□□□□□□□□ (pāyattika).
• The phrase rendered "heals with regard to both aims" is an etymological gloss on prātimokṣa whose exact sense in the Tibetan is unclear. The weaver simile ("discards whatever section of the weave on his loom has gone astray") is also obscure in the Tibetan. The rendering follows the evident point that faults are dealt with as they arise. The term rendered "by force of" translates the Tibetan word usually meaning "power" or "empowerment." Here it names one of four modes of teaching, so the glossary sense "empowerment" does not apply.
• The phrase rendered "'Iron' and 'lump of iron'" reads literally "iron and mdo lcags." The second term is unclear. It is taken here as referring back to the verse's "lump of iron" (lcags kyi gar bu), possibly through a scribal variant. The sense, that the two words do not differ in meaning, is unaffected.
• "A billion" renders □□□□□□□□, a large number whose exact value varies in Tibetan sources; it is taken here as the count of suns and Jambudvīpas in a great trichiliocosm, which agrees with the Chinese parallel. "Juniper leaf" translates □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ as written; the Chinese version has a jujube leaf. "In the manner of the Śūraṅgama Samādhi" most likely refers to the Śūraṅgamasamādhi Sūtra.
• The phrase rendered "no circulation, no corresponding process, and no ripening" is obscure. "Ripening" may here mean the digestion of food rather than karmic maturation; the point is that the Buddha's body has no real bodily processes behind these acts. In "the divine māra and the māra of intrinsic nature," the second term probably answers to the māra of the aggregates in the usual list of four māras, but the Tibetan is terse. The quoted vows of the seven steps are rendered in the first person because the whole passage is the Buddha speaking of himself.
• The verb rendered "deliver" throughout is used here in its ordinary sense of saving beings, not in the wrathful-rite sense. The phrase about Brahmā and the gods, literally "showing obstruction" to their devotees, is somewhat obscure; it seems to mean the Buddha appears in their form to thwart wrong reliance and redirect them to the Dharma. The phrase rendered "since my passing into complete nirvāṇa is permanent" is ambiguous; it may instead mean "I do not pass into complete nirvāṇa in a final sense." The "perception of looking" at the charnel ground is also uncertain; it may mean "no notion of views."
• "Wonder-working sects" renders □□□□□□□□, literally "those possessing marvels"; context (going forth among them, crushing their pride, showing them to be coreless) indicates

non-Buddhist ascetic sects (tīrthikas). The unnamed questioner is Kāśyapa, the interlocutor of this section. "Material things" renders □□□□□□ (Skt. āmiṣa, worldly or carnal goods). The phrase translated "is the Tathāgata also to be likened to the vessel" contains the unclear form □□□□□; the sense is supplied from the following sentence.

• "Householder with servants and wives" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, which recurs as a fixed phrase and might be intended as a name; it is translated descriptively. "A poison used as medicine" renders the terse □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, whose exact sense is uncertain. The verse is the familiar saying on those who hoard nothing and fully understand food. The second form of the verse, with its interrogatives, has been kept as questions. The word-explanation of "full" (yongs) and "accumulation" (bsags) depends on the Tibetan compound and has been rendered with the English words used in the verse.

• The phrase rendered "a term for what surpasses others" (literally "a term for what has a remainder or excess") is obscure. I took "excess" in the sense of surpassing, which fits the examples that follow. "Wounded by a falling stone" renders a phrase whose exact sense in this simile is unclear. "Those of great desire" renders the Tibetan term for the icchantikas, a key concept of this sūtra.

• The heading "afflicted, afflicted" is kept as the Tibetan gives it, although the section explains that liberation and the Tathāgata are not afflicted. The term rendered "not fragile" is uncertain; it seems to mean brittle or hollow, and the contrast drawn with a cracked clay pot supports "fragile." "Does not perish" renders a word that ordinarily means "unpacified." In this list of negations it most likely stands for "not ceasing."

• The precious object of the wheel-turning king is □□□□, normally "bell-metal" or "bronze." Its exact sense here is unclear, and it is rendered literally. □□□□□□□□□ is rendered "free of danger." The images it is set against (cardamom colors, a lamp on its stand) leave its exact sense somewhat uncertain; it could also mean "free of disturbance." □□□□□□□□□□ ("those of great desire") is this sūtra's standard Tibetan rendering of icchantika. The sentence linking the icchantika to the Tathāgata's inexhaustibility is terse, and it is rendered closely.

• In the passage on "free of afflictions," the Tibetan literally says liberation is "like that" while contrasting it with a graspable myrobalan; it is rendered as a contrast ("by comparison"), which the sense requires. □□□□ is read as "fist, handful." In the final item □□□□ is rendered "severance" rather than the glossary's "annihilation," since it here denotes the cutting off of desire, not the nihilist extreme. "The essence of butter" as an example of the unstable is given as the text has it.

• "That which is ignorance is liberation" is translated as the Tibetan reads; the sense is presumably that the transformation or subduing of ignorance is liberation. "Liberation makes itself known to oneself" renders the obscure phrase rang la brda sprod pa; the meaning is uncertain. The plant name pa mkhal could not be identified and is left in phonetic form. The nāga tree is probably the nāgakesara.

• "Nothing equals the word of the teacher" renders the uncertain phrase bla ma'i tshig gcig tu med pa; it might also mean that the teacher's word is not one-sided. The passage on "cutting off paths" is syntactically ambiguous. It may mean that grasping at selflessness and grasping at a self are what is cut off, and that holding the existence of the buddha element is liberation. I have kept the Tibetan sequence as it stands. "Source" renders skye mched (āyatana), used here in its sense of "abode" or "source" rather than "sense base."

• "Foes that take the form of afflictions" reads □□□ ("enemy") for the written □□□ ("sound"), which makes little sense in the hunter image. The kinsman's question at the start of Fascicle Seven is elliptical in the Tibetan and is rendered literally. □□□□□□□□□□ is taken as the jīvaṃjīvaka bird.

• "Ordinary being of the eighth rank" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, which corresponds to the "eighth person" (aṣṭamaka) of the Chinese parallel, i.e. one counted eighth from the

arhat, the candidate for stream-entry. "In the abode of the buddhas" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□; it may also be understood as "to the rank of a buddha."

• The householder named □□□□□□□ ("the one with a voice/melody") has been identified as Ghoṣila on the basis of the parallel in the Chinese version from which this Tibetan text was translated. The phrase "They have become a support for the world" reads a missing syllable □□□□ ("support") into the text as written, which says only "they have become the world"; the following lines speak of the persons being "a support," and this confirms the reading. Some phrases in the simile of the troops are unusual: the kind of sword named □□□□□□, the expression "as if grinding to powder," and □□□□□, rendered "hold their ground." They have been rendered by context.

• The grains □□□□□, □□□ and □□□□□□□□ are rendered "coarse grain, millet and wild millet." □□□□□ in particular is not securely identifiable; it denotes some inferior grain. □□□□□□□□□ in one occurrence is taken as a slip for □□□□□□□□, and the doubled □□□□□□□□□□□□ is read as a single verb.

• In the one-Ganges case the Tibetan says these people will explain the teaching widely to all people. Some parallel versions say instead that they cannot yet explain it to others. The translation follows the Tibetan as it stands. The word rendered "frost" is uncommon; it may instead mean dense mist or dew, but the simile works the same way.

• The phrase rendered "by force together with other caṇḍālas" reads in the Tibetan as gdol pa dag deng de mthus, which does not construe as written; it has been translated as the evident reading gdol pa dag dang de'i mthus. The expression chad pa'i gnas in the monk's objection is rendered "an occasion for censure" rather than "annihilation," since the context, followed by talk of punishing the immoral, concerns blame or penalty, not the nihilist view.

• The list of those relied upon to remove the holders of the eight improper things (literally "accomplishers, chiefs, and grain gatherers") is obscure; it is rendered as "administrators, chiefs, and grain collectors," apparently referring to secular officials. The phrase rendered "join with them in granting leave, in the poṣadha, and in joining palms, while carrying out acts that afflict them" is likewise difficult; the sense seems to be that the bodhisattva outwardly takes part in communal acts with the immoral monks while working to suppress them, as the brahmin did with the caṇḍāla king. The questioner is not named in this piece; in this sūtra it is presumably Kāśyapa.

• The phrase rendered "acts of homage with joined palms and bowing" is literally "acts of tormenting with joined palms"; the verb is most likely a slip for the similar word meaning "to bow," which matches the sense of the parallel Chinese text from which this Tibetan version was made. The speaker of the questions is unnamed in this piece. "Invitation ceremony" renders the Tibetan term for pravāraṇā.

• "Māduraka" renders the transliterated incense name as written; its Sanskrit identity is uncertain. "The eight great matters" are, in this sūtra, the eight impure possessions improper for monks to accept. The text reads "these four are like reliances"; I have taken it as "these four are the reliances," the evident sense. In "those four persons are not authoritative, for they are the definitive meaning," the negative contradicts both the explanation that follows and the earlier statement that the four persons are authoritative, so I have translated "authoritative." In the final two sentences, the same word for "authoritative" is applied to the Dharma body and the body of skillful means. Here I have taken it in its sense of "measure," but the intended sense is uncertain.

• The phrase rendered "connected with discontent ... and flattery" reads literally "that become without (□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□) ... flattery"; since the context (the alleged permission to keep possessions) shows these writings foster such faults, the rendering follows the sense, but the Tibetan construction is awkward. "The three bases" most likely refers to the Three Jewels, the Buddha, Dharma and Saṅgha, whose permanence was just asserted. The simile "just as one

conceals the signs of what one is doing" is obscure in the Tibetan; parallel versions speak of a hunter disguising himself. Throughout, □□□□ is rendered "valid authority," as it concerns which teachers and scriptures may be trusted (the four reliances), not epistemic instruments.
• The brahmin's name, literally "Sheep Glory," could not be securely identified with a Sanskrit form and is translated by meaning. The deity called "the Desiccator" is likewise rendered literally, as its Sanskrit identity is uncertain. Several items in the list of forbidden possessions and practices are obscure in the Tibetan, notably "the flower chariot," "satchels," "clubs," "fine refined powders" and "kissing heads"; these are rendered as literally as the words allow.
• "Heterodox orders" renders □□□□□□□□, literally "the strange or wondrous ones"; the sense of non-Buddhist sects seems intended but is not certain. "Later Section" and "Last of the Later Sections" render □□□□□□□□□□□ and □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□; here □□□□□ does not mean a tantra but a later portion of the scriptures, and the exact referent is unclear. In the final sentence, □□□□□ ("concealing") is read as □□□□□ ("claiming"), since a false claim to have attained the fruit is the defeat concerning superhuman states.
• The opening phrase "the Later of the Later" seems to name a section of the Vinaya literature, as in the preceding piece. The exact sense of "brought down in regard to the superhuman qualities" is uncertain; it appears to refer to the pārājika of falsely claiming superhuman attainments. In this translation of the sūtra, "those of great desire" renders icchantika, and it is translated that way here. It is distinct from "craving for greatness," which is the monk's vanity. The final long passage is the false teaching attributed to Māra, not the Buddha's own position.
• "Grave offense" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□, the Vinaya category sthūlātyaya, which the following passage goes on to define. The sentence "In the Great Vehicle there is no destruction of self and life force either" is ambiguous in the Tibetan. It could also be read as "there is neither a self nor a destruction of life." The phrase rendered "together with whole companies of followers" (□□□□□□□□□□) is uncertain.
• "Grave offense" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□ (Skt. sthūlātyaya), the class of serious but non-expulsive monastic transgressions. The phrase □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ in both lists of austerities is obscure. It is rendered tentatively as "having others carry out malicious deeds"; the Chinese parallel at this point lists harming living beings. "The arts of concoction" for □□□□□□□□□□□□ is likewise an interpretive rendering, perhaps alchemical or occult preparations. The questioner's name is not given in this piece, so he is left unnamed.
• The term rendered "the heterodox" is literally "those who are strange or remarkable"; in context, and in light of the parallel Chinese version from which this Tibetan text was translated, it evidently refers to non-Buddhist teachers (tīrthikas). The list of the "four inversions" in the path section names only three items, as the Tibetan stands.
• The man's reply, "as soon as my son is born of you," is translated as the Tibetan stands; it differs from the Chinese parallel, where the man simply offers to show the son the treasure.
• The term rendered "the embryonic mass" in the list of bodily constituents is a Tibetan word for an early stage of the embryo; its place in a list alongside phlegm and colors is unusual, and the sense here is uncertain. The name of the elixir, "Bee Essence," translates the Tibetan literally; the parallel Chinese version names the medicine "Delightful Taste," so the Tibetan reading may reflect a different or corrupted source. "Gelpa" is a Tibetan name for a kind of tree or shrub that I could not identify with confidence.
• The phrase rendered "with different dispositions" reads □□□□□□□□□□, literally "different lungs" or "different sides," which makes little sense here; I have read it as □□□ "mind, disposition," a similar-looking syllable. The verse about śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas and "cow's milk" is translated as it stands; its exact point is ambiguous in the Tibetan.
• The phrase rendered "the three entities that overcome fear" reads literally "the three entities that destroy"; the object is unstated, and "fear" is supplied from the preceding verse about the fearless. The simile of arrows passed "one after another" is obscure in the Tibetan; the

rendering follows the literal wording. "Vast deeds" interprets the Tibetan word for "waves," taken in its sense of vast or magnificent activity.
• The Tibetan □□□□□□□□□□□□ normally means "leech." The image of seizing one spot and quickly letting go of the other may instead refer to an inchworm-like creature, as in other versions of this sūtra. "The Sūtra Gathering All Merit" may refer to the Sarvapuṇyasamuccayasamādhi Sūtra; this identification is not certain, so the title is translated. "The Light of Entering Nonduality" seems to name a section of the Perfection of Wisdom literature and is translated literally. The sentence about nirvāṇa having "no basis and no abode" is rendered as the Tibetan stands, though its syntax is compressed.
• The grass name rendered "Unctuous" translates the Tibetan word meaning "oily, rich"; I could not identify a Sanskrit name with confidence. The Chinese versions describe it with a similar word meaning "fatty, rich." The speaker of the questions to the Buddha is not named in this piece. It is presumably the bodhisattva interlocutor of this section, usually Kāśyapa. The phrase "they see it dimly, as though not seeing it" renders an idiom that literally means "seeing it as not seeing."
• The recurring term rendered "dimly" (Tibetan 'ol phyir) conveys indistinct, partial seeing; the point of each simile is that even tenth-ground bodhisattvas perceive buddha-nature only indistinctly. The phrase about the prince's night of music is obscure in the Tibetan and has been rendered by sense. The final sentence is phrased as a statement in the Tibetan and may introduce a question taken up in the next piece; the speaker is not named in this passage.
• "Akṣara," letter, is etymologized as "non-leaking" or "imperishable" (from kṣar, "to flow"), which explains the wordplay on non-leaking and the nine openings. The Tibetan says the succeeding king's son "found that sword," although the parable's sense, and the next sentence, imply that he did not. It is translated as written. "King's son of the far-off land" renders an unclear expression (literally "the king's son of the border"), which apparently refers to the prince who went to another country.
• "The three bases" renders a term that in this passage refers to the Three Jewels, Buddha, Dharma and Saṅgha. "Those without discernment" takes the rare word bgrungs as "shrewd, discerning." The phrase rendered "weeds" literally reads "the face of the field," understood from context and the Chinese parallel as weeds or tares to be cleared. "Rāhula" here is the Buddha's son, the model of a parent's love.
• The word zalmo is left untranslated. It is not a common Tibetan word. The text itself explains one kind as a bird that keeps company with geese. This matches the parallel Chinese passage, which speaks of two kinds of birds that always go in pairs, but the exact identification is uncertain. The glossary gives □□□□□ as "tantra", but in this sūtra context, a list with mantras and dharmas, "treatises" seems to be the intended sense.
• The questioner is not named in this piece; he is the interlocutor of the surrounding dialogue, so he is simply called "he." The phrase rendered "out of loving-kindness" (Tibetan byams pas) could in principle be read as the name Maitreya acting as subject. In context, the Buddha's love for beings as for his son Rāhula, the reading "loving-kindness" is the more natural one.
• The bird named here, alongside the goose, cannot be identified with confidence. It is rendered generically as "waterfowl." The phrase "like geese moving on" renders an obscure wording. Its sense, birds leaving one place for another, is inferred from the simile that follows.
• The birds named in the Buddha's reply are uncertain: the first term is taken as the shelduck, and the second, zalmo, could not be identified and is given phonetically. Parallel versions of this sūtra compare the Buddha to a pair of birds that are never separated. The phrase rendered "the various sects of wonder-workers" is literally "all those possessed of marvels"; parallel versions say the Buddha is seen going forth among non-Buddhist ascetics (tīrthikas). "A medicinal tree against poison" renders a compound literally meaning "poison-medicine tree."
• "The three foundations are ruined!" renders the obscure phrase gzhi gsum ma rung, which

seems to be part of what beings think on seeing the Buddha bleed; its exact sense is uncertain (possibly the Three Jewels). In the physician simile, kha ba is taken as "the bitter one" (a medicinal taste) rather than "snow."

• "The three bases" most likely refers to the Three Jewels (Buddha, Dharma and Saṅgha), as the preceding exhortation about the Tathāgata, Dharma and Saṅgha suggests. The Tibetan has "being like the sun is the nature of reality of the pratyekabuddhas," though the simile just given compares them to planets unseen by day; it is translated as written. The questioner is not named in this piece.

• The phrase rendered "hold generating the mind of awakening to be unnecessary" reads literally "having generated the mind for awakening, hold it unnecessary"; the context, which concerns those who have not generated the mind, favors the rendering given. The names of the legumes and grain in the seed simile are approximate. In the vajra simile the Tibetan states that the vajra does not cut a sheep's horn; this has been kept as written.

• The list of plants that sprout again after being cut is given largely in transliterated Indian names; several (doṅka, valmīki, karṇavalya, skandastava, vīraṇa, rocana) cannot be identified with certainty, so they are given in approximate romanized form. The phrase rendered "even though they do not hold that they must generate the resolve" is obscure in the Tibetan and may instead mean that they need not deliberately generate the resolve. The glosses beginning "'Well done' means awakening" comment on words not quoted in this piece. The paragraph beginning "One who is held to be an arhat" is ambiguous in the Tibetan as to whether it describes the icchantika or a genuine upholder of the Vaipulya. The following simile of the messenger suggests the latter. The kataka fruit is the clearing-nut used in India to purify muddy water.

• The phrase rendered "once it has sealed itself in" translates an unclear expression in the silkworm simile, apparently referring to the completed cocoon. The questioner in "He asked" is not named in this piece; in the surrounding dialogue it is the bodhisattva interlocutor.

• "The nāga called Bird-Choker" renders the Tibetan "bya gag", which I could not identify as a standard rendering of a Sanskrit name; the translation is literal. In this passage "the Later Section" refers to the concluding portion of a medical treatise that a skilled physician masters (compare the Uttaratantra of Āyurvedic works).

• "The old trunk of a poisonous plant" renders a terse Tibetan phrase whose exact sense is uncertain; it appears to describe the discarded body of skillful means as something worthless, like a poisonous stalk. The interlocutor addressed as "son of noble family" is not named in this piece.

• "Saindhava" renders the Tibetan transcription sen da pa, the Sanskrit word for things "from the Sindhu region" (rock salt, horses, and so on), famous from this simile in the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra. The trees palāśa, aśoka and karṇikāra are identified from the Tibetan renderings and the parallel in the Chinese version; the Tibetan for the second tree is unusual.

• The terms rendered "multitudes upon multitudes" are two names for very large numbers whose exact values are uncertain. The item rendered "unfavorable times" is obscure in the Tibetan; it might instead refer to faulty writing materials. The tree called dongka could not be identified with confidence and is kept in its Tibetan form. The interlocutor who answers the Buddha is not named in this piece.

• The questioner is not named in this piece; in this section of the sūtra it is Kāśyapa. The phrase "they are, in my sense, supremely permanent" renders the elliptical □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, which could also be read "they are permanent through my supreme [nirvāṇa]." The wordplay on □□□□□□□ ("no place" for others, and the Great Parinirvāṇa being "without place," that is, non-abiding) has been kept as literal as English allows.

• The name rendered "Utterly Joyful" (Tibetan rab tu dga' ba) is translated by meaning, since a Sanskrit form for this future tathāgata cannot be identified with confidence. "The three

foundations" (gzhi gsum) here most likely refers to the Three Jewels, whose permanence this sūtra stresses. "Uphold the sacred Dharma" renders a verb that literally means "bring forth" or "draw out"; the sense of protecting or upholding the Dharma is taken from context. In the opening answer, the Tibetan grammar has the element mixed with afflictions as the subject that pervades the tathāgata element; this is translated as written.

• "The three permanent bases" most likely refers to the Three Jewels (Buddha, Dharma and Saṅgha), whose permanence this sūtra teaches; it is rendered literally here. "Nalita" is kept as the name of a measure of grain; its exact Indic equivalent is uncertain. The phrase rendered "no larger than the tip of a splinter" is uncertain in its precise sense.

• "Three Jewels" renders the Tibetan "three bases" (gzhi gsum), taken here as the Buddha, Dharma and Saṅgha. "Meaning with remainder" and "meaning without remainder" render the Tibetan literally; in context they mark a statement that admits exceptions as against one that is complete without exception.

• "Passing dust" reads □□□□□□□ as the evident slip for □□□□□□□ ("adventitious, sudden"). "Place to cling to" takes □□□□□ as a variant of □□□□□□, "support". "Just as one clears a field" is a reading of the obscure □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, which probably refers to weeding a field. "The three bases" are presumably the Three Jewels.

• "Ninety-six heterodox schools" renders a Tibetan phrase literally meaning "the ninety-six possessing wonders"; it is taken as referring to the traditional ninety-six non-Buddhist (tīrthika) schools. The clause about the patient and the ghee uses a verb meaning "grant," which is somewhat awkward; it is read as the patient asking for a large amount.

• "Carries an unstated qualification" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, a statement that is not exhaustive and requires qualification (sāvaśeṣa). In the final section □□□□□ is read as □□□□□, matching the parallel phrases. The line □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is rendered literally as "endless"; its exact sense is obscure, and Mañjuśrī's discussion treats it as a phrase to be qualified rather than explaining it. Making defeated monks "wear white clothes" means returning them to lay status.

• The brahmin's name, □□□□□□□, is translated literally as "Sheep Glory," since no secure Sanskrit form could be identified. This text was translated into Tibetan from Chinese.

Taking □□□□□□□□□□□□ ("victorious upward") as a calque of Ujjayinī is a reasoned identification, not a certain one. The same caution applies to the householder's name Kotaka.

The verse line about those "free of avarice" who "waver," and its explanation (holy beings "sparing toward themselves"), are obscure in the Tibetan and are rendered literally.

The large number in the closing sentence (□□□□□□□□□□) is rendered loosely as "countless myriads."

• The figure "twenty-five thousand chapters" is translated as the Tibetan gives it. It reflects the traditional claim that the full Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra was vastly longer than the portion actually translated. Devacandra (Lha Dawa) was a Tibetan translator who is known by this Sanskrit form of his name, so it is kept here.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the

Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.